

**meat-flavored ash**

—Millennials... The boomer muttered, folding his wad of clenched cash into itself.

—But sir, we had a good faith agreement that-

—Faith?! Faith is like your dick Faust. Who or what you put it in, that's on you. It is Faust, isn't it?

—I mean it, it's my artistic avatar, a prismatic persona through which I'm able to render the world look we agreed that three thousand dollars-

—Only thing we can agree on Faust is that you're a goddamned promosexual... Juug van Sant said as he removed a smartphone from silk sport coat innards the red of clotted blood, then pinched its screen with the detached curiosity of a child dismembering an insect.

—Like look here. This selfish selfie you took in front of your mural's already cost me four thousand likes. Now that's four thousand brain glands ejaculating their glance value on Zuck's platform when I need them to be fertilizing my Likecoin walled garden.

—So what. You saying I can't have pride in my work?

—Oh not at all son...Juug seized, then squeezed the top of Faust's trap muscle. —I'm saying that pride has a price. See going rate on my Likecoin cryptoplatform's a buck an eyeball, which means after subtracting your three grand in sweat equity vis-a-vis creating the mural from the eight thousand in social equity that you just now unconsentingly juiced from its exposure how do you want to settle your balance of five thousand-

—What? Likes don't work like, like...The millennial stammered, his voice stalled by halting breath. —Likes aren't currency! Look Mister Van Sant, I, my work it, it has rights.

—Problem is son, it don't have money...Juug sucked sharply through a snarled canine. —Tell you what. Seeing as I'm already late for a meeting with myself, how bout we write this whole thing off as a learning experience.

—Learning experience?! Fuck you mean learning-

—You know, taking an l on an earning experience. Thought you millennials would know all about that by now.

—Don't fucking patronize me!...Faust whined, shrinking his posture fetal so he could shrug Juug's hand off his trap muscle – a hand which, in the recoil of its rejection, flashed a gold crowbar cufflink before pinching the cuff on its opposite wrist for leverage so both shoulders could shrug a fresh fall onto a sport coat the blue of oxygenless blood.

—Precisely the point, son...Juug torqued his torso so his platformed brogues turned away from the millennial muralist tossing a tack rag against his Jersey City brick canvas with the limp velocity of a fighter throwing in a towel and toward a Midtown Manhattan skyline churning upward beneath scaffolding cranes baby-birding glass panels upon a clump of structures that in the day's mid-morning light, cast a shadow back across the Hudson River like a drawbridge.

—The shadow. It is both proof of a thing's existence, and the absence of it. Shouldn't you be able to say the same thing about your money?

As Juug paused to calisthenically flex jaw and jowls, a passing pedestrian swiveled the boardwalk in his search for Juug's audience.

—Because that's the opportunity I'm presenting to you today. Now look, we both know that when it comes to sheltering wealth, Manhattan penthouses are the stripper's tits. But why stash your money all the way up on some top-floor pied-a-terre that the southern district can easily see when the same building's shadow's right there waiting for you? Now I know what you're thinking. Investing in a building's shadow, seems a little shady am I right? But I want you to do something. Just look out at any of those trillion-dollar buildings over there across the river and tell me where their shadows are located. That's right. The ground floor. That's the shadow investment opportunity I'm presenting to you today. Because everywhere else in the world, a building's steel defines its shadow. But only in America is it the other way around. It's why if you can sell your shadow in this country, they'll let you do anything...

Like a nature broadcaster introducing a predatory species, Juug flit his head back at Battery Park City perched over his right shoulder.

—They'll even let you build out from the sea, rebar a whole goddamn zip code out into the Hudson. And all on a foundation of only three materials. Cash, trash, and ash. That's right you rustle up some foreign cash, gather up all the trash nobody wants, and then as a binder you mix in the fresh Lower Manhattan ash of well, you remember...

A gold wristwatch slithered behind thin blue lined pinstriped cuffs as the hand Juug placed over his heart suffocated the furling flag pin pinned to his lapel solely for that morning's chamber of commerce meeting.

—By which I mean never forget. Now I know what you're thinking. A foundation of cash trash and ash seems flimsy, sure. But layer enough of all three and you can bet your bottom nut that's an investment strong enough to support the American Dream. Now see this marina? That's where we're gonna build out our own battery park on this side of the Hudson. That's right my revolutionarily new shadow investment tranche is based on America's tried and true cash trash and ash formula see first we'll

layer your foreign cash with a collection of trashy mortgages nobody wants then as a binder we'll mix in the fresh ashes of all these burnt out millennials still searching for their american dreams. Now I know what you're thinking... Juug held up an open palm to address the hypothetical objections brought forth by the onshore breeze. — Millennials? Mortgages? But Juugie boy, hasn't America written off underwriting millennials? See that's because these millennials, they do things that don't pay. Which is something that our generation just didn't do. That's because us boomers were smart enough not to work for anything less than a living wage. Which is why all these banks needed to lure us into a mortgage was a goddamned toaster or tie rack. But as American generations got weaker, banks got more desperate. Remember how we had to dangle subprimes so those cynical gen xers would finally bite? Now these millennials, they're a completely different financial species. And different species require different lures. And that's the real opportunity I'm presenting to you today. Introducing the first real estate investment ever to be underwritten entirely by the like, the social mortg-goo!

His ribs elbowed and lucidity severed, Juug turned hard to his right to determine what caused both; there he felt salt pepper his face in its sprinkled ricochet off a steak skewered by a plastic pitchspork, its handle wedged into a bellybutton whose surrounding gut refused sweatsuited elastic bands on both sides.

— Quite the nigger rig, ain't it?... Captain Jim Cancelme's heaving chuckles bobbed his gut-platformed steak beneath neck rolls that suggested his appetizer had been a rack of haloes swallowed whole.

— Fuck you do that for Jim!

— The meat, it don't taste the way it used to. So I rigged up this lazy steak susan to make it taste great again.

— Steak's too far gone to accept flavor Jimbo. You can launder the thing in salt, still won't taste the same when it was fresh off the flame.

— Look don't get all butthurt because I interrupted you prehearsing for your meeting with your Russian magnet.

— Jim how many times do I-

—No no look I get it. You got your bigshot russian magnet coming into town, and me, well, I've been told Captain Jim can be a bit polarizing. So even though the meetin's gonna be on my sportfisher, I'm gonna voluntarily refuse myself from attending. But only on the rendition you tell this russian magnet one thing for me.

—And what's that?...Juug muttered as his fingertips kneaded shuttered eyelids.

—Tell em we're gonna squeeze these millennials by the short and curls the same way we used to squeeze these nig-

In snatching the steak from Jim's hand, Juug stalled the slur from leaving his mouth. Raising the grey meat at the same locked unyielding angle as lady liberty's torch looming in the distance between the Hudson and the horizon, Juug's unsalted eye scanned passing foot traffic for any faces scrunched in judgment. And only after confirming nothing from his brother's bigotry interrupted the murmur and shuffle of the day's business, only then did Juug slacken his cringing wince, insert the butt end of a tomahawk lollipop back into Jim's bellybutton, and with it, a rapscallion tousle of its surrounding gut hair.

—Don't get butthurt just cause Captain Jim's telling it like it is.

—And eating it like it was, I see.

—I mean why we even targeting millennials anyway?...undigested gristle punctuated Jim's question in its hocked arc over a passing stroller and into Lincoln Harbor. —Ain't a lot of meat on dem bones.

—Got a point there Jimbo. It all comes down to putting our clients on the meat, don't it? What deep water is to you, dark pools are to me. And sure most folks simply wanna gaff some fatty tuna spike some fatcat's short position that type of thing. But then there's the more noble client, the one who wants to be put on trophy species like marlins or say millennials, not for their meat mind you but for the pride of mounting them on their wall. And those clients, they're the ones who butter our caviar bread.

—Oh now I get it. It's because millennials got all dem trophies.

— Sure Jim. Point is we're only as lucky as our lures. And I've got the one that'll finally get millennials off their parents' basement tit so and bite on a million-dollar social mortgage.

— Speaking of biting million-dollar tits. Ma'am.

The dogwalker leaned back as she walked so that she could counter the two taut labradoodled leashes tugging her toward a bench seating the four eyes on her which were not her own. Her senses heightening by a welling anxiety, she began feeling the impact of each sneaker's heel reverberate revealingly through flesh encased in mauve lycra. And as the dogs drug her closer to the two men on the bench, she could see her creeping suspicion confirmed in slacked jaws demanding foleyed *awoogas*, eyebrows boinging at her jiggled rhythm above pupils narrowing in scheme.

— Would you look at these two.... The hands the dogwalker placed into opposite armpits as a protective breast measure were quickly yanked away by both labradoodles straining toward the limp, overturned hand extended in front of them. — Ever wonder why dogs flock to an empty hand hun?

— Probably not your hand dude... The dogwalker monotoned while attempting to flap twin-helixed leashes free from sixteen legs in, of, and around the bench. — Probably your fat friend there sweating Worcestershire.

— Exactly. They can't separate the scent from the sustenance, bless their wormy hearts.

— Yeah it's not their fault. They were bred to be that way.

— But do you know that it's not what you know, but how you use it?

— What?

— I'll speak plainly. Do you know how to turn an empty hand into a raised ass?

— What.

— You know, a raised ass. The consent form of the natural world.

— Frankly looking the way you do, how'd you not know about raised-

— Jim, please. See hun I come from a similar background as yours, though I was a breeder, not some hussy walker. Guaranteed I could get your dog to show their butt in under an hour. Best way to learn the business come to think of it.

— What business is that? ... The dogwalker asked, stretching the conversation with Scheherazadian self-preservation while she attempting to double-dutch her braided leashes free.

— Just, business. I mean fucking the other guy over, that's what this country's all about right? Well hun let me tell you that process is a hell of a lot easier if you can convince the other guy to show his butt to you. Like this kennel of rescue millennials I got making murals and minting crypto for me, they're so desperate to be pick of the littered they'll show their butts at the sight of any blue thumb out there.

— If you want a visualization toots, I got some septic dye in the trunk and something that's shaped like a thumb.

— That's it, let's go boys.

— Really?! The both of us?

— For fuck sake Jim, she's talking to the dogs. Miss, miss, before you go miss please if you'll just let me apologize for my friend's proposition with a proposition of my own see I'm willing to wager one million followers I can get those two black bitches of yours to show their butts to me right here right now. And I won't have to give em any meat or milkbones to do it.

— Sorry but no.

— Fine. But don't apologize to me hun... Juug removed a butane lighter, a white gold inlaid double-guillotine cutter, and a compensatingly-endowed cigar from his sportcoat. — Apologize to your glance value. Apologize to a profile that could have had a plus m in the followers tab.

— Last I heard tuts, that's more than a numbuh.

— So you can't just give them the steak... the dogwalker said while contemplatively somersaulting gum between tips of teeth.

—Spoken like a true capitalist...A sharp snip of the double-guillotine cutter punctuated Juug's smarm, so that the cigar's severed tip fell between two labradoodles recoiling in its descent as if it were a dying dog's turd. And after having inserted the freshly circumcised cigar between back molars, Juug thrust his right hand into the dogwalker's personal space. —So ew we ave a eal?

—Whatever. And ew.

Juug placed his rejected hand over the cigar as a canopy against a butane flame illuminating his pursed lips popping like a pacified baby so his sucked breath could sieve heat through packed tobacco.

—Dude you do know that dogs don't like smoke, it causes them to-

—Panic, yes...As Juug leaned forward off the bench, he pulled a drool-wilted cigar out from gold molars which after hovering directly above the two labradoodles, he tapped the cigar with the slow-motioned smarm of a troll tallying an invisible point, three inches of dislodged ash fell unnoticed between the two canines self-blinded, triggered into pawing snouts stung by the passing smoke. — Know what pairs perfectly with panic hun? Jim the tray please...

Juug's hand reached his behind its own shoulder to snap, then spread horizontally open; fingers feeling nothing, the cigar's orange ember increased in size and pulse before he seethed — For fuck sake Jim!...through teeth pried ajar from the cigar.

—Wha?

—I need the tray!

—But you just told me that the meat didn't have any flavor anymore so why would you-

—Damn it I don't need the meat just need the tray.

—But if I give you the tray then where do I put the-

—Gee I don't know Jim... Juug peevishly snatched the tray away from Jim, removed the tomahawk steak inside, then tossed the tray back atop his brother's slumped torso. — Maybe stick it in your belly like before!...Juug's tone modulated from anger to the



begrudged rushed monotone of delivering a stale punchline. — It's hope hun. Panic pairs best with hope. And if you trickle it down just right. . . Juug paused so he could poise the tray directly over the panting dogs; then closing his left eye so as to calibrate his aim, he slowly tilted the tray to the right until a brown-pink liquid rope flung down off its styrofoam lip to splash onto the pile of ash, changing its color to blush, its consistency to mush, the sound of its transformation the sound of soft applause.

— They'll lap up anything it touches as if it's the steak itself. . . Juug's hand panoramically flourished across and above two canine anii circling the ash-puddle whose mouths lapped up its content even beyond it becoming nothing more than a puddle of their own consumption. — See?

— I, I see cruelty.

— So you do see it! Because that's all capitalism is hun. A continuation of cruelty by other means.

— Now tuts I knows you wanted those million followers, but how bouts the two of us follow you home, you know as like as one of those consultation prizes.

— Jim please. Now before you go miss there is the matter of resolving your balance of the aforementioned million followers.

— Man fuck your balance.

— Now now, we don't want to reinforce the stereotype that you millennials are sore losers do we?

— Unless you just want to be sore.

— Jim, please. See thing is hun I can be a real asshole about getting you in arrears on owing me these followers but then I think about the inconvenience in mounting all those dildos and halo lights in your closet. Now I'm already late for a meeting with myself so how bouts I simply take a profile picture with your two dogs there call it even, chalk the whole thing up as a learning experience.

— A picture. After how you just humiliated them.

— Arbitration is what you should call it eh Juug?

— Humiliation just makes them hope harder, you know that right hun? ...Juug asked the dogwalker while he lowered ten wiggling fingers; those on his left caressed the furry undershot jaw of one dog as his right tickled the stitched scars where the other's balls had been. — See? Juug said before shooting a glance down at his trousers its shin creases being playfully nuzzled by one's snout and the other's wagging tail. — Now I'm a little old school hun so I'm gonna take your silence on the matter as consent. So how bout you hand over the reins on your leashes to Jim here while you take my camera and walk over toward that marina gate over...Jim? His question directed to a man too captivated with dangling the steak over the dogs while dancing a bowed-hip trolling leprachaun jig to respond.

— Damnit Jim get your head in the game!

— Hey take it easy! ...Captain Jim urged with locally-sourced, passive-aggressive passion, where after taking the transferred leashes from Juug, watched two wet black noses work together to nudge a wet brown nub atop Jim's teal topsider ridges diabetically stretched on all sides.

— Damnit Jim don't pick that up. It's just the bit.

— Well maybe Jim wants the bit...After putting the steak in the hand that held the leashes, Captrin Jim wiped a freed tallow-residued hand on his brillo-haired belly, bent his fupaed torso beneath the horizon, and picked the cigar nub off his topsider's top. — Ya ever think of that?

— Jim you're like everything else in this country. Try not to think of you until the moment I need you...Placing exasperated fists on hips Juug watched a pair of paws leap on Captain Jim's belly as a mlemming tongue lapped Jim's belly hair, triggering a tickled giggle. — And I need you to put that goddamned steak away so all threes of yours can calm the fuck down for our profile picture.

Only now noticing that his empty styrofoam tray had blown into the marina basin, Captain Jim swiveled his torso for a place to store his steak; flinch-froze his body as if having been thunderstruck by his own solve. Captain Jim lowered his eureka-raised index finger

so it could tug his sweatsuit pants' hem beneath his ass's apex; then after having holstered the tomahawk's butt end between the two cheeks behind him, he cranked his freed arm's backhand over the dogs until it triggered submissive asynchronous whimpers.

—Now hun just as a heads up I'm best at a shallow depth of field either one point four or eight on the f stop alright now on the count of three say hashtag fat cats and starving dogs one, two-

—Yee!...Jim leapt off the bench to meet the camera's flash clutching a flapping hand by its wrist like a toddler having just lost his stove virginity. —Fucker bit me!

—Damnit let me see how bad it is.

—See? See where one of those bitches made the hurty marks!

—Damnit Jim wasn't talking to you!...Juug snarled as he shoved Jim aside to walk toward the dogwalker holding his DSLR; where after peering down its viewfinding monitor with cupped palms over temples, he calmly lifted the camera's lanyard over her neck to then punt into the marina basin. —For fuck sake Jim these rescues bite the hand that teases them something fierce, you know that right?

—Look are we done here cause I gots to take these two back before-

—Oh ho, not yet we ain't...A steak, unsheathed from Captain Jim's anus, raised high above a head muttering—Need to take these two to the meatshed first...

There, at the gristle cudgel's smiting apex, a parabola of fur yojinked the meat from Jim's grip so that the only follow through he could make on his threat was a spritz of stale Worcestershire.

—Guh?

A peaked Captain's cap, its embroidered anchor the color of dog piss, spun off its axis while the head below swiveled in the opposite direction, divided in their search for retribution against what was now nothing more than two shadows stretching toward the horizon they sought, and the clatter of claw and leash against concrete, as if tap dancing.

As the bus entered Lincoln Tunnel, light snapped to darkness to reflect back the self-pity David Engram was projecting upon Manhattan's layered capitalist acres lacking his opportunity. Seated behind him but through that same window, Byron Chianti watched the tunnel's pearlescent white bricks flicker red in warning from the traffic ahead. The bus bobbed severely as it bore out the tunnel, fighting against the current of suburban commuters merging onto 495's helix so it could maintain its route through low-level Weehawken; where, by means of its wheezing pneumatics, the bus announced its Lincoln Harbor stop, lowering its chassis in mock reverence to the two men it discharged.

After stepping off the bus, David stopped on River Road's curb so that he could input *Lincoln Harbor Yacht Club* into his phone's map app; feeling his body jostle forward without consent, David watched a man pass him at the velocity of intent. And after having digested the offense with pursed lips and rolled eyes, David started

walking in the same direction as the disruptive man was heading; where, in between downward glances at his phone's map app to confirm he was on his intended route, David began muttering snarky commentary concerning the man ahead's striding stride and breezy swagger billowing through his oversized black duck canvas coveralls, despite David subconsciously aping those same mannerisms.

Byron Chianti felt eyes on him that were not his own. Turning around, he watched a man in lurking vicinity flinch into a frozen pose, as if calcified from the shame of his own motion. Byron continued watching the man behind him, the heat of his unblinking recognition eventually thawing the lurker into a spastic powerwalk across River Road with a hand raised against his face shielding him both from Byron's gaze as well as the oncoming bus that they had just exited.

Pushed air from that passing bus provided David with the unfamiliar sensation of the wind being at his back. Crossing Harbor Boulevard in a half-stepped jog, he found refuge behind a business foyer's tiled pillar whose mosaicked portrayals of Algonquin canoes, Tappan Zee purse-seiners, and war-effort triple tugs honoring those capitalist vessels that increased the property value of Weehawken's waterfront to its current prestige of a multinational investment firm squatting its headquarters on its harbor. It was only after waiting for what he estimated was sufficient time somebody would take to bore themselves out of surveilling a nobody like himself, only then did David peer out from the tiled pillar to find, through pockets of passing foot traffic, the man ahead's eyes still latched upon him. Seeing this, David entered into his bag of gestural camouflage: cuticles were inspected; earlobes pinched; hands shoved in pockets, he vaudevillianly rocked himself heel-to-toe. After a quick glance across the street confirmed he still hadn't shed the man ahead's gaze, David segued to light calisthenics, placing his right boot's heel atop a planter box mulched with crumpled, corrugated cigarette butts. In his effort to authenticate his dire need to keep limber during business hours, David leaned into his pose, stretching himself beyond comfort. There, protruding from his redwing boot's ankle flap, David clocked the folded corner of a performance improvement plan placed earlier

as hairshirt inspiration for his upcoming interview. Feeling a wince percolate, David turned his body way from the man ahead and toward the bank's blue glass exterior so that he could shield any leaking weakness from being revealed to the man ahead he had never met. At which point, and similar to a horror movie in which every television in a local electronics store's showcase window begins broadcasting the villain its protagonist had been fleeing, David watched the man ahead's reflection kaleidoscopically project upon each of the bank's gridded windows. David kept watching as a man shaped like a squished orb enter the window's frames; who after merging then uncoupling his image with the man ahead's in what David assumed was a handshake, pointed an outstretched arm in David's vicinity, as if confirming a hint to a hunt.

Similar to how prey paralyzes themselves to avoid a predator's instinct, David held his clenched stretch while hush-grunting so *fucking stupid* at his elevated right boot; his judgment based not only on fecklessly fleeing an interview he had just travelled two hours to take, first riding the Q line groin-to-groin with the hoi polloi, then queueing in Port Authority's low-clearance parking garage depot huffing rush hour exhaust all so he could hop on a bus over to fucking Jersey, four whole work units he could have spent in a Park Slope cafe grinding out disability disclosures and custom cover letters for that day's self-mandated twenty-five job applications but also due to the two-hundred-dollar vintage redwing boots purchased for the sole purpose of this interview, a complete and utter poser move if ever there-

A vibrating thigh shook David out of a trance spent staring at the sale sticker still stuck to his right redwing's tongue. He pulled his phone out from his basketball shorts' mesh pocket; it was his map app confirming he had arrived at his destination. After sheathing his phone back inside his pocket, David glanced across the street in time to watch the orbbed man flutter backhanded wrists in his direction as if shooin' a varmint. And as he watched this fat orbbed man open the marina gate to usher in the man ahead, David felt hope drain from heart to gut in a well-worn rut like a gully erodes into a dried gulch.

A gust from an approaching high-pressure system suddenly reversed the gate's shutward momentum so that it pivoted ninety degrees back open, its clang against the marina's retaining fence jarring David from his self-pitying stupor. As the gate began to waver back closed, another gust fluttered it back open again, as if anticipating David's objection that the distance was still too great for him to even try. Now filled with the belief that nature had become his bellhop, David sprinted toward the marina's gate, redwings clomping at every bound until one wedged itself between it and its jamb's coiled frillwork.

David clenched both safety railings as he descended down a bobbing catwalk sharply steepened by low tide. Walking atop a floating dock snaking with wake, he scanned each vessel's stern decal yawing behind crisscrossing stern lines — *Warrior Lush*, *Metis*, *Infinite West* — before he found his vessel, *The American Dream*, and with it, the man ahead, who leaned against the vessel's bulkhead, eyes and mouth agog in unctuous surprise.

- Hey uh howdy there sorry about all that back there just then I-
- That was back then. Now you're just there.
- Sure sure. Guess we're here for this influencer onboarding, huh?
- Guess you better board then.
- Yeah, I guess I sh-woopsies!

Just as David extended his boot off the pier with the rote familiarity of boarding a subway from its platform, cresting energy from an incoming tide yaw-yanked the vessel away from the pier so that what started as a simple step now demanded a leap of faith. And in a movement resembling a Jumpman or grand jeté on a planet with a higher gravitational force, David transferred enough of his balance across for his body to board, but not enough for his dignity to join him, his trail boot clipping the teak gunwale upon landing so that he fell upon the stern deck flailing like a still-green catch. Feeling his thud throb reverberate between his skeleton and the stern deck he now lay fetal on, David opened his eyes in a wince to find the man

ahead standing over him, eclipsing the mid-day sun as if wearing his own shadow, blonde bangs fluttering seemingly from the breath that had just been knocked out of him.

— You must be David.

As David's eyes squint flatter to determine whether the man above's tone indicated confirmation, inspiration, or accusation, a door slid open against the bulkhead's bumper, breaking the silence. Out its darkened entryway emerged a thicketed gut sandwiched by the two bands of elasticized cotton it refused; above, ochred teeth slowly revealed themselves in the disingenuous smile of a casting couch impresario who plum forgot double-booking that afternoon's audition.

— Permission to board granted, heh.

Captain Jim led both men into the vessel's salon by turning his back and leaving them outside. There Byron and David stepped into a room offering a head's worth of headroom and an arm's length of free movement — barely enough to keep their personal space but not enough, as both men soon discovered once Jim shut the salon door behind them, to keep their personal smell.

— Alright, alright, alright, so Cap... Byron wedged his flip flop into a recessed seam of one of the four floor hatches outlining the salon's grey-green carpet in the shape of a singles tennis court. — We here to fix up this neat yacht you got here or what?

— Fix?!... Captain Jim stopped to wipe scoffed snot with a bent wrist. — You millennials couldn't fix shit if you gave it an enema. Know why? Cause to fix something you first gots to know it. And all you millennials know is what yous was taught. Matter facts I bet you two chucklefucks can't even tell me why we named this here vessel the American Dream.

— Probably because a yacht is the ipso facto chef's kiss late capitalist symbol of decadent consumption inaccessible to the common man just like the actual American-

— Sure sure sure but it's also about repowering that decadence like how Van der Weyden lived through all that decadent medieval suffering so he could express a level of detail previously unseen by



man and so like similarly working on this here vessel the American Dream represents our collective parthenogenetic white wake as we head out to the endless hopeless late capitalist horiz-

—Fuck me Jesus...Captain Jim muttered as he straddled a corner of the portside floor hatch. Stooping to a three-point stance, he pulled a coach bolt burrowed in a patch of carpet, then deadlifted a floor section the size, shape, and weight of a wealthy man's headstone a foot off its frame. Where after briefly pausing to deliver a series of self-motivational grunts, Captain Jim raised the hatch from ankle to shoulder level to swivel it past perpendicular, then lean it at a ninety-five degree angle against teak trim framing the portside window.

—See this engine? Jim sputtered spent breath out a body bent over at the hip. Then, having mustering enough cardio to lift a hand off its knee, he grabbed a maglight from the salon's workbench so he could strafe its light across a refrigerator-sized engine block beneath their feet and nested beneath arcing throttle cables, braided fuel lines sheened in diesel, and exhaust pipes flaked with rust at every right angle. — These engines're why we named this bitch the American Dream. Shit it's whys we even gots a American Dream in the first place. Because see these Detroit Diesels won us a motherfuckin' war.

— Which war?...David snickered while watching a redwing boot kick alpine green paint flakes off the top of the port engine's heat exchanger. — Vietnam?

— Victory...Captain Jim shuddered with grit teeth. — Victory was not possible in that theater. You know you millennials sure are some dumb shits. I bet you two couldn't count your nuts twice and come up with the same number both times.

— We only counting nuts that hang Cap? Because I can't really speak for David here but-

— Matter facts your new boss Juug wanted me to tell you twos how this Likecoin influencer internship position constipates you somewhat differently than your conventionalized job but I think first you millennials need to learn a couple of three things about what America's all about.

The eyes David rolled toward Byron seeking sarcastic solidarity found blinks bat toward Captain Jim in rapt attention.

—Neat!

—First ting is that America's all about working ugly. See when we showed these Detroit Diesels off before D-Day, know what the Brits said? Said they looked bad, sounded worse, and fuckin' vibrated enough to make their nuns uncomfortable.

—They brought nuns to their military testing-

—David hush we're about to learn about what Captain's America's all about.

—Yeah well maybe looking at all these rusted dingleberries hanging off the engine's grundle doesn't exactly push my patriotic buttons.

—Think he means the oilpan Cap.

—See that's the problem with yous millennials. You care more about how things look than how they work. Matter facts you're just like the nazis. See the nazis, they built these sleek, highfalutenooogen engines for the war. Type of engine that tickled the eye's balls, sure, but when it came nut-cutting time, those brittle-dicked nazi engines wouldn't fuck unless you trimmed their pubes first.

—And for the record pube trimming is or is not standard maintenance on diesels?

—See back then America was smart enough not to let looking good get in the way of working well. But you millennials don't know that. All you know is how to lose and look good doing it. It's like your generation forgot that winning and working are on the same page of the dictionary.

—Know what Jim? If you think you're just going to compare me...David stopped to sniff and shrug his shoulders. —Hell my whole generation to nazis well then respectfully you know, you got-

—Got wha?...Captain Jim asked David with threatening enthusiasm. —Sumtin comin to me? Captain Jim only needed one step to enter into David's personal space, where he then lifted his heels as a means of burrowing the top of his skull into David's chin.

—And is that sumtin coming from you?

—Hey Cap how bout putting some distance between your face and my bud's safe space mmmkay?

—Got a bedder idea. How bout the tree of us head out to deep water and David can give what's coming to me out there? You know take this from zero to a hundred fathoms real quick.

—Capital idea Cap. How bout it David?

—I, uh...David's voice retreated into his backtracking body whose boot searched the vacated floor below for support. —Guggh...

Watching David backstroke the air to reclaim his lost balance, Byron stepped on his redwing boot's reinforced toe as a means of levering him back upright.

—I'm tellin yous, you millennials are just like the nazis. They couldn't handle the thought of being taken to deep water neithers... Captain Jim hlf-heartedly raised both palms in mock surrender. —Just sayin. See the nazis, they knew their highfalutenooogen engines weren't built to handle deep water because you see wha ha happens is all that chaotic chop out there scrambles the engine's egg so that instead of the exhaust farting out the manifold's poop chute it comes back through the engine's intake valves make it start hiccuping and choking like David here.

—Ok so did America figure out a cure for these deep water hiccups? I mean like did we engineer these Detroit Diesels to be able to drink from the rim of the oilpan or something? You know, asking for a friend's engine.

—See that's the ting...Captain Jim genuflected on the salon carpet and winnowed his maglight beam upon a circlipped lever protruding from the engine's fuel governor, its light throwing a debossed shadow upon the NORMAL and BATTLE MODE settings etched on the governor's mounting bracket. —Out in deep water, both sides were in the same boat chaos-wise. But while those Daimler dingoes tried to coddle the chaos with their whisper-quiet engines, America we went and conquered it, made it so whenever these Detroit's began

to gag a patriot could flip that there Battle Mode switch and flood the whole engine with fuel. See by turning the wick up and redlining its work rate make it so that there's no room for any gagging or hiccups to creep in so that the engine has no choice but to exsponge all the hot air inside.

—Yeah but I while doing some advance research for this interview I read that redlining a diesel engine you know pushing it beyond its limits can run the risk of-

—Run what risk? By running the damn engine? I mean fuck me Jesus son!

—I think what David's asking and frankly I myself am also curious about is when we all take this here vessel the American Dream out to deep water as you just stipulated, like do we have your permission to flip this here Battle Mode switch? Because I think that could be this real neat allegorical titty-pincher to start off our social campaign about how millennials can use Likecoin to flip the switch on taking their own American Dreams to deep-

—Yous millennials...Captain Jim rattled outstretched index and pinky fingers between the men. —I'm tellin yous, you're just like the nazis. Because see the nazis wouldn't push their engines without their captain's permission neithers. But guess wha? Instinct doesn't ask for permission. Know who said that son?

—I, uh, Patton?

—My daddy, right before he nuttet me inside some bitch he picked up in Dieppe. And see the only way he could get his dick wet on dry land was by flipping that there Battle Mode switch. See that's what yous millennials don't understand about the greatest generation they didn't ask anyone's permission to be great. They just went and took it by taking the action the moment demanded.

—Quite the origin story you got there Cappie!

—Yeah that's the third ting. America's about having a story. At least it used to be. But you millennials wouldn't know a story if you snorted it. Like you there what's your story?

—Cap, if you knew my work, you'd know my story.

—Fuck you know about work. You're a millennial!

—I know that work is the engine with which we propel ourselves closer to God.

—The fuck you know about God! Tell me the last time you heckled a gay or smeared shit on an abortion clinic's doorknob? Captain Jim sharply raised his palm in a reverse karate chop. —That's what I thought. Ok, so you there what's your story?

—Me?

—The fuck you mean, me? You're the only other you in the room!

—Ok sure uh, my story is, well and maybe it's just the osmosis of the moment being on the boat today but I guess my story is that I'm a socioeconomic Odysseus in the sense that-

—Damn it son I said a story, not some al-gore-called liberalature devicewith a bunch of metaoracle crap with fancy trimmings that ain't a story...Captain Jim addressed the mahogany cabinets he threw open as he grabbed a pint glass and a handle of Cadenhead Strathclyde thirty one.

—Want a story here's a story. Matter facts whichever one of yous is supposed to be the writer should write all this down...Captain Jim tipped the handle upside down for long enough that the scotch's sloshing surface came back level with the horizon.

—Story's about how my brudder Juug and I took this here yacht right out from under the dick of some millennial gagootz. See this gagootz, he bought this yacht to live on on the cheap. And so he brought Captain Jim on board to onboard him on how all these boat systems work. You writing this all down son?

—Yeah sure I uh, assuming two o's in ga-

—And when this gagootz comes out to greet me I see that he's wearing these flag pants. Now these pants were very tight-fitting you see and the ting was, this gagootz, he was uh, quite well built. Well built and wearing a pair of tight-fitting flag pants got all that?

—No sure yeah, I'm...David stopped speaking after clocking Captain Jim glaring at his right hand to confirm its progress.

—No damnit don't just fucking write the same words that I'm saying Christ I can do that!

—Don't think that's entirely David's fault Cap. On the bus ride over I took a drive by on his ThinkedIn profile says he's a copywriter so maybe verbatim's just how he's wired.

—You think you can do better? David tossed his pad and pen on the work bench as if he suddenly developed a debilitating allergy to them.

—Well, language isn't exactly what I consider an s tier creative medium, that said I did write the tombstones to my first show, so like my zero draft on this might be something like, like I don't know something like the patriotism of this millennial gagootz was only matched by his endowment.

—This one...Captain Jim's right hand formed, then shook, sideways horns at Byron. — Know what David, while you write this story you should also take some notes from your friend Bryan here on how to write it.

—Look is there a particular reason why we're lingering on that specific part of the uh, the gagootz because-

—His dick's essential to the story David. It's like one of those mcmuffin devices that those Hollywood writers all use. Anyway sos I hop on board and as we're leaving the inlet I begin giving the gagootz the basic captain broilerplate you know red right return right always has the right of way. But then this gagootz starts questioning me and all my infertile wisdom, squeezing my shoes about how to make these Detroit Diesels more egofriendlier and less pollutionary but meanwhiles this gagootz he doesn't know his primary fuel filter from his secondary.

—Yeah but that's why the uh, gagootz hired you, right? To show him the ropes?

David's question was acknowledged only by the silence that followed it; then feeling a soft supportive squeeze of his trap muscle,

he heard Byron whisper — Ropes are for fuck trapezes, buddy. On these here boats they're called lines.

— Thank you Bryan. And see worst of all was that the gagootz was talking to me all patronizational like you know as if he already knew what to do out in deep water without ever having done it. And so that's when I hailed my brudder Juug out on his submarine.

— Our new boss has a submarine? Well that's real neat!

— Yeah so I hail him on sixty nine and I says to him now David be sure to write all this like I'm in a movie ok so I says to him I says Juug psht how bout we take this gagootz to slip and fall school psht over and then Juug goes copy that psht damn it do I have to spell it out for you pee ess eigth tee!

— I think generally diegetic sounds are foleyed in and not actually written in the script but yes right there with you so after psht copy that psht then what.

— After about an hour the gagootz and I we start feeling waves begin to how do you say palpervate underneath the surface all sneaky like, like you know how if you slowly dump frogs into a pot of water, the water'll eventually boil? Eventually the port engine began gagging on its own exhaust on account of all the chaos Juug was making in his submarine below the surface I mean holy shit you should've seen the gagootz's face as the chop started teetertottering him in his captain's chair.

— Sure but that's when you helped the gagootz out, right? You know tell him about that Battle Mode switch you were just telling us about.

— Did the gagootz one better. Told him I'd go down to the engine room and flip the damn switch myself. Wha? You don't believe me? You can go check the case's affadavid.

— No need sir. A captain's word is the fiberglass bond of the vessel he commands.

— But see what wasn't in the affadavid was that when I went down to the engine room, instead of flipping Battle Mode on the port

engine I flipped it on the starboard engine you know like help out the engine that doesn't even need helping. And I mean you should've seen the gagootz's face when we started going round in circles like we's was some hooked tuna pinwheeling up to the surface one engine on the American Dream redlining while the other's dead in the water.

—Well maybe you can help David paint the picture of this gagootz's face for the good of the story. And if need be I can call in a couple courtroom sketch artists who owe my uncle chits.

—I remembers his eyes were all wet and glossy, you know like how a swivel shines when you got a catch coming to the surface? I remembers that because when Juug and I first started gentribuying properties off Frelinghuysen, he told me to look for glossy eyes on all the darkies we were evicting on account of how tough it was to see their faces after we had shut the lights off on em. And sos once wees started twirlin in deep water, I knew the gagootz'd be panicked enough to sign anything I'd put in front of him just like we did with the darkies back in the day. So right when I seenst the gagootz's eyes gloss up all shiny like a swivel, that's when I gave him this savage lien Juug had arthurized me to use and then all simply pointed this ballpoint pen at him as if it were like my poon.

—Think you mean salvage lien there Cap.

—Is that the one where some gagootz's butt gets so puckered out in deep water he signs the title to his boat over to anyone willing to save it?

—The very same.

—Wait ok so just so I'm clear on all this this millennial gagootz, he panic-signed his boat over to you and your brother.

—Yup.

—The same person who initiated the panic in the first place? I mean like can you do that?

—What do you mean can I do that? I did do that. The fuck you think I'm telling you the story for! Because guess what blow and behold the gagootz signed the lien, yep whipped his dick out and everyting.



— Wait what was that again, I-

— Told you the gagootz's dick was essential to the story!... Captain Jim smacked David's back with such resuscitative force that a pen heimlich'd out from his grip into the engine's bilge below. — Yeah see my brudder Juug takes the whole John Handcock thing literally. Here just take a look at this selfie I took at the savage lien signing ceremony the tree of us had out in deep water.

— Yep that sure is one deflated buoy. Now look, Cap... Byron placed one hand on Captain's Jim's trap muscle while he rubbed his other's knuckles against his nose's undercarriage. — Now I know we just met which means your business ain't necessarily mine at least not at this juncture but I gotta tell ya this savage lien swindle story of yours kinda feels too good to be true. And as someone who's currently in protracted negotiations with a number of talk shows and studios it's been made clear to me that the memoir market these days is more in the mood for stories that are too true to be good.

— The fuck you asking, son?

— Asking if you gave this millennial gagootz his right of redemption. Because last I checked a salvage lien holder can only legally seize the entire vessel in rem if this gagootz didn't remit payment for your time resources effort et cetera in rescuing the vessel.

— Look you'll have to talk to Canadian Les about all that. Alls I knows is after we invoiced the gagootz the fuel bill for the nautical mile Juug took his submarine to get over to me and the gagootz it was more than what the boat was worth or the millennial was worth, which I guess was more or less the same thing.

— Ok so you ganked this vessel out from under the gagootz's dick but what about the gagootz? Like what sort of opportunities are on his horizon after like having graduated from your slip and fall school?

— You's millennials... Captain Jim sarcastically wagged his head somberly. — I'm telling ya, you're just like the most famous nazi. Rather take your own life than take a damn life lesson. Yep the gagootz went and rigged his belt to the block and tackle right there where you're standing.

— Wait, here?

— Yous standing anywhere else son? Yep day after the summary judgment Juug and I came through to claim the vessel and I mean you should've seen this gagootz's face, it was the only part of him which wasn't swaying with the wake. I remember his beltless flag pants were all down at the ankles with a copy of the savage lien sticking out of one pocket and in the other there was some crumbled up plan to become this Captain Influencer and inspire millennials to live their best story voyages. And see that dead millennial gagootz's crumbled hope, that's how my brudder Juug got his whole Likecoin cryptic currency idea.

— Well seeing as you went from one dead millennial on board to two live ones, I'd say the vision's clearly working here Cap.

— Glad yous feels that way. Because your new boss Juug wants you two to hop down into the engine room and take a selfie so we can post how fired up millennials are working on this here vessel the american dream.

— On it, Cap! Byron exclaimed with the utmost unction before leaping down from the salon to land on the engine room floor in a frogged squat; and as if tugged by the gravity of Byron's motion, David sat on the floor hatch's exposed framework with both redwing boots dangling into the space below.

— The fuck you doing the okey dokey for son? You either in the engine room or you're out.

— Yeah so like before I join Byron down in the engine room and like start getting some grease on my elbows I uh, I'd like to loop back on my compensation question that I brought up in my email rep-

— Got a better question Cap. You got anything for us to work on while we're down here? Like maybe after David and I take our selfie we can turbocharge some of these pistons, you know get this diesel engine that's about what America's all about back firing on all cylinders after that millennial gagootz fouled em up all liabilically like.

— Fuck me Jesus you don't turbocharge the goddamned pistons, you turbocharge the goddamned air! Want some real work? Fine. Zincs need to be swapped out after running the genny from Key West.

— Cap. Did you just say zincs?

— Yeah so wha? You familiar widdem?

— A passing familiarity, yes. My dead dad taught me that they make fuses out of weak metals like zinc to protect the valuable parts in the circuit.

— Yeah same ting here. See all these engine parts are compromised of these valuable noble metals got your stainless steel in the prop shaft copper in the oil cooler aluminum in the heat exchanger and sos we screw these weak worthless zincs into all the noble metallated parts as a way of starving off the electrical corrosion. Come to think you millennials should think about making some titty pinching post about sacrificial zincs.

— Oh yeah? Why's that cappie?

— Just like these weak and worthless zincs are absorbing all the corrosion aboard this here vessel the American Dream you two millennials're gonna protect mine and my burddah's investment vessel all likewise and such.

— Not sure I follow Cap.

— Don't get smart with me. The zincs, they're self-reverential. They how do you say, equate to something larger. Trying to make it clear by using one of those al gore called liberalture devices.

— Much obliged for the mansplain Cappie. So where can David and I find these fresh zincs?

After rapidly frisking his sweatsuited torso, Captain Jim shifted scrunched lips to the side of his mouth for a sitcom-length beat; wherem, as if thunderstruck by his own solve, he jolted both eyebrows up along with an eurekaing index finger which then curled in its descent behind and below bending hips clearing for entry; where after several writhing peristaltic heaves, Jim pinched a nylon

inseam free from fupa; there the men watched a metal cylindrical turd tumble out of a diabetically-stretched ankle cuff and upon salon carpet the dull grey-green of overcirculated money, its rolled momentum encouraged by the vessel soft yaw from a flowingtide so that the zinc fell off the salon floor and onto the engine room floor where it rattled between David's Redwing boots to the sound of a pill plinking against a turning roulette wheel – a sound which was quickly accompanied by a snapped middle finger whose adjacent index finger pointed up at Jim in a pistol position to pitch —The hung gagootz who hung himself! How's that for a title to your story Jimbo? And then when this flag-pantsed millennial gagootz begins bitching about how there should be laws in America that protect him from your big bad savage lien we throw this wobbly focus past his shriveled dick and quivering grundle so it locks onto our neat new boss Juug as he steps off his Russian submarine to let this gagootz and by proxy the viewer know that he's not in America anymore because of that whole offshore loophole three miles out so like how bout it Cap?

—I gotta try and take a shit.

**flesh wheelbarrow**

Chaos, fate's yeast, the form of all matter as well as the agent of its forming, and that which we study in theory but suffer in faith, began its siege upon the vessel. A rolling wave softly jabbed the stern, squeaking stretching spring lines to the sound of birds heralding an encroaching storm. Behind it, a gathered swell crossed athwartship to generate a violent yaw that to the three men aboard felt as if a train's emergency brake had been triggered.

Wrenches floated. Cabinets twerked. The portside engine hatch, the size, shape, and weight of a wealthy man's headstone, teetered past its tipping point to fall back upon the salon floor's wooden framework framing two poking heads whose ducking bodies clenched themselves fetal in their fall upon the engine room and beneath the hatch's marrow-lacerating impact above them. Despite feeling tremors still shimmer between hatch, hull, and himself, Byron quickly got off his own back. As he stood, his head cracked the engine hatch open; feeling the hatch's fire-retardant undercushion scrape his scalp, he found Captain Jim sprawled upon the galley's parquet floor with his sweatpants' waistband pushed beneath his wrinkled ass's apex.

Byron knew a mammal's periphery is sharpest when threatened with death or humiliation, so he knew better than to keep watching Captain Jim as he wiggle-wallowed on the galley floor as a means of generating enough momentum to fully roll from belly to back; who, after staggering to his feet while tucking spilled flesh back into waistband, strafed his surroundings, found the eyes on him that were not his own, and bullrush toward them with flushed jowls the color of cured meat.

—Yous better watch your butts!...Captain Jim shouted down at the shut hatch's snickering carpet. —Matter facts think I'll keep yous twos down theres till Juug gets here.

—Hey come on Jim!...David pled up at the clatter and slosh of toolboxes and oil buckets being arranged on the patch of hatch directly above him. —Can't see shit down here!

—Let's sees if you can smell it.

Suddenly, the hatch cracked open to reveal a teal topsider beneath a grey sweatpant cuff stretched loose like undercooked bacon. Both men watched a grey ankle cuff ripple before the hatch's cracked crease closed, wafting Jim's flatulence along with salon carpet's fetid, foreclosed-roller-skating-rink odor into the engine room.

—Fuck's his deal?

—Fuck's your deal?

The triggered head David snapped in Byron's direction was met by a thrustured smartphone screen displaying search results for **“david engram portforlio”**.

—Fuck's that mean?

—Means you call yourself a writer, shit you're even posing with a goddamned typewriter in your profile picture here but then I go and look for your actual work and I mean holy shit dude there's Turkey Trot times on your first page of search results!

—So.

—So life's so much better when you live it as a verb instead of a noun, you know that right? Like I get it, you're well on your way to

being the greatest writer who never wrote. But don't you think it'd be a lot more rewarding if you you know became like that rare breed of writer who actually writes?

—Rather be the rare breed of writer who actually earns...David watched the face in front of him and illuminated by his search results turn concerned, as if a festering wound on his face had just revealed itself to Byron. — Yeah well guess what I searched you too. Checked out your portfolio site after cross referencing your b e underscore chianti email address on our interview confirmation.

—I know you searched me dude. Why else you think I went and searched you? See I instrumentated this neat api that notifies me whenever my name's searched across all these walled social gardens. You'll see that I'm kind of this neat funhouse mirror that way.

—Whatever look maybe I'm just not on your creative level ok like maybe not everyone has funhouse apis or some killer portfolio featuring a growling exhibit at ps one or whatever that meta-muerte motivational poster's of yours is about.

—Creativity isn't measured in levels, my friend. Only energy.

—Ok well then maybe I need a fucking spark...David seethed as he flamingoed his right redwing boot on his left knee to pick at the performance improvement plan protruding from its ankle flap. — Like maybe after getting fired time and time again for trying to become the noun you want to be eventually at a certain point you, you get too burnt out to even verb anymore.

—Know what's neat about diesel engines? They don't need a spark to start. Yep just fuel and pressure. And as far as I'm concerned I the pink mushy engines inside our noggins act in much the same-

—Know what? You can save all that homespun bullshit for the interview later.

—Dude. Do you even know what a spark is? Byron punctuated his question with a parabola of spit audibly splattered atop the engine bilge. — It's a handshake. Handshake between load and source. One side's got too much energy the other doesn't have enough, and

then they find some reason to connect. That's all all of it is, a difference in potentials. But see the only way the handshake happens is if a working load is placed on the circuit.

—So.

—So if you're actually serious about finding your spark how bout you and I get to placing a working load on ourselves and start fixing up these here engines on this here vessel the American Dream.

—Yeah ok sure. You want us to start working, even though we don't know if we got the job yet?

—The best way to get the job is to do the job.

—Yeah but we're stuck down here trapped in the dark.

—Best environment to see your spark.

—Yeah but did you hear Jim tell us how we're not going to get compensated for our work? The fuck is that all-

—I recall Cap telling us we're not going to get constipated for our work which considering how blocked you are creatively might be the best thing for you so-

—Dude honestly I don't get it. You're an artist. You of all people sh-

—Hold on there professor. To be clear, as an artist, I am all people.

—Okay then you should understand that like working for free or for likes or whatever is beneath people, that our work has intrinsic value which-

—Well no not really because see I created my first work for free and then that work then freed me up to do all my other work. So if you think about it working for free isn't so bad when you're talking about your freedom so like as a roundabout answer to your question about this Likecoin work being beneath me I'd say no not particularly.

—Ok well maybe I can't afford to be unparticular about my work, what with this traumatizing economy every time I check my savings account balance looks like a hijacked airplane's altitude the fuck are you doing?!



As David stooped down to shoo the two hands clutching his ankles, he felt his torso get turned up above him without his consent.

—Getting you off your high horsepower silly...Byron grunted as he sprung out his squat and elevated David's achilles to his eye level. —Nothing's ever beneath you if you're writing or acting, you see that right?

—Ok quite the inspirational titty-pincher dude now get me up from underneath this rusty oilpan.

—No sure but like I was thinking this flesh wheelbarrow we got going here's at the ideal angle to jumpstart this broken down Detroit Diesel engine that's about what America's all-

—The fuck are you talking about. We don't even have the keys.

—Man fuck the keys. Just take a quick peek behind the oilpan you'll see a big battery and the starter motor and-

—How bout you take a quick fuckin peek at the battery behind the-

—I can't.

—Why the fuck not?

David's heels picked up a shudder forking off Byron's shoulders.

—Because I'm supporting you silly. And considering I've got you in this compromising position you're really not in the best position to get me to compromise here.

—Fine fuck look I'll help you jump the engine but you better free me the fuck out from down here when we're done?

—Deal.

—I'd make you shake on it but considering the position I'm in-

—What did I just say? The spark is the handshake. Shitty listeners make shitty writers Engram, you know that right? Now I can see you're rolling your eyes good now roll them a little further back behind you where you'll see the starter motor ok now see the two red studs that're sticking out from the solenoid? Ok so take this flathead and lay the shaft on that big red stud so the tip like hovers right above the smaller red sender stud and-

— Look are you sure this jumpsparking won't ruin the engine? Because I can't really afford to fuck up a million dollar yacht, not with my commaless savings account.

— Ruin it? David's heels felt Byron's convulsing scoff off his shoulders. — How, by running it? Work is an engine's best maintenance Engram, you know that right?

— Why would I know that.

— Look all we're doing here is channeling energy that was meant to go to the engine in the first place. And actually if you think about it, jumpsparking the engine like this means there's less resistance in the starting circuit on account of how we're shorting the circuit that goes all the way up to the ignition and back.

— And you're sure this is safe? Like I'm using this metal screwdriver to channel power from this big coffin-sized battery meanwhile feel my neck getting wet from some puddle think it might be coolant or something

— Ok David, got me there bud....David felt his shins tilt with Byron's swiveling torso. — D.A. Urquhardt would squeeze my tasseled trial loafers something fierce if I put another battery splatter situation on her docket. Oh ho here we go. Knew this would be on a boat somewhere ok just slide this over the handle.

— What, this koozie?

— Yeah, that koozie! It's like the perfect prophylactic for the job. So again whatcha gonna wanna do is place the screwdriver shaft on the big stud because that's wired to the battery's positive terminal and then when you're ready, just tap the small solenoid sender stud with the scroogie's tip there. Now there's gonna be some severe arcing so you gotta make that connection with authority no pussyfooting as Brian Eno would say, or come to think he actually-

— Gah!

The whipcrack of a shorted circuit shot through both men's skulls as blue the hue of a new star lit the engine room in a flash.

—Hey now!...Byron pressed David's shins together to amplify a downward holler over the whirring starter motor engaging with the engine's flywheel. —Felt that in your cavity didn't ya!

—Great you can get me the fuck out from this running engine now.

David shouted in sarcastic monotone below the glugging peristaltic thrum of a diesel engine hunting for its idle.

—Hey those are some neat Red Wings you got here.

—Oh so that's your angle? Turn me upside down then gank my vintage boots right out from over me that it?

—Too bad they smell like someone else's sweat.

—Ok well get me out from under this engine and I'll be fucking sure to get to remedying that for you.

—No yeah of course but like I got this silly idea that maybe now's the perfect time to start putting your own sweat equity in these soles of yours you know pull yourself out of this situation by your own redwinged bootstraps instead of begging me, you know the guy who put you down there in the first place to get you-

—Dude are you gaslighting me?

—I mean if that's what it takes to like get you fired up...

After kicking open a nearby toolbox, Byron flicked his flip-flopped foot bare; where, having felt the bulbous carouselling metal of a dogbone socket wrench, he braced both of David's calves against his collarbones with one arm, clenched his core, then squat on one leg so that his free hand could grab the wrench from the prehensile foot clutching it.

—Damnit stop fucking around. The oilpan I can feel it's beginning to burn my chest.

—Don't fret I got you, boss.

—Don't fucking get me! Just get me the fuck out from underneath-

—From underneath yourself exactly that's what I'm trying to do here dude, like give you the spark you need so you're able to get off your own back yourself.

Byron twisted the pressure gauge off the starboard engine's primary fuel filter; instantly, the odor of burnt rotten eggs leadened the cramped room's air. Then after pulling a white bandana from his coverall's back pocket and threading it through the dogbone wrench's five-eighths and nine-sixteenths sockets, Byron dipped the bandanaed wrench into the filter canister's red font of fuel, touched the wad's dripping tip to his nose, third eye, both lymph nodes, and flicked his makeshift psalter down at David.

—The fuck is that? Is that fuel?!

—No, David. That's duende.

—Is that some sort of Mexican fuel because it damn smells like-

—I mean yeah sort of.

—Sort of?!

Still shouldering David's writhing calves, Byron felt an item cartwheel down his spine felt like his father's trickling fingers once did. Clenching his core and sphincter, he stooped down again to scoop up a piece of folded paper sopped in diesel.

—Think of duende as fuel for the fired, lubrication for your liberation that sort of-

—The fuck are you talking about?

—Well I mean that was the agreement, right?...Byron asked while flapping the soggy folded paper until it unfurled flat. —To free yourself?

—Man fuck the agreement!

—Ok but like aren't you tired of being held hostage to your own sense of victimhood so that whenever you're faced with some intense situation, your nuts always crawl back into your body cavity?

—Fuck you my nuts are only crawling back into my body because I'm ups-...Byron watched David glare pleadingly up at him like a marionette experiencing an existential crisis. —Dude, please! The pistons, I feel them through the oil pan they're-

— Hitting bottom dead center don't worry it's all part of the combustion process. Look I said I was gonna work to help you free yourself and one thing you're gonna learn right quick that Byron Chianti is a man of his work now my dead dad taught me you only need three things to free something stuck heat lubrication and leverage now you're already all heated yelling at me underneath this hot engine and that diesel you're wearing's got you lubed up which means all we need now is to find a little leverage. Now where the fuck is that switch that got Cappie's nuts all rustled?

With his free hand, Byron strafed his smartphone's flashlight above an engine still hunting for its idle. Finding the governor's NORMAL and BATTLE MODE etched on its mounting bracket, he placed his smartphone in his unhinged jaw, slid the koozied scroogie's shaft through the governor's circled circlip so that its tip wedged against the bracket's etched bevelled L; at which point, and in the manner of a slot jockey parenting a fussy toddler, Byron rebraced David's dangling lower half against his chest with one arm, then yanked down on the screwdriver's koozied handle with the other; immediately unrestricted fuel flooded the fuel rail and through injector nozzles to trigger a combustion crescendo skipping all rpm octaves in its passive glugging idle to an open-throttled roar upon which all six of its pistons pummeled David's torso beneath the oil pan at thirty eight downstrokes per second. And as he felt his redwing boots instinctively kick off Byron's shoulders, David did in fact feel free, suspended in disbelief that he had for once taken the action that the moment demanded — that was, up until a dipstick's curled hilt violated his falling ribcage at a sufficiently traumatic velocity to trigger his sympathetic nervous system into delivering the adrenaline, oxygenated dopamine, and motivational salience necessary to get off his own back and crab-walk out from the bilge on his own two fists.

— The fuck's your problem!

— Been burning some serious neurological calories on the same question lately Engram but seeing you down there just now I'm starting to think that my problem's actually your solution.

— The fuck you say?!

— Seems wild right? ... Byron smirked as he stuffed his soggy diesel bandana into the engine's airbox to shut it down within seconds. — But don't worry, you'll see.

— Damn it I can't see! ... David whined as his knuckles attempted to juice sight from eyelid rinds.

— But I did. Saw your spark come out from the blacks behind your eyes back then just now. Saw that gloss, that gleam, that unspent soul weeping from you at your moment of crisis like, why it was like Peter's eyes when Caravaggio hauled him upside down on the cross! See that gloss in our eyes it's called vitreous, and that's the fuel that keeps us going when we're burnt out like you are. Don't know if it's the fossilized bones of God or Satan, all we know is that there's an ocean of the stuff inside us just waiting to be used on our deep water story voyages.

— Then sail your own fucking seas!

— No sure I mean like I have that's my point like seeing your glossed eyes down there all trapped and helpless upside down reminded me of my glossy maiden voyage with vitreous. Now look I know what you're thinking but like don't worry I do have experience using bodily fluids as an artistic medium.

— I'm not worried. Why would I worry when there's no fucking way I'm about to indulge in whatever this, this eye fetish of yours is.

— Know what half of Brussels thought the same thing about Van der Weyden had an egg fetish after they caught him chasing breaching hens at dawn. But see they didn't understand that that's what the work called for, that his sfumato's transition between light and shade demanded a tempera with piping fresh yolk.

— I don't give a fuck if he fucked the hens. I mean I could've died down there!

— Well like not really because like did you know that vitreous resists death longer than anything else we got inside us?

— Why would I know that.

— Exactly see you and I we can help each other out. Like I learn how to stir that glossy creative spark you got in the back of your eyes that you like didn't even know existed until today and in the process maybe you'll help me figure out how to jumpspark my stalled brush I mean just think you and I two twin engines working together on the American Dr-

— You and I.

— Look don't get mad ok.

— There is no fucking you and I! Just like there's no sfumato no jumpsparking and no goddamned deep water story voyage.

— I mean sure like not yet but know how you told Cap you're this unemployed storyteller without a story to tell? Well like what better story is there than to take the American Dream out to deep water you know where the water looks like tarnished gold and become the swashbuckling hero of your own story voy-

— The fuck you call me?

For David, no word possessed a greater variance between private worship and public revulsion; a triggered body shot up from its crouch, its skull hitting the closed hatch above to rattle the toolboxes and oil buckets reinforcing their confinement.

— A swashbuckling hero now I know you think you can't rise to the occasion here... Byron paused to watch David listen intently as a way of getting closer. — But I'm super confident I can help draw it-

In a blink and still blinded, David lunged at Byron's throat, where the webbed skin between his index finger and thumb, that last part of our reptile selves, latched onto the first part of Byron's biblical self.

— Damnit why? Why turn me upside down baste me with fuel why trap me underneath a redlining engine then after all that why the fuck do you go and call me some swashbuckling-

— What do you mean why turn you upside down why baste y-

David's locked arm walked back the throat it held until it felt its attached skull thud against the generator's plastic shell.

— Why!

— You, you said you wanted a spark.

— Damn it what fucking spark? I mean what the fuck are you even-

With the twitch and motion of a duel-wielding gunslinger, Byron reached into both back pockets to fling a flicked flame beneath their knees with one hand while the other lifted a smartphone above their heads as it thumbed the autofocus off and the iso down.

— Now do you see?

A fluttering flame cauterized David's forearm hair as it revealed Byron's bugged eyes flitting toward their conjoined H-shaped shadow projected on the portside engine, auraed by squiggled air made visible by ambient diesel fumes.

— The shadow, that's the spark, you see that right? Wait wait wait maybe it's the spark is the shadow you're the writer so like which one's in active voice because like we don't want to have some passive tone for our first Likecoin post together don't roll your eyes hey-

At which point, and with the petulance of a bratty dragon blowing out birthday candles in front of the only friend who brought cake, David snuffed light and shadow with a nasal scoff at a pace the exact opposite of a snort.



Seeping light from above snuffed out the darkness David had just breathed into existence. There he felt neck webs bulge against his clenching palm, before watching Byron's softly illuminated face strain toward the sweeping plane of light as it he had suddenly turned photosynthetic. The opening hatch then cracked beyond its crease of light to reveal a backlit, baggy-suited silhouette who laid a crowbar to the side, squat on his haunches, and extended both hands down to the men as if an undertaker correcting a clerical error.

—Heard you twos might be looking for some upward mobility.

Unnerved by the pocky harmonics of two hands heartily clasping that weren't his own, David blindly pawed the air as he watched Byron leverage Juug's outreached hand to get out of the engine room until, turning back, he discovered the hand intended for him recoil at the speed of a prank.

—Smells positively carcinogenic down there boys. Like flesh being tested....Standing upright, Juug brushed fleeting creases off trousers the color of fresh concrete. — So tell me. What caused all this chaos?

— Don't ask me, I was taking a shit.

— Wasn't asking you Jim... Juug shut his eyes in a wince, then pinched a patch of forehead. — How bout you down there.

— Me?

— Yeah, you. The only one still down there.

— Uh sure see what, what ha-happened was... David paused to place all possible limb combinations on the salon's waist-high floor lift himself out of the engine room, each multipodal attempt splooting on carpet slicked by the diesel he himself dripped. — Byron and I were in the engine room to take a selfie like we were told but then this big wave hit us which triggered the hatch to-

— Yeah but like just when the hatch was going to scramble both our eggs I took the action the moment demanded and drugged David down into the dark engine room just in time.

— Well I must say as your twoses superior, I can't help but feel responsible. Jim take a lap around the marina and track down that wave. We owe it to both these boys to make sure it'll never traumatize them again.

— No look Mister Van Sant, the wave wasn't your fault see I was doing some advance research to prepare for this opportunity working on your boat and-

— Yacht.

— Yacht yes, and see I learned that things can get pretty chaotic during low tide which is probably what caused the wave to hit us like it did. So me my perspective is we just chalk this hatch kerfuffle up as a learning experience.

Byron watched Juug suppress a smirk through grit lips.

— That's quite mature of you, son.

— And besides that wasn't even the traumatizing part see after the hatch fell on top of us and Cap here sealed us in this manic fucker not only turnt me upside down without my consent, then he basted me with fuel before redlining the eng-

—Baptizing. I was baptizing him with fuel, sir. And there was a reason see I was trying to get David fired up for this neat intern influencer opportunity you're offering on board here.

—How the fuck does drenching me with fuel get me fired up?

—Well I mean like how doesn't it? Look sir you said it yourself in your email said you wanted an inspirational influencer that can provide fuel for the fired millennial and I mean just look how combustible David is right now.

—Didn't think you'd take my input so literally.

—No sure but then like later on in that grovelling email of yours you talk about how much you need me to help get millennials on board with the american dream and then when I get to the marina I see the vessel's named the American Dream I mean like no traditional nautical punning effort or nothing then some writer comes on board so like you tell me how it's my fault I took everything so literally?

—Understood. We can just swap David out and onboard another millennial that's a better fit.

—No no it's all good David and I are already helping each other out not only he jumpspark the engine he helped me learn that diesel is this neat great lubricant, I mean like look what slid out of him as we were working...

After watching Byron pull a sopping piece of folded corporate paper out of his duck canvas coveralls, David rapidly pat his short pockets as if they were infested before flamingoing on alternating legs and pick beneath ankle flaps of both redwings.

—This termination notice fell out of David and I think it's a nice like add-on to your whole Likecoin fuel for the fired metaphor in that Likecoin lubes up your psychofinancial flow state so your prior failures and firings slide right out of you just like with David here.

—Look Mister Van Sant I don't know what he's talking about. All I know is that he's fucking crazy turning me upside down-

— Talking about Baselitz upending his whole perspective with working men from dresden, talking about rendering swashbuckling heroes marked in failure and resignation that's what I'm-

— But just to be clear, what Byron's holding it, it isn't a termination notice, it's actually a performance improvement plan which yes eventually led to a mutually agreed upon parting of ways but I only keep on me as a reminder to track my focused time, to improve what was noted on the plan as needing impr-

— No it's a pink slip. See?

— Damn it that's only because of that red fucking fuel you were flinging on me!

— Sheesh, son... Juug winced with upturned palms, as if helpless to his own impending ruling. — I can't hire flammable people. Last thing I need is the state to start looking into my firing practices.

— But you haven't really even hired me.

— That's what makes this so difficult.

— Sir, if I may... Byron paused to press pistoled index fingers against lips. — Now I know I'm just an intern in your baby Likecoin subsidiary within the Juug Van Sant Family of Companies which means your business isn't really mine at least not yet but I do feel like I should mention that David here, he actually didn't really catch.

— Catch.

— Yeah as in fire. He's got no spark, see. Felt it firsthand myself. Couldn't squeeze the seed out of his own adam's apple if he tried.

— So?

— So I'm thinking why fire some burnt out millennial if you already know he lacks a spark, I mean shit those weak hands of his might as well be made of ash.

— Son. Did you just say ash?

— Yes sir, I believe I-

— Well why didn't you say so?!

— Duly noted, sir.

All it took was a quick upward flick of his wingtipped espadrille wedged between David's palm and salon carpet the pale green of overcirculated money for Juug to snatch David's suspended hand by its limp wrist.

—I tell you what...Juug shook his head as he kneaded David's hand. —Used to be you'd only feel a grip this fetal after a lifetime of labor. But you millennials, I mean I really got to hand it to you. With your generation it's like the lack of work that wears you down.

—You know hands how, sir?

Juug could only suppress his smirk on the right side of his mouth as he dug a cigar out from sportcoat innards the pale purple of clenched buttohole.

—So few things are handmade anymore...Juug said while raising the cigar to his ear, rolling it between fingers equally thick. —Cigars, predatory lending. See this Upmann? This Upmann's one of the last handmade cigars. See even though all the other cigar makers switched to rolling machines, Upmann stuck to his nuts, built himself an empire from his own burnt out hands.

—Hear that David? Upmann? Burnt out hands? Think it's a sign bud!

—No, not his own hands. His owned hands. His hands' hands to be precise. See Upmann went and taxidermied his sharecropper's hands, bound em up to create, how do you say like like a guide or-

—Like one of them handbooks.

—That's right Jim. A handbook. A handbook on how to beat the machines. A handbook to help predatory lenders like myself take on these big bad machine learnt mortgage brokers Christ modularizing the whole damn seduction of a sale into a goddamned funnel. Shook the ashy hands in the handbook myself when I visited Upmann's setup a few months back, you know they say there's no better inspiration for a job creator than a plantation.

—You just said you were a predatory lender.

—Can't have one without the other because see even after all the other cigarmakers replaced their human hands that did everything

with machines that did everything separately, Upmann kept his hands working.

— Shit sir that's downright noble of the man.

— Haven't thought about it that way son but Upmann probably did feel that positively medieval feeling of seeing people as your property. Matter facts I heard nobility once describe as having the wind at your back your entire life.

— The homeless old breeze, if you will.

— But see after Upmann raised the price of his cigars on account he was the only maker left who could sell his products as handmade, his hands for whatever reason started thinking their work had worth.

— Ok well what's wrong with taking pride in your-

— Wasn't their pride to take, son... Juug jabbed David's collarbone with the index knuckle banding the cigar. — That pep to their step, that gumption to their function, they embezzled that from Upmann. I mean shit that type of insolence wouldn't even occur to a machine.

— Insolence.

— Yes insolence! The hands, they got uppity. Started building themselves up instead of building up Upmann. See one of the hands went and taught himself legalese learnt their sharecropping contract stipulated everything that grew from Upmann's land was Upmann's. So then some of the hands began ganking dead soil from outside the plantation while the hands assigned to work Upmann's garden parties started picking up all the leftover cigar nibs and nubs to be mulched into the dead imported soil. Only took the hands three months to take their indoor outdoors. And damned if Upmann didn't spit out his cold brew julep on his fancy girl's titties one morning when he saw buds sprouting out from the ten gallon box planters the hands placed outside their hovels. Now even so, this play wasn't really any skin off Upmann's dick. See he knew that those ten gallon planters couldn't grow the type of girthily luxurious leaf that Upmann's patented fifty gauge cigars required. But those planters tobacco could grow a five-gauge cigarillo for the working man.

— Yeah didn't you say the handses cigars were only like an inch thick? You know like the size of these two millennial's dicks put together.

— Jim I only said some of that. But see Upmann didn't need any tiddlydick ten-gauge working man cigarillos. He just needed his hands to roll the same fifty-gauge cigar as a rolling machines did but could just enough of a veneer of humanity so he could sell his cigars at a handmade premium. So guess what Upmann did?

— Applaud the ingenuity, cut the hands into the fold with some sort of land lease crop rotation play like how craft beers distrib-

— Fuck no. Upmann went and changed the contract so that it stipulated whatever the sun hit was his. Thought that would take the handses uplevelling idea down a peg but damn if one full moon's night Upmann didn't spit his cloudberry julep on his mammie's aproned fupa as he watched his sharecropping hands began wheeling their crops beneath bright night sky.

— Oh ho! So these are moongrown cigars? Wow diggity that's pretty neat Mister Van sant, guess that's what explains your whole ashy hands kick you're on since the moon's surface is made of-

— No these aren't neat moongrown cigars. Know why? Because the law back then stated only banded cigars could be exported to be sold off the island. And since the hands had no land, that meant no band. And no band means no branding. But damned if Upmann didn't spit his boysenberry julep on his stevedore after being told his quota to Ybor City was being dialed down in order to make room for boxes of the handses working man cigars. See instead of making bands like everyone else, the hands went and crafted these mellifluous, effervescent cigar boxes handpainted with the stories of their struggle. So guess what Upmann did, son?

— Who, me? Why would I-

Juug picked the pinked paper off the salon carpet that he then dangled with a lifted pinky as if a damsel trolling distress.

— Oh because he fired them okay sure.

— Damn straight. Upmann went and burnt their whole uplevelling operation to the ground. Hovels and all.

— Put those hands out on their ass, I tell you what.

— Yeah but Upmann had to have destroyed his own tobacco crops in the process, right? Doesn't seem like some big brain move.

— No see that was Upmann's genius. He understood more than anyone else that true wealth isn't about yield, but delta. Think about it. What's the point of making money if you can't make more of it than the other guy? So he missed out on selling some cigars that year big whoop. It just meant that he was able to increase the wealth gap between he and his hands.

— Oh ho! Now I get your ashy hands angle! Just as burnt land sows more after a fire so do the burnt hands reaping it! Pretty slick Mister Van Sant. Prettay, prettay slick. Ok and so just as the hands and Upmann worked together to create that sustainable phoenix cigar you're holding so shall the four of us create the same upward mobility for millions of burnt-out ashy-handed millennials like David here-

— No. Fuck no. Upmann went and scooped up the plantation's ashes before his hands could use it.

— Wait. He actually did that?

— Well he didn't do it. He made his hands do it. Then he went and traded his big pile of ash for a coal scrip printing press so he could pay his hands to rebuild his plantation with more affordable money than before.

— You mean worse money.

— Yes worse money that's well put son. Like giving the hands the scent of earning without any substance behind it. Because see after Upmann's First Company Store stopped accepting cash the hands started losing the dignified fires in their bellies until they finally began producing the product Upmann needed all along....Juug paused to pull a cigar cap wilted by drool out of his mouth before



holding it at eye level in admiration. — The gumptionless cigar. Rolled with the repetitive focus of a machine, but with just the tiniest veneer of humanity so it can be sold as handmade.

— But how do you even know that it's han-

— See that ash?... Juug corralled David closer with his elbow's crook while pirouetting the cigar between them. — The ash didn't come from the handses phoenixing ashes. It came from the hands handling the coal scrip then rubbing it onto the cigars. See you can see it all on the binding along the shoulder seams there.

— Yeah but who even wants to taste ash? I mean I guess it's an acq-

— See that was Upmann's genius. He acquired that taste. Got the muckety mucks believing ash was some luxurious binder, that only in an Upmann could one taste human suffering in every puff. Then he got the local politicians believing Upmann was this big helping hand for the community after Upmann parceled his barren plantation over to his desperate homeless hands even went so fugazi as to accept their handcrafted cigar boxes as a down payment for their mortgages.

— Ok so he traded his burnt land for a bunch of boxes. Big deal.

— Huge deal son because Upmann had the vision to see those boxes not just as some cute titty-pinching trinket, but as a better way to tally taxes for the local politicians that were now on his payroll. See by that point Upmann was every politicians' wet dream. Not only was he the island's biggest job creator, with this cigar box mortgage play he was now its biggest housing provider. Meanwhiles the only thing his competition's housing are their goddamned rolling machines. Only took a couple legislative sessions to get Upmann's regulatory cigar box bill passed. After that Upmann had the whole damn cigar industry by the short hairs. Got to the point where Upmann shut down his plantation operation and live out his boyhood dream of becoming a bank.

— Sure but the ashy hands in the book, I still don't-

— Son are you my second wife? No? Okay then let me finish. The hands got all butthurt after they found out nothing was growing on the

plantation but Upmann's business. Something about how the paved parking lot dammed up the water that used to trickle down from the master's house and into the handses lowlands. But, and see this is part of his benevolent genius, Upmann gave his hands an out from thirty years of rolling leaves and making boxes on barren borrowed land. All the hands had to do is head on over to Upmann's First National and put theirs on the lobby's lopping block and they were free and clear to roll as many working man cigars wherever they pleased.

—Non-compete claws! Bet that's what Upmann called em eh Juug?

—And as I flipped through all those ashy hands bound up in Upmann's marbled lobby I got to admit my flag got a little unfurled thinking about all the burnt out millennial hands out there like David's that can produce that same veneer of humanity I need to beat these machine learnt mortgage brokers.

The smoke Juug pushed through his jutting jaw formed a noose snare in its waft against the salon ceiling. — Which is why, as Likecoin's first social sharecroppers, you twos will do likewise. Likes will be your leaves, content your filler, brotherhood your binder, as you two hands will roll me my gumption-less American Dream all within the confines of my walled Likecoin garden.

—Wow ok so like how neat is this Mister Van Sant... With one hand, Byron coiled a smartphone in front of Juug as he pat his sportcoated trap muscle with the other. — Like you go and tell us this whole stemwinding story about your cigar fetish without even like knowing that David and I have been rolling this whole time. I mean just check out these hopecore videos we filmed down in the engine room this first one's with that bright blue flash is fuck the keys start the engine where we show how Likecoin jumpsparks your financial engine then this next one flesh wheelbarrow got this wide-angle shot of David working upside down you know so much depends on a sweaty grundle with hardworking Likecoiners oh and then this last one you know that selfie you asked us to take I got David and I's conjoined shadow projected on the engine but it's only like partially developed because David went and snuffed out my vision during the all important moment of recognition.

— Yes yes yes this is just the type of go-nowhere do-nothing inspirational content that we need on the Likecoin platform. Nowtomorrow I got a potential foreign investor coming on board says he's a big millennial fan for whatever reason so I'm gonna need you two to pick something on this here yacht that's about what you millennials are all about.

— Sure thing boss. Mind handing over that investment prospectus you got there?

— You're an artist. Fuck you care about the financial ins outs and what-have-yous.

— Because curiosity fuels my creativity. I mean take David here, only way I could create all that hopecore content you just watched was by being curious about what he does and who he thinks he's about.

— Whatever. No skin off my dick. ...Juug blithely tossed a spiralled-spined mylar binder to Byron as if it were a chew toy before turning to David. — There an issue son?

— Me?

— Yeah you. The one watching your boot scuff the floor as if some other job creator's gonna come on aboard and tickle your balls better.

— No of course not obviously I'm fired up about this gumptionless human veneer vision you've laid out but and maybe this is just me personally but I'd uh just like to maybe get a little more visibility into you know the uh, compensatory specifics of the role.

— Son you'll have to be more specific.

— Just in terms of you know, whether or not this is a paid internsh-

— Of course it's paid...Juug's yapping chuckle bopped the cigar against his nose, its jarred ash falling on salon carpet the xanadu-taupe of old money. — Paid in the sense that exposure is a currency.

— Exposure dollars! Both millennials harmonized at atonal enthusiasms.

— I mean exposure's the one thing you millennials value more than money itself ain't it? It's why I created Likecoin as the first ever currency that recognizes recognition!

—Okay like initially I get paid in Likecoin but if I work hard enough at this internship could there be an opportunity for a permanent-

—Follow? Well if you outperform some key kpi's we can certainly consider that David. And shoot we don't even give those out to our salaried employees.

—Look I appreciate this opportunity Mister Van Sant, really I do, but the thing is to be honest I'm barely making it in the city as it is so I don't see how-

—Couldn't have said it better myself making it in the city is the american dream's all about for you millennials, ain't it? And what better way to make it than by making it on this here vessel the Ameri-

—No yeah sure but for me making it just means making next month's rent, and I can't really see how I can do that if I, if what I'm getting paid in isn't the same currency as what I need to pay out each month in order to surv-

—Son do me a favor...Juug asked as he seized David's trap muscle.

—Take a look out the window. See the big green bitch bout three clicks in the distance?

—Uh, where?

—Fuck you mean, where?! Jim reverse karate chopped the air. —You see another big green bitch out the window?

—Oh. The statue.

—That's right when the French sent her over to us, she had the complexion of one of Jim here's bowel movements. But after a few years of American-made exposure now take a look at her.

—Surface has got a nice thick layer of turd and grease.

—See that's what exposure does to you in this country. Makes your whole being green. Now are you going to let worrying about a roof over your head stop you from this exposure opportunity?

—Ok but I mean...David anxiously segued his scratched scalp into a scraped nape. —Maybe if we used those posts Byron just showed you as an example of the earning potential here, you know so I can get a sense of the exchange rate between Likecoins and actual money?

—Look son going rate's a penny an eyeball. Now I'm already running late for a check-in with myself so if you think getting paid with old-fashioned fiat is gonna get you ahead in this country so be it; Jimbo! Hand over the bag we were gonna pay our blockchain dev with before he selfishly self-disappeared.

Like a sumo wrestler battling jock itch, Jim lifted alternating legs as he dug into his sweatpants' pockets; then, pulling out a bag of pennies, he tossed it at David, who caught its topknot warm to the touch.

—If it's all the same sir I'd prefer to get paid in Likecoin. Only way we get this country back to greatness is if millennials like David and myself stop selling out to our own individual ambitions and start buying into the collective vision of job creators such as yourself.

—Glad you feel that way. But you two are a package deal. See you're the one who millennials want to be. But your burnt out friend with the ashy hands? He's who these millennials really are.

—Oh come on David! Puh please please?

—Before I give a definitive answer either way I, I think I should check my email as I do have a couple other employment irons in the fire as it were so to speak.

—We're all here waiting...Jim muttered — With bait on our breath.

David pulled his phone out from mesh basketball shorts, tapped open his email app, then tugged down his inbox to refresh its client. There he watched the ouroboric sprite on his screen chase its tail in its search for any communication he could plausibly latch his hope upon: a creative director following up on his follow-up, a boilerplate solicitation from a recruiter, even a no-reply notification that someone — anyone — had viewed his professional profile. And as the screen's footer flashed **“downloading 1 of 1”**, David felt the tingle of hope rise inside his spine until the subject line **“Byron Chianti wants to be friends with you”** burrowed into his inbox, at which point David clicked his screen closed, swallowed hard to push back down dignity yearning to breathe free before finally sighing in resignation.

# 5

## job as job

More than the petty lengths David travelled to deny the acknowledgment of his existence — scraping his nose against the narrow galley's bulkhead so he could shimmy past him with his head turned away; lifting the toolbox Byron was using as a footstool as he read the Likecoin prospectus in order to pose-browse its tools as if loitering in an airport bookstore; and, worst of all, unthawing the hot pockets Byron had left on the galley counter while he was in the head taking a shit — what Byron noticed most about David was his work. And more than the outcome of that work — Byron softly shook his head as he watched David horizontally suspend himself a foot above the engine room floor, raised calves pressing against the starboard engine to thrust kegelling energy through his torso and locked arms into clenched hands gripping a pipe sheathed over the port engine's seacock's ball valve in a feckless attempt to move it clockwise from its nine-o'clock seizure — what intrigued Byron was how David approached his work.

It was a whole ritual, one which David initiated by initializing a smartphone app that, from Byron's vantage point, looked to be an egg timer rendered on some kind of red produce. Then after slipping his phone back into his basketball shorts' mesh pocket, David would visibly anchor his breath within a bellowed ribcage, place the butts of both palms into his eye sockets, and slowly wipe his face down with stippling fingers. Then and only then did David begin work, entering the engine room by way of sitting down on the salon carpet and cautiously butt-waddle himself off the hatch's ledge until he arrived at the safest fulcrum to fall into the engine room below. Once in the engine room, Byron watched David work earnestly for roughly half an hour until a muffled ding reverberated through the fiberglass hull, triggering David to climb out of the engine room and spend a short work break bothering Byron by standing idly in his direct line of sight looking unbothered, his petty dawdling ceasing only after hearing his phone ding again, at which point David tapped his phone's timer, wiped his face, butt-scoot back down into the engine room, and begin work anew. But what held Byron's attention through what was now David's fourth work period wasn't what he failed in doing, but rather what he failed to do; that is, not once while in the engine room did David pull out his phone to check his feed, calm an alert, forward a meme, glance a reply, or share an update. Wondering that maybe David's discipline was untested, that man is only as focused as his social options, Byron opened his Likecoin app to send a reminder of his outstanding friendship request. And as he heard that request reverberate through the engine block — but fail to break David's plank-hover posture — Byron began strafing an activated zippo's flame over a frozen hot pocket schemingly slowly, like a villain stroking a cheshire cat.

Having heard that same ding muffle past his shorts' mesh pocket, and only recently having conditioned himself to recognize the haptic nuances between the ding of a completed work unit, the thwong of a received email, the bloop of a received text, and the vibrating chime of some ridiculous social media request, David unflexed his focus from the seacock. And after wiggling the pipe sideways off a ball valve still

stuck in its horizontal position as if an imperial thumb administering purgatorial judgment, David pushed against the prop shaft so he could shimmy out from the cramped space backwards on his belly. Sitting on his heels in a kneel, he reached at the redwing boot behind him to pull out a piece of folded-over paper from its ankle flap; then, after having tallied his fourth work unit on his pink-stained performance improvement plan, David pinched his indented palm then realized the seacock had made more progress moving him than he, it.

—Has anyone ever said that the way you work is fascinating?

David glanced up to a frowning face above him nodding dastardly, squinted to sift Byron's tone, then spat in the bilge.

—No one's ever said anything about my work.

—I mean the way you're knuckling down on the seacock there is pretty inspiring not gonna lie.

—Look I just set this timer on my phone to twenty-five minutes and work until the timer tells me not to. It's not a big deal.

—I mean yet it isn't...Byron blew on the steaming meat pastry as if coaxing an ember. —Like I'd say your whole ding thing is pavlovian but I mean holy shit at least the dogs fought against their learned response every so often.

—Maybe I'm trying to learn a learned response, ever think of that?

—No...Byron jut his lower lip as his frown deepened. —But now I am.

—Look it's called timeboxing okay, goes all the way back to Ben Franklin not like I invented it.

—Sure sure so you ever use this timeboxing thing to you know start a revolution, fight for your freedom that sort of thing?

—No.

—Got it. So you're doing all this just so you can free the stuck seacocks of these rich fogey fucks for wha, some bag of pennies?

—Look you heard Juug. We need to present some show-and-tell titty-pincher about how something on this here boat the American Dream is about what millennials are all about for his investor



meeting tomorrow Christ as if the totality of our generation can be reduced to a fucking middle school metaphor.

—Sure, but the seacock? A little too on the dick bub don't you think?

—No see I was reading the engine manual and I learned the seacock keeps the engine from overheating by like sucking up the sea water it creates this constant cool flow state inside and so like you know how our generation's known for being cool in terms of setting the cultural discourse well I was thinking-

—Not sounding like that we don't. Ok so like your main slide here is what, millennials suck but in ways that keep everything cool that it?

—No that's not how I'd characterize-

—I mean look Engram I'm all about championing the importance of flow state to our Russian magnet investor as it pertains to bilateral trade policies, but we can't champion shit if this seacock concept of yours is stuck shut.

—Fuck you think I've been trying to do down here?...David said as he clenched the vessel's stale air with both fists. —And besides where the fuck is your titty-pinching millennial metaphor?

—I mean it's tough, no doubt... Byron squat on his haunches so a coiled finger could flick a wintergreen paint fleck off the engine's heat exchanger. —Cap said it himself that this Detroit Diesel's what America's all about but then like where do we fit in? Sure as shit ain't the governor cause we'd distribute fuel a little more liberally than that fat fuck Punt up in Trenton. Could be the pistons, they do all the work plus they're all confined in this tight liner like you can make the connection to millennial housing situations cooped up basements efficiencies what have you but then like pistons are actually recognized as being an integral part of the engine.

—Yeah plus the next time someone says that millennials are integral to the economy'll be the first.

—Not to mention filming that sort of piston tittypincher means not only taking the head off the engine block but also detaching all the fuel lines fucking flat drench us in diesel.

— Yeah can't have that...

Byron's snapped index finger pointed at David in its downstroke. — Which reminds me you should really think about tossing some fuel down the snout of that stuck seacock you got there. Because I mean sure you got all that leverage but that's only one part of it, it's like my dead dad used to say doesn't matter if you're freeing it or fucking it you need three things heat lubrication and leverage now you got the heat of work with that process of yours and I like how you're getting more leverage with that pipe you're putting over it but you're still lacking that last shot of lubrication to jar it all loose.

— Look I'm sorry to hear about your father whatever happened there but I'm not sure how-

— Wait wait wait wait wait maybe that's what millennials are, we're the fucking fuel on the American Dream! I mean think about it we're easily combustible, plus we're not like part of the system we're a resource the system consumes kinda just like how you've been complaining about being used in this late capitalist economy. Best part is it ties into Juug's whole spiel about Likecoin being fuel for the fired millennial, and and since you already smell like diesel we can make this be like some extrasensory tittypincher for our presentation tom-

— Damnit stop!... The steel pipe David tossed into the engine bilge ricocheted rastafaringly between the different noble metals comprising the prop shaft, sea strainer, and stuffing box.

— Stop what? Me brainstorming neat ways to help us out?

— Damnit there is no us to help out now look I, I don't exactly know what your game is here but you need to understand-

— Oh you don't do you? And what game is that Engram? What precisely don't you know about the nature of my game?

Having hoisted himself from the engine room to the salon floor in a frogged hop, David pulled out his phone as he rose to his feet; there he shoved a screen stacked with friend request notifications into Byron's direct line of sight.

—David I believe a millennial's net worth starts with his network. And just as rhizomes bind together as a means of sharing resources beneath the surface so shall the connections we make on the Likecoin platform become our underground path to generational wealth.

—Know what I believe?...David flung his phone into the top inside half of an open toolbox so that it toppled backwards and shut upside down in a clatter. —Or what living in this goddamned city has forced me to believe? That with all these failings and firings we, we fall through people too fast to become friends. And that these social media networking friendships you think are so fucking neat have no real value no connection no collaboration all they are are these participation trophies that these rich fucks give the rest of us to keep us on the sidelines while they're out there playing to win.

David watched Byron look at him with the concern of a medical professional evaluating a wound.

—Friends aren't trophies, David. They're mirrors. Mirrors that teach our souls how to grow.

—So that's why you friended me. You think I have a stunted soul.

—No just like that maybe a friend can like point out blind spots in where you may be a little flabby production-wise in terms of your writerly body of work now look don't get mad okay?

—Damn it I'm not mad. I... David involuntarily recoiled his jaw to choke back a percolating gag. —You, you don't think I've tried? Dammit I've tried. Why you think I started this cockamamie timeboxing process in the first place? Thought I could scale the ten thousand hour genius mountain twenty five minutes at a time but then when I actually sat down at the typewriter I, it was like I couldn't shake the feeling I was writing off my back foot.

—Oh ok so like passive voice.

—No not like passive voice like having no voice at all, got so desperate I started kneeling at my typewriter before every work unit praying for something interesting to write about. Christ, how cringe. Then guess a couple weeks ago as I got up from kneeling I kind of came up out of myself realized what I was doing it, it wasn't for

anyone's benefit not even my own and all I was doing was like boring God with some navel-gazing titty-pinching story simply to satisfy my own pride. That's when I decided writing wasn't really even worth doing.

— But see that right there's your problem. Instead of praying for your art, you should you know like prey on it. Like murder and create, creative destruction that kind of thing.

— And what's there to fucking destroy?! I own nothing, am worth less, and all I got going for me are these two ashy hands... David swiveled clapped hands in the manner of a blackjack dealer wrapping up a shift. — Shit whole damn soul like like some cartoon character's still-standing soot after being blown to smithereens in this economy so like you tell me what's there to destroy?

— Yawn.

— The fuck you just say?

— Yawn. Yawn dot com slash login dot ay s pee ex. That's the site I'm seeing right now dude.

— Whatever, dude.

— See that? That right there's your problem. Your eyes. When you roll them you're unable to look at your life squarely, you know that right? Ever think that that's why you can't see why God's bored with you?

— You tell me. You're the fucking mirror.

— Me my view of it is that you're a victim. I mean you're not but I can see that you see yourself as one. And you know why victimhood is boring Engram?

— Yeah yeah because it's solipsistic. Everyone's got some trauma to take care of just like every day is someone's birthday.

— What? No. Fuck no. Victimhood is boring because it is sinless. I mean like why else you think God gave all his books to sinfluencers?

— Plenty of virtuous characters in the Bible Byron.

— Talking about vitreous, not virtuous. Don't worry I get same-sounding words confused too but since you're a writer you should probably get on top of that. So like here's a good way to remember the benefits of vitreous like you know how the tax collector's like the least virtuous character in the Bible, right? Well just head over to Brancacci Chapel and see that green-cloaked shylock's eyes brimming with vitreous flat glossed with greed in the face of Christ then you'll see that that's the kind of dude that can make God nod.

— Well good for God.

— Damnit Engram I'm not talking about God... Byron hushed with clenched eyes. — I'm talking about you. I mean the Bible, that's like the world's most popular book. That's because people read for two reasons, at least I do to learn and have fun. And see sin does both.

— Look I just told you I don't want to write. I just want to do my job and for once try and work my way up-

— You mean do your internship.

— Dammit you know what I mean.

— Sure I mean kinda do but I kinda don't because since I've known you you've been super focused either on how badly you were victimized in your last job or feeling all defeated about your future job prospects but like ever think that you already have a job? And like maybe that's why God's bored with you because you're not really working the job that He hired you to do.

— What?

— Like ever think that maybe your job is Job? You know the story of Job right?

— No.

— So this guy Job gets cosmologically fucked with even though he's all blameless and upright just like you say you've been and-

— Yes I know the story no I don't think God's calling me to rehash some fucking biblical yarn.

— No I know but-

—No I know! I'd fucking know Byron! I'd fucking know if I'd been called be, because no one fucking has ok! And they haven't for over a year.

—Exactly that's my point this is just like the story when Job whined to his friends about his sores just like you're whining to me all sore about your job situation. But see Job's friends wouldn't let Job see himself as a victim, even if God Himself was the One doing the victimizing. Because they knew. They knew the only way Job would be able to live it through is if he kept his pride, you know his sin. And in like doing so Job's friends became this like healing mirror for Job because they showed Job that by that point all those sores he was bitching about weren't coming from God's given affliction but because he was still scratching them with idle hands. And that if Job would just like nut up and get back to working righteously you know like get some sweat on his sores they'd eventually scab into callouses then over time his callouses would scar over so that Job would have this neat distinguishing mark he could look at with pride for the rest of his life you know as he wistfully remembered the time he rode out God's wrath. And guess what guess what dude because Job listened to his friends and kept on working righteously, God never got bored with Job yep He always kept tuning in to the Job show, and to show His gratitude guess what Job got in return?...Byron flicked a backhanded wrist at David's flinching ribs.—Got his own wisdom book.

—Appreciate the sinfluencing lesson Byron. Certainly got a lot to chew on as I head back down into the engine room and try to finally fucking free that-

—Dude you are so missing the point. We don't learn from sin. God does. I mean like sin is how we make God self-aware, you know that right? But see here's the thing, God can't learn from you, can't turn your page if you've already closed the book on yourself.

A head lifted at the speed of a triggered projectile conked the eraser end of the oil cooler's pencil zinc, cleaving it flush off its threads so that it fell to the engine room floor to rattle between David's redwing boots to the sound of a rolled die.

—And what fucking book is that?...David barked as he rose upright, rubbing the top of his head with the technique and rate of a man desperate to start a fire on his own scalp. —Tell me the precise fucking nature of the book I'm closing on myself!

—Ok well like I know you haven't even opened Likecoin's investment prospectus Juug gave us as inspiration. Because if you had you'd see how it's all right in front of us I mean like look here on the front page where it says how content is king on the Likecoin cryptosocial platform that means you right since writers are the world's first content creators ever since before the Bible.

—Why are you even reading that. Likecoin is just a fucking pyramid scheme, you know that right?

—Actually see it more as a triangle Engram because like look at this diagram here where it says just as content creators earn Likecoin based on user's attention spent on their posts, users earn Likecoin based on viewing ads attached to that created content and then at the top of the triangle between the two you got advertisers earning better roy on their media buys I mean you said you were in advertising right?

—It's not roy it's, it, actually it doesn't matter what it is because-

—Ok so I'm learning see you and I, we can-

—No you're not! You're not learning because there is no you and I!

—Sure I mean not yet but like if we become these two great friends who start inspiring our fellow millennials with our-

—No not ever! Can't you see that none of this is about inspiring millennials? That Likecoin is just the same goddamned grift in a different garment? Just another shady way for those who have the most to get even more? And that the two of us pitching this dipshit crpyto to our fellow millennials is like pitching some neat new whip to our fellow slaves.

—No I know that's what I'm getting at like see where they put all this language about how Likecoin was built to build up millennial equity but we both know that our boss Juug is really banking equity into some other shady investment on the side.

—So.

—So I'm thinking we do the same thing from our side of the Likecoin ledger you know like we create all this hopecore Likecoin content for Juug but on the side we'll be off banking equity in our shadow narratives like remember when I showed you how shadow's your spark? Well we can use the light from our Likecoin recognition to amplify that spark into this fire that touches our vitr-

—Banking equity in our shadow-

—Look don't get mad ok.

—How can I not get mad? Christ, how can I not go mad? With with with your manic rambling about story voyages and shadow sinfluencing but then whenever our neat new boss is around you shapeshift into this, this fucking fawning obsequiousness!

—Ok well I'm like supes frustrated too I mean I'm like burning some serious inspirational calories pitching you all these different ways to jumpspark your shadow but you choose to roll your eyes at like every opportunity.

—Damnit why are you acting like I'm choosing all this?! Because I'm fucking not ok I'm not choosing to roll my eyes, I'm not choosing to close the book on myself, I'm not choosing to free some rich fuck's seacock... David pulled out the plastic bag of pennies from his shorts by its topknot. — And I'm sure as fuck not choosing to work for goddamned pennies! He tossed the bag at Byron's feet with a halfhearted shortarm so that it landed on the salon floor's open ledge where it rested for a dramatic beat until incoming ferry wake yawed the vessel and topple the bag off the wooden framework and onto the engine room floor, its impact freeing its contents to the sound of a just-won jackpot.

—No but see it doesn't matter what you choose when you're chosen. Like Cappie and Mister Van Sant, they could've chosen anyone for this intern influencer job but they chose you and I for a reason just like God chose Job and Job's friends for a-

—Yeah you know why? Know why they fucking chose us? Because we're replaceable.



— Well that's just not true David.

— I mean maybe not for you because you and your sniveling your social following all that's integral to this cockamamie Likecoin enterprise. That's because you're who millennials want to be. But see I'm not you. I'm who they really are. Which means if I try to sinfluence on the sly or bank some shadow equity in myself know what'll happen? Jim and Juug will replace me with another millennial slave just swap me out like, like... David kicked the sheared zinc, scattering the smattering of pennies across the floor.

— Like Jim's grotesque zinc demonstration!

— Showing his ass, yes...

— Which by the way you said you'd handle. Told your neat new friend Captain Jim that you're just the man to swap these sacrificial zincs out since dead daddy dearest taught you all about how nobility works ok so instead of riding my ass about what I'm working on how about you just fucking focus on-

— That's it. David, you beige bitch, that's fucking it!

— Fuck you that's what.

— The money in the mouth of the fish! Quick hand me some of those pennies scattered down on the floor there.

— Nope those are mine. You chose to get paid in Likecoin remember?

— If the king takes tax from the conquered then the sons are freed, you know that, right? I mean holy shit Engram don't you want to be a son to this country and not a slave?

— Sure who doesn't but I don't see how these pennies will-

— Oh ho! So now you're interested in my vision? Well then start reading off the mint years on those pennies down there.

— Fine probably need to pick them up anyway so that they don't clog the bilge pump I uh, here this one's kinda old think the year's twenty six or-

— Toss it.

— Ok this one might be interesting, looks like it's double stamped.

—David do I look like the Salon des Refuses? No? Ok so don't tell me about the impressions, just read the goddamned year.

—Fine it's a nineteen sixty-

—Toss it.

—Okay well looks like the rest of these are all newer from like the eighties and nineties so either get a little more specific in terms of what you want or-

—Want the whole damn bag Engram...Byron monotoned as his forearm swept the work bench clear. —So do me a solid after you scoop up those newer pennies go and toss me that propane canister along with that vice grip down there in the toolbox.

—Oh ho so that's your millennial titty pincher, you're gonna burn these pennies to get them fired up just like me taking that selfie in the engine room that it?

—Not burning...Byron sandwiched his work into his voice, stacking the snap of a vice grip's corrugated jaw finding purchase on penny ridges, the click of a turnt ignition dial, the clack of a torch's pulled trigger, then a dallopped roar of freed propane. —Galvanizing. The first turn of the screw pays all debts, you know that right?

## microfailures

Juug cupped his hands in order to shield Ben Franklin's crisply undercirculated face against onshore wind the strength of an invisible hand brushing tears off a whiner's cheek. Holding the bill was a slender man whose sharkskin suit camouflaged him against sky the color of fresh concrete until light from a flicked flame sheened him iridescent. And as he watched the flame find purchase upon the money, this man in the sharkskin suit clacked an emerald lacquered zippo closed against his hip, placed a yellow American Spirit between lips moisturized by caviar oil, and with puckered smirks, sucked heat off the smoldering currency, hastening its transition from cash to ash.

—Go ahead pick any one of those buildings across the river there and tell me where its shadow is located? That's right, the ground floor. That right there's the opportunity I am presenting to you-

With one arm and in one motion, the man in the sharkskin suit waved off Juug's pitch while waving in a man with a lens around his neck who had been lingering in servitude's vicinity. After genuflecting on the boardwalk's herringboned concrete, this man with a lens

around his neck threw his focus between the backdrop of Midtown's skyline of tax shelters and a foregrounded flame forking off the money both men held until his focus locked in on the empty smiles of privileged men whose ebullience only spurts in their documented proximity to burnt fiat, game carcasses, and well-worn pornstars.

Having blessed the image shown to him in the DSLR's lcd monitor, the man in the sharkskin suit entered the marina with Juug, Jim, and the man with a lens around his neck in tow. There they woozily walked down a jostling catwalk sharply steepened by low tide – a consequence of Captain Jim consulting his tidetables before scheduling the meeting so that his brother would make his entrance with the most gravitas possible. Like a wrestling heel entering the ring, Juug twirled his torso in his descent down the catwalk, thrusting both index fingers at the dilapidated, single-use brick buildings surrounding the marina as if pointing out rubes in the crowd. Playing the role of the heel's weaselly hype man, Captain Jim rushed ahead of the men in order to pull the vessel's stern line closer to the finger pier as a means of easing his brother's entry.

Hearing the salon door whoosh open, Byron and David turned to watch Juug step inside, flit down his aviator sunglasses, and reveal eyes squinted into slits.

—Welcome Likecoin investors. We've got the mettle to meddle with-

—Your metal yeah remember you telling us about having some important russian magnet for your meeting? Well David went and thunk up this neat promotional banner see he said there's something about the whole Russian punning tradition that transcends-

—I can see you're still chewing on the line sir so also want to let you know I've got some strong alts we can comp out real quick Byron's actually a pretty strong one-stroke calligrapher so it's not that big of a-

—Jim.

—With pleasure...Jim's arms threshed the banner into tatters with several puerile rotary swipes that quickly transitioned into wild flails in their attempts to break free from the tangle of blue painter's tape joisting banner to ceiling.

—Hey!...Byron objected in a deep muffle.—We were gonna use that for our influencer portforlios!

Juug stepped to Byron seated at the work bench, stooped, then sniffed; after a sitcom-length beat, Byron cough-burped out a plume whose density suggested a genie's impending arrival.

—Excoose me.

Having successfully ducked most of the billowing high pressure system approaching him, along with Byron's dainty apology for it, Juug stayed bent at the hip and maximized his posture's yield to examine a work bench strewn with pennies stretched oblong like souvenir tokens. After a review consisting of a sneer and a snort, Juug bowed up, torqued both wingtips on carpet the pale grey-green of old money, and twirled toward the salon door.

—Step right in to Likecoin's first selfie studio my friend. Boys post up over to the wet bar and whip up a dividend for our guest here.

Seeing no progress on his command but a shared shrug, Juug sharply inhaled while slowly bisecting his torso with a flat hand pointing skyward.—Cliquot with a splash of vodka...Juug seethed through bared teeth. —And a dash of bitters!

Then, in an attempt to reset his psyche, Juug pinched both crowbar cufflinks with opposite hands as leverage to shrug a fresh fall off a sportcoat the ruby red of chapped butthole.

—Now sir, I don't know how many properties you own in America... Juug paused to raise thatched fingers to serve as an altar for chin folds.—All I know is that you haven't taken a shit in any of them.

—This metric is how your country evaluates potential investors?

—No no sir just my way of praising your investment acumen. See we both know that when it comes to sheltering wealth, Manhattan real estate is the stripper's tits.

—Then we are in New Jersey, why.

—Well sir I could say we're in New Jersey because your Midtown penthouses have constipated liquidity. I could say we're in New Jersey because the Southern District's gonna make you wear the

brown hat if you keep borrowing against said property's fraudulent equity. But what I am going to say instead is that we are in New Jersey to make people property again.

— Make people property again... The man in the sharkskin suit puckered each phoneme as he repeated the phrase. — Sounds like it should be stitched on ball cap, not printed on investment prospectus.

— See it's the damndest thing. Property rarely undervalues itself. But people... Juug bobbed his right thumb at Byron and David behind him as if they were a game show's dud prizes. — People undervalue themselves all the time. See these two? Know what I'm paying them to work on this here yacht the American Dream? You'd guess money, wouldn't you?

The man in the sharkskin suit wrinkled his lips as if waiting out a stubborn bowel movement.

— Well guess again. I'm paying them in Likecoin. See right there I'm saving eight nine bucks an hour on my overhead. And that labor play, that's just the appetizer in your Likecoin investment.

— The amuse bouche, if you will.

— Actually in New Jersey... David held up an index finger with one hand as the other thumbed his phone's screen. — Says here that the New Jersey state minimum wage is eleven eighty-

— See the kid's making my point. These millennials, they know the price of everything and the value of nothing. Which is why America's mortgage lenders have already written off underwriting millennials. Because this generation, they do things that don't pay. Which is something you and I our generation would never do.

— There is no you and I, Mister Van Sant... The man in the sharkskin suit flicked his soul patch with his tongue's underbelly. — Not nyet. Just so I am clear, you want me to invest ten million dollars into a segment of your citizenry widely known for doing things that don't pay, as if I am tossing table scraps to who, David the doggie and bow-wow Byron? A hand flung up in a reverse karate chop. — Pah!

—Likecoin isn't table scraps sir. It's bait. Mortgage bait. Try and think of America's fiduciary system as a vast network of fisheries, each specializing in their own species and just as-

—Yes and I presume this is why you held our meeting on a meager sportfisher and not, a helipadded fifty-five meter megayacht as men of our net worth deserve, to assist in making this strained analogy?

—Well I just hope you read your Likecoin prospectus as well as you're reading me I tell you what but yes see just as fisheries need to fill their respective quotas on pollack salmon fluke what have you fiduciaries must do likewise with all their mortgage holdings jumbo fixed-rate et cetera. But here's the thing over here on this side of the Bering our mortgage fisheries take up half our goddamned gdp. See that's why I created Likecoin, so that real sportsmen type predatory investors like yourself can chum for a mortgaged millennial a trophy species if there ever were one not a lot of meat on their bones sure but looks damned good when you're showing them to the market.

—And after we bait this trophy millennial species, this is where I presume the switch enters into your scheme's calculus?

—Not a switch per se but a swap. See that's the genius behind Likecoin, it's both the bait and the barrel! Because once we show the market where millennials are surfacing up to the mortgage pool it'll be a goddamned fiduciary feeding frenzy everything from derivative plays to debenture ventures I tell you what and best part is it'll all be hidden behind my neat new shadow investment tranche I created for just this purpose, which don't worry is totally legal and definitely cool.

—Shadow investment tranche.

—That's right because what is a shadow anyway? It's both proof of a thing's existence and the absence of it. Shouldn't you be able to say the same thing about your money?

—Tell me Mister Van Sant...The man in the sharkskin suit took a step starboard so he could peer out its window. —Do you know why I collect penthouses? He asked with a back turned to Juug and craning upward so he could look up at what was his across the Hudson River.

—Not for the articles that's for fuck sure.

—Jim please. As I said when it comes to tax shelters penthouses are the stripper's tits but even Chesty Love eventually got brought back down to earth so to-

—No not for shelter Mister Van Sant. For stature. I purchase my penthouses so I can, in the manner of domestic parlance, stunt on American job creators much like yourself. Now earlier, you tied my investment acumen to my bowel discipline inside my own properties. So when you suggest I invest in the ground floor of some hidden shadow investment well I must ask you Mister Van Sant, how am I able to not take a shit in something which does not exist?

—Fuck me Jesus that's an egg-scrambling equinox I tell you what.

—But see that's what the southern district wants. They want your money to have an address so they can-

—Do not concern yourself with this, as I have on good authority that that particular federal constabulary has grown quite fond of plants. Now Mister Van Sant, constructing your country's upper crust has been of great value to me and my countrymen. So tell me, why shouldn't I simply keep dipping my investment beak into your penthouses and pied-a-terres much like those cheeky novelty drinking birds do? You have these carnival trinkets in your country, yes?

—Because this country's isn't built to build buildings anymore. All America wants to build these days is levers and edges.

—Wealth is fleeing to the margins, yes I subscribe to The Economist as well Mister Van Sant.

—No sir. Let me be clear. For men of real means such as ourselves, true wealth is the very shrouding of it.

At this, the man in the sharkskin suit wrinkled his nose in an anxious wince, as if having just been made aware of a hygienic blind spot. And as he watched his potential investor contemplatively twiddle thumbs between hands clasped behind sharkskinned coattails, Juug took one slow long step back with palms out, as if attempting to leave a laboratory with a successful yet wobbling experiment.



Ferry wake weighted from the day's first rush hour route sharply yawed the vessel, croaking the instep of the man in the sharkskin suit's crocodile loafer. Looking down, he watched late afternoon light project four shadows upon the salon's grey-green carpet: two stretched themselves thin in an almost craven lunge toward his person; in doing so, they loomed over the two other shadows proleteriately silhouetted by rolled shirt sleeves and splayed shoelaces. These shadows, the man in the sharkskin suit observed, made no effort to move toward him, as if something stuck in place had made it sturdy. He then flexed his jowls and whistled at a periodontic register to summon the man with a lens around his neck into the salon; where, once within arm's reach, the man in the sharkskin suit snatched a paisley tie dangling between his black nylon lanyard; then coiling it closer as if hand-reeling a catch to the surface, the man in the sharkskin suit pulled a pen from inside his sport coat with the other, flicked off its cap, and began scribbling differential equations upon the taut tie's white whorls.

—Is that the ole rates of change growth and depletion? Well if you're concerned about a collateral boom take it from me that the math works out on this Likecoin play. And if it doesn't, in a few months we'll simply put the right men in Washington to make the math work.

—You.

—Me?

—Yes you. With the exposed velcro on your tuxedo's inseam.

—Whoops I uh, good looking out there.

—Tell me son. What is your DTI?

—Bit of an intimate question around these parts sir but despite a recent string of let's say foggy choices at Johnny Utah's, my latest battery of tests did in fact come back negative.

The man in the sharkskin suit chuckled with the cute courtesy of being misunderstood by a toddler.

—Excuse me...Byron thumbed his nose's undercarriage as he stepped into a billionaire's personal space. —Is there something amusing about having a clean dick?

—Nyet...The man in the sharkskin suit wrung his patronizing smile wry. It is an admirable trait in both our lines of work.

—The fuck you know about my work?

An alligator loafer's squared-off toe kicked the work bench from below, sending pennies warped oblong airborne. Having snatched one suspended in mid-air, the man in the sharkskin suit pinched the penny by its melted ridges as he poised it at eye level.

—The way you manipulate currency, it delights me. As if Lincoln posed for Munch, yes?

—Yes well look closer and you'll see that penny was minted in nineteen eighty two. Now eighty two was a year of transition for both our nations, what with Brezhnev dying and-

—Pah! Nothing more than a shuffling old man, clinging to power.

—Exactly. Which brings us to ole Ronnie over here on this side of the Bering. See Ronnie was up to his diaper in a recession so he was like supes desperate for some revenue to start trickling down from America's limpdicked economic prostate. So know what Ronnie did? He found a way to make money off how we were making money. Yep went and replaced the copper in our pennies with zinc, a weaker and far less costlier metal. Changed the entire constitution of our currency and best part is Ronnie, he did it all by fiat. Which is why all pennies minted before nineteen eighty two are known as two-cents because the copper inside-

—Is more valuable than the value it endorses.

—Exactly sir! See my boss Juug here didn't think you'd understand my penny tittypincher but I knew, I knew you don't become this bigtime aluminum magnet without understanding that some metals are just plain more noble than others, and that's just the way Ronnie and the good lord made it. Now eighty two was also an important year because that's when our country began minting millennials.

With one arm's elbow, Byron chummily corralled David's neck as the other's palm cupped David's chin so its fingers could squeeze both his cheeks.

—And I believe it's no coincidence that the same time America changed what was inside a penny, they changed what was inside a generation. Now our boss Juug asked David and me here to pick something on this here yacht the American Dream that's about what the millennial generation's all about. And sure, we could've pitched you some tittypincher on how millennials are some cultural seacock distributing the creative flow state keeping the engines on the American Dream cool and unoverheated. Or we could've given you some self grandizing speech that millennials are these integral hardworking pistons housed in some tight studio-sized liner. But then David here reminded me that that's how we millennials see ourselves working in the American Dream. But that's not how we're actually being used. I mean not really. Like let's face it we owe it to ourselves to talk to each other as dutch uncles about the millennial generation. I mean we're weak, we always seem to fall victim to depressions, and we're easily manipulated to the point that our net worth's all stretched out like that zinc penny you got in your hand there.

The man in the sharkskin suit glanced at the flattened penny in his hand, blinked twice, and said nothing. Behind him, Juug twirled an horizontal index finger, as if to suggest if Byron was unspooling something, he was unspooling it too slowly.

—Which then begs the question. If millennials are so weak and worthless, why the fuck are David and I even aboard this yacht in the first place and you know like breathing the same salty air as two bigshot global nobles such as yourselves?...After straddling a corner of the rectangular floor seam outlining the floor hatch, Byron stooped down, pulled a carriage bolt buried beneath grey-green carpet, and single-arm deadlifted a hatch the shape and weight of a wealthy man's headstone a foot off the floor.

—Yep, lots of nobility on these yachts...Byron gruntnunciated as he jerked the hatch from shin to shoulder, flinging mold and mites off its carpet at the velocity of intent so that they shimmered like pixie dust in their waft into shafts of golden hour light shaped by Jersey City's skyline's slatted gaps. Then after resting the hatch upright against the portside window, Byron turned back to the men while holding

a maglight near his ear whose beam he strafed across the engine beneath their feet. — You got your cast iron block, aluminum pistons, stainless steel prop shafts, there's even a bunch of copper all coiled up in the heat exchanger there. Problem is that these expensive noble metals're not only exposed by this brackish salty air but they're also grounded to these two big battery banks. So we got nobility, salinity, and electricity. Anyone know what that means?

— Shit Byron... David monotoned half-heartedly as he swung a rootin-tootin arm across his torso. — That's corrosion's favorite recipe.

— Exactamundo which means it's just a matter of time before corrosion eats up these noble metals just like it's a matter of time before corrosive influences eat up your foreign investments what with this country's saltiness against successful global nobles like yourself not to mention an increasingly charged and polarized sociopolitical landscape. But wait a sec, what's that thing poking out the oil cooler?

— Gee I don't know, to me it just looks like some weak and worthless metal. But why ask me? I'm just a millennial.

— Wait why am I asking you when we got a goddamned captain on board with us? Hey Cap mind dropping some nautical nobility knowledge for us here?

— Ok look before I say that that's a zinc I just want to say that all these two noxious little faggots are doing is reinstituting something I already told them.

— Thanks Cap, now why would-

— No one gave a shit when Captain Jim talked about zincs a few days ago, but now that we've got some metal magnet on board I guess zincs are now some big revelvetation.

— Sure Cap now why would zinc, the weakest of all noble metals, a metal so worthless it devalues pennies, why would that particular metal be screwed into all these engine parts?

— My egg's so scrambled, I don't know if I should give an answer or if this is one of those metaoracle questions.

—Got it from here Cap. See a zinc's value lies in its weakness. It's lack of nobility is precisely what allows it to soak up the electrical corrosion before it hits the nobler metals on board you know like the stainless steel prop shafts and copper-coiled oil coolers. Kinda genius, how a flaw was engineered into function am I right? And get this they're not even called zincs on boats they're called sacrificial zincs you know as if the metal needed a reminder to know its role...

Byron dug into his cummerbund to pull out a grey-pink cylinder clad like a piece of pastel chalk left out in the rain.

—Now my boss Mister Van Sant here has got this crazy idea to apply the laws of metals to money, in that global nobles who have it should be protected by millennials who don't. Now I know this is all somewhat abstract and complicated so to demonstrate a millennial's value in this Likecoin play what I've done is weld a bunch of millennial pennies together into a sacrificial zinc in much the same manner of how Likecoin will layer your laundering investment with a tranche of millennial social mortgages referenced in your investment prospectus.

—Yes quite clever son but we really need to move on from this penny tittypincher of yours. I'm sorry about this sir. All these millennials want to talk about is change.

—Wait wait wait wait wait I haven't proven how millennials protect all your other financial instruments below the surface of all that dark pool financing referenced in the appen-

—This, it is not necessary... The man in the sharkskin suit reassured Byron with a languid, backhand wave. —Why should I make a man prove something when I can pry it out of him?

—You sure? You don't seem like you're sure.

The man in the sharkskin suit's palm rolled deferentially open.

—Your adamance suggests a wish to wring this euphemism further.

At this, Byron tore off his velcroed tuxedo with a stripper's elan, then after sliding two makeshift cylindrical zincs into ziptied holsters cinched against the doiled hem of his silk thong's hip, he grabbed an adjustable pipe wrench from the work bench, bound out the salon, and cannonballed over the stern.

—Now this... The man in the sharkskin suit wrung open palms into fists. —This is America's greatness! Men of action! He exclaimed, giggling as he lifted his loafers at the vibrating hull like a masochist stepping on hot coals. —I have no idea where he is going next!

—Down, I'd assume... Juug said while whisking uneasy chuckles into laughter making a meal out of his investor meeting. —Now look Kuvetli how bout we cut to the nut cutting here.

The man in the sharkskin suit's chortle deepened into a defensive snort, nostrils flaring below eyes flit between David and Juug.

—Don't worry Kuvetli your name's safe here. The one down there working beneath the surface, he's the one with the social following. But this one's got absolutely zero in terms of name recognition. For our purposes he's more mannequin than man. Now we both know this money laundering thing of ours is a three legged workhorse place layer integrate, and so naturally I structured this Likecoin cryptosocial play similarly see first we're gonna place your investment into millennials as payment for rentovating our shelter properties into higher appraisals.

—And I assume these millennials are bonded to perform such work?

—God no. See that's the point it don't matter if it works well so long as it looks good because once Vic the appraiser does his thing we can issue these social mortgages at the after-improved value so that we can then layer all that Likecoin through this blockchain-based fractional property ownership model so that all these micro-transactions can tumble laundered value back into your account.

—And the fiat with which I purchased the property. What of that.

—Yes of course which brings us to the big swinging dick upon which our investment tripod rests by which I mean integrating your initial investment see by tokenizing, then fugazily appreciating real estate assets like this wink wink million dollar yacht my proprietary cryptosocial shadow tranche can create on-chain credit derivatives that we can then wrap into depreciated scratched and dented mortgages representing a seventeen billion dollar market cap more than enough coverage for you to keep your gains gotten.

—Look Mister Van Sant, this Likecoin idea, it is fun sure. But fun is flimsy. And flimsy fails.

—You'd think so wouldn't you but look at Battery Park bobbing over my right shoulder. That right there's proof positive if you layer enough cash trash and ash you can bet your bottom nut that's a shelter property strong enough to support the American Dream.

—I'd rather bet neither testicle if I can help it Mister Van Sant. Because if my investment here fails, the eleventh chapter in your country's insolvency canon makes it difficult for me to, how do I say this in common vernacular...

—Make yourself whole, no look I get it.

—Good. So you get I often find it necessary to take parts of people in order to make that whole...Kuvetli leaned into Juug's personal space, where he peered unblinkingly until he watched the face in front of him wrinkle. —Or maybe this one we leave alone. Keep being nosey with the grindstone as it were and next time you'll pitch me a better investment than profiting off peasants.

—You know a time like this I'm reminded of an old russian saying. Profiting off a poor man is as difficult as squeezing his liver to make turnip gazpacho.

—Tell me Mister Van Sant which oblast does that saying originate?

—Because look you're right. Not a lot of net worth on these millennials bones...Juug punctuated his point with a derisive flick of David's flinching ribs. —But their parents, they're the ones who are fat happy and loaded. Forty times their kid's net worth on average, haven't seen that type of inequality around here since separate but equal.

—Yes a particularly cruel period in your nation's history.

—Yes see you get it. That's what capitalism is, the continuation of cruelty by other means. And you know what the first ingredient in cruelty is? Hope. Which is why I'm getting these two to spread all this inspirational hopecore content about how the only thing between their fellow millennial and their american dreams is a couple Likecoin to rub together and their parent's signature.

Then when these millennials fail at my social mortgage just like they've failed at everything else that's when we'll cash in our leverage short the american dream and fucking foreclose on an entire generation I mean holy-

— Mister Van Sant. The glee with which you articulate the methods with which you will profit off the misery of your countrymen, it both troubles me and reassures me of your capabilities as a investor.

— Why sir, that's one of the nicest-

Both men stopped their conversation so they could turn toward the burbling surface disrupting it; there they watched a hand clutching an eroded metal emerge from the water with the triumphance of a magician's filed-down shackle; where after bobbing the rest of his upper torso above the surface and burp-vomiting the marina's brackish water where he tread, Byron butterfly-stroked his way back toward the vessel. Seeing this, Kuvetli pinched emerald bezel cufflinks off opposite wrists, pulled starched sleeves over sportcoat arms pushed above his elbow, then leaned over the teak gunwale with an extended hand and felt worn warm metal exchange in their splashed clasp. As Byron barrel rolled his hips over the gunwale and collapse onto the stern's fiberglass deck, Kuvetli rolled the pockmarked metal nub in one hand as if evaluating overripe produce. Nodding a frown in satisfaction, Kuvetli removed a nose hair trimmer from his sportcoat's interior; slid open its plastic compartment to tap out its double-a battery, where he then inserted the battery into his lower lip as if it were a snuff pouch before licking the worn zinc for an uncomfortable length of time.

— See I knew you'd be able to see the value in these sacrificial zincs sir I mean shit you can taste it. And see just as zincs are both the cheapest and most valuable investment a captain can make, investing in millennials like David and I will give you the same type of roy for captains of industry such as yourself.

— Well done, my friend... Kuvetli softly applauded without making a sound, Battery still bulging from bottom lip like a bullfrog ,his tongue flicking excess charge from his mouth like a snake smelling



the air. — But there is one flaw...After hocking the battery overboard, Kuvetli lifted his subordinate's tie to daub spittle from his mouth. — You do all this work to make this galvanic connection between valuable weak metal and valuable weak millennial. Nyet you are clearly strong millennial.

— Well my dead dad's body'd be spinning in his grave if he heard someone say that about faggy meager artist son of his you know like if he still had one.

— No no I must give you credit my friend. You bend money, you dive into danger. You do all this, and nyet your partner, he has done nothing. It is like you are all wet with inspiration like woman who knows her price, but your friend here is dry with doubt, like woman who questions her worth...Kuvetli turned toward Juug. — This is known in your country as the baiting of the switch, yes?

— Yes well I think what you mean to say is-

— Mister Van Sant. You must have me confused for someone who means what they say. Me, I just say. And I say the weak millennial should install the weak metal.

— Well with your investment here today we'll be able to expand this Likecoin proof of concept to other vessels in this marina where I'd be more than happy to toss David overboard into whichever body of water you so choose.

— No see Mister Van Sant, this here's a twin engine sportfisher. Which means two sets of props shafts trim tabs everything which means David can dive down do the same thing I did but on the starborn side, I mean so long as he's like down to do it.

After catching the penny zinc tossed to him, David felt the heat of ten eyes volley upon his person. — Yeah I mean I'd totally be down to dive in but see thing is I, I don't really have a suit.

— You think this is a suit?...Byron hushed through his smile's unbroken teeth. — This is electrical tape and a maternity thong!

— Yeah, well maybe you should, you know...David vertically flicked his eyes. — Gather your belongings.

— Well maybe that's my point like maybe you need to like let your own nuts hang for once instead of looking out for everyone else's.

— Look Byron even if I wanted to-

— You do.

— Sure, but I don't know how to even-

— You'll know when you're down there.

— Yeah but did you know that there's all this hidden electrical danger beneath the surface? Because after you told me about this cockamamie zinc plan of yours I found out that just one stray electrical line in the water can-

— Gentlemen!... Byron shouted over his shoulder before hooking David's neck with his elbow's crook as a means of shepherding him toward the stern. — In the salon I've prepared some latkes dipped in green pea compote. Head on in grab a couple and I'll get you once David here's ready to dive in.

After closing the salon door behind the two men, Byron kept his back turned away from David; after shrugging his shoulders as if trying to tear something in two and spitting a piece of plastic off the starboard side, he turned back thrusting a thumb and pinky to David's ear and lips. — Your future you's on the line David. Will you accept the charge?

— What? Why the fuck would my future me call me collect? Is he somehow even more destitute than present me and had to resort to pawning off my smartphone?

After feeling a flick against his ribs, David followed Byron's bugged eyes darting downward to find white powder piled upon the side of his pinky inches from his right nostril.

— So you gonna answer the call or what?

— Wait, is that...

— If by that you mean that which'll get you to hold your nose dive down and take the action the moment demands then yes David it is that.

— Look Byron I know what you're trying to do here, but-

—No you don't. Because if you did, you'd have already done it. Know what fine fine fine fuck it fine I can see it in those dry eyes of yours that you don't want it. But just remember that what you dismiss at first usually becomes your last resort.

—Some fucking influencer, am I right...Juug said as he slapped Byron's back from behind with enough cajoling force to jostle the powder off his pinkie. —See this just shows the lengths that these millennials aren't willing to go in order to win in the marketplace which is to say millennials like David will do whatever it takes to not do what it takes to take ownership of the American Dream. Now even so, if you do want to someone dive down there I'd be more than happy to swap David out for another weak millennial who'd be all too eager-

—Metal, meddle...Kuvetli chuckled deflatedly while holding the torn banner, as if receiving a gag gift already unwrapped. —The way you triple pun amuses me. As if Nabokov sold out to the oligarchs.

—Yeah well see while some writers like David here may feel that puns are cheap, me I think only something as loose as a pun can suggest a much richer truth than we can ever articulate.

—Yes great well no richer truth than money am I right? So how bout we take one last look at the tender because it's as simple as it gets ten million of yours for one billion of mine. And remember that's on a cap of one point five billion Likecoin tokens plus as a good faith gesture I'll even throw in a non-diluted follow-on offering.

Kuvetli curdled his lips as if smelling something foul upwind.

—Seems like he doesn't believe us, Mister Van Sant.

—Yes thank you Byron but how about letting the men with the money talk.

—I have money because I have Likecoin remember? Like remember in your prospectus when you said that Likecoin makes likes work like money?

—Fine yes, but this part right now doesn't concern you.

—Well I mean like if I'm the only one here who shares the concerns of our potential investor here I think it kinda does because like after our

new russian magnet friend buys a bunch of Likecoin, how's he even gonna circulate any of it? Because he'd have too much while David and I, we'd have too little.

— This has not gone unnoticed. If you have a solve by all means—

— My solve is your solve boss. I mean you said it yourself when you said this vessel's your proof of concept okay well then let's prove that concept. Let's sign over ownership of this here vessel the American Dream to our russian magnet friend so that when David and I rentovate it in exchange for his Likecoin our neat new investor will be able to reap its after-improved value. I mean we're out here talking about good faith gestures ok then let's like really make one not like some slick, non-diluted gesture.

— This forty-five footer? Son that'd be shamefully small for a man of his net worth. Why it'd be like putting ten pounds of his boar sausage into a five pound condom I mean am I right?

— Dictating my shame. How American. Sketch me the shape of this rentovation strategy of yours son.

— For fuck sake he doesn't have one!

— My strategy shape's same as yours, boss. Like look here in your Likecoin prospectus where you talk about this neat earning triangle between users content creators and advertisers well yesterday right as I was reading that David here begins complaining about how he's this victim of this rising inequality that's basically creating this millennial slave class and so I got to thinking about the oh gee triangle trade where whipped slaves would pluck out cotton which was like the most valuable resource back then and in return for that cotton these global nobles gave rum to the slave-producing countries to like lubricate the triangle keep the whole slave flow running smooth. Then I got to thinking about that old saw about how economic history is boomed to repeat itself because Likecoin's got a similar triangle trade vibe in that it'll produce a millennial slave class that can harvest these social media eyeballs which're today's most valuable resource just like cotton used to be and like not only that these millennial slaves'll even go and plant these

plucked eyeballs in this neat new walled cryptosocial garden our boss Juug has set up and all they'll need in return for our work is a dose of Likecoin which delivers the dopamine of money but with none of the dough just like how the global nobles lathered their slaves with rum back while hoarding their florin I mean holy shit how's that for an investment shape?

— In a word, sturdy. But my concern is that this oh gee triangle trade you referenced took several generations to reap profitability.

— Well yeah but like look here in the prospectus where it says each like on the Likecoin cryptosocial platform is like its own micro-transaction so that the more likes there are the more it speeds up this transaction triangle so that it becomes this like vanishing point for your traceable money. Now if you're concerned about being made whole from this risky initial investment I get it but like look here at this underwriting stupidlation in which all rentovations must be completed within six months on account that these neat social mortgages Mister Van Sant is gonna sell in phase two are these repurposed scratched and dented two hundred and three k loans which means if David and I aren't able to rentovate this vessel into a million dollar appraisal by like say labor day you can just swap in two new millennials on board to run the same grift again you know like I just showed you with the sacrificial zincs I mean do you need me to dive down and prove it again on the starborn side because I still feel like you kinda still don't believe me.

— God no son just keep your damn pants on please. Now look if signing the American Dream over to you is what it takes to get you on board with my Likecoin play then fine, no skin off my dick. But as far as the Likecoin tender itself, I'm assuming we want this to be a cash transaction for tax avoidance purposes.

— Yes, well... Kuvetli rapidly pat his sheened suit as if it had become infested. — Unfortunately I cannot consummate the transaction as of currently. Only when visiting Petrossian Boutique does my assistant Smerdykov here carry that amount of tactile fiat.

— Oh please. Physically exchanging currency that's for primitive savages out on some island swapping wigwams for wampum.

We'll take it all offshore where it's all very legal and totally cool.  
Now how bout we pudder dare?

Having watched Juug stab his right hand into his personal space, Kuvetli raised a snapping hand above and behind its own shoulder. Immediately the man with a lens around his neck scurried out to the stern where he produced the zoot of an unzipped bag before returning to the salon with the same breeze he let in order to place a saranwrapped white egg into Kuvetli's expecting palm with the care and urgency of having just midwived a chalk ostrich.

—Gotta admit I'm a little stumped on this gift you got here. See here in America powdered eggs are for the poor.

—This egg isn't meant to be eaten Mister Van Sant, but consumed.

—Damn, this ruskie's just chuck full of equinoxes ain't he.

—Perhaps it is best I gift directly to your workers as a how should I call it, a participation trophy for our rentovation endeavor.

—Then you should definitely give it to these millennials. They love trophies!

—Very well...Kuvetli extended the egg to Byron, who received it with wide eyes and outstretched overlapping hands as if a child receiving his second eucharist. —Consider this as an up payment on our future success.

—Your gift honors us, sir...Byron carefully set the egg on the work bench, then lifted a bent wrist underneath his nose to stanch a salivating sniff. —You can count on David and me to put your gifted gift to good use on this Likecoin rentovation play really put our nose to the grindstone on this bump up this vessel's value stimulate your investment real nice like.

—Yes well it is getting to be rush hour for the ferries, and that type of chaos doesn't sit well with men of our net worth so what say we continue this dialogue while tying one on at Ruthless Chris?

The vessel yawed from the four men's exiting momentum; stretching spring lines intermittently squeaked against the rattletrap clang of a perforated floating pier grinding against the concrete piling

tethering the pier in place during its tidal rise and whose rubber rollers reciprocated the security the piling provided by stripping a strip of mussels clean off its concrete. After David walked into the salon, Byron stayed out on the stern to watch Juug's hand hover near his Russian investor's shark-skinned back at the distance of a prom queen's pity date, his burgundy sportcoat flapping against gathering offshore wind like a signal flag indicating dangerous cargo aboard.

—Hey! I just want to see it...David whined in response to Byron wrenching the egg out from his hands with the bratty indignation of a child taking a toy from a friend unable to unlock its capacity to entertain.

—Yeah well I wanna smell it.

—Ok so that's what I thought this egg is. But why would that Russian give us a-

—What a griffin egg? Very observant David. You noticed the scales, didn't you? But you know why orthodox churches used griffin eggs? ...Byron picked a pressed penny off the workbench, then genuflected on the salon carpet near the egg on the work bench to stab at its clingwrap until an orifice tore free. —To keep all the rats away from the holy oil.

—Why would I know that? And why are you even talking about griffin eggs when we should be talking about why the that russian gave us this-

—Talking about the older materials shaping the new...With the same oblong penny, Byron chiseled a white clump off the egg, guide that clump upon the webbing between his index finger and thumb on his opposite hand, and pressed the penny against his handshake flesh to turn clump into powder.

—Talking about the gift which unlocks our gifts...Lifting his hand to meet a nose with one nostril open, Bryon produced the sound of a staccatoed sniff, belted out —Comeonayea-hah! while producing a piston-punching movement as if calling a third strike on a passive batter. —So how bout a quick little whiffer picker upper Engram? Byron asked with a wagged tail smile beneath dilated black irises set

against glossed brown pupils like a moneylender opening an empty yet freshly-oiled leather satchel for reimbursement. — You know a quick taste just so you can see how it smells.

— Uh I'm good dude I can smell it from here, smells like diesel fuel.

— Ok so it smells like you on the boat maybe this is a sign buddy! I mean aren't you writers all about seeing and smelling the signs that are right in front of-

— And what sign is that? Like what the fuck does some cocaine egg signify to-

— Look you don't need to get so worked up and mad about it I mean it's just drugs ok.

— Me? You're the one who's all worked up didn't you just have that stuff on your pinkie when you offered it to me just then?

— I only pack a small snort on me in case of emergency. And like just because you have some doesn't mean you don't want some more. I mean that's what this country's all about, you know that right?

— Emergency? What fucking emer-

— Your emergency ego, silly. Like remember how back then just now you held yourself back from diving into a new experience? Well that was your emergency ego holding your personal development hostage at the expense of your physical survival but see that's what's great about cocaine powder we can use it as a tool to gain leverage over our emergency ego just like you got all these wrenches sockets screwdrivers to help this engine run smooth this powder helps us tune up our own pink mushy engines.

— A tool? Thought you said the egg was a gift.

— It's the tool that unlocks your gift, silly. Now come on just toss a toot in real quick.

— Look on some level I can understand your passion for cocaine but you really don't need to get so close to me.

— Hard disagree Engram. Closer I get to you, closer you'll get to being yourself.



—Yeah but you're talking inches from my face all rapid and rabid like and each time I try to subtly take a step backwards you just close the gap even closer so that my back's now literally up against the wall ok so look-

—No...Byron picked up his smartphone off the galley counter; where after unwinding the wired headphones coiled around it, and akin to a quack doctor sharing a stethoscope with a dubious patient, offered the right earbud to David; then, having placed its left bud into his right ear upside down, unctuously urged in a lilt to— Just listen.

## apply the high

—Pleasure, according to tonight's guest on Gavel to Babble, is the defining resource of our time. As one of America's foremost psychiatric disruptors, her insurgent Apply The High therapy is poised to grab an entire generation by the noses. But first, it must pass the FDA's smell test. I am pleased to have Doctor Joyce Neumann in this booth. Welcome.

—Thank you Glen, but that really wasn't the introduction we discussed on the ride over.

—Yes, yes it wasn't. Now Doctor Neumann, before we talk about your therapy, let's talk about what's holding it back. Specifically the FDA's galling take from your rejection letter quote while there is a clear need for anhedonic ptsd patients to rehabilitate neurological plasticity as a means of regaining creative fluency, that need does not override a century of American jurisprudence nor the ethics in distributing a dangerous pleasure to vulnerable populations as Doctor Neumann's quote therapy unquote suggests unquote.

— Yes well I think it'd be more productive if we began from the perspective of the patients themselves instead of-

— No no no no if the FDA wants to discuss the ethics in distributing dangerous pleasures to vulnerable populations then let's discuss the ethics in distributing dangerous pleasures to vulnerable populations. Let's discuss the ethics in distributing the pleasure of recognition, our most dangerous pleasure, to vulnerable children, making their bookshelves groan with trophies before they can fucking even push out a pube.

— Glen I'd really rather-

— Then let's discuss how these millennial plaque babies grow up with stunted grit so they can enter into a workforce in which every corner office is slinging out rock star trophies in the shape of a rock out hand-

— Dammit Glen I specifically told you-

— That are of course made out of rock. Corporate recognition is a forty six billion dollar industry Doctor Neumann. And if you want to know why that is, just look at who it's directed at.

— Yes Glen. Millennials, the trophy generation.

— The so-called trophy generation, called so by the same grooming boomers who forcefeed millennials with recognition so they can starve them of compensation but oh ho as if that's not enough they then gaslight these same millennials into believing that they're the ones setting the socioeconomic menu in this country.

— Can you please at least attempt to pivot here?

— And then when these burnt out millennials are at the ends of their flaccid ropes and fallow tubes you Doctor Neumann create a therapy that helps them hack the same pleasure centers these boomers have been tapping dry for decades and then oh ho all of a sudden the fda begins squeezing your psychopharmacological shoes.

— Yes well be that as it may-

— Which by the way is exactly what butters the caviar bread of the North Jersey cartel.

— What, squeezing psychopharmacological shoes?

—Hacking pleasure centers. Cartel's running a goddamned trillion dollar supply chain of industrial sin in this country advertisers executives distributors I mean holy-

—Glen!

—Wha!

—If you would give me the courtesy of letting me finish, I may be more inclined to reciprocate the gesture later.

Dead air audibly crackled in the intervening silence.

—Baud's all yours, Doctor Neumann.

—Thank you. Now for any bureaucratically-inclined listener who may be questioning the motives and methodologies behind pleasure-based creative remediation I'd ask-

—You mean Apply the High.

—Yes fine I would ask that they examine the board-certified logic behind stocking every oncology wing in this country flush with anabolic steroids. See we administer synthetic test to cancer patients not so they can get a second callout at Mister Olympia but to build their body back to something approximating their pretraumatic form.

—Yeah, well tell that to that one-balled biker.

—And in that same way, my patients are applying the high as you put it not necessarily to show at p s one or win a national book award, but as a means of building themselves back to being.

—Back to being what exactly, Doctor Neumann?

—Of use. First to themselves, and then to the rest of the world. As opposed to being used by the world, which is what many ptsd patients disclose in their intake questionnaire in some form or fashion.

—Let's loiter on that point for a tick Doctor Neumann. Because some of our listeners out have accused you of gratuitously spreading your diagnostic lips in order to accept any unemployed limplicked and or clitted millennial into your patient subset.

—Glen we discussed this. Unemployment is a socioeconomic diagnosis. The clinical term is anhedonic. Which studies have

shown is a key indicator of post traumatic stress regardless of the precipitating traumatic event. And so when we consider that anhedonia is literally latin for the absence of pleasure, it shouldn't really surprise anyone that activating a patient's hedonic hotspots could effectively treat the dysregulated anhedonia brought on by their traumas.

— You say anhedonic, I say broke, back home and smoking chronic. Point is when we think about ptsd patients we think of veterans rape victims those who have you know earned their trauma. So tell me Doctor Neumann, how have millennials earned their trauma? Because our some of our listeners out there might just be thinking oh boo hoo these poor millennials.

— Well I agree with that characterization Glen. When a generation possesses twenty percent less equity than any other generation at their age while also possessing a twenty percent higher risk for suicide or overdose, what else can you say but poor millennials?

— But I was the one who said poor millennials Doctor Neumann.

— Yes I'm aware.

— Doctor Neumann I'm not sure you understand the concept of a podcast. See you were brought on to share your unique truth, not to spit back whatever the host ejaculates like that one time you convinced me to play babybird.

— Fine then how bout late stage capitalism has traumatized an entire American generation. That an original enough neurosocioeconomic take for you?

— Well ladies and listeners, I think we have an early leader for this episode's promotional soundbite.

— Better yet I'd argue that in some ways these traumatized anhedonic millennials have it worse than clinically diagnosed ptsd patients who have as you've said earned their trauma. Because unlike those patients, who we rightly sympathize with and honor their truths, traumatizers like systemic inequality and social oppression are flung back in millennial's faces so that their generation is portrayed as being feckless victims of a victimless crime. I mean holy shit Glen,

imagine telling a returning soldier struggling to make rent to pull themselves up by their bootstraps.

—Millennials more deserving of a trauma diagnosis than veterans. Had I known you were going to bring these hot takes to the podcast I'd have thrown our erotic tongs into the roadie cube.

—Damnit Glen. Unlike how you negotiate plea deals, this isn't a pissing contest. Now it's not like I'm shooting from my cunt here. All of this is based on sound neurological research. Primates suffering through poverty and its subsequent diminishment of social status exhibit the same amount of damage to their dopamine receptors as those primates who have suffered through a clinically recognized traumatic event such as rape or violence.

—All we are are stoned traumatized apes, that it Doctor Neumann?

—And instead of dividing these patients into which subset deserves their diagnosis more, I'd rather talk about what's common to all ptsd patients. And that is what they resent most, even more than the traumatic event itself, is the victimhood that their traumatic experience breeds within themselves, whatever it may-

—Shit it's become a meme, the victimized millennial.

—Yes and unless we provide patients with tools that can help them shed their sense of victimhood and take action on the world, a million more millennial lives will be lived at the depth of a meme.

—And just to be clear here, you believe that tool to be cocaine.

—Well I prefer to frame it as pleasure being the tool that induces a patient's flow state which yes cocaine does act as a proxy for.

—Spoken like you've recently had a litigator's dick in your mouth.

—Oh for fuck sake Glen.

—Look Joyce I don't care if we're husband and wife outside this booth inside it we owe it to our listeners to speak to each other like dutch uncles about what this Apply The High therapy really is.

—Booth's fucking yours Barrister Grynzspan.

—Well me personally I'd characterize it as an eightball for any millennial that's behind the eightball.

—Glen that's not only too clever by half but it also overlooks the companion drug in pleasure-based creative redmediation's two-drug regimen as we also administer psilocybin to patients after their cocaine-induced flow sessions so they can contextualize and synthesize their creative progress.

—Oh okay sure as if their serotonin sundae's not piled high enough, let's sprinkle a little cosmic dust on top.

—It's not about getting these patients high Glen. It's about getting them to take action and assert themselves in the cosmos by any means necessary because and let me be professionally clear about this, passivity is a drug that's as potent as any plaque or powder out there. I've seen it. I've seen how passivity withers a patient's will, how it turns a mind brittle and a soul bitter. How day by day, a patient becomes chronically addicted to the belief that their inner being is being controlled by outside forces. And I guess where I'm going out on a psychopharmacological limb here is that I'd rather my patients risk addiction to a drug which compels them to take action than for them to stay passive and risk nothing for the rest of their lives.

—But unfortunately Doctor Neumann, your Apply The High therapy is itself in a state of passivity, as its fate is being controlled by outside forces and other people.

—Yes and you've sufficiently unpacked the fda's stance in your a block so how bout we move on, counselor.

—See that's the thing. These fda pencildicks only see the world in doses and deltas. They don't understand that standardizing nose dosage is damn tough when it comes to this stuff.

—Yes Glen I fondly remember litigating the standardized length and girth of a line with you during the early days of this therapy. But as you know since then we've been able to establish a baseline intake of twenty milligrams of cocaine per creative session which we believesufficiently stimulates a patient's flow state while still operating at a cardiological risk factor similar to what's chronically prescribed in amphetamine salts to millions of suburban teenagers.

—And the delta? Meaning the improvement in a patient's flow state?

—I admit that establishing a neurological metric for flow state has proven slippery. Standard issue psychiatric tools like journals and EEG pasties have proven insufficient for this task as they both intrude in and distract from the mental state we're trying to track. And the inconclusivity of data from these methods suggests that any psychiatric evaluation reliant on a patient's conscious effort to recognize their own subconscious flow state proves to be a monumental waste of time for all involved parties. Because of this I've shifted my therapeutic focus from tracking a patient's mental state to their in-phase productivity. In doing so I believe I can simplify flow state into an equation where creative production is equal to pleasure consumed over time. And now that we've been able to lock in the appropriate nose dosage as it were, all we need is to do is identify the right time-based flow-tracking heuristic and I'm confident we'll-

—But the whole point of flow state is to forget that time exists.

—Yes that's true Glen. Creation's eternal thrall and so forth.

—I know it's true because the opposite is true. Back when I was in-house at Murk bored out my gourd watching my monitor's clock collating my existence billable second by billable second.

—Yes, well...

—I mean let's be honest here Doctor Neumann. The FDA wouldn't know flow state if it flew out their puckered buttocks.

—Glen I think we should give the FDA some credit, if only to put on a diplomatic veneer on what I feel has been a needlessly contentious dialogue-

—The FDA's got enough of a credit line from Murk and the rest of the North Jersey cartel as it is Doctor Neumann. By the way speaking of the North Jersey cartel-

—Dammit Glen when are you not speaking of-

—Doctor Neumann if this Apply The High therapy were to gain some let's call it efficacious traction, that is to say these millennials begin replacing their fourteen-day refills with eightballs I mean boy howdy that would really grab those North Jersey cartel fogeys by the ledger wouldn't it?



—I'm not trying to grab anyone by the ledger I'm simply trying to help an overlooked-

—Somewhat surprised the cartel hasn't tried to snuff ole Glen out yet, half expect some lab coat to sneak up behind me in a Parsippany parking garage club me over the head with an Omaha steak.

—Look all I want is someone to give serious consideration to this therapy. Because I've seen it work. We both have.

—Well let's talk about the first patient in whom we've seen this work, the so-called poster boy of Apply The High therapy who-

—Dammit Glen you're the only one who calls him that. And remember that we promised him-

—That true art rejects victimhood remember it fondly Doctor Neumann that's actually what I wanted to sidebar with you about because that was the moment when this cockamamie therapy started wouldn't you agree? Remember how we had just come back from our annual anniversary dinner at Tilted Kilt and we saw his art dealer's business card tacked to our front door along with a note apologizing for fucking up our kitchen table suggesting that we should sell it to cover his funeral costs. Even wrote the damn tombstone of the piece talking about how his last work should be viewed through the same meta-muerte lens as his first one. And then remember when we walked in Joyce remember seeing our boy B wobbling up there standing on his easel and that's when you started screaming true art rejects victimhood must've repeated the damn phrase for an hour true art rejects victimhood true art rejects victimhood just fucking wailing like an alleycat over the wobbly easel legs screeching on our burled wood kitchen table but then remember Joyce remember after I took my emergency baggie out from my sportcoat and dangled it at him like it was a calm doll, remember that that was the combination that got B to finally put some slack in his belt and start snorting his way to success!

—For fuck sake, Glen.

—Oh dry your ovaries Joyce. We both know these types of therapies need a sordid narrative in order to sell.

— Damn it that boy has-

— You mean our boy.

— Yes fine he's had enough legal exposure as it is without you putting him up on a wanted poster for a therapy that's still very much illegal.

— Well let's loiter on that thought for a beat Doctor Neumann. Because how is it that the law of the land of the free still bans the personal possession of powder? How is it that we've devoted a century's worth of jurisprudential energy toward churning citizens into felons simply for possessing the same goddamned materials that have woven America's greatness I'm talking Cobain's dotted forearms Edison's clotted nostrils Clemens's puckering nutsack.

— Quite the patchwork quilt you got there, Glen.

— And for all the political titty-wringing around our war on drugs, you got the North Jersey cartel suckling three percent off America's gdp like a goddamned defense contractor. But before drugs coddled capitalism, they cradled civilization, isn't that right Doctor Neumann?

— If that's what passes for a segue then yes Glen many if not most primitive societies treated psychoactive drugs such as psilocybin and the coca leaf not as a marketplace good but as a core social concept very much like ritual, religion and taboo. And like those concepts, psychoactive drugs were adopted independently and unanimously throughout the primitive world.

— All we are are stoned enlightened apes that it Doctor Neumann?

— Yes well putting aside your mckenna fanboner, I do believe there is merit in attributing our evolutionary leap to entheogenic drug consumption, as no other psychological input could have induced a parthenogenesis of man's individual self and spark creative breakthrough in early clan-driven societies particularly in agriculture, but that's clearly outside my purview as a psychiatric-

— Can't spell parthenogenesis without entheogenic drugs that it Doctor Neumann?

— Do less Glen but to answer your original question for the better part of human civilization psychoactive drugs were able to withstand

man's profit motive all way up until the last gasps of imperialism, where desperate empires began taxing indigenous drugs such as the coca leaf as a way of imposing a kind of war bond on the Mesoamerican tribes they themselves were warring with, nations who interestingly enough responded by distributing the coca among themselves to generate socioeconomic energy for one last final uprising.

—Exactly America can learn from the rest of the Americas on social uses of the coca leaf. Like do you know about Al Bignon this heroic economic botanist from Peru?

—I know I specifically told you not to try and shoehorn his story into our interview.

—No I know, but know what you call a lawyer who does what they're told? A paralegal. Ok so back about a century ago, you know back when coke was legal around these parts, Murk was so desperate to stake their pharmaceutical claim they went and blasted through the Andes in order to pillage that sweet sweet Peruvian coca. But guess what Al Bignon did Doctor Neumann?

—Why should I guess if I was the one who introduced you to his writ-

—He made do with what was done to him. Yep he figured out that the soda ash leftover from the mountain ore Murk had blasted, that ash could be used to refine the the coca leaf. Al then went around the country to teach his neat new refinement process to his fellow peasants so they could use it as a catalyst for upward mobility into the viceroial economy. You know, teach a man to fishscale feed him for life that kind of thing.

—Yeah sure Glen. Powder to the people.

—And get this get this Doctor Neumann this guy Al he had twice as many published articles as Freud, something that might interest you as you're looking to get traction on your career track. Matter facts one of his reports got all the way to the u n one of the things he wrote really stuck with me is that freeing a society depends on three key elements-

—Glen.

—Initiative culture and resources and guess what guess what Doctor Neumann cocaine is core to all three. I mean anyone who's ever done

a bump or even simply seen Scarface can make the connection to initiative and culture and then as far as resources like guess what kept the banks afloat during the last financial crisis? Yep that's right, white powder on the black mar-

—Glen!

—Wha?!

—Your producer's waving his hands and tapping his imaginary watch behind the glass there.

—Well it looks like that is all the time we have here today on Gavel to Babble.

—For fuck sake Glen I specifically told you to pay for the full hour. That this was too important to squeeze your producer's shoes with whatever two sevenths of an hour bullshit like you bill your clients.

—And in the interest of that time, I'll let Doctor Neumann have the-

—Fine look above all else, I hope your listeners understand that pleasure based creative remediation therapy-

—Apply The High.

—Yes fine it, that my patients, they don't use pleasure as some fun toy but rather as a functional tool, a tool which they'll carry with them long after they stop applying their the fuck are you snickering for?

—Nothing, I-

—No, please. Speak on it.

—Hearing you talk about fun toys and functional tools Doctor Neumann I can't help but think about the latex-dipped Dremel wand and jelly rubber impact gun attachment underneath our mattress but clearly that's neither here nor-

Words suddenly silenced by the crackle of adhesive shearing off scalp follicles, then the thud and thwack of a palm pressing a hairpiece's acrylic undercarriage against soundproof glass.

—Thank you, Doctor Neumann. It has certainly been my pleasure.

## papa grinnie ' s toot clear float recipe

—Objection...

Glen lifted his eyes to address Governor Punt, who loomed atop the train placard's purchased perch to preach **FATHERS DON'T LET FAMILIES PLAY WITH ADDICTION** to his straphanging constituents and on behalf of the private business entity Punt shared the public service announcement with, metonymized as a capless, prison-jumpsuit-orange pill canister, toppled seemingly by its own emptiness, yet propped up by a rattle and gavel beneath it.

—Calls for narrative response.

Having offered his muttered rebuttal, Glen stepped up to the placard; squinting at its lower right corner to find **BOUGHT AND PAID FOR BY MURK** in the thinned typeface and scrunched kerning characterizing media's legally mandated disclosures, nodded in a frown, then rested his caseload against the train's door. Claspig his right wrist with his left hand, he peered out the train's scuzzed oval window framing cauliflower clouds parallaxing against a lower Manhattan skyline glinting recycled light. Suddenly, Weehawken's palisades sheared Glen's view with the severity of an attendant shutting a first-class curtain; cragged rocks stacked like rows of trees were speckled with

rust-ochred, restaurant-grade heating lamps and tarped shopping carts angled against the terrain like game traps, this blurred landscape of human exile punctured every half mile by industrial drainpipes whose runoff bleached the rock bald.

Thudding boots bearing the weight of authority disturbed Glen's lucidity in their crescendo up the train's corrugated rubber aisle. As he watched the train's scuzzed oval windowpane milkily reflect a shape cloaked in the authoritative blue of oxygenless blood pass behind him, a flickering hackle reminded Glen that he lacked timestamped fare. After shrugging the feeling off the fall of his rose-with-cream windowpaned sportcoat in a shimmy, he picked up his caseload and began tailing the officer with a two-car cushion. Entering the train's swivel-bridge car, another hackle reminded Glen that the route was about to peel sharply south toward Lackawanna Station. Pressing his palm to the car's ceiling as if a waiter bussing his own balance, he peered over the swaying crowd just as the swivel-bridge's slinking accordion walls formed the right angle to surveil; where after clocking her jurisdictional shoulder patch as *Pavonia-Newport Mall* — not *New Jersey Transit Police* — Glen pursed a smirk through grit lips, as if winning a match by forfeit. His periphery now heightened from the adrenalined thrill of misdemeanor fare evasion, Glen picked up eyes on him that were not his own. Turning to his left, he found a man leaning bike and body against the train door's sign prohibiting both, grinning with criminal empathy. Glen flipped his business card over as he extended it so that before his potential client would search the name on the front, he would vibe with the motto on the back: *"The law is a game to be played, not a God to be revered."*

The train arrived at its Lincoln Harbor stop with a ding-dee warning to those pedestrians playing palsied footsie with the station's crosswalk. Out its peeling doors Glen's snapping hand's unfurling palm slapped the side of the other hand's fist at the rhythm of a nearby piledriver pounding a steel H-pile. Walking past IBS's blue glass ziggurat headquarters, Glen spat derisively into one of its foyer planters mulched with cigarette butts. Arriving at the marina's gate, he put his finger on printer paper taped to and flapping against its beehived steel

door to take in its scrawled calligraphic warning — COMING SOON: ATMAN PROJECTS. NO TRUST PASSING — with a nodding, conciliatory frown acknowledging that there's no deeper truth than a mistake.

The salon door flung open with such swashbuckling panache that its impact against the bulkhead's rubber backstop wobbled the saranwrapped egg positioned on the workbench. Like a parent watching their toddler teeter, Glen lunged toward the egg with outstretched arm cradles, accordion briefcases jangling around each elbow's crook. Only after Glen reached within trolling distance did Byron casually secure the egg by placing a three-quarter inch socket on its top. Seeing this, Glen bowed his posture, rested his caseload against the work bench, wiped lapels with both hands, and removed a retractable pen from inside his sportcoat which he held in a fist pressed against his jaw as he began to circle the egg, highstepping over Byron and David's horizontal legs heeled against the work bench as he did so. Then, clicking the pen open at the tempo of a protracted claw, he flicked the egg's top with its tip to, presumably, calibrate its center of gravity. Finding a torn saranwrap swatch haphazardly resealed, Glen kneeled on the salon carpet, wafted his hand from egg to nostril, then turned toward Byron with a soft shakle of the head as if like a disappointed father discovering their child opened a present too early.

— For Christ sake Glen just have a toot.

— Now what kind of dad would I be if I snorted dirty coke in front of my son here?

Byron extended his smartphone in Glen's direction, then swandove his index finger upon its screen.

— Glen Grynszpan. You are...not the father!

— Fucking Maury...Glen muttered against the warbled whoops punctuating the talk show's judgment. — Look B as you know I only got ninety six billable seventh-hours in a day. And I'm spending most of them working this false light tort regarding that recent hit piece on me in the Weehawken Reporter so how about we-

— Oh yeah, what was that headline again? Local attorney fights waterfront erection?

— And you sure as shit know you know I can't comment on pending litigation so how about we just get to cleaning these here drugs.

— You may approach the work bench, counselor.

— Wait where's the nail polish remover? I mean you guys did get the notarized memo I couriered over, right?

— Why would we source the nail polish remover if you're the one living with Mom.

— Yeah well after our podcast, Joyce began marking the levels on all her nailcare bottles. Gawl! ...Glen synchronized shoving balled fists down with the wingtip he stomped on salon's carpet. — Treats me like I'm in high school! And why is it always Mom with Joyce but with Dad it's Glen huh, B?

— Probably because you're my uncle.

— Yeah. You're. As in were. Because look just like your aunt Joyce stepped up to be your forever mother I'm ready to step up too, B. To be honest I contend I already have, I mean I've had as much of a hand in getting your creative career going as she has.

Byron again extended his phone at Glen's eye level, then tapped.

— Barrister Grynzspan. I have determined that was a lie.

Glen winced, then clawed the air with both hands as if a stress ball.

— Look B let's just get to brass facts here because we both know Papa Grinnie's toot clear float recipe calls for a heaping helping of nail polish remover.

— Ok so wha you want me to knock on that tug's hull on the next slip over see if they could spare a cup for our booger sugar, that it?

— Thought you'd at least look into that dockbox out on the stern.

— For nail polish remover? Didn't think the previous captain ran with that type of crowd.

Glen leapt out the salon with one exaggerated step and onto the stern deck; kneeling above an open dockbox and rummaging through it like a pig to a trough, he returned with the same breeze he let in, swishing a sloshing metal canister over his head as if it were a proselytizer's tambourine.



—Acetone. Protector of pulses. Savior of stepped-on shit. Patron saint of sinii.

—Wait I'm no expert but is it safe to like use boat chemicals to clean some cocaine egg?

—B looks like this new friend of yours needs a quick acetone demo. You got any eight hundred grit laying around here?

—No.

—No you don't have the sandpaper or no I shouldn't do the demo? Wait wait wait question withdrawn, just realized I got my stubble grown out to the same grit.

After removing, then folding his sportcoat over a teak step on the pilothouse staircase, Glen flung his tie over his shoulder, dashed acetone on his palm, and dramatically splashed his cheeks and chin as if auditioning for an aftershave commercial.

—Glen. Whatever you're about to do, you really don't have to do it.

—Now if acetone wasn't such a neat great cleaning agent...After wagging an instructive index finger toward David in a circular motion, Glen bent over the gunwale, wrapped his shins around two stainless steel rod holders jutting underneath so that his torso dangled over the side of the stern deck as if seasick.

—Would I be able to do this? There Glen swayed his upside-down chin back and forth against the hull as lapping wake splashed scalp sutures exposed by gravity's pull on its dangling bangs.

—That hull's so damn clean you can set your watch to it! Whoa lil help there b!...

Watching Glen's wingtipped heels flail while hearing a yelp muffled by the sheened hull smeared by his acetone-soaked swaying face, Byron somersaulted gum between tips of teeth for a dramatic beat before grabbing Glen by his starched cotton collar to lever him upright.

—I mean just take a look at how the acetone broke up the gunk on the hull. Now imagine what it'll do to the gunk in that powdered egg of yours no really look you can't see from that angle, lean over the gunwale see for yourself.

—No need unc. That white shit smeared on your chin's all the evidence we need. Matter facts if I didn't know better I'd say you've been stepping out on Joyce letting missus claus take nightly sleigh rides on your face.

—Well for the record it's your forever mother who taps out from that position before I do. Ok now that we got our acetone all we need is a sheaf of ten micron filter paper, a Meyers beaker, a squeeze bottle, and a roll of autoclave tape.

—Ok look we got your damn memo Glen, but all we could find is some coffee filters, a turkey baster, and this mayor mccheese glass. No tape though.

Glen pinched his nosebridge as he began pacing the salon in two-step circuits.

—You check down in the engine room?

—Did a total inventory stem to stern, all that's down there are sockets, koozies, screwdrivers, and a couple spare fuel filters.

—Fuel filters, you say?...With the earnest alacrity of a contestant on an obstacle-driven game show, Glen clean-and-jerked the salon's floor hatch, propped it at a ninety-five degree angle against the portside window, then leapt down into the engine room below, where he was not seen but heard by virtue of his wingtips landing upon the fiberglass floor in a flammed clack, the tinny clatter of rummaged tools, and the rip and spit of a bit plastic pouch; at which time both Byron and David watched two black bands emerge from the hatch's hole to land at their feet like gifts from a wishing well.

—Gaskets...Glen gruntnunciated as he clutched a cabinet handle for leverage to haul himself from the engine room back up to the salon floor. —Sealer of flow state. Favorite of flanges. Protector of pressure.

—You need two of those there Glen?

—Yeah one for the drugs, one for my rug. Okay now wait...Hands on head pinning his hairpiece back, Glen looked down at the engine room, then swiveled waddling elbows between it and Byron. —Wait just one nonbillable second. B. This boat, it ain't a sailboat.

—Quite trenchant counselor. And to think all this time, David and I couldn't square the lack of sails on board.

—Which means this is a powerboat.

—Yes.

—Which means big, lead acid batteries.

—Glen.

—I mean when Joyce told me you got a gig working on some boat, thought it'd be on some boomer's schooner told her not to worry because batteries on those things are about the size of my recess dumps at the courthouse. But having seen the cubic inches on these diesels, I mean holy shit B got to be at least two eight Ds on board probably looking at upwards of two thousand cold cranking amps.

—Instead of talking bout cranking amps how bout we start cleaning the crank out of this here egg-

—Ok so you there, smells like you've been in the engine room with him. Has B seemed comfortable working near those two big batteries down there?

—Comfortable? Yeah, he's comfortable. Comfortable enough to turn me upside down without my consent, comfortable enough to baste me with fuel that comfortable enough for you?

—Yes, that is comforting...Glen pressed his palm to a breast pocket sewn shut. I mean I don't want to embarrass you in front of your new friend here B, but-

—Then don't.

—David, I don't know if you know that your Byron here-

—He doesn't.

—Ok ok I won't say nothing.

—Thank you I appreciate th-

—Look all I'll say is that big batteries used to be a bit of a trigger for Byron look don't get mad ok B because you know I've always had faith in you. I mean why else would I have bought the hashtag rights to battery bravery if not for this very moment right here?

— Put your goddamned phone away Glen.

— Oh come on, B!

— Don't come on me as if I'm Joyce's tits.

— Puh please-please B? Because let me tell you there's nothing better as a father figure than sharing your son's growth across your family of followers now wait a sec B don't get mad ok just talk to me because real talk the monthly retainers on these hashtags cost something fierce I tell you what just daddy dialogue alone's costing me-

The slammed salon door's echo momentarily punctuated the two men's conversation, until Byron's head wedged through the gap created by its recoil to shout — Want some daddy dialogue? Hey pops, your fucking wig's on backward!

As stern lines cackled from the yawed strain of Byron's exiting momentum, Glen peered into his reflection projected on the galley microwave's black window.

— So, uh Glen, I was wondering...

— Barrister Grynzspan...Glen petulantly barked while tapping the microwave window as if having paid for an item which had not yet been vended.

— Yeah sure uh Barrister Grynzspan I, well I just wanted to know how you know so much about-

— What, drugs? Suddenly, Glen snatched his hairpiece, catburgling his scalp without breaking gaze or posture. — I practice law in the state of New Jersey kid. That's how I know so much about drugs.

— No I, I was gonna say yachts like all that stuff you know about cold cranking amps and nail polish remover in the dock box like I've been passing the time reading some of the manuals on board here and it's kind of interesting how all the systems have to-

— Asked...Glen stopped to fully concentrate on torquing a head tonsured with wig tape one way while twirling the blonde hairpiece he held above in the opposite direction; a movement which from David's vantage point resembled a shih tzu chasing its tail on a flesh-colored lazy susan. — And answered.

Having placed his hairpiece on his scalp with the cautious finality of a crane releasing a capstone, Glen clapped his hands clean.

—Ok so you ready to help me scramble this here drug egg?

—Honestly I don't know much about cleaning drugs, so I guess you tell me.

—No son, you tell me. Because proprietary knowledge of Papa Grinnie's toot clear float recipe is conditionally contingent on your disclosure of any and all hearsay from yesterday's investor meeting.

—Hearsay. And that means what exactly?

—Means what the fucking word says it means. So say what you heard, kid.

—Okay sure well I remember they talked about using Likecoin to build some housing development in the marina something called the Atman Projects.

—Shit, son!...Glen flung a backhand toward the bow. — I know that! It's on the goddamned gate out front!

—Yeah so after Byron dove underwater our boss Mister Van Sant—  
—Juug.

—Oh ok, so you do know him.

—Know enough to know we can dispense with the fucking honorifics.

—Ok fine well yeah Juug he was talking about how the end game of this Likecoin play was to like get millennial parents to cosign his social mortgages, something about tapping the American Dream dry one family tree at a time.

—And to your recollection Juug was pitching this to a potential Likecoin investor a man who B describes as let me find my notes here a neat russian aluminum magnet who totally gets what you two are trying to do here on this here yacht the American Dream.

—Yeah now I remember Juug, he called him Kuvetli.

—Kuvetli?...Glen scrunched his face, then pinched a patch of forehead. — As in Mortimer Kuvetli?

— Fuck if I know. Seems like you know the man better than I do.

— Can't know a man like that. Asking to know a man like that is like asking money to know its maker.

— Well I know he didn't give any money to Juug. That was the weird thing this Russian guy got a billion Likecoin plus the title to this boat without-

— Yacht.

— Yacht yes but didn't give anything up in return.

— Except for this egg he gifted you.

— Well yeah. He called it like this participation trophy, something about it being an up payment for our future success.

Glen drifted both palms down his face, stretching cheeks and chin like melted putty. — The mayor mccheese glass David, if you please.

— Why we even cleaning this coke anyway? Looks pretty white to me.

— Always got to proofread pleasure's fine print, son... Glen spat into the mayor mccheese glass, then contemplatively wiped its insides clean, striped tie as saloon rag. — I mean sure this egg probably started out pure in Peru. Coffee filter. But there's a lot of steps between there and here, each one providing opportunities to step on the brick and add some toxic shit. Gasket. Kind of like how your neat new boss is adding toxic shit to these social mortgages he's got you two touting.

— Wait. what kind of toxic shit?

— Interest markups, lidor fees, adjustable rates based on prevailing markets that they themselves manipulate not to mention the dark pool deriv-

— No I mean the drugs.

— Baby laxative if you're lucky. Cattle dewormer and fentanyl if you're not.

— Cattle dewormer?

— Don't fret, boss. This is why the good lord created Glen Grynzspan, so he could in turn create the toot clear float. Ok so I've already

drummed the coffee filter over the glass with this gasket, now just need to mince this piece of egg with my State Bar card here and scoopy doop the powder on top of the filter paper here's the acetone canister and turkey baster you are now free to do the honors.

— Uh, what honors?

— The high honor of dipping thy psalter in thy font, and baptizing thy blow.

— Ok which means-

— Just suck the acetone with the turkey baster and then squirt it on top of the powder! I mean gawl!

— Well how should I know?

— How shouldn't you? Cleaning drugs should be s i p for all you creative types.

— Ess eye pee?

— Standard insufflation procedure.

— Fine look now that I actually know what to do I can actually do it ok so I'll baste the powder with the damn turkey bwait, uh, Glen?

— Hold on kid looking for a foil pan to-

— No Glen look the powder, I think I went and squirt too much of the acetone on it, it it's all turning into a puddle goddammit I knew I'd fuck this up somehow.

— Jesus kid, have some faith in the process. See it's already drying out.

— Oh. Huh.

— You know, puddles triggered Byron for a minute there. Couldn't eat any halal for the better part of a presidential administration. Something about wet fried goat meat reminded him of his late father.

— I uh, I'm sorry to hear that.

— That's kind of you to say. Because missing out on Jersey City halal is no small sacrifice. And don't get me started whenever Jiffy

Lube had their quarterly battery blowout sale had to avoid seventy eight added close to an hour to B and Joyce's therapy commute.

—And Joyce is your wife?

—Yep. No shame in it, you know.

—What, having a wife?

—Fuck no. Having a wife is all shame, son. Therapy.

—Yeah no sure, like with all the things that've gone wrong recently I, I'd be crazy to think something isn't wrong with me. But it's not like I can afford to pay a therapist to-

—Therapy isn't about paying a headshrinker to figure out what went wrong. It's about investing in yourself to figure out how to get right.

—Well I don't think I can afford that either.

—Nonsense. A time-disciplined man like yourself should be up to his nuts in self-belief.

—A what?

—B tells me you live life two-fifths of an hour at a time. Me I'm more on a sevenths-of-an-hour billing cadence but time-based heuristics sure are something, aren't they?

—Look I'll tell you what I already told Byron. I'm not going to be some lab rat for your Apply The High scheme.

—Know what, you're right. You're not a lab rat...After using the back of the tuna filet knife to sweep cocaine at soufflé consistency off the drummed coffee filter and into the foil pan, Glen fired off a gratuitously long glance at David, then muttered—At least lab rats spin a fuckin' wheel...before returning to his work circuit, rolling the rubber gasket off the Mayor McCheese glass, replacing the acetone-soaked coffee filter on its rim with a dry one, then after rerolling the gasket back over the glass to drum the dry filter taut against its rim, he scooped a chunk off the egg with a spoon, place a flimsy yet sturdy State BAR card atop the spoon so a torquing thumb could squish chunk into powder that he then drizzled on the drummed coffee filter with the intensity and purpose of a confectioner staging on garnish. Then after firing another glance that ricocheted between



David's eyes and the turkey baster held aloof at his hip, Glen shot a passive-aggressive nasal scoff through barrels of both nostrils, his sarcastic ammunition triggering David to peevishly baste the powder with acetone. And as he waited for the drug puddle on the filter to solidify into scrapable slurry, David endured a series of Glen's psycho-pharmacogeneurological talking points, each punctuated by Glen lecture-pointing a tuna filet knife caked in white residue on various parts of his toupeed-skewed skull.

—Now all we got to do it pop this white loaf in the oven for it to desiccate at two hundred degrees for a few and the three of us'll be snorting in high cotton-

—How long should that take because I really do need to get back to Park Slope so I can hit my daily job application quota.

—Just enough time to bend your ear on this Three's Bumpany screenplay I'm pitching on the early days of Apply the High therapy. See these studios are giving me all sorts of limpducked headwinds about how they can't sell a family dramedy centered around a schedule one drug to their ad networks.

—And I give a fuck why.

—Well B mentioned you work in advertising, thinking once this white loaf's dry you and I can chop it up burn some narratological calories on how best to tell a family story through the lines which bind them.

—Well B should have also mentioned I haven't worked in an ad agency for more than a year or for that matter anywhere else. Which reminds me I heard you say on your podcast you used to work at Murk what are the chances of you getting me an in there because I do have some pharmaceutical proofreading experience.

Raised eyebrows pushed Glen's hairpiece into retreat beneath a jaw slacked at an incredulity reserved for clients declining to appeal their conviction.

—David, the mind is a terrible thing to waste on the North Jersey cartel, you know that right?...Glen asked while he opened the oven door, its released steam smelling of burnt vodka singeing David's nostrils in its waft out the oven and up through the open hatch letting

in a parallelogram of sunlight which, due to the intruding mid-morning flood tide, bobbed as it spotlighted the foil pan placed on the counter.

—Now David, before you or B ingests this heretofore product, it is my jurisfiduciary duty to evaluate any potential insufflative harm.

—Wait what?...David asked a man too enamored with the white clump he swished between fingers and thumb to answer; and who, after leaning into limbo position and poising a pinched hand above a face peeling back below the horizon, released the powder above his right nostril like an arcade claw over a prize chute, then produced the sound of a man attempting to gargle his own nose.

—Hoo doggie!...Glen exclaimed while jabberwockying himself upright. —That's some certified organic shit Bignon himself would be proud of.

—So I'm guessing that means the coke is clean.

—David, let's just say we are now free to season our holiday hams. Now hand me that empty foil pan so we can see how much of the egg's left over after scrambling all the adulterants out.

Having removed a digital scale from a starched shirt pocket, and after zeroing out the scale with the empty pan, Glen switched in the foil pan filled with the white caked product; then, looking down at the scale's LCD screen, he sheepishly scratched the back of a low-hung neck like an unsuspecting owner of a record-breaking 4h hog.

—Forty two grams, boy howdy that there is quite the, quite the uh-

—Quite the what, jail sentence? I mean you are a lawyer, right? So you surely know that this egg no matter how much we clean it, that possessing it is, is...David stopped to pull out his phone and rapidly tap its screen. —A class B felony punishable by up to nine years in prison and a hundred thousand dollar fine as it is in violation of-

—New Jersey subscript two twenty dash sixteen...Glen's nostrils audibly aired in frustration. —Listen just because you haven't let your nuts hang yet doesn't mean you can try to shove mine back up into my body cavity.

—The fuck is with you Chiantis rooting for my balls to drop like, like I'm some fucking creative cinderella?

—Let's get one thing straight kid. I ain't a Chianti. I may represent em, even try to reproduce em on occasion, but me myself-

—Ok well I'm not either. And I don't know how many times I need to tell you and your son or nephew or whoever Byron is to you that doing a bunch of blow won't change that.

—B doesn't want you to be him. Shit most of the time, he doesn't want to be him. He just wants you to be who you can become.

—Well I don't think I can be that either.

—Oh ho, that so?...Glen turned a hunched back to David so he could sprinkle powder on the inside of his outstretched pinky. — Brring brring David, your future you is on the-

—He already refused the call, Glen.

David and Glen turned toward the salon door to find Byron slithering through the gap created from his exit's recoil.

—Sorry about that back there just then. Shouldn't have left him with you unattended.

—No worries B I was just educating your friend on the finer psychopharmacological points of-

—Talking about leaving you unattended, unc...Byron said as he vaulted down the staircase's parallel barred railing without touching its four stairs to land in the cramped galley; where after removing a carbon steel painter's tool from a beige plastic bag that had been jangling from his wrist, he leaned between the two men to scoop product from pan before sniffing the painter tool's tine with the practiced elegance of a sommelier sipping a ladle. — Sorry David this one's all apply the high all the time. Might as well get the goddamned phrase tattooed on his nut sack.

—Tell you what, if the image of me strapped to a dentist's chair with my sack spread taut, if that's what it takes to change you twoses decision-making calculus on applying the high two point oh why I'll clean the goddamned forceps myself.

—No look that's not necessary, I mean on some level I can appreciate both of you trying to help me improve myself with this cocaine therapy of yours but I, I just don't think it's for me right now.

—Exactly see this therapy isn't for your present me but your future you! Why else you think I put him on the horn for you just now?

—Ok well right now my focus is making enough for my present me to survive. So I'll just take my half of this scrambled drug egg and we can go our separate-

—Your half?...Byron and Glen scoffed in two-part harmony.

—Yeah my half. The Russian gave the egg to both of us, didn't he?

—He didn't give it to us. He gifted it to us. There is a difference, you know that right?

—Actually no I don't know that. What I do know is that this stuff has some serious street value because this one time at a party I paid this girl twenty bucks for just one line, so-

—Oh ho! So this powder's good enough to add value to the streets, but not good enough to add value to yourself?

—Dammit I already told you I can't afford to add value to myself, at least not right now not with this traumatizing economy like have you seen the latest quarterly job-

—David, if I may...Glen's fused index finger pistols snouted his caked nose. —Now since you're not my client I'm aware that your business isn't necessarily mine, at least not at this juncture even so that said I do feel like it is in both mine and my boy B's interests to talk to you like a dutch uncle here as you consider your options. Because look, I know a belt-and-suspended soul when I see one. And after hearing from B that your story is that you don't have one, then having seen your search results or lack thereof from my vantage point it looks as if this powder gift right here might just be your last best chance to assert yourself in the cosmos.

—Cosmos?...David scoffed, then spat in the galley sink. —Don't talk to me about asserting myself in the cosmos you kidding me? Cosmos?! I just hope I can assert myself on next month's rent check!

—Look David don't get mad on account of Glen like I said he's-

—Fuck that. Let me talk to you like your dutch nephew for a sec Barrister Grynzspan because you're right my business isn't yours. You know why? Because there is no goddamned business to speak of! I mean holy shit last week got lucky enough to get to the third drink on a first date guess what I wasn't thinking about asserting myself in the cosmos I was thinking how to close the deal after asking her to split the bill damnit Byron can you please fucking stop with the motherfucking scraping!

Byron shrugged, then stuck the painter's tool into the galley's white cabinets like a lumberjack at quitting time.

—Can you give us the vessel Glen.

—Sure B. Now as an attorney I cannot encourage the furtherance of a crime, but let me offer as a closing thought that as a practical matter consuming the evidence as opposed to selling it would give you let's call it pleasure's plausible deniability for lack of a-

—Glen, we talked about this. Just be plain with your speech.

—You two simply vacuumed the whole egg mess up. See? Glen's index finger suggestively tapped the side of his nose. —And fellas we are under zero obligation to divulge which appliance was used.

—Great Glen. We have been so advised.

After saluting both men with the tuna filet knife with such goofy ebullience that he inadvertently detached several toupee sutures, Glen waddled backwards out the salon door, dangling cupped palms between bowed thighs that inferred his dire need to cradle overgrown testes. Where in the immediate moments after Glen had crossed the entryway's threshold, Byron shut the salon door with the urgency of getting rid of a varmint's presence.

—Let the straws fly high, gentlemen!...Came muffled behind the salon bulkhead door, its bobbing sill intermittently framing the top of Glen's scalp and a hand pinning hairpiece half-flapping against stiff headwinds as if it were a hat.

## the starting line

Caked white crags clung to a foil pan pivoting upright into diamond position, with Byron balancing the pan's lowest point with a finger on its highest point with the technique of a placekicker's holder.

—Linger awhile dude.

—Linger awhile?

—You know, help me jar it all loose.

—Jar it all loose.

With his free hand, Byron positioned his phone beneath the pan's bottom corner; then, picking up the painter's tool, he looked up at David, nodded downward, and began tapping its edge against his smartphone's screen like an expectant hockey stick on a power play. Seeing this, David shot mocking air through his nose, the exact opposite of a snort, shook a pursed-lipped head before knocking the back of the foil pan once with a cusped, sarcastically limp knuckle. Then he curiously felt his rolling eyes stop in their tracks so they

could track white clumps pockmarked in sheen avalanche off the foil pan, onto the phone's black screen, and within threshing vicinity of a painter's tool mincing clumps into powder, sweeping powder into a pile, then sorting a portion of that pile into two inch-long, cigarette-girthed parallel lines. Snapped out of his trance by the sound of Byron setting the painter's tool down with adjudicative velocity, David then watched Byron dig a rolled-up twenty out from his jeans' pocketwatch pocket, before tilting the bill in David's direction shivering as if it were a rookie moneylender's signing pen.

—I uh, it's a little early for me.

Byron shrugged, then stuck the spiraled currency inside his snout.

—Or maybe it's a little too late.

—Look Byron I know what you're trying to do here.

—Yeah and what's that?

—Well I don't know exactly what but it's almost like you're trying to tempt me into saving mys-

There David was interrupted by the sound of a man attempting to inhale his own nose.

—Ain't no almost about it Engram...Byron grunted beneath a Newton's cradle of dangling blond bangs swaying with and against his snort's momentum. —But look if you're scared about that sort of thing I get it.

—Scared to what, save myself? Come on that's silly.

—It's not silly, silly, it's your soul! Overhauling something like that should pucker your asshole something fierce. Sure as shit puckered mine, insofar what was left of-

—Dammit I'm not scared to do it ok to apply the high it's just that, well maybe I think it's simply not worth doing.

Byron looked at David as if evaluating an open facial wound.

—Nothing's worth doing until you've done it. Because it's in the act of doing that we redeem the choice of the doer.

—Look just because you're wearing duck canvas coveralls doesn't make these lunchpail tautologies you're spouting any more poignant.

—No sure but like aren't you a little concerned you haven't really done anything on this here vessel the American Dream? Especially after we were given this neat gift by our new Russian investor?

—Given this gift? More like given this grift I mean holy shit the fact that you're so goddamned earnest you can't see how much a fucking farce all of this is how getting paid in shitty crypto for working all the livelong day on this here vessel the American fucking Dream is-

—Hey don't get mad, okay?

—Damnit I'm not mad, I...David stopped to stare at white powder dashed and dotted on his smartphone's black screen, then blinked deeply and sporadically as if a filmed hostage attempting to communicate with the outside world. —When you're a kid, they make you feel like everything you do is worth doing. Shit, they give you trophies for doing it. But really all you're doing is participating in the same damn grift game as everyone else. Sixteen years sitting at a desk playing the same damn bigoted game of low expectations until one day you get in a gown hear some smarmy success story troll the class of who the fuck cares to go forth and do something worth doing. To hashtag run your race.

—Yeah but like see this line? This here line can be starting line for the rest-

—But when you finally get out into the world, all you can see are all these damn things that aren't worth doing. But the thing is, you have to do them in order to survive. Which means you can't hashtag run your race because you're too busy running yourself into a rut filling up some rich fuck's sales funnel.

—Yeah but like see this pile on the screen? Guess what piles are great for Engram? That's right filling in ruts so how about you and I get to-

—So even if by sheer bumblefuck luck you do find something that's actually worth doing, you can't do anything about it because the whole damn existential purpose these days is to make your net worth



worthy enough to own your own home, your own goddamned participation trophy in the goddamned American Dream.

— Exactly and speaking of participation trophies, remember how that neat shiny-suited Russian said that this here egg is our participation trophy? An up payment if you will for our future usses?

— Then one day having put in your forty years submitting to the same bigotry of low expectations as your previous sixteen some smarm hr matron wearing the same denim muumuu your kindergarten teacher did when she gave you your first trophy gives you your last one the brand but not before hashtagging you as found your finish line while making you wheeze out one last corporate hollow smile to meet the flash that puts you out to pasture.

— Well speaking of smiles look at this if I turn the ends up on this line with my painter's tool here-

— Will you please just stop!

— Stop what? Me finding ways to turn that unproductive frown of yours upside-

— Damnit stop pitching me about how this line can be the starting line for the rest of my life or that this line'll get my heart racing again or whatever titty-pinching metaphor you may have for-

— Okay I mean sure but that's not the part of you I want racing.

— What?

After grabbing a maglight off the portside windowsill, Byron stood atop the galley's counter and threw a narrow beam that sharply carved David's dark silhouette against the galley's white cabinet in the aesthetic of child's shadow portrait.

— Now do you see?

— What, my shadow? You want me to snort this shit just so I can race my shadow?

— Dammit Engram I want you to get out in front of it! Have you lead it for once instead of having it lead you.

—And where the fuck am I supposed to take it? I'm stuck here with you working for free on the American Dream.

—Not for free David. For Likecoin.

—Dammit Byron. Likecoin is a scam, you know that right?

—Scams make the best stories Engram. You know that, right? I mean you tell me are you like the rest of these fucking sluggers who think the only reason something's worth doing is if they're paid to do it? Or are you about the love of the game, about pushing yourself to pull it all off?

—Pull what off? My fucking aorta? Look maybe you need to consider the fact that if you have to snort something to do else that thing wasn't worth doing in the first place.

—Sure thing Engram. Right after consider the fact that maybe all you'll ever do with your life is what you'll get paid to do.

—Damnit I'm not getting paid! You fucking know that!

—Exactly. So why'd you even take this job in the first place?

—I, look I panicked okay? Started believing there weren't any other opportunities out there, nowhere else to place my hope and then when I actually got a response to my Likecoin application I guess I went and took the bait is that what you wanted to hear?

—I mean wow is this crazy or what because I used the same logic for my pleasure based creative rehabilitation. Like why would I even snort these fucking drugs in the first place?... Byron tapped a white-residued painter's tool against his temple. — Because I panicked. Started believing there weren't any other opportunities in here. Nowhere else to place my hope. And then after I got a response to my powder application guess I took the bait too same as you.

—That is some specious fucking logic there Byron.

—That's species logic, fool! All we are are stoned apes, you know that right Engram? I mean holy shit humans used pleasure to establish dominion over the planet and you're still flicking your dick about whether you should use pleasure to establish dominion over yourself?

—Yeah but...

Fists on hips, Byron craned his neck and confront David's avoidant eyes like an offended ostrich.

— Yeah but what.

— Yeah but aren't there serious side effects to doing a bunch of coke every day?

— Dude. For anyone who takes their work seriously, life becomes a side effect. I mean look man listen... Byron drug the palms just dug into eye sockets down slacked cheeks so that the pinkies of pronating wrists wiped beaded rheum from nostril crevices while his other six fingers squished lips vertical before pressing against their opposite in exasperated supplication. — Do the drugs or don't do them. You're gonna regret both, mmkay? Just don't not do drugs because you're coddling your future you.

— See that's the problem. All this abstract future me shit makes this apply the high therapy sound like a pyramid scheme.

— Oh ho! So you read the National Geographic that I left out?

— What?

— On how the Incas made themselves make the pyramids? No?

— No.

David watched Byron bound into the head, heard him fling open its medicine cabinet before he returned holding a furled magazine in one hand while rerolling the twenty dollar bill against his jeans' corrugated hip seam with the other.

— Look Byron-

— No just listen.

Byron placed the index finger originally raised at David to indicate that his consumption overrode his objection against his right nostril; then lodging the rolled twenty in his left, he stooped down to ingest a three-inch line passing ferry wake had jostled into a jagged lightning-bolt shape of a bullish financial projection.

— Hoo fuckin doggie!

After attempting to clear his nasal passages with a clogged flatulent sound of a whoopee cushion exhaling underwater, Byron lifted his left flip-flop atop the work bench to unfurl the magazine over a leg bent in halftime-speech position.

—On truth, sir, I detest the coca leaf no less than anyone, but need forced me to chew it. Hear that David? Need.

—Look I'll be sure to read the article on my bus ride back but I really need to head out soon so I can make the five twenty two or else I'll have to wait a whole nother hour-

—Without coca, I would not be able to bear the burden. With it, I have strength and vigor to undertake my labors. Hear that David?

—Yes damnit I'm right here there's no need to-

Byron placed the recoiled magazine to his mouth so he could amplify his recitation to a booming kazoo. —Strength and vigor to undertake my labors!

—Know what maybe improved productivity under imperial rule doesn't start my engine the way it starts yours.

—And the fuck you know about starting your engine?

—Look it's a metaphor okay.

—Ok and the fuck you know about metaphors?

—Well despite my self-recriminations I am a-

—Nope no you're not. Said it yourself you don't write you bore God. And I mean holy shit David this stuff is a lot of things but boring ain't one of them. Unless we're talking septums but that's why Glen cleaned all that gunk out of the coke in the first place see I got all your bases covered here.

—Look even if I wanted to-

—Oh ho! So you do want to?

—That's my point. It doesn't matter what I want to do. The only thing that matters is that I can't afford to do it.

—Nevermind that. Leave it to me to turn that want into a wish.

—A wish.

— Yes a wish. I mean holy shit Engram the way you tell it you've been victimized by this economy so many times you deserve a wish same way an adolescent with relapsing leukemia does.

— Look I already heard all this from Glen when you left after your tantrum ok? How Apply The High is simply make a wish for adults, how just as every pediatric oncologist has John Cena on speed dial, so should every psychiatric professional have, have-

— Juan Coca sure but did you know that wishes improve a child's quality of life in a bunch of different ways all of which ultimately produce better health outcomes? And that's not Glen, David, that's the goddamned New England Journal of Medicine.

— Damnit Byron. I'm not a child.

— That's what I'm trying to tell you see this? ... Byron peeled a prospector-sized nugget off the foil pan which he then flung against his forehead at the velocity of intent so that its disintegrated ricochet peppered David's face before falling onto the galley's parquet floor.

— This right here will get you back to being one. Back when anything you did was worth doing. And before you got a trophy for doing it. I mean holy shit David who doesn't want that wish?

— Look I can see how badly you wanna be my pity genie but I'm not some charity case.

— First thing you've said I agree with Engram. Then how about we make a bet?

— A bet.

— Yeah like I bet I can get your future you working for you, starting today.

— Dude what does that even mean? Like all this carnival barking future me shit it makes this therapy of yours too abstract to even understand.

— See that's why you're like the perfect patient for my forever mom's apply the high therapy because she really needs a present you that's as neurotic about time as you are. See I see you Engram. You don't think I do, but I do. I see how you've been marking the back

of your old pink slip with those time tallies of yours you got what eight of them today, that's like what, four hours of work?

—Technically a little over three and a half but if you also count the unconscious thought that goes into-

—Ok so I bet I can double that you know getting your future you working for you starting today.

—Look I don't even know if my future me is going to be around here much longer. I just got a thirty-day eviction notice on my Park Slope apartment on account of my landlord selling his building over to some investment firm which means I gotta find three months rent just to get into a new place which for me is at least six straight weeks of freelance work which means in order to keep future me from heading back to my parents with my dick between my wallet, present me needed to find a paying job two weeks ago.

—So stay here.

—Here? You mean on the boat?

—You see any other here here Engram? I mean like who exactly's gonna stop you?

—Well Juug. Then there's that Russian who I actually owns the-

—You know, besides you.

David blinked twice, crinkled his lips, then shrugged as if sloughing off a physical burden.

—Shit. I guess nobody now.

—See I'm already solving problems for your future you. Now with that said, I will need for you to pledge some advance collateral as a good faith gesture for our bet.

—Collateral for what.

Byron smiled at the painter's tool he stirred the pile of powder with before tapping its tine against his smartphone's screen and free caked cocaine residue with the contemplative etiquette of a Sufi's spoon against saucer.

—The debt incurred.

— Which means what exactly.

— Means how bout you put up your share of all the Likecoin we're gonna earn from these hopecore posts we're about to shoot.

— You do know Likecoin is worthless, right?

— And you've put a similar valuation on your future you. So like for Likecoin I mean that sounds reasonable right?

David slowly let air out his nose as if deflating a toy before placing it in long-term storage. — None of this sounds reasonable.

— Yeah but like what else do you have to lose.

— What do I have to lose? How about arterial lining for-

— You know, except who you've become.

David looked down to Byron's black screen, its thin white line across its landscape a moonlit horizon on a night voyage. — Fine. I'll do one.

— He gonna do one he gonna do one! That's what I'm talking about when I talk about Ameri-

— Just please calm down. Now make sure it isn't a big one.

— Sure just a quick whiffer picker-upper. Here take the green baton here while I grab the scale to divvy out your proper nose dosage.

With unblinking eyes and unsettled breath, David twisted the rolled money tighter with both hands, shoved the green coil in his snout, and bowed down to the powder on the screen; where, with a sniff more snore than snort, David swept the line of cocaine off the smartphone screen and onto the galley floor.

— Gonna need a little more urgency from you there chief.

— Fuck wait wait wait I think I can salvage most of it if I can just sort it on the floor here ah jeez damn sweaty hands wait maybe if I just mush it into a wet ball and jam it up my nose it's still somewhat effective that way, right?

Byron stooped on one knee so he could level his gaze with David's, as if earning a toddler or golden retriever's trust. — Dude you spilled an allele's worth of the egg. There's lots still left alright so no worries.

—Byron I appreciate what you're trying to do here but maybe this is a sign that-

—Fuck yeah it's a sign! It's a sign to stop putting powder on a pedestal. Drugs are like art or genitalia in that they're best approached as if they're approachable, you know that right?

—No but I guess I more or less get what you're-

—Now as far as technique, I've found that a good snort thought to have is to think of yourself as a referee, and you're using your nose to whistle a reverse foul on your brain you know because instead of exhaling you're inhaling.

—So you mean just breathe.

—No I don't mean breathe. I mean breathing at the velocity of intent.

—Ok so how do I do that.

—Just think about how different you'll be after the next breath you take. You're excited to meet that person yes? Your future you?

—Yeah sure but my hands, are they supposed to be shaking like this?

—Not before you take the drugs, no. Here just cross them over your chest. You right or left nostriled?

—What? I, I I guess right. Wait so like right off the webbing of your hand?

—Best way to find your reptile mind.

Byron peeled back David's coffin-armed torso at tango level with one arm, shouted —Hark! Let us make this farce our fate! then smothered powder into David's right nostril as if putting something spilled back in its container.

—Yowza.

—More like yowza bobowza, right?

—Dude, what are you?...David asked the thumb and index finger pinching his voicebox.

—Lymph nodes firing out, good. Now let's see those black holes...Byron's cusped knuckle lifted David's chin. —Why they're positively peristaltic! Pulsing like a porn star's puckering-



— Wait, what? Let me see... David twirled himself in circles in his search for a reflective surface until, with his high's heightened periphery, he caught his own whirling blur in the medicine cabinet's mirror through the head's open door; then, as if suddenly ferromagnetically infused, David leapt toward the mirror, shutting the head door behind him with his trail foot's achilles.

— Just don't spit the drip there bud...

Inside the closed head, David leaned close enough to the mirror that he could see his rapid breath fog it. Propped up by locked elbows, he clocked a distant speck of glossed light pass behind his eyes similar to watching someone pass a peephole from the outside looking in. After a series of blinks fluttered out his manic lucidity as if someone was changing his noggin's projector reel, David grunted a thick snort that jostled his skull.

— Drip's the cherry on top of that serotonin sundae you got there.

Just as Byron leaned into the head's door to place a surveilling ear, he felt its swinging breeze sweep his bangs back with enough force that it flung him backwards. Teetering jabberwockingly back upright, he came upon David's outstretched phone's red timer set to twenty five minutes, smiled, then uttered — Let us play... with the soft solemnity of a leader concluding initiation rites.

## portion controls

—Scale says forty one grams.

—And you're sure that you-

—Yes I zeroed out the pan first.

—Ok now how many minutes are one of your work units?

—Twenty five look we don't have to adhere to my silly pomodoro work process it's really not that imp-

—And how many weeks til Labor Day?

—I uh I think about twelve, twelve and a half...you know you got a calendar on your phone same as me.

—Now if remember right Joyce's neat new formula's is creative production equals pleasure over time and so with our suggested nose dosage at a quarter gram a day we just need to divide-

—Quarter gram a day? That kinda seems like a lot.

—As much as what these pediatricians prescribe in amphetamine salts to their patients over at school twenty eight and most of them haven't even pushed a pube out yet so your fuckin gripe being?

—Ok. Don't get mad.

—And see this is why your neat timeboxing process is so important because now we'll like evenly apply our quarter gram high across our work units. Ok so if we divvy our daily quarter gram equally to your future you's daily productivity goal of sixteen pomodoro work units what's that come out to?

—What's what come out to.

—The fuck you asking me for? You're the one holding the calculator.

—Sure I uh, point two five over sixteen comes out to...point zero one five.

—Ok so fifteen thousandths of a gram per snorted work unit like how's that for a lot?

—I guess it doesn't look so bad when you're distributing it across all those empty pill capsules.

—Setting aside whatever personal animus I may have with Glen, I'll admit there's no one else I'd trust to gank me a pipette grid... With his high's heightened periphery, Byron clocked the folded fifty dollar bill David pinched between his thumb and index finger, its crease splitting the U.S. Capitol clean down its middle.

—No need to pay me for the party favors boss...Byron said as he kept his gaze on the golf-ball sized pile of powder he scooped off the pan with a sturdily flimsy Metrocard, which after depositing that scoop into a baker's funnel, Byron tapped the funnel's top with the butt of a bent palm while snaking its spigot across a 10x10 pipette rack loaded with open pill shells. —Like I said your Future You's Likecoin earnings'll be more than enough to cover your half of the egg.

—No I know I just figured we could use this as like our intake valve that twenty we've been using is a little damp and wilted-

—Oh so you're too good for my money that it Engram?

—No like I mean to be honest I don't usually carry that like strata of denomination but as I was packing up all my shit from my apartment I found this fifty in an old birthday card from my parents I had stuck in one of my books.

—Touching yarn Engram but pro tip the spiraled edges on these cash batons'll chap your nostrils something fierce. We can use this instead.

—What, that red straw you just pulled off a can of what is this? Starting fluid?

—No better metaphor am I right?

After shrugging off a just-slugged shoulder, David pinched his left nostril while placing the red straw inside his right; then, bowing down to the smartphone, he watched his breath fog a reflected face split vertically on the black screen by the white powdered line.

—Dude. Moisture!

Startled, David snorted and immediately felt cold wet heat snake around his eye socket before shooting up his skull with enough force to jolt his posture upright. After clenching his eyelids closed so as to let this neat new flaring feeling seep into his brain's inner folds, he pulled his phone from his basketball shorts' mesh pocket. He opened his eyes, he initialized his timeboxing app; then after placing the phone on the work bench, David burrowed both palms into his eye sockets, drifted stippling fingers down numbed cheeks, and leapt from the salon floor's carpeted ledge to land on the engine room's floor in a superheroic kneel upon which he felt his own impact reverberate back up from a fiberglass hull swaying from his momentum.

—Ok so I feel like I got the high part down but still a little unsure how to actually apply it.

—Well on my first go round Joyce made me choose between finishing something I had started or starting something I said I was finished with.

—Ok which means what.

—Means thinking either you can finish freeing up that stuck seacock you've been dry-humping for the better part of a week or you can start writing that swashbuckling deep water story voyage you've been steadily refusing the call on ever since we-

—Dude it's way too chaotic on board for me to even think of writing so since I'm in the engine room already so might as well-

—S'what I thought. Which is why I invited Cappie over. Figured after you wiggle that seacock free he'll have no choice but to honor his promise to take us all out to deep water.

—I recall it sounding more like a threat.

—A threat is a promise with primitive intent, you know that right?

—Look can you at least make yourself useful and rig that cage light above me so I can see whatever the fuck I'm trying to do down here.

—On it Engram how bout I loop the cage over this rail right where Jim said that millennial gagootz rigged his noose.

—Not sure why that's a point of reference for you but sure whatev-

—Likecoin go to market campaign post one take one welcome to Likecoin live where we are on board the American Dream with the one and only Captain Influencer-

—Dude Byron cmon...David raised his forearm to blunt both the smartphone's eggshell-white light and the yolk-yellow light coming from the caged trouble light dangling from the salon's ceiling's grab rail and which, due to the midmorning's flood tide, swayed at a ventriloquist's tempo. —I'm just getting started down here.

—Damn straight he is. Problem is that these fogey mortgage-lending banks think your American Dream starts when you're at the top of your game and already having achieved some high Exfearian credit score. But if you're starting at the bottom of your American Dream like we see Captain Influencer here working down there below the waterline, these fogey mortgage banks are nowhere to be found. Well hoo-doggie that's about to change because there's a new mortgage lender moving onto the blockchain. Introducing Likecoin, the mortgage-backed cryptosocial currency designed to meet you where you're at, not where you need to be approved. See with Likecoin's neat social mortgage concept, every like you earn on our cryptosocial platform gets you one step closer toward your American Dream of home ownership. Now I know this social mortgage concept might seem a little abstract and complicated, which is why over the next three months I'll be filming Captain Influencer as we rentovate this here vessel the American Dream

into a million dollar yacht earning Likecoin all the livelong way all culminating in a deep water story voyage that he, me, and millions of millennials just like you deserve. But first we need to make sure all these nautical systems are working the way they should. And as I was reviewing this voyage prep checklist I noticed that it's weirdly similar to the checklists these fogey lenders give us to prepare for our thirty year mortgage voyages. I mean like this first one pull the engine's dipstick to check the oil level well shit that's basically these banks pulling your credit history and checking your Exfearian score to see if there's some dipshit delinquency draining your credit levels. So Captain Influencer how our dipstick doing down there?

— Right at the line, first mate fuckface.

— Ok but does the oil look milky? Milky like how Exfearian milks these thirty sixty ninety day credit delinquencies for upwards of seven years?

— No. It looks oily.

— Nice next up make sure thru-hulls and seacocks are in working ord-

— Yes I was in the middle of doing that before you ambushed me with this ridiculous live vlog-

— Proper flow state is critical for any vessel I tell you what. But for hardworking millennial vessels like David here, finding that steady financial flow is what's keeping him from experiencing the dignity of home ownership. Now imagine that there's a cryptosocial platform out there designed to help you find your financial flow state with a mortgage approval process that's not based on the income you earn but rather the likes you churn well imagine no furth-

— Fuck me Jesus.

— Oh ho, hey there Cappie... Byron stretched his greeting's warbled enthusiasm as he clicked his smartphone screen closed, vault down into the galley by its parallel-barred staircase railings in order to casually yet carefully sweep a cocaine-filled foil pan and pipette rack stocked with pill casings from the galley counter into an open utensil drawer.

—David and I here were just burning some nautico-engineering calories to get the vessel proper seaworthy so we can go on a voyage like you promised during our onboarding see we were thinking we shoot this neat Likecoin inframercial in deep water where-

—Got a bedder idea. How bouts you twos stay at the dock and start rubbing out all the rust on those engines.

—Sure thing Cap always happy to pivot on my patron's whim. It's just that well you've kinda led David and me to believe America's more about working well than looking-

—Son, America's about what the goddamned money says it's about. And your boss's money is about to whip Congressman Punt into zoning this marina as a decadent area so we can gentribuy it on the cheap as per your rentovation pitch to that Russian magnet like so much. Thing is he's gotta show Punt some proof that you millennials are capable of cleaning these decadent zoned areas all neat-like.

—Ok but I don't see how scrubbing rust connects with dec-

—Nothing more decadent than a yacht son. Couple sprays of Ospho'll turn the turd and grease on that copper seacock nice and bright green like old money. That'll sure to hit that greedy fuck Punt where it's nice and tingly.

—Suffering succotash Cap! Is that Ospho?

—Goddamnit Byron I'm right fucking below you can you at least try to make an to say something without spraying it.

—My bad bud just a little fired up that Cap here is familiar enough with my body of work to know my history with Ospho.

—Wait you've used this this, what is this, osphosphomoric acid?

—Yeah self-commissioned a Penn Station mural few years back. Total Thomas Hart Benton rip job. Biggest lift was camouflaging myself so the cops wouldn't clock me, had to paint my coveralls the right shade of ochre to match the rust in the rafters thankfully my indian yellow skin's roughly the same swatch anyhoo Ospho sure was the right tool for the job cut straight through the century-thick layer of rust on those steel arches sometin fierce there's something about its

active ingredient that renders this really neat shading effect you know because like you can't spell chiaroscuro without osphosphomoric acid or can you David you're the writer.

—I don't know and it doesn't matter. Look Cap since I'm already in the engine room go ahead and toss the bottle down but I still need some guidance on how this rust spray actually works.

—How the rust spray works? Fuck me Jesus it works by working just spray the damn spray all over the seacock's turd and grease then apply some elbow grease with this here brush and wall-the-fuck ah!

After watching the wire brush and spray bottle Captain Jim flipped flippantly from above carom off the engine room floor and into an oil-pooled corner of the engine bilge furthest from where he stood, David shot a perturbed, pursed-lip glance up in Captain Jim, who responded with a sharp shrug and a —Wha? whined with New Jersey's locally-sourced, passive-aggressive passion and triggering David to snarl a skull-shaking snort that pushed most of his postnasal drip down a delighted esophagus upward velocity lifted his hung chin as if being encouraging to buck up and get over some silly bigleaguine bottle toss. After wiping dry the remainder dribbling down his right nostril glazing mustache stubble like farm dew which a with matted forearm hair, David laid belly-down on the engine room floor, angled his arm by the oilpan's contours, and began pawing at a bottle situated at the trolling distance between knowing that it's there and knowing that it's out of reach. David squirmed on the engine room floor, experimenting with a range of finger flicks and shoulder rotations before learning that turning his head away from what he sought maximized his reach, he snatched bottle and brush and pulled out an arm spattered with ochred rust, alpine green paint flakes, and popped-cherry red skin scrapes. After placing the spray bottle and wire brush on the engine room floor, David rolled on his back; where, resting a heaving core, he clocked the spray bottle sliding back toward the bilge on its oil-slicked bottom; lunging toward the receding bottle, David rolled on top of wire brush's steel bristles, reopening the rib wound originally suffered from his upside-down fall upon on the dipstick. Feeling his torso curl in a curdling wince, David rapidly dug into both



mesh pockets as if paying for an item in a rush; pulling out a half-filled pill capsule, he tilted his head back so that the top of his skull scraped the engine room's floor as he screwed the capsule's top off and pour its powder into an upside-down nostril level with the horizon. Feeling his wince wash away in the span of a sniff David rediscovered his motivational salience, rising upright like an activated zombie and butt-scoot himself toward the port engine's seacock as if a bobsledder on top of a track.

Facing the stern, he side-planked his torso to wiggle through the crawlspace between the wire-rubberized raw water hose above him and the one-and-five-sixteenth's-inch bolt protruding from the transmission mount directly beneath his quivering left hip. His right arm reached behind its own shoulder to grab the bottle of Ospho and poise its nozzle near a bronze stuffing box corroded with verdigris the wintergreen of old money. And right as David flicked the spray bottle's trigger, incoming ferry wake sharply yawed the vessel to fling osphosphoric mist back into his face – a face which quickly spat into the bilge with spent breath, hocked a loogie inward, then get wiped down with a mugging palm as if David were starring in a buddy comedy with the cosmos. Hocking his adnoids, David felt postnasal drip's residual pleasure, withdrew his loogie, and wiggled deeper into the cramped crawlspace. With one free hand and in one rushed motion, David picked up the bottle that lay directly beneath his rib wound's palsyng oblique, sprayed the seacock at close range, dropped the bottle back into the bilge, picked up its nearby wire brush and began scraping the seacock's burbling surface until, no longer able to ignore eyes being burnt blind, he pushed on the prop shaft to gain the necessary leverage to crawl out from the crawlspace backward on his belly. Sitting on his heels in a kneel, David daubed both eye sockets with cotton-rolls stacked on his bicep. And despite having initially picked the bottle up to search its safety protocols in case of ingestion, his motivation-action response now fully recoupled as a result of the day's uninhibited dopamine reuptake, David noticed that the Ospho brand lacked the professional touch of a tagline.

## hacked cabinets

As he stood facing the galley's white cabinets, Byron's left arm hugged his torso as its hand tapped the painter's tool's tine against his right kidney with its wrist propping a right angled right elbow so a fist's middle knuckle could furrow chin folds.

—The fuck you waiting for son? All that rust down there ain't gonna rub itself out.

—Kinda locked into the allegorcore potential of these cabinets Cap.

—Fuck me Jesus son your boss went out and pitched Punt your whole millennial zinc titty-pincher and now you're telling me you'd rather work on some cabinet idea that's not even real yet I mean if that ain't being hypothetical I don't know what is.

—Here's the disconnect Cap. See as a condition of coming aboard Juug gave me carte blanche creative authority on whatever project I-

—Think I give a fuck how empty your shopping cart is son? And the fuck you laughing at?

—Nothing Cap...Byron's grit lips ground down his smirk as he levered the painter tool's tine against the acetone canister's finicky rubber lip.

— Just that yesterday someone called me son. Got so damn triggered deboarded the vessel as I was walking to Dykes you know over there on river road I began rereading your brother's Likecoin prospectus.

— Yeah so wha.

— Well it's the damndest thing... Byron's index finger pinned stacked tack rag folds atop the acetone canister's open mouth while the rest of his hand briefly turned the canister upside down; then after setting the canister back upright and closing its mouth with its tethered rubber nipple, he drug the damp tack rag down mahogany cabinets that left behind a glossed gessoed veneer. — So there's this section talking about how these Likecoin social mortgages were designed to gentrify the mortgage market itself as much as the physical properties that those mortgages purchase due to Likecoin's ability to gussy up underperforming scratch and dent mortgages into these government subserdized two zero three c loans.

— Like I said so wha.

— Well like here in these footnotes where it says there's one point five billion dollars of scratch and dent mortgages already out on the mar-

— Damnit son do I have to threepeat myself? So the fuck wh-

— Just wanna ask you the same question I asked your brother... Byron multitasked his dramatic pause in glancing the painter's tool against the cabinet with a dainty underhanded flick of a wrist which quickly bent stiff for dragged resistance against the steel blade's upward progress through a burbling white paint to reveal wavy trails of the cabinet's grey lead-paint undercoat and brown exposed mahogany as white paint ribbons gathered at the blade's sides like a prow's plowed wake. — Are we men enough totake that one point five billion? Because like from where I see it these foiegy banks're just waiting for someone to take these undervalued scratch and dent mortgages off their hands. And all we gotta do is create this appealing human veneer over the scratches and dents to just like how these gentrifying developers sell the manufactured veneer of lived through humanity by propping up the brick exteriors of some building while they gut its insides out.

—Son I don't know about all that crap with fancy trimmings. Alls I knows is Juug wants some hopecore posts about yous millennials sprucing up decadent areas so if you'd please relucitate me on what the fuck's so decadent about these old cabinets.

—So glad you asked Cap...Byron snapped the thumb and middle finger wrapped around the painter tool's that he swept across his torso with the technique and enthusiasm of a carnival barker's rattan cane.

—Need to prehearse my IBS pitch before Juug and I run it up the flagpoles of their big cigars later today ok so like back in the day cabinets were this decadent way for global nobles to show off their sheltered wealth. See these global nobles'd store all this exotic baroque shit in their cabinets shit like narwhal tusks and unicorn horns.

—Yeah but these cabinets here are empty. I already checked.

—Exactly Cap that's what the scratches and dents are for. To give the surface this mysterious appealing veneer of humanity make it all look interesting and lived through.

—Interesting like how? Just because of some scratches and dents?

—No not just some scratches and dents Cap scratches and dents dented and scratched at the velocity of intent you know like rendered both ways so that no one knows if the energy behind it is trying to get into the cabinet or get out same as how no one's sure if all this financial energy within this scratched and dented mortgage market is from millennials clawing to get their American Dreams or if they're these like duplicitous scratches coming from those rich boomer investor fucks trying to claw out of their shady overleveraged mortgage banked security positions ok yep now I am fully primed to promo hold my phone Cap will ya.

—And do wha with it?

—Do what you whitebread boomer township fucks do best point and shoot okay gametime B Likecoin promo two take one...before there was social media, there were cabinets. Cabinets of curiosity. See way back when, you know back when all people could look at was the physical world around them, global nobles would patronize their local renaissance men and minstrels into creating cabinets of

curiosity. These neat memory theaters displayed all sorts of wonders of the natural world. Behind their wooden curtains held all sorts of exotic baroque shit shit like trolls, stuffed tit birds, and sad looking frogs which and maybe it's just me but kinda seems a lot like how today's social media platforms are these memory theaters where we all display trolls, stuffed tits and sad looking frogs. And because curiosity's in the eye of its beholder, every cabinet was this bespoke window showing the soul of the renaissance man or minstrel whose objects were inside it which again is a lot like how social profiles show the souls of today's millennial men and minstrels...

Byron paused to sand his nose's undercarriage with his thumb, then lift his flip flop onto the second stair on the galley staircase and rest both forearms upon a knee bent in motivational speech position.

—The only difference renaissance men and minstrels way back when actually got paid by their global noble patrons. Meanwhiles we're freely broadcasting our bared souls on these social platforms letting billionaire facefucks like Zuck play us like suckers. But I've got an opportunity that can change all that. Hullo I'm local artist Byron Chianti. And I'm here to talk to you about Likecoin, a cryptosocial platform designed to open the doors to your social earning potential. With Likecoin's revolutionary profile patronage you're not only earn real live cryptocurrency for every post you make on the Likecoin platform but you can put that Likecoin toward making your American Dream a reality. Now I know this whole profile patronage idea seems a abstract and complicated so let's use this abstract sketch I scratched on these cabinets as an example. Now normally I'd post this on that facefuck Zuck's platform and get like wha a few ten thousand likes which like big whoop but see that doesn't get me any closer to achieving my American Dream of owning my own home but now watch me post my scratched and dented cabinet of curiosity on my Likecoin crypticsocial platform profile watch my dashboard as each like my post receives earns me one whole Likecoin a Likecoin which I can redeem toward my very own social mortgage that will get me my American Dream of home ownership. Now I know what you're thinking. You're thinking

there's probably nothing of real value behind this neat new cryptocurrency just like there's probably nothing behind this scratched and dented cabinet behind me but guess what after awhile guess what cabinets of curiosity eventually turned into for these renaissance men and minstrels hey Cap do me a solid and pan out a little will ya...damnit don't take the foil pan out the frame just swivel the damn camera to the salon...no no no don't even think about grabbing the tackle box ok how bout yaw can you yaw the goddamned camera over here good great thank you anyhoo after awhile global nobles uplevelled their most popular cabinets into complete living spaces called studiolo. And one of Likecoin's international profile patrons over at Likecoin are giving me the same opportunity to uplevel my scratched and dented cabinet post into forty two feet of my very own floating studiolo. That's because Likecoin's profile patronage program is designed to give us millennials the same patronage opportunities as those global nobles gave their renaissance men and minstrels way back when. Now don't go and be silly and let this profile patronage opportunity pass you by. Take the first step toward getting approved for your very own rentovate-to-own studiolo opportunity by attending Likecoin's first ever walled garden party. Just download Likecoin's cryptosocial app and for your first post submit a screenshot of yourself deleting that facefuck Zuck's app and we'll send over an invite. It's time to wake your American Dream up. Cut it Cap hoping you got all that.

—Oh yeah big time lemme just tap this here red circle on your screen here to stop the filming here ya goes.

—Thanks Cap just need to cut our hamfisted fourth wall panning and swiveling chat and we're wait why the fuck is this still recording?

—Oh wait, lemme see that...ah ok I think I see wha ha happened. See when I went to turn it on, it was already on then when I tapped the button to turn it on, it turned off so that when I went to turn it off, it was wait now it's ringing maybe it's been listening this whole—

—Damnit give me that...oh mister van sant hullo there I was just about to...no yeah he's here...not taking up space at all put him

on the ole floating eyeball for our hopecore campaign...telling you the man's a natural with the camera regular Caleb Deschanel... David? No haven't seen him since he hopped down to clean all that crud out as social proof for your decadent Punt pitch... who gave him posting privileges didn't know posting on the Likecoin platform was point of fact a privil...oh he did did he? okay so what'd he post the opening scene of his swashbuckling deep water story voy... a tagline? A tagline for what...oh ho Ospho, that so? Speaking of appreciate you sending Jim over with that bottle touched that you'd remember my Penn Station mur...oh you didn't did you...ok well then please excrow my gratitude over to your Russian magnet investor friend anyhoo so what was the actual line that David landed on...wait say that again... spray it don't say it with Ospho? Doesn't matter if I get it matters if the fine people over in Ospho's marketing departm...well not sure I'd characterize what David did as embezzling your exposure but yes I get your larger...no look I get it I'll tune David up calibrate our creative output closer to your go to market motion...nope we've already read the creative brief...no sure fine go ahead and resend the approved hashtags...yes of course we're aligned Juug... aligned in the sense that it's fuck or walk with getting these millennials registered with your cryptosocial platform and that if we don't hit our kpis or you'll swap us out for two millennials who will to hit them for us so I'm grabbing David right now we're walking up to the pilothouse as we...Byron snapped at David down at the engine room, tapped the side of his nose twice, and shot an upward thumb; then, responding to David's perplexed shrug, he squinted, pursed his lips, then rolled invisible dice near his groin.—Matter facts as a good faith gesture David and I're gonna shoot that storyboard you emailed over the one about a successful inspirational million dollar millennial up on the pilothouse captaining his American Dream... twenty five minutes... Jim? Yeah looks like I let him out of my sight you should probably check the nearest Ruthless Chris here the tomahawks are scalp-worthy...nope yep okay byeee!

—Dude no way we can take this vessel out starboard seacock's still seized shut plus we don't even know if the port engine'll turn over nevermind that neither of us know how to maneuver it out the slip without smashing against some megayach litigated to the gills just waiting for some uninsured unlicensed coked-out captain ito-

—Fuck all that. We just gotta make the surface look appealing as if we're on some deep water story voyage ok so imago grab a two by four from the floor hatch's frame so I can stir the water make it look like we're on the high seas.

—C'mon dude they're gonna see through that.

—Not if the surface dazzles them they won't.

—We're not gonna dazzle anyone we're gonna broadcast me acting as some nautical poser still tied to the dock I mean shit the bow's fuckin pointed at the goddamned cliffs.

—You just leave your spatiovisual concerns to my bootlegged final haute pro license. All you need to do Captain Influencer is climb that pilothouse ladder filled with the belief that Likecoin has made you into this million dollar millennial. And to boost that belief Ima go up and arrange a nice girtharoonied line right on the steering wheel so when I count you down you go and give me a sharp snort at the velocity of intent ok because when you lift your head back up this floating eyeball's gonna be pointed at you ready to roll.

—Ok but what do I even say when-

—Don't have to say anything I'll be your mouthpiece ok? All you have to do is physically live out the dreams of Captain Influencer, the ideal million dollar millennial man.

—The fuck does that mean.

—I'll leave that up to your interpretation but I can tell you what it doesn't mean it doesn't mean adopting some pose of what you think Captain Influencer should be nor does it mean some stilted portrayal of who our target audience wants Captain Influencer to be ok just be the Captain Influencer who's living deliberately.

—Ok so how do I do that.



—Gee I don't know how bout you you know captain! Check the gauges awn your eyebrows with your hand so you scan the horizon as if you're saluting the sun I mean holy shit Engram you want me to pick you up your ankles like before and flesh wheelbarrow walk you every step along the way on our story voyage here?

—Okay. Fine. Don't get mad.

—Now look Mother Nature's shutting her golden hour legs as we speak so if we're done with our prehearsal here imago start rocking the boat for the both of us... Where after scampering into the salon, Byron brought out a seven-foot-long four-by-four that he tossed onto the finger pier so he could deboard the vessel free of its weight; then, picking the wood beam back up, he braced it vertically against his shoulder and began to pace the finger pier, stirring the water below as if the marina were his personal cauldron.

—Now just got to position the ole floating eyeball on my smartphone in this low angle nadir shot to get you rendered all heroically imposing ok David go ahead duck down and take the line so I can clear the shot nice dude we are so go for recognition Likecoin post one take two hullo again and welcome back to Likecoin Live where we see Captain Influencer here has found some upward mobility on the Likecoin cryptosocial platform because when we last saw him he was jiggling some stuck seacock below the waterline but now after having earnestly earned some Likecoin through his created hopecore content now he's atop the pilothouse sitting in the captain's chair of this here vessel the American Dream. And for more swashbuckling behind the scenes footage of Captain Influencer going on his deep water story voyage head on over to Likecoin's Exfearian page where a customer service representative will be your first mate as you begin your own mortgage voyage and we're clear ok dude you can head back down now got what we came for.

—You sure you don't need another take? Because the view up there's like way better than being down in that dark dank engine room.

—Yes I'm sure we got enough footage of you bumblefucking up your captain influencer character up in the pilothouse.

— You make it sound like that's a good thing.

— Great thing Engram the only way to get your boss over the barrel is by doing exactly what you're told and have it fail miserably. And if I know our boy Juug, he's gonna take one look at the engagement kpis on this promo video we just shot and his management aperture's gonna pucker flat sour like some post-scene pornstar.

— Yeah which by the way do you know if our Likecoin dashboard give us any visibility into the i p addresses of the likes on our posts wanna see if there's any around Palm Beach Gardens that's where Ospho's headquarters are thinking maybe I can get a freelance gig handling their social-

— Look David don't get distracted by trying to monetize your future you ok just stay focused on making sure he measures up.

— The fuck does that mean.

— Means you track how many work units did you assert into the cosmos on your first day applying your high?

— Let me check the notes in my redwing boot here ok that last one puts me at sixteen.

— That's good right?

— Uh yeah actually I'm pretty sure that that's a new record.

— Well hoo doggie there Engram! And I got just the substance to toast to your pb in productivity had Glen ship us over a sixer of my homebrewed psilly beer in anticipation of your future you crowning

— Unsure what makes a beer silly but I would like some kind of evenner chest does feel a little tight.

— Here ya go but only on the condition that you take this dry erase marker with you down to the captain's room.

— Why.

— Thinking instead of using some pink slip from your past to tally the progress of your future you, that big mirror in the captain's room is the perfect clean slate for your timeboxing scorecard.

— Scorecard.

— Yeah for the fight.

— What fight.

— The fight for your future you silly! Hey if you want that postgame sniff mister you better throw those rolling eyes of yours into neutral real quick hol up got someone on the line here...hullo hullo...mister pennyman no this is mister chianti...oh yes yes yes yes this is he...are we enjoying the egg how can we not sir it's made from the same stuff that made our species into what it is today...well I'll be sure to tell David no doubt he'll be fired up that his headline made such a good impression, oh multiple impressions even better...sorry you saying bought impressions or bot imp...no sir programmatic ad buying isn't really top of palette for me but my friend David here recently retired after a stellar career in advertising so maybe he's the one you want to...me I think creating a media market on the Likecoin cryptosocial platform is a fine play and tell you what since you've been feeling David's output ima throw in his copywriting skills as a good faith gesture...nope yep got plenty of products on board like Ospho to shill been thinking this can of starting fluid can be a neat great metaphor for-hol up sir sir sorry but I do have an incoming call that's...yep its from the bossman... yes cockblocking our hustle how American...and toodles to you too my friend hullo there mister van...hey don't get mad ok David and I did exactly as you...yeah I wasn't in front of the camera because I needed to rock the boat so that it looks like we're actually out in deep...no I know that I'm who millennials want to be...that's what I'm trying to tell you he's who they are which is like a way more engaging brand narrative for our millennial target market than...look Juug you're my boss and because of that I love you but it's high time I talk to you like a dutch uncle about your creative direction...no I mean that's my point like you keep reminding me that you own everything on the Likecoin platform well guess what that also means you gotta take some ownership on these limpdicted kpis...don't give me that shit sir I shot it how you wanted it shot even shoehorned that whack ass call to action Exfearian wanted by the way since when are we opening our brand kimonos to let credit bureaus like Exfearian grab our hopecore

content by the short and curlies? Ok well if you're seeing the same kpis I'm seeing then you can see that David's titty-pinching Ospho promotional post is getting the most engagement... my idea's your idea boss I mean you want us to create all this hopecore content on the American Dream well guess what hope doesn't start at the finish line...means that these gloatcore million dollar millennial videos with Captain Influencer looking down at our target audience from atop the pilothouse aren't getting it done verisimilitude-wise...thinking instead of David and I touting ourselves at the top we keep ourselves on the humble head back down below the waterline film some hardcore hopecore content on repairing these broken down engines maybe get a few boat brands to bite as episode sponsors like remember where you said in your prospectus that advertising media is like at the top of the Likecoin earning triangle ok well ...no I agree probably not a lot of meat on Ospho's bones but if we like depucker our revenue aperture for just a minute maybe we can see a new way to launder your investor's investments... no I know the degree to which your revenue aperture is puckered isn't my concern it's just that well I'm still a little concerned how our new Russian investor will...yes of course...no yeah fully understand that I'm in the Likecoin game to run your plays not to draw them up...yes...got someone on another line great you go and take that while I knock noggins with my partner David here on a solve what's up bud...

— Hey did you put something in this homebrewed beer?

— Just my time and care.

— It's just that this beer's lot more bubbly than most beers and then I'm finding these specks floating in the foam and-

— Oh ho so you blow through a quarter gram no problem but now you wanna squeeze my shoes about whether I've introduced what some like psychotropic biome into your stupid psilly beer?

— No just curious like you've been telling me to be curious about

— Look just trust the process same way I'm trusting yours Christ I'm changing my whole flow living my damn life twenty five minutes at a...hol up got the boss back on the line still some reel to be cranked

before getting him on board with my sinfluencing play mister van sant how ya doin me I'm reasonable...oh he did did he...oh he does does he...well I think he's more your neat new friend considering that he's invested in your cryptosocial platform not mine...sure but isn't like knowing the man's name a prerequisite to being in cahoots with him I mean alls I know about this Russian magnet investor guy is that he owns the same type of shiny suit I wore to both of my trials...well if it doesn't matter then why'd you even ask me in the first...well I'm sorry that he's making you make a market for sponsored media buys truly but considering we already got a proven sponsored content maven on board in one David Engram we might as well make earned media salad out of earned media...no I agree your whole decadent scratch and dent play is still top of mind but I'm confident David and I can snort and chew gum at the same-

Despite the vessel calmly floating atop a slack tide's stilled water, David clutched both railings with eight free fingers — his right thumb and index finger constricting the beer bottle's neck in an a-ok gesture — in his four-staired descent from the salon to below deck. Shouldering the galley's bulkhead for support, David swayed into the captain's room, and sat at the foot of its bed, where, with elbows collapsed upon knees, he watched psilocybinized froth billow out from the beer bottle's mouth for an unspecified amount of time until a blood rivulet trickling off the tickled tip of hung head's nose shifted his lucidity in time for his crossed glossed eyes to clock its fall between a body diamond of duck canvas thighs and cotton forearms to splash off a parquet-laminated linoleum floor to firework into smaller blood droplets. After wiping his nose with a bent wrist, David lifted his shirt to compare the streak of blood on his handshake webbing possessed the same regrown tissue hue surrounding his reopened rib wound. He chewed on the potential significance of this connection for an unspecified period of time until a flickering patch of light projected upon the bulkhead shifted his lucidity; there he spent another unspecified period of time deducing that the sporadic rhythm between shadow and light was being dictated by an onshore breeze rippling the mast flag of a sailboat berthed two slips east between erect and flaccid to block the shaft of golden hour light from the open hatch above.

Suddenly feeling a head high combine with the sunken ache of earned fatigue, David felt too top-light to stay upright. He fell backwards on the bed in the vulnerable posture of a trust fall; feeling his brain stem knock against padding firmer than a pillow, David turned over to discover a pair of boxing gloves laid upon the bed with fiendish care. Picking the gloves up, he found a vintage alarm clock beneath, its twin bells figure-eighted by a nylon rope's working end captain's knotted to a carabiner hooked to an eye screw screwed at a haphazard 45-degree angle to the wood stud behind the ceiling's sewn fabric. Obscuring the arrowed hands on the clock's glass screen was a brain-pink pastel post-it with *and...new! shadowweight timeboxing champion of the world, The Big Focus, David Engram!!!* scribbled in one-stroke calligraphy. After briefly rolling his eyes, David waddled up the bed on his knees. Reaching the mirror affixed over the teak headboard, he sat on his heels in a kneel, pulled the cap off the marker; where, having subconsciously picked the patch of mirror directly in line with his face, he tallied the quicksilver surface sixteen times, incarcerating glossed eyes with the tally bars of his quantified work. And as he waited for the eyes on him that were his own to blink first, David burnt some more psycho-pharmacogenomic calories reflecting on a day spent sublimating white horizontal lines into black vertical ones. After setting the dry erase marker down on the bedside table, he picked up the bottle, observed its faint *psilly beer* label similarly scrawled in palsied, one-stroke calligraphy, and took a swig whose depth briefly releveled the liquid inside with the horizon. He then pulled on the carabinered line's working end with the verve of pulling a funhouse chain and hoist the chocked clock up so that it dangled from the ceiling block at a speedbag's height. Then after hitching the line's working end taut against the head door's flared doorknob, David propped his phone against a pillow, pulled a pill capsule from his mesh shorts' pocket that he quickly pinched open with a snarled canine, and dashed its contents against handshake flesh; then, sniffing at the velocity of intent, he somersaulted backwards off the bed for the first time since he was a child, tapped the screen's red record button, and laced 'em up.

## gumption and focus

- B** —A mechanic is not an engine's therapist!
- So why the fuck do we let therapists be the mechanics of our pink
- C** mushy engines?
- Welcome to Gumption and Focus, the show where two
- B** millennials rebuild a broken down engine to show how you can get your own pink mushy engine back firing on all cylinders.
- And as you can see, Gumption and I are both standing on breaker
- C** bar that's locked onto this engine's crankshaft bolt.
- That's right Focus. Now if this were a healthy working engine,
- B** this crankshaft would turn right over and give us four testicle contusions rarely seen outside of a bmx competition.
- But the reason why you the viewer won't be sharing those nut shots
- C** on the Likecoin platform today is because this crankshaft nut is shot.
- B** —Flat no movement at all.
- Now look we could spend this episode doomscrolling all the
- C** different ways this engine broke down. Maybe it was starved of fuel.

— Maybe it got hit by a generational Kondratiev wave.

— Hell it might've simply been sabotaged by its very own captain.

— But see here's what's up. One of our core beliefs here on Gumption and Focus is that just as all running engines are the same, all broken down engines are broken in their own unique way.

— But what unites every broken down engine is that the lack of work after the trauma is far more damaging than the traumatic event itself.

— Which is why another core belief here on Gumption and Focus is that work is an engine's best maintenance.

— Now the first step toward getting this crankshaft working again is ironically enough to introduce some play in this stuck bolt.

— Now to be clear this type of play is supes low stakes I mean we're not even gonna ask the crankshaft for a full revolution here, just to show enough play in its rotation for it to feel its own movement.

— And helping to deliver that play is today's episode's sponsor Knock Er Loose brand starting fluid.

— That's right Knock er Loose is the perfect lubrication for this crankshaft's liberation. Just watch as I soak the rusted threads on the crankshaft bolt then give it a quick a shot of heat here from this hair dryer and ok now let's hop back on that breaker bar.

— Well lookie here this bar's bouncing like a fucking diving board!

— And it's all due to Knock er Loose. That's Knock er Loose, all play, no work.

— Now that you've seen us add some play to this diesel engine, let's talk about the pink mushy engine sloshing around on your side of the screen.

— Because if you're like Focus and me, you've been gaslit about how your millennial model pink mushy engine will always break down at the worst possible time.

— But no one's talking about how to fire these gaslit engines back up.

— It's why Focus and I are teaming up on the Likecoin cryptosocial platform so we can help millennials get back on their high



horsepower simply by adding some play to a few special parts in their pink mushy engines.

—Now board-certified neuromechanics call these parts hedonic hotspots, which is why we're calling this next seg-

—Yeah right Focus. As if any of those lab coat pencildicks have ever visited Negril or even seen a prolapsed-

—And so the first segment on our hedonic hotspot series is the ventral tegmental area, or vta. Known as the crankshaft of the cranium, the vta is what motivates our motivation. See just as this crankshaft seized up more due to its lack of use after a breakdown than the breakdown itself, our motivational crankshafts act the same way whenever our pink mushy engines break down.

—Now I know this might seem abstract and complicated so let's take Focus here as an example. See after Focus got fired from his job, he developed this conditioned fear of work, got so bad his pink mushy creative engine stopped firing altogether.

—I mean that's not exactly how I'd character-

—But thankfully just as we were able to free up this crankshaft by spraying some Knock Er Loose brand starting fluid, we've got just the product for the vta crankshaft in Focus's pink mushy engine. Introducing Gumption and Focus's powdered starting fluid! Watch as its patented lubrication properties add some much-needed play to Focus's motivation just like-

—Dude! You can't hold that vial up on camera!

—Why not? I mean like what's stopping us from applying any resource necessary to get our broken down pink mushy engines back on their high horsepo-

—What's stopping us? How bout the fact that what you're holding is a schedule one-

—You know besides ourselves. See that's what's so fuckin neat about the Likecoin cryptosocialplatform is that it's this safe social space where content creators like Focus and I are empowered to do anything we think is worth doing, especially all those risky and

risque things that that facefuck Zuck won't let you do on his platform you know like applying non-FDA approved starting fluid.

—Ok but maybe we should still caveat that uh, applying powdered starting fluid isn't always a right course of action and that for some pink mushy engines the prudent thing to do would be to seek prof-

—Seek that facefuck Zuck's platform because that's where you'll find all your prudent and fuck all content. But this? This is Gumption and Focus cutting it loose on the Likecoin cryptosocial platform so Focus how bout you tilt back and show our audience your intake valve?

—Ok look fine but like just to be clear I'm only doing this because I get a little nervous when I'm in front of the yowza!

—More like yowza bobowza am I right? Now if any of you pink mushy millennial engines out there are looking to add a little play to your motivational crankshaft like Focus here well you're in luck because we'll be raffling off grams of powdered starting fluid with this ticket drum we bolted to our newly liberated crankshaft wheel. All you got to do is register a Likecoin account with the promo code yowza underscore bobowza. Then you're gonna receive your very first Likecoin whose fiat value is bubkus sure but the transaction hash, that'll be your raffle ticket to rebuild your future you. So if you're ready to knock your motivation loose and turn your pink mushy engine's conditioned fear of work into conditioned feats of work, come on over to the Likecoin platform where just one like can get you a whole bunch of lines. And remember...

—It's not worth getting likes if you don't earn Likecoin...god damn dude that line was a fucking zoomer!

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—Gumption and Focus sliding back onto your feed and I don't have to tell you twice that the Jersey coastline's a salty environment. Not as salty as say Florida, but damned saltier than those diurnal tide dandies over on the Pacific.

—And when these raw-water cooled Detroit Diesels are working at twenty three hundred revolutions per minute, they got no problem spitting out all that salt water their seacocks suck in.

— But after awhile just sitting here zero rpm, the salt that's still in the engine begins creeping into the combustion chambers and get the pistons inside stuck at bottom dead center like we see here.

— Now we've got a user in our Likecoin Live chat a j cancelme at jimmy dot net who is of the all-caps belief that the reason why these pistons are stuck is that they're too goddamned sensitive. That since all the other parts of the engine are exposed to the same salty environment, perhaps these pistons simply need to nut up and develop a thicker liner. Now look Cap does have a point because pistons are point of fact made from aluminum a metal which is way more sensitive than the cast iron engine block that the pistons sit in. But there's a reason for that. See in order to create the combustion necessary to propel a fifteen ton vessel at twenty two knots these pistons have to maintain a five hundred psi compression pressure in their combustion chambers all while operating at a temperature of around two hundred degrees. And taking that kind of heat and pressure demands a level of sensitivity that other parts of the engine just can't handle.

— Call it the irony of cast iron.

— Problem is, when salt is introduced into this high-stakes fragile operating environment, aluminum's sensitivity becomes a vulnerability.

— A vulnerability that throws off the piston's dwell time, which is a fancy way of measuring the time the piston spends combusting at top dead center.

— And so all this salt we see here in the liner is gonna make the piston rush at top dead center as well as drag at bottom dead center. Now I admit all of this is very abstract and technical so to demonstrate how salt influences dwell time I've got a pile of regular old sea salt in my hand now I want you to watch something watch this-

— Gah! The fuck you do that for?!

— Never mind why I did what when it's your turn to read the promotional copy.

—Damnit I can't read! For fuck's sake I told you I couldn't afford to fuck around that I need content that shows me in a positive professional light not as some snorting stooge I mean fuck I sent this Likecoin Live link to friends family basically anyone who's visited my professional ThinkedIn profile in the last thirty days.

—Ok well then all those important people are watching how you dwelling on all your built-up salt of the past is keeping you from propelling your future you forward. But no worries Focus I got your cue covered just watch as a quick spray of Kroil brand starting fluid cuts through all the salt that's built up in this stuck non-combusting piston ok so lets hit the liner with a quick shot of heat from our hair dryer here and you can see as I crank the breaker bar how these pistons are now free to rise up their respective combustion chambers so they can fully hit their destiny at top dead center. Now the good people at Kroil were nice enough to sponsor the second installment of our Hedonic Hotspot series which day is focused on the piston in our pink mushy engines known as the nucleus accumbens, ay kay ay the nac. See just as a rotating crankshaft pushes a piston up its liner so it can combust at top dead center, the vta and nucleus accumbens act likewise as the vta pushes the nucleus accumbens to take the action that their motivation demands. And just as a crankshaft-motivated piston combusts compressed air at the top of its stroke, the nac does likewise, compressing reward signals as it rises to its destiny at top dead center and fire our synapses in neat new ways that keep us moving us forward in whatever our vta's are motivating us to do. Problem is, when your pink mushy engine's stalled out at zero rpm, minor salty stuff like job rejections can seep into your uncombusting combustion chamber to get your nac piston stuck at bottom dead center like we see Focus here all bent over and keeled at the hip.

—Did you have to use coarse grain? I mean fuck!

—Now to be fair Focus here isn't alone, lab rats with salty lesions on their nac pistons suffer from what's known as a diminished reward expectation which is a fancy way of saying that the rats stop hopping on their work wheels not because they're like these lazy

sensitive millennial rats but because they're stuck dwelling at bottom dead center about whether their work on the wheel's even worth it anymore. But see after some brain mechanics mixed some powdered starting fluid into the squeeze bottles tethered above the rats cages guess what blow and behold the rats hopped back on their work wheels. Now watch as we're gonna do likewise to Focus free him from being stuck dwelling at bottom dead center with just a quick whiffer picker upper of this powdered starting fluid now in spray form let me just crane the bottle's nozzle underneath your schnozz here and-

— Hachi machi!

— Now just look at Focus I mean holy shit he's bobbing up and down so much he's doing the goddamned drinking bird! So if you're looking to flush out all the salty rejections and criticisms that are throwing off your dwell time and get your nac piston back firing on all cylinders with top dead center combustion well you're in luck because we're giving away over a hundred hours of Gumption and Focus's proprietary blownase calibrated to the same nose dosage as you see in Focus here's glossed eyes.

— All you pink mushy engines have to do is head over to Kroil's Likecoin page and simply dwell there for one whole minute that's right investing just one minute into the Likecoin platform will get you an hour's worth of your future you hoo doogie am I wired tight!

— Because like God Himself, Likecoin cares as much for a minute as it does for an hour.

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— Gumption and Focus back brightening your black screen and viewers I want you to take a look at the spectrum of emotional corrosion that's built up on this neglected battery's terminals. Rust the ochred nutmeg of loneliness. Flakes of apathetic turquoise in the exposed wire strands. Even got some melancholy lapus lazuli powder from the leaked battery acid that evaporated. Now what I've done here is clamp one half of these jumper cables to the battery's terminals now as I lasso the other ends of these jumper cables' gator clips I want you to watch Focus ok now watch this-

— Gah damnit!

—Felt that in your cavity, didn't ya? Now without all this corrosion dragging down the battery's amperage I would've been able to kill my man Focus here instead of simply sparking his nips.

—I mean fuck! My fillings feel out of tune.

—But we need this lead acid battery to do more than jolt some old nag like Focus. We need it to giddy-up the three hundred ten horses in this here Detroit Diesel engine. And to do that, this dead battery's gotta dig deep and discharge most of its two thousand cold cranking amp capacity into the engine's starter motor. Problem is, when a battery is wired up to a broken-down engine, all the acid inside's got nowhere to go and nothing to catalyze with so that eventually it begins seeping through the terminals and erode its capacity so that what was once a starting battery powerful enough to send this here vessel the American Dream on a deep water voyage is now reduced to a house battery only able to deliver these small passive draws like rotating this twelve volt Trump brand executive tie rack that I've wired up to the battery.

—Which is why we're so lucky to have PB Blaster brand starting fluid as our sponsor for today's episode. Just a quick spray on these battery terminals and PB Blaster's best in class penetrating properties are able to cut through the spectrum of corrosion. Now we just work in some elbow grease with this wire brush and these terminals will look good as new.

—Which is all well and super Focus but take it from me there's more to resurrecting a battery than making its surface look good. And that brings us to the third part in our Hedonic Hotspots series. Just as a battery accepts, stores, and releases energy, the hippocampus does likewise. It not only accepts new energy by being the only brain part that creates new neurons, it stores our emotional energy as the hippocampus holds our memories and it also releases energy by transmitting dopamine which is what starts the engine of every known species in the cosmos. Problem is if we stop requesting deep draws from our hippocampus, it begins shrinking in ways that just can't be fixed by a couple shots of powdered starting fluid. Now I know this is all very abstract and technical so I went and brought in

this battery diorapa used as an evidentiary exhibit in both my Paterson Patricide trials I had way back when whatever happened there. Anyhoo let's take a look at this exploded cross-section of the battery here ok now see these lead plates inside, see when I flick them there's no give no bounce no plasticity? That's because whenever a deep draw is asked of a battery, electrons start flowing from the negative plates to the positive ones. But if a battery's denied that deep draw, the electron flow stagnates in ways that totally limpicks its energy potential.

**B**

— Which is Gumption's deeply personal way of explaining that a key part of recharging a battery is allowing it to discharge.

**C**

— Exactly see wha ha happened is my dad went and shoved all this positive energy into his dead Trojan battery, but the only draw he was asking was to power some lame low energy Trump brand

**B**

executive tie rack. Which as you can see by these cheeto-cruste mothballs glued to the diorapa's terminals here, if a deep draw isn't being asked from a big battery, all that positive energy has no place to go and nothing to catalyze until eventually the lead plates swell up and burst in some messy dramatic super-litigated event.

— So we won't be charging this battery with some external charger designed to soften its lead plates with a steady trickle of positive alternating current that goes back and forth like some sort of talk therapy for batteries.

**C**

— That's right Focus instead we're gonna charge the battery by asking it to give one last final last draw over to the engine's starter motor. Now I know what you're thinking. You're thinking Gumpy my dude it's flat fucking futile to try and resurrect a dead battery with a broken down engine well surely you recall how we've been hopping this here engine up with all this combustible starting fluid which means all this dead battery needs to do is bump the starter motor over just enough that it turns the motivational crankshaft just enough to raise our pistons up to top dead center and combust the necessary momentum to sustain itself.

— A crankshaft which as you can see here has this rubber belt looped over it connecting it to this alternator rotor.

— See contrary to its name, an alternator actually delivers direct current into the battery through this exciter circuit that channels energy from the engine's work back into the battery as electricity.

— And this direct current generated by the alternator via the engine's own work replasticizes these brittle lead plates way better than some external therapeutic charge designed to bring a bunch of positive energy from the outside.

— Which is why here at Gumption and Focus we believe an alternator pairs perfectly with starting fluid, as it can both harness and contextualize all that sweet sweet combustion brought forth by a hopped-up engine.

— And why we're so fired up to introduce the ideal resurreccessory for your dead brain battery... Gumption and Focus's cap and stem alternators!

— That's right the space-age neuroelectrical formula inside these cap and stem alternators debrittizes your hippocampal memory plates to enhance your connectivity to the world help your brain battery to accept a charge again.

— And see just as an alternator depends on the energy of a running engine, these cap and stem alternators are only activated if we place a deep draw on our pink mushy engines.

— Now I know this psychedelic alternator promotion is somewhat abstract and confusing so let's take one of these pungent alternators out of the baggie here and Focus zoom in on the cap I'm holding ok now pan over to the engine's alternator I mean tell me that that there rubber rotor doesn't look like the black ribs on the undercarriage of this here shroom cap?

— Now if you've got a made in the usa brain battery like mine, you know the deepest draw we'll ever place on our brain batteries you know like the thing we'll devote the most energy toward is the a thirty-year discharge of paying off our American Dream of homeownership.

— Problem is, simply getting approved for that thirty-year burden can be as feckless and frustrating as starting an engine with a dead battery.



— Just flat fucking applying over and over again like trying to turn over some thunking limpducked ignition.

— Well Gumption and Focus wants you to recharge your American Dream with a complimentary two-week supply of cap and stem alternators. All you got to do is head over to Exfearian's likecoin page to check your credit score. Be sure to enter promo code hard starting inquiry to get your caps and stems shipped overnight! Focus how bout you take us to break.

— Coming up!

— It's the engine's comeup! That's right the next time you see us brightening your black screen we'll finally start this damn diesel up.

+ + +

— Dude I can't just flow on flow.

— Welcome back to Gumption and Focus and the hot air you're hearing come out of Focus came from our next hedonic hotspot, the prefrontal cortex. Known as the injector of our flow state, the prefrontal cortex is what regulates our concentration's combustion. But if our pink mushy engine breaks down, hot air creeps into our prefrontal cortex in ways which gatekeep or as I like to call it hatekeep us from reaching our necessary flow state so that every time we try to start our pink mushy engine up after a breakdown event we choke up and doubt the power of our combustion similar what we all just heard stammer out from Focus back then just now. But in fairness to Focus, when it comes to starting up a broken down engine, the first six hundred rpms are always the toughest.

— Yeah so uh pan out a bit there Gumption so our viewers can see just how far fuel needs to travel to get it actually combusted so it obviously all starts at the tank which is beneath my feet here where it first gets sucked through the primary filter through this gear-driven pump that's being driven by the flywheel also connected to the starter motor which is why the battery's so critical so then the gear pump shoots the fuel up through this smaller secondary filter before finally arriving here at the engine's head where it flows into the injector which sprays this fuel mist into the combustion chamber.

—I mean holy shit that's quite the journey the fuel has to travel simply to combust. Just think how fuel the whole time, flat fighting the gravity of its own emptiness. Ok so we whined long enough about what's holding this engine back Focus, how we gonna reinitialize our fuel flow so we can move things forward?

—Yeah well because fuel lines are back pressurized we can't just simply you know like rig a beer bong to a jerrycan and fill the injectors from the top down.

—Damn Focus it's almost like you're saying we need to I don't know like trick the engine into combusting all that stale post-breakdown air that's stuck inside it. Well thankfully we've got Sea Foam brand starting fluid as our episode sponsor. As the loki to locked up engines, Sea Foam's top-notch volatilization properties tricks your engine into combusting during those first six hundred rpms that are critical toward the engine achieving the momentum it needs to pump its own fuel and produce its own combustion without the crutch of starting fluid. Now as you can see I went and loosened the nuts on the lines going both in and out of each of these fuel injectors. Though these flared spigots on these copper fuel lines sure are tough to spin free thankfully Sea Foam's supplied us with this helpful red extendo straw that I can simply twist onto the nozzle here and squirt an upside down shot into all six injectors until we can see starting fluid bubble out from the loosened nut. And as I tighten back up those nuts to their recommended twenty two foot pounds of torque let's recap all the neat ways starting fluid has torqued up Focus's pink mushy engine. First we added play to his motivational crankshaft, then after we cleared out all that salt stuck to his nucleus accumbens piston we calibrated his dwell time to hit top dead center, we cleaned the surface-level emotional corrosion off the hippocampus's battery terminals which combined with our stem and cap alternator will help redirect and contextualize all that combustible energy being pumped back into Focus so that now when we give his prefrontal cortex one last final last shot of starting fluid it'll trick his pink mushy engine into entering that all-important flow state now let me justoposition my red extendo straw underneath Focus's schnozz here and-

—Ga-goo! Dude that was way too much.

—Damn straight it isn't so long as it's enough to get you to turn the ignition on your future you which speaking of let Focus hand me that koozied scroogie while I slither down into the engine room.

Leaping down from the salon with arms out like a boy freely falling into a familiar well, Byron landed in the engine room near the port engine's starting battery and in a genuflected kneel. After reaching the koozied scroogie protruding out his coverall's back pocket fulcrummed its shaft against the starter motor's sender stud; where at its see-sawed descent, its metal tip tapped the stud's solenoid to trigger a fountainhead of sparks the color of tarnished gold, the thunk of an whirring protruding bendix gear engaging a flywheel the weight and shape of a primitive sundial to turn a crankshaft that itself pushed six latched pistons up their liners where, reaching top dead center, compressed salty air met an aerosolled injection of starting fluid, upon which combustion reached the inevitable.

—Ok Focus have at it the flow is yours!

Hearing Byron manipulate the starter motor into bumping the engine over at a wheezing three four beat, David brought both palms to his face, then drug stippling fingers down flushed cheeks.

*Gumption and focus, we function on hocus  
consumption awoke us, brains bumpin, take notice  
two engines, done choking; two broke men, unbroken  
rambunction, no joking; combustion, nose dosing!*

*My flow's like Cziksentsmihai from the high that I applied  
Put my future me on the line that I snorted to decide  
To let Byron guide my strive like a moon is to a tide  
Pried the gloss out from my eyes then shone a shadow on my why*

*First he made light of a social self cozily posing  
Diagnosed my choking by illuminating my inner loathing  
Now my pistons totally stroking, diesel soaking my clothing,  
Powder acetoning so we're not overdosing*

*Eyes opening glossy, hoping suddenly floating,  
I pass on passivity; too much moping and coping  
No longer about splitting the bag, I want the whole thing;  
I'm not joking, I think I snorted up an o ring!*

*Got powder scrubbing our burdens like we overdosed on detergent  
B's a self-determined neurosurgeon immersed in his emergence  
encouraging my insurgence, coercing our assertion;  
A like is to a line is like a sermon to a servant*

*An internship sinfluenced into becoming my future me's apprentice  
A reverse intervention turned my apprehension to attention  
Where I cracked my starting circuitry's infinite resistance  
Sparkng mushy engines with an urgent vengeant dependence  
A reverse intervention turned my apprehension to attention  
Where I cracked my starting circuitry's infinite resistance  
Sparkng mushy engines with an urgent vengeant dependence*

As he watched David lean over the running engine to toggle its fuel governor clockwise from NORMAL to BATTLE MODE, Byron nodded an acknowledging frown like a crusty sensei bearing witness to his blooming pupil. Cuing his *ATH 1.0* playlist from his smartphone to a pill-shaped pre-paired bluetooth speaker laid beneath the oilpan with fiendish care, Byron hopped atop the redlining engine's open head and balance on a rotating camshaft like a logrolling lumberjack, its offset cams kneading his flip flopped feet; where, feeling as much as hearing Trent Reznor's warbling tremolos syncopate against six crescendoing pistons combusting forty times per second, he bobbed a manic torso down to the depth of a deferential bow then rapidly back upright at nobility's posture.

—Ruh roh! Looks like our engine has got its swagggggger baaaaack! See unlike all these poser social platforms who tickle your balls with empty hopecore content, here on the Likecoin platform we don't just post about rebuilding engines we fucking prove it!

—Which is why we're about to ask that you to prove your pink mushy engine's working by solving these proof of work puzzles.

—That's right see the first pink mushy engine who solves these neat verbal rebiis Focus and I've sprinkled into your social feeds will get the mining rights to a big ole block of Likecoin.

—Now I know what you're thinking. You're thinking why prove all this work just to mine some worthless dipshit crypto but see when you mine a block of Likecoin you're actually mineing your American Dream of homeownership as in like hey this Likecoin I just mined is getting me one step closer to making my American Dream mine.

—What's more whenever a proof of work is proven it makes the next proof even more rewarding for the next pink mushy engine to rhizomatize Likecoin's value in this grassroots way throughout our

walled cryptosocial garden so that there's not just this one path to attain your American Dream of home ownership like how these underwriters makes us believe their puckered-butt income thresholds and debt ratios but rather multiple decentralized pathways to-

C

—And speaking of millennial networks building up millennial net worths let's take a quick peek at Focus's Likecoin dashboard and wowzers well lookie here thanks to our merry band of pink mushy engines who have been with us every snort of the way our boy Focus here is a freshly minted Likecoin thousandaire! Think this calls for taking our pink mushy engines out for a celebratory lap around Ruthless Chris's waterfront bar what say you dude?

B

C

—I'd say take a look at the screen you set up behind the camera.

—What our confidence monitor?

B

—Yeah whatever see how frizzed and fucked up our hair is? Mine from being nip-whipped by your amped up gator clips and you from that head banging fit on the engine back then just-

C

—Got a focal point there Focus not as if we've got some styling mousse on board shucks golly if only there were some do-

B

everything aerosol that can not only start our engines but slick em up for a night on the town but wait lookie here Focus take a ganders at the ingredient lists on all these starting fluids Kroil Knock Er Loose Sea Foam they all got dimethyl ether in them which did you know strangely enough is the same active ingredient in styling mousse! Hear that Focus?! Acti-

C

—Damnit of course I hear it you're yelling it right in my-

—Look don't get mad I'm only yelling because I feel like you still kinda don't believe in the power of starting fluid just watch as just a quick shot from each of these starting fluids gives my bangs the bounce and gloss they need to help make all these neat friends friends like my man Focus as one of the core tenets here on Gumption and Focus as well as the Likecoin cryptosocial platform writ large is that friendships are the mirrors which teach our souls how to-

B

—Damnit we don't need any more starting fluid applications we need to shut down this engine pronto see while you were bobbing on top the engine like Trent fucking Reznor I went up to the pilothouse and took the keys out the ignition but as you can obviously hear it didn't really-

—Man fuck the keys. Hear me? Fuck em. Didn't need em to start the engine sure as fuck don't need em to stop it.

—Yeah that's my point we don't know what we need to stop the engine and if we don't figure that out soon we run the risk of-

—Run what risk?...Byron pushed back scoffed white snot with a bent wrist. —By running the damn engine?! I mean holy-

—Not running damnit redlining! Here ust look at the engine manual dogeared this page in advance after you pitched me this cockamamie starting fluid series right here overreliance on starting fluid increases the risk of a dangerous runaway condition in which the engine is addicted to its own self-sustaining combustion so that even if the operator manually shuts down fuel intake the engine is still in effect held hostage to its own combustion and will scavenge ambient fuel vapors and crankcaseoil until eventually it fails catastro-

—So glad you brought up that angle Focus because that brings us to our final hedonic hotspot. Known as the momentum in our pink mushy engines, delta fos b is what keeps us seeking combustion at top dead center over and over and over and over and over and over again. That's because just like the momentum from a piston's previous stroke pushes it to hit top dead center for its next one, delta fos b does likewise for our pink mushy engines creating this neat compulsive combustion loop where we get addicted to our own work rate so we can generate the swashbuckling momentum we need to push past our passivity and create novel solutions for ourselves out in deep water.

—Neat novel solutions out in deep water dude what are you even talking about can you please stop fucking rambling for one-

—Talking about your pink mushy engine getting all choked up when Jim threatened to take you to deep water also talking about that same

pink mushy engine gagging when I told you that a swashbuckling hero is what your being clearly wants you to be but guess what guess what dude now that you're applying your high pa-pow that engine of yours revved back up again flowing on flow setting pb's in pomodoro productivity so that you've got you some real creative momentum behind your swashbuckling story voyage so like how's that for a novel solution to your novel problem? I mean that's what this cockamamie powdered starting fluid cap and stem alternator therapy's all about finding ways to take action on the triggers that trigger our pink mushy engines into passivity like take this old carpet right under our feet to most everyone it's old musty carpet big whoop but me I see it's got the exact grody grey green hue as the carpet in my dad's garage which then triggers all the memories of me on chafed knees and elbows feeling my dad shock my buttock with his staticked dick but see starting fluid is perfect for removing the adhesive keeping you stuck to your triggers just watch as I peel a corner swatch back and shoot a quick shot and tear this trigger a new one.

—Byron whatever you're gonna do, you really don't have to do it.

—Don't have to need to Engram see that's what's great about starting fluid it cuts away the layers of your past so you can find your galvanized primal growling you that needs to get out from behind all these posing layers you've put up to protect yourself over the years like this here carpet.

After dashing three cocaine-filled pills on the salon's grey-green carpet, Byron prostrated himself as if a moose to snow-dusted moss or a muslim to dandruffed muezzin; then, having snorted at the velocity of intent, he chomped on a corner of grey-green carpet curled from curdled mildew, and flung his neck back at the ferocity of a lion to sinew.

—Umption and oculus, win hinges redhining on he ehmurican ream now rowl ith ee ruddy! Hmon avid rowl!

She pressed a blank black smartphone screen perpendicular to her paunchy, deflated womb; where, feeling as much as hearing tremolos warble out its speaker, two triggered ovaries twanged her into the memory of the first time she heard the growl. His growl. She remembered it was the only time she felt what was inside her had itself felt something. She remembered the growl orchestrating itself across the visiting room's acoustics: muffled past inch-thick plexiglass barriers; modulated through curlicued phone cords coiled around the wrists of the other better mothers seated between her; then finally matriculating up the hard plastic chair she sat in a squat to thrum between both her bone structures that she remembered making her feel like she was gestating a tuning fork. Clutching her heaving paunch with both palms, Joyce let her hand-abandoned phone fall facedown on her navel; then, remembering that she used this exact same pained-tummy gesture as her getaway alibi to the detention center's guards and guests she fled from that day — his day — Joyce doubled over in maternal guilt.



A shutting front door momentarily shunted Joyce back to present; hearing Glen's twirling keychain ping back and forth against his palm and knuckles, she remembered the correctional counselor's key hoop tambourine jostling against her hip at a similar  $3/4$  tempo in her rhythmic escort to the detention center's visitation room. Joyce felt shame spiral down her vacuumed womb as she remembered her selfishness that day; not only for wallowing in the flattering feeling that even in her zeppelinned state, she could still fit a felon's fetish, but that on the day she was there to support Byron, all she felt was saggy; that is, in order to avoid the hassle of having her tits wanded at the detention center's security checkpoint, Joyce replaced her wire maternity bra with two layers of lycra she remembered serving no real purpose other than to make her feel an extra trimester of droop so that the blob below did most of the supporting for the two blobs above.

— Is that Terrible Lie I hear?

Joyce lifted her eyes to find Glen's shadow teetering in the space between her bedroom's shut door and its floor and remembered seeing Byron's similarly slivered shadow bob in the gap of the detention center's vestibular door's and feeling suffocated with worry about what Byron could possibly be doing behind that door — or, worse, being done to him — to produce a shadow making that sound with those movements. Pivoting her phone upright, she felt chin folds stack as she glanced down to a screen still blank due to their family plan's bandwidth throttled by Glen's early morning porn torrents. Sinking her posture level with the horizon, and behind eyes clenched shut, she willed a positive projection of Byron to the front of her consciousness, remembering the first time Byron was comfortable enough to reveal his growling mania in front of her, bobbing his torso with both hands clamped to his skull in a movement which eventually became so common during their work together they coined a name for it: *doing the drinking bird*. Then she remembered the Nine Inch Nails concert the four of them attended as their first family outing and how on the ride home from The Stone Pony, Byron asked if she could help him lasso his manic energy just like Mister Reznor.

—Look Joyce by now you’ve no doubt seen Byron acting in ways which would lead you to believe I acted unilaterally in violation of certain intraspousal narcotic-based injunctions. But it’s important to understand that the very nature of an injunction can be appealed in a higher court as it were and there’s no higher court than a man courting his high so to-

Joyce pulled her bedspread to fully turtle an exhausted exasperated body; seeing a black jersey bedsheet haphazardly spattered with faded pink blotches, she remembered Glen’s initial *Apply The High 2.0* pitch amounting to the same repetitive series of smarmy, simpering *c’mons* only previously used for anal play appeals. But the hackles raised after discovering her car battery had died while taping Glen’s podcast slowly percolated over a glacial light rail ride groin-to-groin with the hoi polloi were immediately confirmed as she entered their railroad condo to find Glen raised-pinky pinching a black bedsheet draped over Byron’s easel while wearing a white blouse only previously donned for their annual butt pirate cosplay; then, with a flamenco dancer’s elan, Glen stomped his brogue while flinging bedsheet off easel with such goofy whiteboy gusto that Joyce remembered smelling the burnt-feather, high-voc wafts come off Glen’s psychoneurological exhibit before seeing a freshly spraypainted nerf football fumble off the easel to daub their grey sulci-patterned rug brain-pink. And as she imperially stopped the ball’s momentum underneath her heel’s raised toe, and as labels labelled **mesolimbic dopamine system** and **infralimbic cortex** fluttered in the air like confetti, Joyce remembered seething *never again* with the same hollow hush as a grieving mother’s second take for a gun control PSA.

—But as we’ve told our boy B it’s not the drugs you take but the friends you make along the way and this new friend of his well he’s something else bit of dodder but earnest and severe as all hell no rounded corners on this one I tell you what but guess what guess what Joyce this friend’s he might have a time solve for your pleasure based creative remediation therapy’s flow formula now I know how much you hate to say I told-

As if by instinct, Joyce cradled the blank black screen against her during her turn away from Glen's voice behind the door. Feeling the continuing slosh of her motion stretch marks, she ran a finger over the corrugated skin between her right hip and ovary, the receding waves of its existence; his existence. As a manic panic began to percolate, pushing pulsed heat through scalp pores, Joyce remembered snatching Glen's toupee while they fled the detention center's parking lot, sopping tears and underboob sweat with it as restitution for the smarm with which he reminded her how he had "*girded her for the growl*" for the entirety of their drive up 78 earlier that morning, warning that since the arraignment B's growl had grown in both endurance and force to the extent that it now sounded like a hybrid of Eddie Vedder covering Gregorian chants and a runaway engine on an empty fuel tank, two analogies that to her felt like receiving directions in a foreign language.

A belly bursting with light brought Joyce back to present. Before she could remember that the last time her torso was illuminated in that way was during her final fatal ultrasound, Joyce pivoted the lit phone upright; there she watched pixels coagulate into low-res footage of Byron doing the drinking bird while standing on top of what looked to her to be a running engine; footage which, due to the video codec's attempts to catch up to and calibrate with the growling audio already broadcast, accelerated Byron's bobbing rate to that of a syruped hummingbird. Holding seized breath, Joyce flicked down on her screen to load the next video; seeing its introductory thumbnail — a close-up on torn green carpet dangling from Byron's snarling canines — she remembered pulling off route 206 after the verdict and picking roadside kale beneath a new moon's light in the panicked hope it would pacify Byron's still-growling mania; a more sympathetic option, Glen later admitted, than deploying the two nitrous canisters painstakingly rigged to a novelty beer helmet concealed inside the welcome home cake box he clutched to his lap as he sat in the back seat.

While Joyce's worrywartedness compelled her to watch more videos, the cumulative effect of their jarbled cuts and gyroscopic tracking shots induced vertigo symptoms similar to what she felt in the weeks after the procedure; her procedure. Instead she tapped on

@Gumption&Focus's profile picture to find Byron standing in side profile, shirtless and wearing a chieftain's necklace beaded what looked to be saran-wrapped white powder, his back against a boy she'd never seen before, also shirtless but wearing Glen's bandolier from his assless chap cowboy cosplay and which holstered alternating tomatoes and kitchen timers. Her fingers as forceps, Joyce stretched the screen's image to frame Byron's left eye below a cocked eyebrow; finding a widened hazel pupil glossed eggshell white, and similar to a mother refolding their child's musty clothes after their first dorm call goes to voicemail, Joyce reached underneath the bed for Byron's medical files. Rolling back on her back, she extended a manila folder above her with locked arms so that the pink medical intake form inside dangled down from its two brass tacks. Framing her view was a popcorn ceiling speckled ochre from condensated rust sweat off pre-war steam pipes that ran above their unit to render a sprayed blood aesthetic to their bedroom – a detail which Glen regularly cited to dinner guests as the reason why their condo's rent was so low.

She remembered the last time she had seen Byron like this, shiny-eyed and shirtless. She remembered arriving at St Joseph's trauma wing still trembling from the utter scene she made at her brother's garage where after demanding to see her brother's body, only to watch the Passaic county coroner fix his gaze on his hairnetted loafer pawing the garage's grey-green carpet, she began screaming hysterically to the high heavens for some fucking answers, and there she saw Jim's goop already dried into the garage ceiling beam's woodgrain.

—Look sweetie if you're not going to let me in I have no other recourse than to produce the noises which triggers you most. Here come the facet joints, vertebrae first...

Joyce turned belly-down, planking both elbows on a pillow so freed hands could flip between the **KADS**, **CAPS-1**, and **CAPS-5** forms fastened to the manila folder; there she remembered the solemn prolonged flaps Dr. Locock took between those same forms before scooting his rolling stool over to Byron; in a folksy attempt to contextualize the coming pain of a relocated shoulder, ask him if he'd ever endured childbirth. Then she remembered how it was only after

Dr. Locock softly tapped the outside of Byron's elbow until it triggered a deep dull sound that visibly shuddered her but didn't move either man, only then did Byron lift his eyes at Dr. Locock to deadpan "no, but *I have been fucked before.*"

Having shut the manila medical folder, Joyce reached back under the bed to pull out a keepsake box safekept from Glen's prying eyes by an alibi that it contained her polaroid collection of her tape-measuring her ex boyfriend's manhoods. Lifting its top, she pulled out a baby blue therapy binder.

*Stated goal of therapy is to make patient hungry, not happy.*

Wedge in the binder's clear mylar cover was their therapy contract, scrawled on a Applegate Farm napkin in Byron's one-stroke calligraphy and notarized by Glen at neither party's request. She remembered choosing an ice cream parlor for their initial consultation, believing that a deleting a boysenberry silo together would build a vibe; a notion she remembered Byron agreeing with in principle but, seeing him dunk an open pint of rumplemintz into the silo, interpreting differently. She remembered rehearsing talking points designed to convince Byron that, unlike his intrafamilial work with Glen, she had higher psychogenic aspirations than simply coaching him to whimper at a court-ordered psychiatrist's satisfaction.

*Good Will Hunting has done for behavioral therapy what Stop Snitching has done for law enforcement.*

Joyce swallowed a cringe as she opened Byron's baby blue therapy binder, already remembering that her notes from their first sessions consisted of naive cynicism adorned by wholly unprofessional Stussy S's. She flipped through the first few pages — their trimester of silence, she remembered calling it — with nothing written save for a scribbled circle signifying their completed session and inside it, the scattered dots of an idle, anxious, and overwhelmed red pen that only now did she think look like polyps in a vacated womb. Then she came across the October 4 entry:

*He speaks! "Look Joyce your brother broke into my butt. Simple as that. And I flat had to do. But more than some silly wonky diagnosis was the outpoured emotion so much sniffing and gesticulating. And his eyes! My goodness the way his eyes glossed over when he talked about the hope he had for his future him as if he were a separate person. The trimester of silence is over! Oh what a day!*

Turning the page, she remembered why she stopped taking notes verbatim:

*"Keeping things to yourself has been the glue of civilization Joyce. That shouldn't change just because you hung some talk therapy shingle out on Frelinghuysen"*

*"I've already regurgitated enough of my father, thanks for asking though"*

*"Joyce here's the deal ok? My word will never fully be mine. As its recipient, half of it always yours so really this trimester of silence was on both of us"*

*"Maybe you should've taken your residency inside an MRI machine, at least there you would've figured out the language center is the furthest distance from conscious thought"*

Finding the October 6<sup>th</sup> entry pockmarked with pen gouges, she remembered watching Byron recline in her chaise lounge with clasped hands atop his head in a surrender cobra position; where in the midst of spouting yet another snarky bohemian koan against talk therapy, she noticed a flared right nostril's rim dusted white.

— Sorry sorry sorry just peeking my beak in see if we have any nose spray nothing more musty than these old boats am I right and uh, else that thinking maybe I can pinch a dollop from that petroleum jelly vat you still keep under the bed near the latex dremel wan-

As she reinforced her espresso espadrille against the door jamb in order to shut Glen's protruding schnozz, Joyce remembered Glen's recursive justifications for giving Byron cocaine behind her back: that the cumulative toll of his criminal and civil trials — not to mention the abuse precipitating the whole ghastly act in question — all that had put B behind the eight-ball so to speak and so you know why not give one back to the boy as restitution; that she wanted to be a talk therapist didn't she and the boy wasn't talking simple as that; and that the boy wanted to be an artist didn't he and he wasn't arting simple as that.

*Patient frames cocaine as a tool to bump future production, running counter to how most trauma patients use drugs to blunt past pain (Jacobson + Southwick 2000). Justifies daily use as "putting his future self to work"; immediate concern is managing patient's day-to-day health and wellbeing (i.e. eyelids the texture of raw hamburger). Unpack sleep's connection to uplevelled creativity? How to approach dream/sleep from the same productivity angle as Unkie Glen's midnight baggie sessions— kekule?*

She remembered pivoting Byron's session plans from processing past traumas to priming future creativity. They watched The Terminator; They unpacked Kubla Khan's romance, despite Glen

standing outside her studio's window for most of the hour, tapping his imaginary wristwatch while asking in a muffled shout when oh when would B be free to fling dancing white rocks across their sacred rivers together. She felt a flare of guilt tinge inside her as she remembered rumplemintzing a boysenberry silo as a way of enticing Byron to participate in a karaoke duet of *I Can't Get No (Satisfaction)*, with Byron later slurring in passing on their ride home together that a silly stupid blocker in his getting back to arting was that his pair of self-sewn work coveralls had been confiscated into evidence after that battery blowup thing with her brother, whatever happened there.

Later that night, over a glass of pinot noir she sipped, swished, and spat into Glen, Joyce searched “**sewing + dreams**” on her smartphone; where after Glen dispatched himself to the Passaic County drug court's ganked and found station, she teased their upcoming dream therapy session by texting Byron a picture of a Singer sewing machine she painstakingly arranged on her therapy studio's chaise lounge only to arrive at work that next morning to find him pacing the parking lot while cradling a stack of burlap and a bottle of beeswax; Where, having cleared her docket by calling her day's roster of suburban whiners, she remembered watching Byron stride into her studio at the velocity of intent to unfurl his sheet of burlap he held in this mesmerizing flamenco-trickster way so that its flung dust glittered like pixie dust as it shot across slivers of midmorning light brought on angled shutters projecting slatted shadows on her studio's carpet that she remembered interpreting as a prison, he a crib.

She remembered the pattered click of the Singer's needle piercing burlap sync with its treadle's motorized whirr as she began telling Byron the origin story of the sewing machine; that for years Elias Howe felt like this big poser inventor for not figuring out how to automating the needle switch by integrating the needle into the bobbin – up until the night he dreamt he'd been taken hostage by a tribe of cannibals. And after these cannibals gave Elias a twenty-four hour ultimatum for him to fulfill his personal purpose, Elias said he recalled feeling just as frustrated working subconsciously in his dream as he did during conscious work until, on the next dream day's morning;

where after fecklessly begging the cannibals converging on him for just a little more time, Elias Howe lowered his eyes in shame to find, pointed at his bellybutton, spears bevelled like a needle's shaft their tips featuring hollowed-out eyes never before seen.

But as she watched Byron scale their fourth-floor walkup in four-step leaps then waddle her bloated bowling ball of a body up those same stairs at a glacial pace and find him hunched over a baggie Glen held at their condo's entryway, Joyce remembered feeling the giddiness of Byron's breakthrough session drain from her heart down into her abdominally split gut. It was then she understood that for Byron's dream therapy to stick, there were still the brass physiological tacks of getting his body to bedrest. This task she foisted on Glen for the obvious reason that he was supplying the controlled substance keeping Byron awake in the first place; and who, after initially pushing quaaludes and other equestrian remedies, ultimately agreed he would covertly add powdered melatonin into Byron's nightly kale, beet, and boysenberry smoothie. That same night, Joyce remembered leaning one fourth-trimester-inflated butt cheek on the musty mattress Byron hauled from his father's garage, hoisted four flights and wedge into her nursery's vacant crib in which he contorted himself in its u-shaped bulge like a bao bun ordered with blonde fatty pork belly in order to tell Byron how Kekule arrived at his groundbreaking benzene formula in a dream; then, seeing Byron scrunch his cocooned blanket tight against a sleepy smirk, she remembered hearing Byron unctuously mutter how neat those gambling atoms in Kekule's fire were and that maybe all this arting stuff is simply about chasing his shadow's tail.

*From: be\_chianti@hotmail.com  
To: joy\_neumann@gmail.com  
Subject: I dreamt.*

After picking Byron up play-passed out on one of MLK boulevard's corner curbs, Joyce remembered Byron stretching out the majority of that day's session with the kind of equivocating teases — *Will my memory accept the rose from my metacognition? Find out after my short piss break* — that would make reality tv producers tap their imaginary watches. Then after disclosing that yes, he and Glen tossed a few



drops of a homebrewed psilocybin tincture into last night's kale smoothie without her consent and that yes, he'll personally pressure wash her aqua foot massager-turned-carboy first thing once they get home, Byron finally unpacked the contents of his dream.

He found himself inside the arena, standing in front of a bull already having been released from its pen. She remembered Byron making it abundantly clear that he was the matador in the dream, not some picador or peone; and that he suggested it's best they gloss over how handsome he looked in his bejewelled, midriff-baring peach jacket with matching beaded chinos. Then Joyce remembered that the only time Byron ever attempted to peek at her therapy binder was to personally confirm that his hatred of frillery in all forms had been noted for the record. She remembered Byron describing the bull that standing before him: forequarters deflated by dangling banderías still stuck to its swell; hooves too weak to break ground crusted by its own dried blood; how the slumped bull's every movement seemed to be weighed down by its own effort. And even though Byron told her that he initially refused the local magistrate's call to put the sword in the bull — *honest* — he admitted that the crowd's welling whistles eventually compelled him to take action. Then she remembered watching Byron spring off her chaise longue to stretch himself as tall as possible, his locked arm raising an invisible puntilla high above his head before thrusting it and his whole self down upon her leather ottoman; where, with a voice hidden behind blond bangs splayed on the ottoman and muffled by its tufted buttoned leather, Byron said he felt the bull's growl crawl up through the blade he had just lodged behind its noggin and vibrate the hilt he held in this weird somnioelectric way that not only kept him from letting go but also pulled him closer to the bull like, she remembered him saying, a mentor shaking an intern's hand. Byron then told Joyce he flung out the red cape behind him — a cape he admitted he forgot he even had in the first place — so he could hasten the bull's death by trolling its instinct. He then told her that as he watched the blacks in the bull's eye gloss with spilled vitreous, he clocked his own image reflected in its convex lenses, a dream image which he interpreted as proof that his existence existed beyond the bull's focal point. And after she asked

Byron what he thought his dream represented, Joyce remembered Byron first emphasizing his total deference to her in all matters of psychiatric interpretation before telling her that to him the whole bull-brain-puntilla-tug-of-war dream was a kind of reverse sword in the stone type scenario, and that maybe for this creative thing is all about holding onto the growls of our wounds as long as one humanly can.

**Black bull = id** | Shadow is the self unshown to the world. A weakened bull signifies a repressed shadow, also power dynamic of mentor and intern, thinks his shadow's leading him instead of he, it

**Matador = ego** | The ego's reality honors the id's instinct, directing primal forces by dancing with them, giving the bull space to act out its instinct, masters the bull through performance, and appearances (byron questioning why he simply didn't brain his dad brain dead).

**Cape = aesthetic-principle** | survival through artifice, flourish, and symbolic play. If art prepares the living for death, artists like matadors, transforms death into spectacle

**Blade = superego** | Sharp objects like puntilla represent decisiveness, whether through separation or sacrifice. the cutting power of discernment or transformation. blade? because it imposes judgment — but the act of wielding it still belongs to ego.

Similar to the weeks after a child first learns the existence of dinosaurs, subsequent therapy sessions consisted of Byron endlessly spouting bullfighting arcana. In between being regaled about entrails and ears, Joyce remembered the social custom of keeping bulls in the dark before they're let into the ring, so that the bright sun confuses them when they're released into the rigged fight for their lives; a fact which even a first-year therapist could connect to Byron's anxiety about entering the creative arena.

*Cross-reference patient files to make sure postponement alibis aren't being used twice—first gestational diabetes test, then alpha-fetoprotein test, nuchal translucency as last resort! Methinks the preggio therapy lady doth blood test too much.*

After Byron's dream breakthrough, Joyce remembered the dread with which she dealt with her roster of paying patients. While sessions with Byron were spent learning about who he wants to be, the only thing she remembered learning about her patients — outside of the banal depths of suburban suffering — were which ones had PPOs, as the first thing she remembered Dr. Pflasid teaching her was how to classify patients by their reimbursement rates. Joyce remembered choosing a talk therapy emphasis for her masters in Clinical Psychology not based on a personal desire to spend the next three years at Seton Hall immersed in the discipline, but rather to placate a welling anxiety in beginning a career whose only certainty was that its debt had already begun to amortize.

She remembered the lengths with which Dr. Pflasid squeezed her suede clog mules about pursuing her initial emphasis of pediatric behavioral health; how every Tuesday office hour he would cite a different medical journal supporting the burgeoning talk therapy vertical before concluding their one-sided chat by lifting her chin with his cusped, notoriously hairy knuckle to deliver the same bland, patronizing-as-fuck reminder that only the dictionary can put passion before profitability.

Flicking her thumb against the corner of a business card stapled to her one and only promotional mailer, a headshot of her leaning against a brick wall with crossed arms, her practiced half-cocked smile betrayed by lips, nose, and cheeks scrunched in confusion at the miniature stuffed bull calm doll Glen dangled behind the tripod camera at her moment of recognition and without her consent, Joyce remembered the day she received the thousand-count box of business cards embossed with the LPCC honorific, only to see its torn decorative ribbon haphazardly rejoined by scotch tape, later learning that Byron and Glen had been timing the postman's arrival for weeks so they could intercept the package. She remembered lifting the business card box to find the top right corner of each card adorned with a frame's worth of a zoetrope flipbook depicting Byron in full matador garb, one hand gripping a dripping bandolier the other waving to the fourth wall as if beckoning her to enter the arena with him. This was the latest in a series of "*pitch pranks*"; a cheeky catch-all term for whenever Glen and Byron would throw back a few post-midnight nose beers and think up neat new ways to lobby her into professionally adopting their cockamamie apply the high therapy. Later that night she remembered loading her VHS copy of Karpman's Drama Triangle only for her to discover the cassette had been taped over with a compilation of interviews with sports coaches — Coughlin, Parcels and some pointy-nose varmint-looking guy named Shushsefsky — all attributing their team's success not by being beholden to a specific system of thought but by tailoring their approach to their players' strengths, which Joyce remembered feeling as if she was receiving a pregame pep talk for a

sport she's never played. Then she remembered that the only reason she remembered any of this was that that was what she was watching when she received an urgent call from her obstetrician.

*"Estrogen withdrawal from addiction combined with increased  $\Delta$ FosB in the NAc core impacts anxiety as it relates to fetal health. Taken together, these results suggest FosB expression has a neurological role during gestation in its ties to postnatal pup mortality in FosB mutant mothers."*

*"Despite being normal with respect to other cognitive abilities, FosB mutant mothers are shown to be profoundly deficient in their ability to nurture their young. And that these data establish that the pup survival defect lies entirely in FosB mutantcy within the mother."*

*"A typical FosB mutant mother takes up to fifty times longer to nurture their pups suggesting FosB's corrosive influence on the hypothalamus."*

*"Wild-type females demonstrate high levels of nurturing behavior whereas FosB mutant females showed little or none. Moreover, it would seem that the nurturing deficiencies of FosB mutant mothers cannot be overcome by learning and experience."*

Joyce remembered spending most of her empty trimester scouring lab notes from her Pharmacology and Pharmacogenetics class for any board-certified rationale for why what had happened had happened to her. She remembered feeling shame's heat knead up her spine every time she came across the phrase *"critical nurturing defect"*, triggering the memory of ritually snorting a Metrocard-mashed Percocet off the top of a metallic toilet paper dispenser in the same Cabrini Hall bathroom stall every Monday Wednesday and Friday at 10:58 a.m. Outside of emotional flagellation under the guise of psychiatric research, the only other activity Joyce remembered taking on in the weeks recovering from her procedure was sewing out their bedroom's sunlight by napping the hooked ends off several of Glen's wire coathangers that she then punctured through her bay window curtains' silk slits. She shook off a pursed-lip sigh as she remembered the strawberry fruit by the foot Glen unfurled under the gap of their bedroom's locked door each morning, his limplicked attempt at delivering her sustenance for the day and upon which she projected her placenta.

She remembered keeping their bedroom door locked in the duration since she returned from the procedure up until the day Byron followed up an unanswered knock with a growl timbred to a playful whimper, which was his way of distinguishing his request from Glen slapping his boner against the shut door while whining about not having gotten his dick wet for the better part of her

fourth trimester. And after a lunged leg twisted a knob lock vertical with two of her toes, Joyce remembered sliding her spine up her headboard so she could present herself to Byron with a more dignified posture than a puddle. Feeling leaking milk dribble down stupid-perky tits to funnel off needlessly widened hips before collecting in her deflated paunch's bellybutton, she remembered squeaking *come in* in a voice wrung with grief, then watch the door crack just wide enough for Byron to slide half his body through; where after wiping semen-colored snot on his self-sewn work coveralls's thigh, he prefaced his incoming spiel by reiterating his complete and unfaltering trust in her judgment regarding all matters of recovery; but just as he began segueing into how he was beginning to get concerned about her Joyce remembered blurting out that she was exponentially more concerned about him; that despite having been detached from his life for the past several weeks, rest assured she was worried sick about the psychopharmacological choices he was continuing to make, in particular those choices which are giving him those white snot sniffles, and he should know that every time he leans down to rip another of Glen's poodle legs there's this neurological villain called FosB looming over your noggin just waiting to take your future you hostage and that believe him her this FosB character is one tough mephistophelean hombre and certainly not a psychopharmacogeneurological transcription factor to tangle assholes with; lest she even mention how guilty Byron would feel if lil Remy ever got a whiff of that stuff while pawing your nose as you two cutely coo; where in the subsequent silence only broken by heaving hiccup-sobs recognizing her trauma's false recall, Joyce remembered how sweet Byron was to not cock a sanity-questioning eyebrow but instead pivot the conversation back to this interesting neurological hostage-taker FosB because all he got out of all that cathartic stemwinding of her back then just now was that there is something inside him which still has value.

~~As a mother I know how hard it is to lose a child but just as we both  
worked together that dreadful night after the coroner left to wipe  
your slate garage floor clean, I believe we can do something similar.~~

ShopRite  
Ame  
King's food

Joyce remembered crossing out her half-baked talking points while waiting out the three-and-a-half-ring purgatory before Brenda picked up, the whole stupid ghastly conversation about Byron possibly perhaps moving into her railroad condo culminating in visceral call-and-response wails she remembered rising to the pitch and intensity of **Gimme Shelter's** interlude. Earlier that week, Byron mentioned he'd be game to fill in their condo's recently vacated space under the pretense of advancing their dreamtherapy work together; a request she approved in direct spite of Glen warning her that her pup-nurturing instinct may be a tad raw, given recent events. Lower on that page she listed Hoboken grocers circled and crossed out based on their ability to source out-of-season boysenberry; and as she noticed her curlicued consonants and happy-faced vowels, she remembered how Byron had made her feel like a girl with a crush on a boy, instead of a woman who had just crushed a boy in her womb.

*Send over some dopamine or your child's synapses will get it-by which  
they'll get nothing, get it in the sense they'll of being starved of it)  
look you know what I'm getting at Doctor Neumann.*

*-ΔFosB*

She remembered not being able to sleep the night Byron moved in, as Glen forced her two after-dinner toots as motivation to finish scraping the remaining wallpaper greebles off their nursery's wall before he arrived; Glen's belief being that the wallpaper's sunset ombre gradient recalled the residue of her late brother and early son in equal measure. And so she was already awake when, in the pockets of silence between the grandfather clock's strokes of midnight, she heard the soft rustle of a piece of paper being placed against her closed bedroom door, the tick of a pressed tack, then the deep hollow thunderclap of a hammer striking their bedroom door timed at the chime's thirteenth hour, its impact punctuated by the receding scurry of two socks skidding down their hallway's hardwood floors and a shut door's thwacked lock.

After watching Glen sprint toward the nursery, Joyce remembered swiveling her torso in front of her vanity mirror to triple-check her robe coverage and ensure Byron would not be able to see any part of her butchered body. She remembered arriving at the

nursery's shut door to find Glen squatting on his haunches such that one testicle had pushed past the hem of his manila-colored briefs, muttering "*Commercial-grade lock. They've come prepared.*" as he contemplatively swished the sawdust piled on the floor between both palms. Later that morning, she remembered steaming a kale bouquet to entice Byron from his room while she and Glen interpreted the ransom note's semantics; her theory being that Byron's self-kidnapping was his attempt at exerting control over the first living situation without the lingering threat of his father slash her brother's controlling abuse, and that if she and Glen wanted to get him they'd have to, you know — she cringed as she remembered how she flexed both index and middle fingers between her temples for emphasis — get him. Then she remembered Glen sarcastically shaking invisible dice near his groin in response and suggest through the sides of pursed lips that she dry her ovaries.

They did agree that they should nurture Byron's hostage cosplay. Glen cashed in a courthouse chit to procure a voice garbler so they would be able to negotiate with this FosB character in anonymity. During an argument over which of them should call Byron, she remembered Glen aggressively toggling his smartphone within her personal space so she could clearly see Bergen County's hostage negotiation protocols displayed on its screen, its phase zero decision tree unequivocally stating that first contact should be initiated by the person to whom the ransom note was addressed. And as Glen standing in her sight line stretching invisible dough, she remembered asking Byron through the garbler's screwed-on mouthpiece what should she ask him, then hearing him request in his meek mischievous tone of his she should ask him for proof of life. So she did. Then he did, rearranging the multicolored fridge magnet letters promoting *ACTADID O.N.* a new-to-market SSRI variant for postpartum depression Dr. Pflacid shipped a trimester-high stack of single-use pouches over that month that she remembered feeling undeserving to consume. Joyce hiccuped a chuckle as she remembered Glen's feckless attempts in trying to capture Byron in his stealth anagram act using the same cat-and-mouse energy with which he attempted to catch the steward assigned to refill the daily fruit basket in their honeymoon cruise's cabin.

She remembered Glen chalking up missing Byron arrange the first fridge anagram – **NOT DADDIC** – to first-time parent tucker factor; his frustration rising when on the second night a thwocked nursery lock jolted Glen upright from the nursery rocker recently moved into the living room and slosh a gut-rested tumbler of scotch on his terrycloth robe; where, getting up to refill his spill, he found fridge letters rearranged to **ADDICTION**; when on that third night, Joyce remembered entering their railroad condo after her first day at her therapy studio to find **ACTION DID** canted playfully at a toddler's kerning; then smelling wafts of burnt lacquer, Joyce walked into her bedroom to find a sunny side egg sizzling atop the grandfather clock inherited from her brother's estate, its daliesque yolk dripping down its glass dial door. Then she remembered Glen brush her aside, gum the yolk's runoff with his pinky, bob a nodding frown in contemplation, then unilaterally decide they would extract Byron before first light.

And so, after Glen laced up one of Byron's Red Wings he was convinced he had placed in their mud room as a talismanic aid to gain forced entry, Glen kicked the nursery door off its hinges, despite Byron having unthwocked its lock in anticipation of their arrival. She remembered forgetting how hairy Glen's back was as she followed him into the nursery while fanning aerosolled oven cleaner in a windshield wiper motion to, presumably, disorient the enemy within. Through this carcinogenic haze, Joyce found Byron cocooned to his easel in an upside down crucifix position with what he divulged later was two hundred eggs worth of silly putty paper-maching newspaper clippings from the Newark Star-Ledger's coverage of both his trials. Then after ripping green painter's tape off Byron's lips, she remembered Byron blurting out that boy howdy was she right about that devious FosB character taking him hostage, but that not to worry because like all crummy villains, pausing to spastically flit his restrained head toward the hardcover copy of Goethe's **Faust** that lay behind her on a sheetless crib raised to a newborn's height, FosB arrogantly hid the tools to free him in plain sight. She remembered feeling a hollow rattle as she picked the book off the crib; opening it, she found a gutted word womb filled with razorblades, halved fast food straws, a digital scale,



her missing compact mirror, and a glass vial blackened front flap was a seven-columned table labelled **SMTWTFS** whose horizontal rows presented dates from the past seven Sundays, its grid filled with decimals ranging from .2 to .5; to its right was a to do list of his whole cockamamie hostage scheme – *source epoxy, test easel's tensile strength, paper mache all paterson patricide publicity* – all crossed off with whiteout Cezannely daubed at the texture of intent. Like a flood current stalling against an outgoing tide, she remembered feeling peristaltic waves of relief knowing that the razorblades inside were for sorting powder not slitting wrists crash against the draining truth of Byron's daily cocaine intake; her gravitational lucidity trampled by Glen bellowing "I'll take it from here ma'am" while brushing her aside with an armbar so he could snatch the vial from the hollowed book; who after genuflecting at Byron's side and twisting the vial's cap off and tossing it aside as its fused metal spoon lacked the capacity of what this moment required, poised the open vial's threaded glass rim above flaring upside-downed nostrils and with the care of a chef seasoning spatchcocked fowl tapping the vial's bottom to tumble its contents into Byron's nasal cavity. She remembered hearing a sharp guttural sniff then watch Byron's convulsing body popeye itself free from a putty papoose she remembered being more interested in how Byron got into than out. And as she caught Byron in his fall from his upside-down easel crucifix still coated in a caul of dried epoxy, she remembered Glen muttering something about needing to submit the vial into evidence before she watched him bound out the nursery in one leap and wearing one boot, then hear their hallway bathroom's door shut and its faucet run.

Over a failed stack of boysenberry pancakes later that morning — still frazzled from pre-dawn events, Joyce mistakenly coated their cast iron skillet with the oven cleaner Glen had left in the nursery; its canister recklessly branded the same butter yellow as her non-stick cooking spray — she remembered helping Byron unpack his thinking behind the whole FosB kidnapping event. Where, in between gnaws on wilted kale, Byron admitted aloof he felt like he could only create if he personal physical survival was at stake, Joyce remembered softly whispering that that much was clear; her chuckle dropping to a silent

vince once she remembered her brother's needlessly elaborate and exceedingly grotesque death. Then Byron told her that right after she gave him her whole stemwinding warning about this FosB character that day in her dark bedroom, he biked over to his local library to so he could learn up on all things FosB — things like that it's this equal opportunity hostage taker because get this FosB regulates addiction in all forms, which meant this FosB character was not only behind his past addiction to passivity he'd been trying to shake ever since his dad started dad fucking him whatever happened there but it had been motivating his current addiction to action — *I mean it's in the word y/ know* — she remembered Byron reminding her with unctuous sincerity — action which yes was being jumpsparked via the poodle legs Glen had been arranging him to chase before beginning his creative sessions. And that his thinking here was like why not use this white powder to bait FosB into giving his addictions the ole switcheroo from a passive martyred past to a creator's active future. And that that was whole neuropsychological thrust behind his hostage titty-pincher was to communicate to Doctor Neumann that he believed cocaine's induced pleasure had given his noggin the plasticity it needs to break through his calcified passive past — hence the putty papoose. And that he really thinks he has something special in the way he's applying his high, but that without her maternal support and board-certified guidance, it would seem as if he was this poser rebel artist doing drugs for — and she remembered how Byron's face soured as he said it — the cool factor. So, similar to a parent hedging the outright refusal of a child's request by attaching an unattainable condition to it, Joyce stipulated she would consider Byron's cockamamie cocaine creative therapy idea so long as he could show her any clinical practice article establishing a psychopharmacogenomic connection between pleasure and trauma. That next morning, Joyce remembered finding a note between Glen's toupee and a bust of Phil Hartman's Unfrozen Caveman Lawyer acting as its stand:

**Higher Ground: A Couplet.**

*Pleasure is biologically about getting up, not flying high  
So say these peer-reviewed verbal rebiii:*

Russian fighter aircraft + US inflated stock index ^1: (page 161)  
Seinfeld's sworn enemy in its Mexican syndication. (abstract) ^2  
The Hindu God of compassion's preferred flatbread. ^3  
The only spot to enjoy Thai wings and mudslides in New Jersey ^4  
Not a dog boy but a... ^5

*Pleasure enhances the ability to find a self. In this manner, a drug taken to achieve pleasure may activate mechanisms of plasticity necessary to properly address trauma.” –Miglow*

*Significant neuroadaptations within both stress and reward neurocircuitry may reveal a striking connection between trauma and its potential cure.” –EL Newman*

*Plasticity within the brain's reward circuits is important for patients to actively maintain an emotional homeostasis, particularly after a traumatic incident.” –Krishnan*

*Psychostimulants which enhance dopamine (DA) release were effective at ameliorating symptoms in combat-related trauma patients.” –Houlihan*

*“Low hedonic tone is a dysfunction in the neural circuits that regulate motivation and reward processing.” –Katzmann*

Wedged in the binder's back flap and behind the inch-thick stack of stapled JSTOR studies titled “Work (Ex)cited” was an invitation to Byron's first showing: Throwing in the Growl. Joyce didn't bother opening it, remembering that, like a drug, the enjoyment of audio-enhanced cards diminishes after its initial use.

—For fuck sake are you finally done flicking your memory bean with that damn therapy binder?

—Gah! For fuck sake Glen, how long have you been... Her startle having dredged up the repressed judgements of the man who started all this inside her in the first place, and who currently loomed over her as she lay on the bed upside down with flared nostrils caked white, Joyce felt herself dissociate into an reactionary blur in which she couldn't remember what she was saying as she said it.

—How long have I been hovering? Wha, I can't fondly reflect on my role in shaping our boy B's journey I mean I've had as much of a hand in jumpsparking his creative career as you have. Come to think seeing that binder again makes me wonder if we still had those neat cocaine rebiis trying to infuse some fresh material into my three's bumpy pilot and-

—...

—Yes I was about to say I also have a conciliatory motive in appearing as I wanted to apologize for my part in this longstanding marital tort we got going between us.

—...

— Well I guess first on the docket is unilaterally cleaning our adopted son's cocaine gift a gift that for the record I had no prior foreknowl-

— ...

— No that's not all I'd also like to submit addendums a fucking up our carpet with the spraypainted football exhibit after our podcast and b my deceitful adoption of a devil's advocate persona on said podcast to coverup any premeditated scent matter facts how bout I just give you a class-action apology for any and all emotionally indemnifiable damages over the past few weeks how about that.

— ...

— Just so long as we're clear about who started this whole neurological interventionary kerfuffle in the first place what with you being so adamant about working with our boy B despite my strenuous objections concerning the board-certified ethics of this sort of dual relationship.

— ...

— Well according to Commonwealth v Almeida you started it is point of fact an admissible argument ok I mean I still don't know why you get so mad and defensive whenever I ask you to unpack this new adverse posture of yours against Byron being the poster boy for a therapy that's clearly shown-

— ...

— Well yes fine if that's how you want to characterize it Joyce I am putting you in cross.

— ...

— For being a nimby for one.

— ...

— Not in my boy's y chromosome is what that even means.

— ...

— Well actually I think the cobbler's children going barefoot perfectly describes the situation here. I mean holy shit just last week right before he went and interviewed on that yacht the boy told us he felt his brain crowning then you of all people are denying him the reuptake inhibitor epidural he needs to-

—...!

—No you're right yes you're right.

—...? ...!

—No you're right you're right you're right you're right I prostrate myself before the court and offer my sincere apologies to your womb.

—...

—That stated as the man whose prostate has successfully courted said womb I feel there should be a little more give and take on our parental strategies than you know like me giving the boy drugs and then you taking all this offense.

—...?

—Why can't he simply be clean well because clean dirt bears no fruit that's why.

—...

—Well if legal exposure's your concern frankly Joyce I'm offended.

—...

—Well you should give a shit about validating my offense because guess what I already thought through a defense strategy see we just get a religious exemption for the boy's drug use found already relevant case law in State of Oregon v Wyland summary judgment writes itself the same liberty given to faith-based parents is hereby bestowed onto eighth-based-

—...

—Yes I know that's weed not coke I'm riffing here remind me again who bought whom a leopard print bong bag for our first anniversary?

—...?

—Apparently the egg wasn't given but gifted. Said it was some kind of up payment for-

—...

—Some foreign investor in this Likecoin scheme he's over his skis-

—...

—The kind of foreign investor you don't want to tangle assholes with.

—...

—Well if it doesn't matter then why'd you ask me in the first place?  
Now look Joyce I concede that trust is the umbilical cord  
nourishing every marriage and so yes I concede my actions have  
stretched and stressed that trust to the point that there's whole lot of  
tensile strength holding us together and so if it pleases you I'd like to  
go over some motions on how to restore the plasticity of said cor-

—...

—Well I'll tell you the same thing I told the State Bar's probation  
board just as trust is earned through applied justice, so is justice  
earned through applied punishment.

—...

—Well and this is just me riffing here but I think punishment by  
hammurabian code fits the crime here.

—...?!

—Fits in the sense that the lip service I paid you about how I  
wouldn't go behind your back and clean our boy B's drugs can be  
repaid right here right now by me lifting up your denim muumuu  
and servicing those two neglected lips of-

—...

—Oh no no no don't even act like face-sitting restitution hasn't been  
a cornerstone of this marriage since we made up at Byron's baptism.

—...

—What about his new friend.

—...?

—Sees what I see Doctor Neumann, sees the missing piece to this  
therapy you've been grinding on I mean have you seen their videos  
they're something else I tell you wh-

—...

—No no I know just take a look at the post before their cockamamie  
engine repair powdered starting fluid drip campaign you'll see his  
glossy eyed friend speedbagging that alarm clock Byron went and

rigged up as a titty-pinching motivation for this timeboxing technique he's got which I'm told every tally is roughly twenty-five-

—...

—No one's saying it isn't silly Doctor Neumann we both know our boy B's silly as the day's long but if you can just see beyond the silly-

—...?

—Yeah but like see that mirror behind all that tittypinching bullshit? All those tally marks that's B's friend quantifying his work you know, time spent in flow state and see get this since I went and took the initiative of ganking a pipette grid and sending over a leftover sixer of our homebrewed psilly beer from your foot massager-cum-carboy now B and his friend are set up to meant test your nose dosage with a real live time heuristic which means all we need is your board-certified buy in and apply the high two point therapy's got a fighting-

—...

—Frankly Joyce I have been getting real been burning some serious psychopharmacogenomic marketing calories on getting some real momentum behind your pleasure based creative remediation therapy and speaking to you not as your husband but as your dutch uncle here I'm telling you Joyce this is it. Those black lines B's friend's tallying on that captain's mirror that's what's gonna get white ones up the noses of an entire generwhoakay there alrighty then!..Glen reacted to Joyce curled one hand's index finger with a come-hithering rhythm as the other hiked a denim muumuu past paunch. Spreading her thighs to stirrup-width, she waited until Glen's slackmouthed head entered within her thighs' reach before collapsing one leg's calf behind his hairy nape; then placing the back of her other leg's knee over the top of the choking leg's ankle, she drew Glen in for a taste of her inverted triangle guillotine recipe. And there, with the top half of Glen's skull breached just above her pubic bone and squirming as if he was unsure whether to get out or go in, Joyce drummed four fingers atop the bare dome like a spider feeling for weak spots on an egg.

—These are the terms.

Offshore wind signaling an approaching low rattled a tiara, riffled a veil, and brushed a caked face constipated with glee. She felt her train spastically lift as if it were an impediment, then watch her photographer emerge from behind her, his shutter release cable trailed umbilically from her gown. The photographer then sprawled on his side, he his own centerfold pose, so that the same elbow that propped his head pinched her train to the patio's herringboned concrete. Now pinned to her posing cube's pedestal, she searched the patio's amphitheater of formalwear for support, her smile flattening to a cringe sfter feeling handsewn groin doilies stretch against her womb at each swivel. She found that support casually leaning butt and brogue against patio glass, swaddled in giggles from her gaggle of bridesmaids. She gathered from his puffed-cheek waddle he was describing the proprietary training methods which built the necessary rectal dexterity to be able to fart *I do* on command. Finally, and as if by extrasensory nagging, the eyes she watched found hers; where after hearing him bark that if she knew what was good for her she'd turn around and spread her arms, then watching his tuxedoed elbow seeking comedic support nudge her maid of honor's bodiced tit, she



paired her stuck smile with eyebrows so daggered she felt her botox burble. Her senses now heightened by a welling anxiety, she heard waves lap against the waterfront patio's jutting rotunda beneath her in a slow, mocking clap congratulating a life whose culmination is its betrothal to another. After pressing her doiled groin against the patio's beehived steel railing, she assumed an open-armed pose equal parts crucifixion and celebration. And as the autofocus's whirr made her ovaries hum in ways that made her feel as if she were gestating a tuning fork, and as she watched a flurry of flashes pass past her to illuminate Hudson River's paralleled skyline glass panels into the rose gold — her rose gold — that matched every pocket square and panty on the patio, her smile finally fell in a spasm, as if receiving a belated gift you've since grown out of.

—*Hashtag relationship goals!*

A warbled, over-prolonged harmony cut through the patio's shut glass and mingle with the bar's conversational murmur.

—Bet you that bride's been practicing that Titanic pose since... David said as his thumb and middle finger gimballing a glass tumbler below searching lips. — Since before she touched her first boner.

—Yeah man. Boners are tough.

—What? Look you're the one who wanted to go out and celebrate becoming Likecoin millionaires. I was fine staying in and keep on you know applying the high toward loosening that damned stuck seacock so we can finally-

—Likewise, my dude. Likewise.

—The fuck's that mean?... David asked while blotting a blocked nostril with a wadded napkin.

—Sorry just focused on the game. Thinking pic and roll here.

As David lifted his focus from the bar's mirror to the triptych of suspended flat screens looming above them, Byron flit a glance to the two-top table to his right.

—Actually they're running horns set. See where the big men are outside the key that's usually a-

—Damnit Engram get your head in the game!...A back was slapped with such resuscitative intensity that its pocky impact interrupted the conversation between two women seated at a nearby two-top, whose initial concern was quickly disabused as they watched the back of the slapper's head repeatedly flick back in their direction, to which the slappee, lifting his eyes, boinged carnal eyebrows in their direction.

—Well shit!...Byron flung a cherry on the bar's parquet floor at the frustrated velocity of a coach's clipboard after a designed play wasn't run out of a timeout. —Now we definitely have to go over there.

—What, why?

—Whadya mean, why? To explain that facial fart you just wafted their way back then just now that's why.

—Okay well lets at least have a couple drinks first, you know warm up a little before we go over there and cold approach two-

—Cold approach? Look Engram don't think of it as like running game, just think of it as a game. Now trust me pic and roll's the simplest play in the game just follow me I'll be your lead blocker through these sharkskin suits here-

—Hey man wait...David hushed at Byron as he hunched behind him. —For fuck sake just wait I mean just so we're clear, you want me to go up to those two girls and what, block their path while holding my nuts? Because I don't know how you were taught to set a pick but-

—A picture, fool...Byron turned around to toggle his smartphone in David's face. —Not a fucking screen.

—Oh for fuck sake...

—Oh no no no you better get those rolling eyes of yours in line right now bub you think I'm gonna let any more of that facial incontinence of yours leak into our neat night out you got another thing coming now look imago over there like a mature adult and ask those there women to take our picture.

—Ok. And then what?

Byron squinted, shrugged, and slowly swiveled both palms in the manner of someone confused with another's confusion. —Then we roll with it.

—Roll with it?

—You know. read the defense. Lots of ways women can play these pic and roll situations. They can hedge drop slip trap switch and scam fuck they might even double-team one of us blitz the ball handler that sort of thing.

—Look Byron I know what you're trying to do but I, I just don't think I'm ready to do it. I mean those two over there, they look pretty put together.

—You saying you can't approach pretty? Didn't take you for a brutalist Engram.

—No I just mean I feel like they'll be able to smell my financial impotence wafting off me before I can even-

—Need I remind you mister David Engram aka captain influencer aka the big focus that you're a Likecoin millionaire ok so no reason why you shouldn't be up to your nuts in confidence. And certainly no reason why you should be scared to meet a couple pretty women.

—I'm not scared to meet them Byron it, it's them meeting me that I'm-

—Well I met you. So what do you know about yourself I don't?

—I, well I mean I know I'm not you.

—So.

—So? So have you seen our kpis? Because if you have you'd see you're outperforming me in every metric that Juug and his merry band of Likecoin investors care about glance value conversion rates social shares so forgive me if I feel like I don't measure up to the moment.

Hearing this, Byron pursed his lips into a wince while shaking invisible dice near his groin. He kept this gesture going while leaving David behind, timing his arrival at the two-top so that his final stroke's followthrough brushed back blonde bangs before locking the arm as suave crutch upon a nearby barstool cushion.

—Hullo.

—You here to apologize for your friend eyefucking us or what?

—Marcie.

—Well point of fact my friend David wasn't eyefucking either of yous he was actually eyefucking this areola of light on your table, which now that I'm closer to it,gotta admit is quite pert. See my friend David he's this bigtime international influencer and so like after I clued him into the voluptuous lumens you two were working with over here, well you know how these influencers turn flat diva during golden hour.

—Neat. So.

—So I know we just met which means my business isn't necessarily yours but I think it'd be this really neat gesture if y'all'd be so kind as to let us suckle your light for a quick pic as a way to you know help nurse my friend David's face back to health.

—Yeah, no.

—Puh please please? I promise it'll just take a titty bit of your time, we'll even buy your next round of drinks how's that.

—Oh ho! So that's your game. The ole pic and roll. While I'm distracted taking your picture one of you chucklefucks drop some something in my drink and wallah you're free and clear to roll on top of me for the rest of my blacked-out night that your twisted angle?

—Marcie...

—Ok how bout I do you one better the four of us'll split the pic's earnings see my friend David and I are influencers for Likecoin this new global cryptoplay that's straight off the blockchain calleed Likecoin see what's neat about it is that it makes likes work like money through this triangle of...Byron stopped to observe the two women trading insider snickers.—Ladies. Is there something funny about my friend David's difficulties latching onto light?

—No sorry of course not. It's just that my friend Marcie and I, we're already familiar with Likecoin.

— Wait a second. You two're those bumblefuckers who get coked up and film those engine videos, Function and Focus is it?

— Oh ho! Didn't know I was in the presence of two pink mushy-

— Get one thing straight, chub...A coiled middle finger, its cuticle chomped shorn of its french-press flicked Byron's duck canvas inseam. — We're nobody's pink mushy nothings got it?

— What Marcie means is that even though we are Likecoin investors, we're not really following whatever content you two are creating in the platform.

— Well speaking as an artist, let me tell you that investors are the best kind of followers. Because anyone willing to invest in Likecoin and help millions of millennials take their american dreams out to deep water gets my flag unfurled I tell you what.

— Hate to lower your mast sailor but we're not investing in Likecoin to be a part of some feel-good tittypincher for millions of millennials.

— What Marcie means is that some of our firm's mortgage investments have an exposure problem.

— Yeah. Like a fuckin' white cis executive.

— And Likecoin lets us swap out our exposure to overcollateralized obligations for example there's these stale mortgage derivatives we've been trying to dump since-

— Oh, no. No no no. No artist wants to be called derivative.

— That's cute hun but in the real world, you know the world of men, that world's about finding leverage against your liabilities. Even if that leverage comes in the form of putting this dipshit crypto of yours on our books.

— Not to say we don't value what you two have been doing, I mean that drip campaign you did with those engine videos, how you two got so many millennials to check their Exfearian scores and start participating in the home mortgage process I mean I'll speak for Marcie and say that was a big liquidity boost for both of us.

— Gosh well I'll speak for my friend David here and say we're both willing and eager to take on any additional liquidity boosting opport-

—Come on Byron.

—Hey hey there he is. And from your lips to their lips on my face bud.

—Look just take the damn picture so we can stop bothering these girls and they can get back to their chocolate mousse.

—It's a foie gras parfait, herm.

—Thing is though before we can take your quick clicker picker upper, you're gonna need to choose your calm doll.

—Calm doll?

—Yeah now that you're Likecoin's public-facing face wouldn't hurt to get a little shotty training right so which of these two fine women you think fits that bill?

—Shotty training.

—Look don't make this calm doll shotty training thing some big deal that gets you all mad like some big baby all you gotta do is pick which one makes your peepee go googoo gaagaa the most.

—Byron I don't know how you want me to even...David addressed the boot he watched paw the bar's parquet floor.

—The fuck is this? He was just eyefucking us, but now he can't fucking look us in the eye?

—Marcie...

—Ok well I mean I think both of you are kind of pretty so-

—Now David, don't neg.

—I mean that is a nice uh, sleeve you got there.

—Was that a euphemism David you sly dog? Ok miss your name?

—I'm Margot hi. Yeah they're all defunct currencies and then this quipu kn-

—Ok ok Margot save the ink deep dive for the pillow talk later. Margot this is David.

—Yeah uh hey there...There his hand gripped hers with the moist wrenched tension of an unprepared keynote speaker clutching a lectern.

— That means Marcie you have the distinct honor of holding our floating eyeball for this pic ok so take my phone and head on over there where I made my mark.

— Mark.

— Yeah see that splattered cherry on the patch of parquet back near our barstools? Now in terms of shutter stops I'm an f four man myself really want to blur those grey shiny sharkskin suits we got behind us into this soggy bokeh matter facts might need to box a few of em out to clear some space here-

— Byron cmon the bar's packed so can you please not make some big scene by shoving random strangers out the way.

— Ok here we go. See I knew this was going to happen. Hey Margot! Margot!... Byron beckoned, flapping four fused fingers on his backhand. — Need you to calm David down you know like suss out his fussiness.

— Ok sure uh Bryan is it?

— For you it is.

— Ok Bryan maybe you can help out Marcie? Sometimes when she take selfies she has trouble finding the room's light.

— Onnn itttt!... Byron ululated to exposed beams in the bar's rafters.

— Sorry about him all this is so fucking stupid.

— Sure is. You know how much time I spend on that facefuck Zuck's platforms watching women prettier than me get pretty then searching my own pics for proof I'm not pretty enough? Good news for you is that I've been able to pick up a couple pic tips that I think might-

— Look I don't need pic tips or shotty training or any of this bullshit because I'm not the public-facing face of Likecoin that's just something Byron's feeding you two to get my confid-

— First tip... She clasped both of David's wrists, then wriggled his arms as if shaking a fabric calcified from neglect back to form. — Stiff makes you look stuck up. So let's dial these fists down from clenched to closed shall we?

—No yeah sure fine look I, I just don't want you to get the wrong impression that I'm this bigtime Captain Influencer creating bankable drip campaign content when in reality-

—Next tip...Pushing cuffed duck canvas sleeves past the elbow, her thumbs grazed raised veins at his bicep's root. —Emphasize points of strength. So let's get those dad bod forearms to breathe a bit.

— Yeah that does feel a little better in terms of comfortability-wise-

—One last thing...A licked thumb maternally smudged David's nose. —Didn't realize this place had powdered donuts on the menu.

—Just a little dust from the grindstone that's all!...Byron cajoled as he wedged between their personal spaces. —Ok so I convinced Marcie to turn the iso up which means we are go for recognition ok so all we need now is to pudder dare.

—Dude why are you grabbing my hand-

—Grabbing the American Dream dude see if we foreground our firm fixed heroic poses against this grotesque scene of late capitalist destruction bathed in golden hour light so cmon David puh please please let's look like two great friends just this once and pudder dare-

—Oh drat...Marcie said as she snapped fingers across her womb in her sarcastic reaction to a nearby crane's suspended wrecking ball eclipsing the setting sun. —Looks like that shadow's gonna fuck up your titty-pinching clicker picker upper. Warned you against taking the iso so high now there's too much noise in the shadows.

—That's just fine Marcie...Byron shouted above the murmuring din while he chummily corralled David by both his shoulders. —David here's my shining light! Which means we are still go for recognition hear that Marcie we are still go for-

—Fuckin' do less, dude.

After clocking the flicker of a smartphone's priming light, David flinched in anticipation of a flash that never reached his flesh, its light swallowed up by commercial-grade wattage emerging from a triple-



cold shoe mounted camera behind them aimed at two sharkskin-suited men spitroasting a reflexively-giggling waitress with straddled foam antlers.

— Fuck's that all about?

— Guess you've never seen I-bankers celebrate tranche Tuesday.

— Fuck's this all about? ... David asked as he picked up an ejaculated antler from off the bar floor to take in its promotional messaging:

*Be The Hunted: Happy hour sponsored by Jagermeister*

— Guess you've never been compensated in phallic swag.

— They used my line.

— You ok dude? Scrunching your face like that isn't good for your shotty training, you know that right?

— They didn't hire me but they sure as shit hired my fucking line.

— What line? Happy hour sponsored by-

— Remember their bullshit spec assignment they gave me after my five interview rounds probably still have the brief in my inbox ok here we go on-premise messaging should combine our millennial target market's desire to be desired with the predatory ethos of Jagermeister's iconic stag damnit do you have Glen's number because there's gotta be a law against this sort of-

— I don't think Glen specializes in those sorts of copywriter copyright claims but if you're really mad enough to seek out unc's services you can head to the men's room and scan the qr code on the promotional urinal cakes like everyone else.

— Be the hunted! ... A man slurred in a shout as he rested his slumped body's elbows on Margot and Marcie's shoulders.

— Oh hey Jimmy ... Margot and Marcie warbled their enthusiasm in half-hearted harmony.

— Now me, I'd rather hunt the hunted. But I guess after you millennials got used to getting all them trophies, you grew up thinking that the world'd be your personal trophy case. Then when you got out into the world and realized it's actually the other way

round it's like your whole generation stopped competing and started leaning into becoming this trophy species for predatory boomer lenders like myself who know what it takes in order to play to win.

—Byron Chianti international influencer pudder dare sir now I know your business ain't necessarily mine at least not at this introductory juncture but you may be overthinking the promotional antler's ethos here.

—No look I get it... Jimmy held up his hands as if playfully surrendering to a child. —Being hunted means you're wanted. Means someone's got you in their sights. And that's what you millennials want more than anything.

After wiping rheum off his upper lip with a starched unbuttoned cuff, Jimmy turned toward the bar and tallied his index finger above the drained tumbler he held up above his head, its ice still intact.

—Matter facts you millennials remind me of these endangered grouses I trophy hunt. And before you get all butthurt it's all legal. Shit, it's encouraged. It's called sustainable trophy hunting. Turns out paying for the right to shoot a few endangered grouses lets you preserve the whole goddamned species. About time we got nature under capitalism's thumb am I right? And see it's the same logic with this Likecoin cryptosocial mortgage play because let's face it a millennial with a mortgage is the most endangered species in the market so if this Likecoin walled garden can lure a few thousand millennials into the predatory lending environment we'll be able to preserve the mortgage market for the next thirty years. Now whole I admit my flag gets a bit unfurled knowing I'm doing my part to keep the American Dream alive for the next generation of predatory lenders, but hoo doggie clearing close to twenty mill on this Likecoin play that'll sure help keep the ole pocketbook from puckering.

—Wow that's like forty more of those Richard Milles you got on.

—That's right son... Jimmy stooped down to pick up a foam antler beneath his barstool, booping Margot's butt with it as he came back up with a deferential —And it's all because of this one. See Margot here convinced me that the smart money shouldn't be on Mateo the

domestic millennial but rather Boris the foreign boomer. Best combination of a macroeconomic noggin and stereophonic tits I've ever come across I tell you what. And I mean that literally.

— Thanks Jimmy but our position's a little more complicated than-

— Yeah but I told her to dumb it down to an executive level. You know like as if she were talking to a toddler or a golden retriever. See I'm more than a mentor I'm a mantour, get it? As in I'm a man, touring those tit-tays! Sorry, sorry... Jimmy quickly raised both hands in surrender, his sarcastic apology sloshing scotch over the tumbler's rim. — I forgot that females these days get all butthurt whenever men show them some appreciation.

— No Jimmy it's just that unpacking our position on forex capitalization is probably pretty boring to no offense two influencers.

— Well I'm not sure if Byron mentioned that we're international influencers so it'd be nice to get familiar with the foreign parts of the Likecoin ledger so to speak.

— Dude you don't have to act all interested.

— Ok but is it ok that we are all interested?... David watched his sarcasm sprout a wry smirk in Margot.

— Yeah are you telling David and I we have to like obtain your consent to be interested in your forex position as if we're some hospital blob or sorority pledge?

— Go ahead babe give em the main slide. I mean just look at their faces, these boys are wired tight!... Jimmy shook sideways devil horns between David and Byron. — Always said a well-lubricated eye's the best trait of a top trader.

— Fine look basically all I did was base our Likecoin position on Greshem's law.

— One of the few I actually like.

— Yes which states that if you introduce bad money-

— Like Likecoin-

— Yes Jimmy if you introduce bad money like Likecoin into a market circulating good money-

— You know the kind of money that job creators slash predatory lenders like myself use. Wait a sec I haven't shown you two the size of my wad yet have I?

— And if the bad money circulates faster than the good money over time the good money will be driven from the market. Thing is Greshem's law only holds true if both good and bad money are used on the same transaction Jimmy please put your wad away.

— Wha? Maybe these two wanna take a selfie with it. Green faces bring blue thumbs am I right boys?

— Which means now that Likecoin's beginning to circulate we'll be able to offload the non-performing investments where our good money's exposed to risk-

— Yeah like this C-Bass tranche that's been rotting on our books. Your neat new boss'll chop up toss into his social mortgage stew that'll feed all those millennials starving for their American Dream.

— Wait but aren't there like laws against this sort of market manipu-

— You deaf son? She was just said Greshem's law! See that's what's so great about this Likecoin concept. It's about what America's always been about.

— What Jimmy means is that Likecoin is just the latest version of how America's manipulated currency things like wildcat banks issuing currency beyond their reserves during the gold rush then there was private-issued coal scrip exploiting mining while communities even early colonizers were able to annex territory simply by demanding indigenous tribes trade with pounds and francs instead of tobacco and totems.

— Exactly. Like I said this is all very legal and very patriotic. All we're doing is manipulating millennials the same way America used to manipulate n-

— Jimmy!

— Wha? I was gonna say natives. See Margot's always looking out for my best interests, such a hard worker I tell you what.

— Well I appreciate that Jimmy that's all I really-

— I mean just look at her...Margot felt one of Jimmy's hands reel her in by her right ovary as the other skid its gold band against her collarbone in its sweep across her chest as if a game show host revealing a prize. — Half past eight and these tits are still on the clock! Matter facts see this pearl necklace? Second one I gave her this month, guess what the first one was?

— Given the dynamic between you two I'd say-

— Semen yes! This one here gets it. I mean gimme some!

Byron rerouted the hand he extended toward Jimmy to grab David by his fleeing bicep; in doing so he trapdoored a billionaire's hand descending in dapped expectation.

— Dude where you are going?...Byron asked David, who shrugged his shoulders, wriggled his neck, and flared his lats before flatly answering — To find some gumption.

— Men's room second stall velcroed to the toilet paper dispenser.

— The fuck's this about? Your buddy got all butthurt because he knows he can't measure up with me in the comma department now he has to waddle to the widdle boys room to put a manpon in? And the fuck you so smiley for? Think you can get away with bigleaguign my dap like that?

— No nothing this is all so silly sir I mean if my millennial colleague gets triggered by whatever some richard millied billionaire says like that's on him I mean all you're doing is saying what the market's thinking.

— You I like...Jimmy slammed his glass tumbler on the bar to the sound of a gavelled verdict. — You stand sturdy. How bout we bend each other's ears on this Likecoin play aboard my Oyster yacht tomorrow? Got me a front buoy slip for America's Cup.

— Actually me and my friend David we got our own vessel and me I'm a firm believer in dancing with the yacht that brought ya.

— Fine then at least let me buy that round of whatever fruity drinks you and your friend of yours were having.

— You mean old fashioned.

Genius at  
havng a  
great can

— Oh ho! Fruity and fashion? Didn't know being influencers meant influencing the size of each other's buttholes but sure an alpha takes care of things no matter how beta the drink order.

— Appreciate the gesture Jimbo but think I'll keep circulating my good money while I still have the-

— No son... Jimmy squeezed the top of Byron's trap muscle, then slapped a fifty to the bar's sticky surface. — I insist.

— Looks like we're both dug in here Jimbo... Behind shut eyes, Byron shook off a percolating shudder exposing both canines. — How bout I meet ya halfway... Where, in one calm elongated motion, Byron picked the fifty off the bar, tore it in two, tossed each half over separate shoulders, then playfully spread peacocking fingers back and forth across his face like a magician playing peek-a-boo with a billionaire. — Split the bill, yeah?

Jimmy directed his wry smirk at his sportcoat innards he dug into. Producing a green wad two inches thick, he flared its folded edges so that its denominations flashed like a triggered fish's fanning gills. Then after hunching over the wad to torque, twist, and finally tear it in two on his third try, he rose back upright at nobility's posture to fling the torn cash at the face in front of him — money which, despite being shorn of its value, attracted a shiver of sharkskin suits to converge upon the chummed currency's caromed flutter.

— Now get your goddamned shinebox!... Jimmy bellowed with a punchline's ferocity while spinning on his bar stool with one arm extended so he could slap the lunging hands of subordinates moaning crescendoing o's as they eagerly contributed their share in his round of applause. It was then, with a periphery heightened as much from the humiliation he received as the drugs he took, Byron heard clomping boots accompany a distant tinkle of rattled glass behind him. Turning back, he felt the breeze of two airborne redwings cross his face in the tail end of David's arc launched from the bar's copper rail at the velocity of intent to knock Jimmy off his stool's perch, roll back upright, and plant two suctioned-cupped antlers upon his grey winged temples with the technique and intensity of a cymbalist's one-note solo.

—How's that for a fucking shinebox there Jimbo?!...Byron barked after stooping his cheek down to the bar's parquet floor, cackling as he taunted a prostrate billionaire. —Guess you didn't hear that David here's my goddamned light!

As David stepped over Jimmy's writhing thorax wriggling six appendages, and with a periphery heightened as much from the drugs he took as having taken the action the moment demanded, David clocked a school sharkskin suits encroaching; there his face felt the breeze of a thrusting cocktail strainer pressed against Byron's forearm with a technique rarely seen outside of table tennis.

—Now who else wants to get tuned up!

—Ok Byron now let's get the fuck out of-

—Hol up there Engram still got to put a bow on our episode.

—What bow what episode what are you even talking about and why are you filming right-

—Talking about we gotta punctuate the scene for the good of our drip campaign irrigating Likecoin's walled garden I mean you see all these fleshy eyeballs capturing this scene you just made.

—What but why me?

—Well I mean you're the writer right so why wouldn't it be you punctuating all this ok so go on and let your linguistic light shine!

—Damnit what linguistic light? These grey suits look ready to throw down I can't think of some clever-

A sharp snap rose above the bar's murmuring din; with it, an arm raised at the locked angle of liberty's torch and hoisting a broken pearl strand to its smiting apex.

—Puh-pearls deplore swine, bitch!...Marcie yelped as she flung pearl strand flapped like a native yoyo in its descent before ricocheting off the bar's parquet floor, a billionaire's face, then the floor again at a rimshot's rhythm.

**scarred cabinets & unfrozen seacocks**

—Those maidens back in the day could at least pin their subjugated clits on some knight in shining armor...

Beneath the sherbet glow of an obsolescent streetlight, Marcie braced her womb with a forearm whose wrist propped her other forearm upright so two fingers could pinch an embered menthol off lips which slid to the side of her mouth in order to push out a smoke flume that was immediately dispersed in the passing draft of Byron's third victory lap taken around the restaurant's valet lectern and briefly up the side of its spotlight brick wall.

—Fired up!

Marcie briefly flit rolling eyes at David shaking a nearby chain link fence with the manic energy of a man unsure if he's trying to get in or out.

—But all women got these days are jabronis in faded work boots.

—Ok so Tilted Kilt on me?...Byron pant spent breath out down from a waist-bent body whose nose dripped a mixture of sweat and



rheum upon herringboned concrete. — Just need to head back onboard real quick and apply some three part epoxy to these split fifties your boss gifted me see what you do is you get some two part epoxy then add just a bit of powdered starting fluid and it'll-

— Don't bother dudes. Watching our boss go ass over barstool was more fun than a barrel of jamokes truly but deleting thai chili wings served by bolted-on off-kiltered tits of which Tilted Kilt is known for is probably more heartburn than Margot and I can handle.

— Understood ladies. Farewell!

— Hold on there Byron I uh, I mean there's got to be someplace that's still open so we can keep the night's momentum going.

— We're in a Weehawken business park bubbly. Not exactly tenth and west fiftieth.

— What about that new late night spot, you know the one that just opened up inside our marina?

— Wait didn't you say you live over in Park Slope? You overhear this in your lamaze class or what?

— Marcie please. David what's the name of this place so I can look up the menu on my phone fucking starving all I've had today is a slim jim and a couple bites of that whack ass parfait.

— Margot sweetie don't you think it's getting kinda-

— The name, yeah these things usually do have a name, don't they.

— Usually.

— Ok, uh yeah it, it's called uh... David turned toward the marina, clawing his brain stem. — The, the floating studio.

— The the floating studio? Dude I've been with you every sniff of the way the past few weeks haven't heard anything of the sort.

Turning back, David craned a bug-eyed head toward Byron.

— Oh ho the floating studio! Thought I heard you say the foaming sussudio but silly me that's Paul Allen's joint over in Midtown but yeah floating studio's this really neat spot they've got a bunch of these art exhibits set up on board specifically these cabinets of-

—Ok well I'm searching the floating studio in my phone and-

—Well while The Floating Studio's hasn't shed its beta mode just yet Margot particularly in the manner with which they thaw their hot pockets Margot but to make up for it they got the choicest produce on the black market I'm talking the muggiest nuggets and the cleanest powdered starting fluid this side of the canal oh and then there's this psilly beer they recently got in stock-

—Onnnnnn itttt!...Margot's chin lifted to ululate at a sky faintly sheathed in the full moon's light.

—Hey boys give us a second will ya...Using the hand whose forearm still braced her womb, Marcie subtly tugged the lip of Margot's sportcoat's sewn pocket.

—Ok so powdered starting fluid like that has to mean coke right? Don't know about the silly beer though let's avoid that just to be-

—The foolishness of these boys' booze isn't my concern hun. You on other hand are.

—After seeing that slippin Jimmy fucker get what's his I, I I don't want this night to end...Margot hushed with wide eyes. —Not ever!

After a sigh for herself and a smirk for her friend, Marcie steeled a scowl before turning back to face the two men. —Ok now look I'm sure you two chucklefucks are super respectful toward women and don't have a homicidal bone in your body.

—Well maybe one.

—Byron c'mon. Look Marcie if there's a problem we don't have to go on the boat you know because of the implication.

—No no no no problem no problem at all so long you as two keep your limp-dicked lines attached to the pier.

—Oh c'mon Marcie don't tell me you've never wanted to take a night voyage up the East River see how the Brooklyn Bridge's grundle glows in a full moon's reflected light?

—No I'm gonna tell you that women these days have to balance the romance of taking neat night voyages with coked-out strangers with this weird pesky biological need to avoid getting Sharon Tated.

— You mean avoid getting Natalie Wooded.

— What?

— Natalie Wooded... Byron reiterated as he hooked a flip-flopped foot beneath the stern line to tug the attached vessel within stepping distance of the finger pier. — Sharon Tate was on land. But you're right. Grundle watching's more of a second date thing anyway.

After smacking away Byron's hand extended toward her in support, Marcie took two steps back, flamingoed each foot to scoop off cappuccino suede pumps, then leapt flat-footed off the finger pier with the grace of a grand jete performed on a planet with a lower gravitational force, where she monkeybranched an overhanging outrigger shaft before landing aboard the stern with an olympian's elan.

— Margot's gonna need some help boarding wearing those non-boyfriend jeans she's got on.

— Marcie!

At this, David straddled the teak gunwale to chivalrously close the boarding gap by wedging one boot beneath the finger pier's cleat while the other torqued the stern's fiberglass for traction.

— Hey hey much obliged there Engram.

— Dude cmon let Margot go-whoa!

There Byron's boarding momentum pushed the vessel away from the pier to stretch David's right thigh level with the horizon.

— Ok so while I hate caveating work in advance of its full recognition... Byron said while sliding the salon door open as David hopped aboard with his right thigh raised like a dog stuck in piss position. — I'll admit that while David and I haven't turned what you see into a million dollar yacht just yet...

— Or smell like one wow does that diesel reek.

— But you can bet you twoses bottom ovaries that David and I've got the gumption and focus necessary to bump this here vessel the American Dream's after-improved value to where it rightfully-

—C'mon Byron these girls know the fucking score. They can see that this Likecoin play's all just one big grift, like there's a reason why you can't spell gentrification without grift.

—Ah, but can you spell galvanization... Byron said while vaulting down the galley staircase by its parallel-barred railings. — I mean gentrification sure that's just a bunch of crap with fancy trimmings. Just stacking up layers so corrosion can seep in between.

Having flung the galley's pockmarked cabinets open in a flammed clatter, Byron's voice echoed within its cavernous interior. — But when you galvanize something you strip the false layers away with the heat of work so that whatever's left is a truth revealed in its own survival. He came back up the galley staircase holding a glass bubbler and orange pharmaceutical canister in one hand and a lighter, scissors, and shot glass wedged between the other's four knuckles.

—Those cabinets sure survived something. Feeling stabby much boys?

—So glad you made that connection Marcie because behind these scarred wood curtains is a theater of curiosities curiosities which global nobles back in the day would patronize renaissance men and minst-

—Look I just got done dating an artist so you can save it with the whole art is the concealment of art bullshit.

—Oh ho, that so?

—Yeah. Faust. You probably heard of him. I think your boss commissioned him to paint that Likecoin mural over on Grand.

—Faust, huh?... Byron placed a bent wrist against his nostril to push back the white strands he mockingly scoffed. — Murica's muralist?

—Go ahead talk your shit but that mural's got more staying power than whatever you two slapdick herms are up to on this yacht.

—Well like not really Marcie that's kinda my point with these cabinets I mean your boy Faust is out there hard at work painting over everyone else's work without realizing that eventually the weight of all his layers, that force becomes the flaw.

—Look before you get on that whole tip about what kind of artist makes his mark on top of other people's work, Faust told me all about you ok so I know all about how you got your start painting your fucking dead dad on some chintzy motivational poster.

—Oh ho. Got me there Marcie...Byron nodded an acknowledging frown as he audibly popped the pharmaceutical canister's childproof top, then after placing a pinched nug into a red solo cup, he picked a pair of scissors off the work bench. —Splattered my fair share of layers starting out no doubt...His admission punctuated by the rhythmized click of closing scissor tips shearing flower and hollow clack of their expanse against the red solo cup in a metronomic mulching of nug into shake. —But more I think on it, I'm not sure adding more layers is what this thing of ours should be all about.

—What thing, painting?

The fluttering light of a flame Byron flicked to confirm the bubbler's cleared carb illuminated a smirk expanding into a smile. —I read a story once. It was about this apprentice artist who would go through dead artist's estates. See back then apprentices couldn't afford new canvasses, so they had to scrounge for the ones the dead ones left behind. Same as it ever was I guess. Anyway so one day this forger Wyatt dies. But Wyatt wasn't just any forger. He'd take on commissions no one else would. Van Eyck. Van Der Weyden. Vermeer. The guild masters. Matter facts his forgeries are still spoken in high regard but seldom ever attempted anymore due to the time it takes to render a master's strict technique and bespoke st-

—Yeah ok I mean but that isn't even really art...David came in, sniffing. —I mean isn't a forger just some poser artist that wasn't good enough to create anything that's really you know real?

—A life dedicated toward creating pieces able to soar in atonement of their own fraudulence I'd say that's real. Haunting henhouses for fresh albumen to produce a wet-on-wet tempera at the calibrated viscosity that a period-perfect Arnolfini portrait demands I'd say that's real. Matter facts Engram I'd say it's more real than anything you and I will ever do.

—Ok dude. Don't get mad jeez.

—Anyhoo so after bribing the local priest by becoming his butt-buddy, this apprentice arrived at Wyatt's studio just after last rites so he could gank the canvasses before the local nobles could lawfully vulture it. And the apprentice, he found this massive full-bodied Titian that was right beneath the studio's skylight. Portrait of the Vendramin family I think it was. And you knew it was a Titian because who but Titian could present that spectrum of blues those overlapping pockets of azurite and ultramarine layering a cloudless sky with the depth of its own horizon. And so the apprentice goes and takes the canvas back home to his hovel where after he first copies the forgery on wax paper you know as practice, he starts scraping the canvas clean and he finds this black financial ledger underneath see these medieval fatcats back in the day thought usury was an artistic medium in and of itself same as it ever-

—Ok Byron we get it.

—Get what? I still haven't even gotten to it yet.

—We get that everything fake has some financial layer underneath it trade ye no moneyed art that back-and-forth bullshit between art and comm-

—Damnit listen... Byron hushed with clenched teeth as he knocked an overturned bubbler on the work bench, freeing its ash to the sound of an adjudicating gavel. — The apprentice, he kept scraping. And beneath the ledger, beneath it all he found an actual Titian. The real live Vendramin family it, they were there the whole time and like I know that Wyatt probably didn't know the original was there at the time, but I don't know like, I've put a lot of faith that, that something knew, you know? Having propped the shot glass sideways against a bubbler rim, Byron softly tapped its bottom with the lighter's butt so that his minced shake funneled into a bowl caked in black resin. — And see that's what I'm talking about when I talk about galvanization, how the heat of our searching work strips everything away until only the true surface remains... Byron's sucked breath burbled the bubbler, priming its

pressure so that the mere flit of his reflicked flame crackled the crumbled contents in the bowl; then, pulling the carb out with the extended-arm flourish of a carnival barker, a white flume slithered up annealed glass and into Byron's mouth duck-lipped from suction to the shoopy sound of innertubing down a covered waterslide. — Surely I can't be the only one here who feels that their existence is a copy of a copy with the original missing...the smoke that seeped through the both sides of Byron's mouth modulated his mutter to a muffle. — Anyhoo so like a roundabout answer to your question Marcie these galley cabinets of curiosity are David and I's silly attempt at living that apprentice's scraping story deliberately wait what am I doing hogging the greenies like this here you go Margot my bad that was mad selfish of me.

— Oh you sure? I mean I'm good if someone else wants to-

— Nope on board we pass clockwise per Captain Engram order's.

— Oh ok thanks. So like full disclosure I don't really get art so...Margot trailed off as she brought the bubbler to searching lips and inhale from a bowl still cherried from Byron's prior consumption.

— Only people who don't get art Margot are those who can afford to own it. And considering you bitch slapped your boss with his own pearl necklace, art-buying money probably ain't in your future.

— You're bad dude.

After feeling the back of Margot's hand flick against his ribs, Byron felt a hackle's heat; turning around, he shot a knowing glance at David then subtly pushed face-down palms an inch down and tamp down his jealous sneer.

— I guess I'm just curious how to look at these cabinets like is one part more important than the other?

— Well Margot David'd be happy to break it down for you...Byron slapped David's trap as leverage to rise out of his camping chair. — He was as a much a part of this tittypinching cabinet proj-

— Wait where are you going?

— Heading down to the head. Gotta see a nose about a poodle leg.

—Ok then we'll just wait for you to get back because to be honest I wasn't really picking up on your rants about rendering the scratches and dents both ways.

—Dude don't act like you weren't there scratching and denting with me look they're just cabinets ok so tell her about the cabinets sheesh.

—Ok well Margot before I can tell you what to look at, you'll have to look again...David said as he rubbed steepled fingers against chin stubble. — Because that's what art compels us to do, to look then-

—Yeah that's the thing I don't know even where I should look again first. Like at those squiggles?

—Actually Margot the proper term is arabes-

—Yes the squiggles! Came echoed from behind the head's shut door. David tell her what motivated our squiggles! Byron punctuated his request with a clogged, flatulent snort the sound of a whoopie cushion deflating underwater.

—What motivated our squiggles?...David shouted over his shoulder at the head door below and behind him. — How bout we were coked out of our minds that's what motivated our squiggles! How bout we'd been hacking the cabinets for so long we rounded both points of the painter's tool to nubs then after I found some forty grit in the dockbox and logically suggested that we sand down the squiggles and dents you started screaming how neat it'd be if we used the sandpaper on us instead so there we were sitting on the stern filing our fingernails down to claws listening to birds chirp at the rising sun that's what motivated our squiggles.

—Y'all know why a gorilla takes bark off trees, ladies?...Byron kicked the head door open at a saloon entrance's velocity, his forearm raised as a brace against its swinging recoil. — To announce his presence to the jungle. But David hasn't realized that yet because you didn't call these cabinet scratches arabesques at first now did you?

—Dude cmon don't start this again I-

—Exactly he called them mistakes. David wanted to sand out the mistakes. See David here can't see that mistakes is the language of



work. And that when we actually listen to our mistakes, you know like really live them through, the work works on us as much as if not more than the other way around. I mean like holy shit you don't see a gorilla doesn't go back to the tree to sand it smooth do you?

— You getting all that from some hacked cabinets ok sure dude.

— Look Marcie just because we're both in on this Likecoin play doesn't mean your business is now mine but like speaking from experience, it is kinda hard to look at art squarely through rolled eyes.

— The fuck you know what my rolled eyes have and haven't seen?

— Marcie you don't have to get-

— What. What? These two chucklefucks are simply talking slick so they can get their dicks wet, you know that right?

— Just please Marcie I know tonight's been a big step for you being on the boat and all but that doesn't-

— Doesn't what?

— I'm just saying that all roads don't lead to-

— To what? All roads don't lead to what on a boat?

— No no it's ok Margot. It is getting to be that time of the morning where David and I should open our duck canvas kimonos on why we're so eager to bring you two aboard. Now considering the four of us met only a few hours ago it's probably too forward to ask this type of question but fuck it I'm going to ask anyway... Byron visibly anchored his breath before rolling open two soliciting palms. — Would you two be down to help free David's stuck seacock?

— Byron cmon.

— Fine fine our stuck seacock. See even though we got the engine back up and running it still needs to keep its cool when we take it out on our deep water story voyage which means this seized seacock's the only thing keeping us from taking this here vessel the American Dream out on its maiden story voy-

— Look it's just a seacock Byron we don't-

— Just a seacock? A seacock's too important to be impotent that was the line you pitched to Shur-flo's marketing team right? Now before you two ladies give me an answer I do want to show you what we're packing down there so do me a favor and take a step to the starboard side cause I gotta yank the floor right out from under you... After dragging the work bench out from the perimeter of the carpet's rectangular outline, Byron bent down to a three-point stance to clean-and-jerk the floor hatch from shin to shoulder before pivoting it against the port window at a ninety-five degree angle. — Ok now see that well hung bolt all the way down there at the bottom of the hull? For weeks David's been on his hands and knees trying to raise that thing from nine to midnight problem is he's only been applying leverage but I've been trying to tell him that's only one part of the liberation equation see you also need heat and lubrication.

— And I give a fuck why.

— Thinking the three of us can teach David this neat important fact of life with a little role play because like Marcie you're kinda fiery so you'll be the heat, Margot you're a little sweeter and smoother so you're our lubrication where I'll give it the last little bit of leverage we need to-

— Role play my ass this is just your way of luring us into that trap door dungeon down there I mean the fuck you think we are?

— Think you're two shrewd women trying to make it in the transactional world of men like you said which is why if you're willing to humor me on this whole seacock tittypincher I'd be more than willing to excrow over ten percent of David's Likecoin wallet and to be clear that's the earnings of both present and future David-

— Hold on Byron I'm not sure you have the proper auth-

— Ten percent... Marcie somersaulted nicotine gum between tips of front teeth.

— Now call me old school Marcie but I'll take your silence on the matter as consent so go on and grab that hair dryer hanging on the pegboard and Margot snag that can of Knock Er Loose in the wire basket and come on down!

David grit his lips into a toothless grin as he watched both women sit down on the salon floor's ledge, each accepting Byron's hand for balance as they butt-scoot off the ledge and onto the engine room floor below.

—Ok now Margot see that wintergreen box I'm shining a light on? That's the seacock's ball valve want you to give it a big ole shot of that Knock er Loose I mean like really soak have it to look like bedsheets after a second date...now hold on there before you get all mad I said a second date not our second date ok now Marcie after Margot's lubed that seacock nice and shiny you're gonna waft that hair dryer on it until you start seeing the patina peel ok good good now watch this ladies I actually learnt this neat full body kegel move from David gonna put my feet on the opposite engine hover myself here with locked arms on the ball valve's bolt then start thrusting out ok ok yep yep yeppers I'm definitely feel a little play between the shaft and the ball valve here.

—Wait really?!...David stood up so he could look down at a better angle. —Ok yeah nice I can see it turning! Just push a little harder Byron and I think it'll-

—That's been the problem with us men hasn't it ladies?...Byron grunted with spent breath. —Always doing more even when the situation calls for less. Just thrusting past nuance. Because see here's the thing we brute force this little bit of play we just got we'll end up snapping the stem right off the ball valve flood the whole floating studio ok so instead of trying to push through the play how bout we play with the play instead.

—Play with the play? The fuck does that even-

—Means pushing deeper without pushing harder like swaddle the tension with this slow seductive parabola of energy but see that's gonna require all six of our hands so let me slide this extendo pipe over the bolt ok now we're still gonna need the heat so Marcie go ahead jam the butt end of that hair dryer in my mouth here free up my ands ere ok adees ow e're uhst onna hwaddle it ack a horth ack an horth yuep yuep yuepers adees I hink we ave reahed he inevitale!

A hollow depressurizing rumble gurgled inside the hose connecting the seacock to the engine's raw water pump; then, as if overcome by its restored function, the seacock's flange began to softly weep salt water.

—Chiminyea-hah! Byron shouted after spitting the hair dryer into the engine bilge. —Nine to midnight baby! Now that we got this seacock all throatingly open this engine's got the flow it needs to take on the heat of a deep water story voyage I mean holy-

—Not to be captain comedown but we still need to recharge the starting battery you drained after bumping the starter motor over like a beatbox during our whole flow on flow episode.

—On it Cap think I remember seeing some distilled water in the dockbox now if we recharge the batteries at eight amps per hour thinking around daybreak we probably have enough juice to head out at sunup get a front row buoy for America's-

—The fuck you ain't...Marcie pushed the ball valve back to a closed nine-o'clock position with her espresso espadrille. —You two promised that your limplicked lines wouldn't leave the dock.

—No yeah sure of course Marcie. Like all that deep water story voyage stuff that's just me being allegorical with David.

—Allegorical.

—Yeah since David's a writer the only way I can like speak his language is by using liberalature titty-pinchers with fancy trimmings which reminds me that there's one last final last exhibit aboard this floating studio so come on down to the captain's room and check out this meta-mirror David's got going about how his reflected productivity is perpetuating this like positive self-

—I don't give a fuck if the mirror's in the goddamned guggenheim I gotta get some fresh air, after all that starting fluid you sprayed mixed with the diesel smells like a mechanic bukkake in here.

—Sure thing happy to join you once I head down take a quick progress pic of the mirror for my forever mother see she's the one who actually-

—Fuck no you're not. You're coming with me we need to draw up a crypto escrow on our ten percent Likecoin deal. Margot hun you coming with or what?

—Actually, I...As Margot descended down the galley staircase, a lilting index finger brushed the back of David's hand, melting his bone marrow.—I'm actually kinda intrigued about the next exhibit...

Prompting Byron to lean over to David and hush—Enjoy the mirror dude!...his encouragement betrayed by a palm partitioning the wrong side of his mouth.

## finding the inevitable

—I uh, I'll just leave the door open for us if that's all right.

—Oh ok Marcie'll appreciate that. She's got this hangup around closed doors uh so where should I?

—Yeah uh obviously too cramped for leisure furniture so you go ahead sit on the bed and I'll just lean against the bulkhead here. Also ima put the vial over here think I've had enough powdered starting fluid for one night but feel free to you know like partake.

—Thanks maybe I'll grab a quick nose beer for the road but first what's the deal with these tallies on the mirror?

It was only after confirming Margot's complete visual focus on the captain's mirror behind and above her, did David take advantage of what he assumed was a free gaze upon tops of breasts her tucked knees had pushed past what she intended as an unsuggestive neckline, unaware that the mirror was reflecting a slacked awooged face boinging downward eyebrows back at her.

—You don't have to act all interested about the mirror...after clocking Margot pivot her gaze from his mirror to himself, David quickly put sheepish hands in pockets as additional poles to a tented

duck canvas inseam. — It's just this neurotic way I quantify my work only reason Byron wanted you down here is he thinks this mirror will generate interest or investment or whatever in this silly apply the high therapy that his forever mother-

— But is it ok if I am all interested?... Looking upon Margot's face slacked in sarcastic concern, David's lips wobbled into a smile like a returning astronaut's atrophied legs. — I mean everyone tallies something. Like every Monday night I sleep at the office so I can get dibs on the Bloomberg terminal the next morning and hearing the only sound on the floor of me tapping hot keys tallying next quarter's seed funding and as I watch dawn reflect all those glass capitalist shafts swear to god feel like I'm Hestia keeping vigil at the hearth just so superior's families will stay warm.

— Hestia, huh? Is that why you got those seeds on your elbow? Probably why they're at the bottom of the quipu since they were the first currency, right?

— A cultured jabroni? Be still my clit... Margot kept her eyes on David as she grabbed the vial from the bedside table, tossed her head back, and brought spoon to upturned nostril; where after a staccatoed sniff, she tilted her head back level while squishing her nose between two glossing eyes. — Point is people are shaped by what they count. And so like the fact that you've been tracking your productivity with this, this... She paused to tilt her face up again and clench a blink. — Damn this shit is dialed in where was I the fact that you've been tracking your productivity in with this mirror while everyone else is out there tallying profits gotta say it's kinda inspiring.

— Well I don't know about that...

— No dude give yourself some credit. Not a lot of people see themselves as you do as a gift to be cultivate most people choose to make themselves into some tool capitalism uses for its own survival.

— I, I guess I haven't really considered that ang-uh what are you... He asked the two palms pressing against one of his as if smoothing a crumpled item between a closed book.

— Feeling out my investment.

—What investment.

—These are the focused hands that revved up a thousand pink mushy millennial engines to start a mortgage application are they not?

—Yeah well Byron made a lot of things happen behind the scenes as the show's predator so really it's a team-

—But do they always do this?

—Does what do what.

—Your hands, do they always flinch-whimper like this whenever they're touched?

—What? No, I, I don't know I, I mean maybe it's just that it's been a long time since my skin has like felt that type of material.

—What, skin?

—Yes skin! All I've touched over the past few weeks been this endless rotation of wrenches brushes scrapers and bottles then at night I'm thumbing smartphone glass browsing my kpis.

—So you and Byron don't like slap each other's butts after a long day of working on this here yacht the American Dream?

—I mean we've crossed straws once or twice but no, you'd be surprised how long isolated men can go without human contact, you really would.

—Well it's interesting because your left hand understands my touch much better, which makes sense because that's the hand controls our self-love originates. But your right hand that's the jittery one it's got this stubborn sensitivity to it almost like it's trying to sabotage what your left hand is hoping to accomplish.

—Left hand is self-love huh? ...David's raised right hand met a descending shaft of moonlight framed by the open ceiling hatch above them. —Then why do I use this one?

—You're bad dude.

Like a fish out of water, David wiggled up from the foot of the bed until his head bonked against headboard; there he lay next to her for several silent breaths until, having done nothing for long enough that



a welling anxiety compelled him to do something, he mumbled — So tell me again about this sleeve of yours...while strolling index and middle fingers up her upper arm dotted with color-packed tulips, tobacco, wampum and beaver pelts arranged as if having been combed out of shoulder-length hair dulled from its growth beneath cubicle light.

— Yeah each of them are currencies that the dollar made de-fuck dude!...Margot jolted away from a neck-motivated finger that had brushed against her collarbone, curdling her body into a coil.

— So your collarbone, does it always flinch whimper-

— It's not you damnit it's his fucking ring I...swivelling her body from back to belly, her face sought refuge in her head's depression in the pillow muffling her voice — wasn't like I didn't know what the score was with him Christ I remember meeting him in my interview telling him how much I loved the marketplace and you know what that piece of shit said he said so long as I make love to those who make markets the market will always love me back and that, that the best way to get ahead in his department is by giving it.

— Ok so he was a spineless piece of shit I mean you said it your-

Margot turned back to face David with eyes raccooned by smeared tears, as if what was he said had a greater pull on her than what originally triggered her.

— And go ahead and fucking guess how shitty it feels to be triggered by a lowly spineless piece of shit?!

— No of course like last thing I want is to you know like squeeze your shoes on your triggers because look I'm with ya like every night Byron sneaks in here and tucks that typewriter over there in bed with me as if writing my swashbuckling story is this offer I can't refuse and the weight of it always wakes me up, keys jam into my ribs and reopen this scab I won't show you but trust me runs pretty deep.

— You know maybe I should check in on Marcie...

— No yeah sure given the night's tumult that's probably the prudent thing to do but maybe we can swap numbers and later on this-

—Too bad this ain't prudent and fuck all!

Four eyes shot up to find blonde bangs dangling beneath a ducked head wedged through the open ceiling hatch.

—Goddamn it Byron! How long have you been-

—Don't get mad ok just poking my beak down so I can give you two a heads up that Marcie and me're about to head back into the engine room gonna show her where the horsepower bit me.

—Great plan happy to hear it.

—Thanks dude anyhoo since the engine room shares a bulkhead with you two doing your thing in the captain's room here I was thinking maybe you can you know send over some good vibrations?

—No idea what that means but sure best of-

—Means how bout you excrow me that vial on the bedstand there.

—Yeah sure fine here...

After grabbing the vial off the nightstand, David reached up to the open hatch, raising his duck canvas shirttail like a stage curtain to reveal a pink parenthetical rib wound enclosing a gut guttered oblique bracketing a chiseled four-raviolied core cultivated from daily engine room yoga practice; where, in the vial's transfer to Byron's extended hand, David felt serrated foil press against his palm.

—Dude come on.

—Dude come on nothing that is your condom is it not mister magnum? Found it wedged between two of your typewriter keys ok so like don't get mad that I'm like helping you prophylacticize yourself before you two take the action this moment demands and jumpspark each other's pink fleshy engines like remember when I gave you that koozied scroogie to safely jumpspark the portside engine simply using the same logic here see-

As he reached up to the hatch and close it by twisting the knob of its riser arm loose, David felt a pair of eyes on him that weren't his own. Then, yanking his shirt's hem down and the bedside drawer out, David tossed the gold foil square into the drawer before shoving it shut at the rate of ridding something cursed.

— Look sorry about all that.

— Sorry about what.

— Byron's whole mister magnum good vibrations schtick.

— What's so bad about good-

— No nothing it's just the fucking glee with which he forces the whole issue's so damn irritating every day he browbeats me to take the action the moment demands take the action the moment demands then when I finally do take action not only do I knock your boss off his stool but then had the cringey fucking gall to punctuate the whole episode by ripping your expensive pearls off pearls which you could've at least sold for some safety funds to you know at least supplement your four hundred a week in unemp-

— Dude relax. The pearls weren't even natural. After I saw Jimmy's post proclaiming his renewed vows with missus cuntmunch I did a little research on his pearl purchase while I deleted a couple pints of rocky road and pinot noir and I found out that cheap ass herm bought me cultured pearls which you know rich fuck cheaps out on gift for side piece no news there but then I started reading up on how they make these cultured pearls it's actually pretty interesting see what they do is insert this small irritant inside the oyster to stimulate it into creating the beauty it was created to create in the first place and so I don't know maybe that's why Byron's been so-

— Yeah interesting take by the way you were saying you needed to check on Marcie before Byron barged in just wanted to remind and reiterate that you know you're still totally free to do that.

— Yeah sure I kn-

— No of course I know you know that... David got up from the bed rubbing the back of his head as if he were trying to start a fire on his brain stem. — And just to be clear I, it's not like you you know need my consent to leave not insinuating otherwise it, it's just that I don't want to make it seem like I'm forcing an issue or moment or anything here in this cramped captain's room because of like any sexual implication or obligation so like I said let's like you know swap digits and then maybe later on this week maybe we can-

—Uh ok then I should probably should get out of your hair then-

—But wait before you go I...As if triggered by a recently-trained impulse, David's hand braced against the teak door jamb so that its forearm barred the entryway. —Your eyes on the bed back then just now, the moonlight, the gloss, I-

—Little late in the night for that dude...A cusped knuckle wiped diluted mascara from beneath both eyelids. —All the coke and the crying probably looks like a shadow came on my face.

After dropping his armbar and posture in a self-surrendering chuckle-spasm, David brushed back bangs dangling from a head hung in resignation; then, with a waning high's heightened periphery, he clocked his reflection in the mirror above the bed's teak headboard.

—So you asked me about the mirror. Like every night I waddle up this bed on my knees to tally that day's productivity and as I'm doing it I start seeing my own glossed eyes gleaming behind the black bars of my own making and I don't know seeing that, seeing me like that it's like I'm seeing my unspent soul reveal itself to me at this crazy moment of crisis because I mean let's call my current sociofinancial situation like a dutch uncle sees it I'm broke, coked up and working on this here vessel the American Dream for free and so like when I saw you come up from the pillow right then just now I, I don't know it was nice to see that gloss and in someone else's eyes because I learned that that gloss is this really intimate substance called vitreous that it outlives us even in death and so I'm just really for lack of a better term I guess like glad to be able to see that substance in someone as interesting and beautiful and cool as you are even if it was because I triggered you like some self-sabotaging doofus and like I don't know if that's too intense or too goobery or both but I do know it's the-

—You're good dude...Margot cooed with spent breath; collapsing back on the bed, she gaffed David's calf with one hooked foot. After having landed on the bed's foot, and like an unsubtle slug, David inched his torso toward the headboard until his face found refuge in her neck's crook, where they felt each other's interior breath build for a clenched minute until the sharp squeak of a strained spring line broke the silence.

— Sorry about the rocking this full moon's tide sloshes us around something fierce like we're in a toddler's goddamned snow globe.

— In my homeland, we celebrate full moons.

— Oh yeah why's th-

— Because it brings fresh moisture.

The energy of two jolted eyebrows against Margot's collarbone triggered a smile in her that David could sense without seeing. After he raised up and poise a locked-armed body over hers; she could see his eyes gloss by the square shaft of moonlight descending through the open hatch that reflected off her eyes and project onto his. He momentarily planked on one forearm so the other could wipe rheum that had gathered on his mustache stubble like morning dew, then lowered himself to meet lips already raised in expectation. She felt her womb begin to chafe from his belt buckle's spasmed frottage as he pushed past their initial pressed lips and pursed pecks to thrust a squirming tongue inside her; she pressed a palm against his thrusting hip like a jockey pacing the first turn. She felt his lips momentarily part hers only to return peppering her webbed neck, obliterated breasts, and heaving navel in their descent, then watched him take control of her non-boyfriend jeans, unbuttoning their top two buttons before peeling them off lifted hips and fling to the floor with a snap the sound of a matador's cape. He wiggled down to the foot of the bed, belly down and heels up in a scorpion pose; she felt his stippling lips slowly traverse a pendulum from one inner thigh to the other; his nose trolling silk-sheathed labia at each oscillation until his sweeping oral energy funneled into a deep, gummed bite through wet cotton. Like a diver entering the water, she raised her leg-tucked hips to remove the last barrier between them. He respread her legs with a nudging skull, then lifted his nose above her pubic bone like a pig over a trough. She levered one hand against the teak headboard behind her as the other grasped surprisingly well-conditioned hair; then wiggled her hips as if attempting to balancing her entire torso on his tongue. Feeling him pin the hand clasping his hair to the bed, she removed the other from the teak headboard and let it fall into his restraint. The action of him pulling her wrists led her to pull his, at which point they became co-conspirators in

suffocating his face, her groin as its weapon. He lifted eyes briefly took in her open mouth's purpled roof intermittently obscured by a heaving sternum the color of ghosts, then placed his heels against the grey bulkhead behind him to thrust kegelling energy from torso to tongue; where, feeling her knees clack together in an involuntarily spasm, she found pleasure's leverage, and gasped at the inevitable.

—I, uh, I can get us some water...David stopped to mop surrounding mouth stubble with his forearm while kneeling himself upright.

—Thinking you better put on that raincoat instead...She rose upright to unbuckle, then yank down free-balled duck canvas trousers; taking in his right angle, she tapped its tip with the amusement of a toddler playing with a door spring. —Mister magnum.

At this, David groped for the bedside drawer in the dark, fully pulling it off its slide mount so that its contents crashed to the floor. Hanging his top half off the side of the bed as if seasick, he pawed the darkened parquet floor until he felt serrated foil. Coming back upright, he tore the foil square with two hands and several teeth, then sheathed himself to his hog's hilt in one half of a masturbatory stroke. As David kneeled on the bed between her legs, a rising hackle asked the self-sabotaging question: could he deliver what the smiling writhing body beneath him would demand of it? Then, widening his position, one knee found its answer on a bedsheet's damp spot; it was then, after having waited until his eyes finally had the courage to commit to hers, she pressed her heels against his hamstrings and draw him in with a shudder that collapsed his locked-arm torso so that his face burrowed back into her collarbone's crook. And as fingertips of both hands traced the flared traps and flexed lats that contoured his back like a shield, he began to lay his siege: hot plastic thrustured her two walls apart at a battering ram's pace as a coiling arm corralled surrendered hips as if about to be hauled off as a spoil of war, this as his other's arm's palm chivalrously palmed her skull as a buffer against a teak headboard conducting thrustured vibrations through the bulkhead it shared with the engine room and jostle the line of white powder Byron arranged between the lead acid battery's two terminals softly spotlighted from the pocket of full moon's light that entered through a cowlng vent.

— You're not even listening dude. Like how could you when you're planking doggiestyle over the battery with a red cup between your teeth.

— No look Marcie totally get why you're triggered it's that you feel like you picked the wrong red cup same way I felt that me being dad-dicked was a direct result of me having picked the wrong high-proof ice cream silo at our family's sundae brunches.

— No fucknuts I picked the right red cup that's the only way I can justify what happened happening, that I like jumped on some red cup roofie grenade so one of my sorostitute reunion sisters wouldn't get blindsided by some blacked out trauma sometimes I think the one thing that's keeping me going is knowing that there's a girl walking around without stitch scars because of me.

— Ok but that doesn't mean you have to get all mad at yourself because there's lots of people who get triggered by seeing red cups.

— Yeah like who.

— Ok so like right before I was about to tell Maury my origin story I got supes triggered thinking about how all the equipment in his studio was being powered by the same type of lead acid battery with which I deaded my dad jibs forklifts golf carts dollies and so forth but this curious jamoke Dash Balder comes into the green room holding a red cup and baggied gram and as the two of us chopped it up over a game of don't fuck your brother off the red cup's upturned butt Dash told me how red cups were this big trigger of his something about paying for film school with the ganked proceeds of fraternity beer pong tournaments earmarked for leukemia funds but Dash justified it by saying all that really meant was that they'd fugazily bald a pledge as a means of luring John Cena to their fifths and cuffs party so like I said no need to get all mad about being triggered by red cups.

— Look I'm not mad I'm actually glad whenever I see a red cup. It reminds me how captain rapey's legal team wore the fucking brown hat after they went and publicized any picture of me holding a red cup all deceptively interspersed with pictures of me on the night of the cruise in question so as to paint this public picture of me being this

loose self-roofying skank in advance of his trial. Even though that fucker dug three digits inside me that night... Her right hand's middle finger's french tipped nail scooped a small portion from the pile of powder atop the bottom of an overturned red cup that she then lifted up to an unpinched nostril to delete in a swift, debonaire sniff. — That false light tort let me dig six into his.

— Ok so like how interesting is this like after I beat my criminal and civil cases my dead dad's estate got so butthurt so they torted me a false light claim on account of Glen's unilaterally leaking my sworn testimony attesting to the fecklessness with which my father brought his line of battery resurrecessories to market. I mean I tell you what... Byron wistfully shook a smirking head as the metrocard he held divvied, then distanced a toot's worth of powder from its pile on the battery's shell. — If my pops could see me working on this eight d battery right now as part of this Likecoin grift, why his body'd be spinning in his grave. Which of course is to say if he had either.

— Yeah I've been wondering why you chose this scam gig in the first-

— It's the damndest thing ain't it Marcie? Because if my traumatic origin story has taught me anything it's that it doesn't matter what you choose in this world when you're chosen. Specially if you've got a neat boss who chooses you for being who millennials want to be.

— You are one fuckin egoic jamoke, you know that? Your neat boss Juug didn't hire you because you're who millennials want to be. He hired you because he knew your well-publicized daddy issues would give you this huge blind spot in terms of this parental cosigning foreclosure scam underpinning his whole Likecoin social mortgage play, you know on account of not having one.

— Marcie you bland fucking bitch... Came out the darkened engine room below, followed by a raised hand rapidly snapping in expectation. — Do me a solid toss me my phone there on the portside sill.

— Fine I'm gonna foreclose the rest of this vial then. Call it a snort advance against future earnings for inspiring whatever the fuck you're about to be inspired to do.



—Marcie that kinda talk drives my bargain hard I tell you what... Having caught the tossed phone, Byron tapped one of its five saved contacts; where in the intermittent silence between each outgoing ring, Byron sorted then snorted four double-a-sized lines; hearing the droned tone of a capitalist's voicemail greeting, he briefly pulled his phone away from his ear with one hand while shaking invisible dice close to his groin with the other before pressing the speaker end of the phone against his chin and spout an effervescent — Ahoy-hoy Mister van sant it's ya boy B first off good call not answering mine seeing as you're probably at Ruthless Chris marrow deep into a tomahawk with some global noble investor anyhoo you know how yesterday you told all those big cigars at IBS it was supes critical we get the parents of these pink mushy engine millennials to cosign our adjustable like social mortgages underpinning your whole Atman Projects project but then I spoke out of turn in voicing my concern that this parental cosigning pitch of yours might not really resonate on account of you not having any genealogical foreskin in the social mortgage game? Well how bout this for a solve... Byron multitasked his pause for dramatic effect by skimming a snort off the top of the pile. — Mister Van Sant would you do me the honor and crypto-financial privilege of becoming my forever daddy? I mean remember the first day we met remember telling me how this here vessel the American Dream was going to be your cosigning social mortgage proof of concept well then don't you think it's about time we actually prove that concept because you adopting me means you'd be in this perfect patricianal patronage position to cosign Likecoin's first ever cryptosocial mortgage for me to then purchase this here vessel the American Dream, and see we'd broadcast our whole adoption arc as a way of firing up my fleet of pink mushy engines ay kay ay your millennial target market about pitching their parents the prospects of social mortgaging their american dreams over to you now I know what you're thinking but just to be clear here you'll only be my forever daddy for the duration and express purpose of developing your atman projects residential project anyhoo maybe you can multitask chewing on my adoption concept with the gristle on your

tomahawk chop but I'm gonna need a quick up or down on this because America's Cup is later today which I think'll be the perfect social setting for this adoption awareness play just think about all that inherited wealth floating on the Hudson ok so even though I know it's kinda late or early depending hope you're able to drop me a line back ok toods mister van sant... Marcie I'd like the next solid for you to do me is lower that other water jug down here.

— You really have to do that now.

— Do what now.

— Whatever the fuck you're doing down there with those water jugs.

— Distilled water jugs point of fact Marcie and actually I kinda do see it's imperative that the lead plates inside this battery are nice and hydrated else they run the risk of losing their plasticity, can't even accept or discharge even reverse their polarity if-

— Ok but is that really necessary now? It's gotta be close to three in-

— Uh yeah Marcie it actually is. Because now that you me and Margot went and freed David's stuck seacock the only thing keeping us from heading out for a swashbuckling voyage during America's Cup today is this dead battery I'm about to resurrect I mean just imagine us out on the water with David up in the pilothouse captaining the whole episode like holy-

— Yeah see that's what not tracking for me. This obsession you have with your colleague it's more than a little-

— Friend. This obsession I have with my friend.

— Fine friend point is when I did my diligence on this Likecoin deal I took a look at both of your social metrics and it's pretty goddamned clear you're the draw, you're the philosopher king, you're the one who these millennial chucklefucks think they want to be.

— Yeah but David's who they really are. And having been involved in some intense memoir negotiations that kind of everyman appeal presents bookoo monetization opportunities opportunities might I remind you which'd boost your newfound ten percent stake in David's Likecoin wallet. The one teensty tiny blocker in all this is

4 | marcie tells B he  
was chosen  
because he doesn't  
have a dad/cosign  
play

that the two of us can only redeem our stakes in David if he redeems himself by embracing his swashbuckling shadow narrative.

— Swashbuckling shadow narrative.

— Yeah see I bet David that if he were to apply the high from this drug egg our russian magnet investor gifted us he'd become this swashbuckling heroic storyteller that his shadow being clearly wants him to be. But in order to get David to bet his future him, I had to put up the story rights to my Paterson Patricide past as collateral. It's this silly Maury story bet we made.

— Silly Maury story bet.

— Yeah meaning if after having fully applied his high David's pink mushy engine is still idling at the dock writing social posts about seacocks and osphosphmoric acid and not living out his shadow's story voyage noy only will we both get bubkus Likecoin wise but then I'll be obligated to hand over the story rights to the unnecessarily grotesque manner in which I deaded my dad, rights which knowing David will surely sell to the highest bidder ee gee Maury.

— Guess you're wearing it then.

— Well doy ya dummy why else you think I came to your table in the first place? Sure as shit wasn't to get a better gander at you twoses four tits tell ya that much, it was so I could leverage that pert aureola of golden hour light light which I thought if combined with my smartphone's light of recognition could project the shadow of a drugged-up glossed-eyed David smiling with the pride of being minted a Likecoin millionaire, pride which he could build his shadow narrative upon but your sharkskin suited colleagues had to go and drown out my light of recognition at the exact moment David's shadow needed to be recognized so as a roundabout answer to your question Marcie yeah it is totes fucking necessary for me to be watering this lead acid battery at three in the morning because David captaining a fully-functioning American Dream during America's Cup later today might be the last best opportunity for me to actually shine some light on his swashbuckling shadow narrative I mean trust me when I tell you I've been burning some serious photoactinic

calories here even went and shot this promotional poser video of David acting all captainy up in the pilothouse while we were still tied to the dock as like this motivational role play similar to how basketball coaches make their players cut down the nets at the first practice of the season more to the point here is that despite he and I having already deleted roughly half our drug egg David's only applied his high toward writing social posts for seacocks and rust removers and now Juug told me how he's gonna hire David to lead content for his whole Atman Projects real estate debenture venture which is like the polar opposite of swashbuckling's orbit and so as an even further roundabout answer to your question about my weird obsession regarding my friend David's swashbuckling shadow narrative it's because boy howdy I want zero part in thinking about much less publicizing the events leading up to and the manner with which I turnt my dad into goo...As Byron paused to anchor his breath, he swept a pile of powder between the battery's two terminals with a multimeter's metal talon. — Now even though I can't see you up there in the salon Marcie I feel that you kinda still don't believe me but just to give a little more context on Byron Chianti ay kay ay the Paterson Patricider a man who self-memorized the dates of Jiffy Lube's quarterly battery blowout sales so as to avoid passing by its campaign signage is currently working on this lead acid battery down here in the dark all in an effort to boost David's shadow narrative and thereby avoid telling my own shady story surrounding my battery trigger like if that isn't that a meta-ironical enough reason for you to believe me I don't know what is.

— Look if you got that big of a boner to broadcast your butt buddy's shadow you should know that a shadow shines brightest in the dark.

— Say that the fuck again?

— Shadows shine brightest in the dark. Yeah used the proceeds from my awarded tort to take a three-billable-hour tour of all psycho-therapeutic branches in the tristate area and during my exposure therapy I learned that those trauma patients have this dark disposition and so they cast these forboding sharply contrasted manic-depressive shadows out into the world while those with

brighter dispositions like my effervescent bestie Margot they cast shorter shadows that are closer to the body easier to control but what interest was that the environment in which the most self-harm's done is projecting an overcast passive anhedonic state where you feel like not only can you not cast a shadow start doubting if you can fog a fucking mirror which take it from me'll shrivel your existential ovaries something fierce.

—Marcie, you bland fucking bitch, you solved it.

—Fuck you solved what.

—My swashbuckling shadow exposure conundrum, doy! I mean like here I am all locked in on us voyaging during America's Cup later this afternoon because wha? To ride the trefoiled coattails of some rich fuckers sailing in some daytime race that our vessel can't even compete in? When really we need to focus on having David run his own race in the dead of night as a means of like projecting his swashbuckling shadow across the whole fucking harbor like the goldman sachs tower no no how bout the American Dream's silhouette on the fucking Statue of-

—That interpretation's not even close to being within the trading bounds of what I just said but sure you do you dude.

—Problem is we'll need a bigtime lumen boost to pull this shadow voyage off because we only got a couple softass halo lights aboard and properly broadcasting David's swashbuckling shadow is gonna require something hotter something brighter something commercial sized, something only daytime television can provide.

—Sounds like a job for your butt buddy Dash.

—You know Marcie most people become better listeners after snorting that shit didn't you hear me say how I already escrowed my maury story over to David as part of our faustian future him bet. I mean gawl!...Byron smacked the side of his fist against the fiberglass hull with enough force that the vessel softly wobbled in its slip. —My egg is fucking souffléed on this one I tell you what Marcie, might need to come to grips that David was right that none of any of all this was worth doing.

—Look we're not shooting a Disney movie here ok so let's skip this all is lost dark night of the soul arc and get back to the main slide.... Her right index finger's french tipped nail again broomed powder into a pinky dustpan swiftly lifting up to an unpinched nostril. — Which is what, you went and overleveraged yourself betting on your butt buddy's future that about it?...Marcie briefly tilted a crinkling face to the salon's canvas ceiling. — Damn this shit is dialed in ok look whenever some puffy-vested investor gets overleveraged and arbitrated on some future put outside our margin guardrails I tell you what they don't do they don't tuck their chode between their manscaped legs and hamlet about whether the play was worth doing while derisking their position no what they do is leverage their risk cashing out the collateral securing an even riskier position then using its liquidity to outflank their own position basically you're doubling down on your risk but that kinda of butt-puckering move only seems to work if you've got the liquidity runway of a g six owner so this probably ain't applicable to broke jabronis such as-

—Marcie you bland inspirational bitch!...A flung smartphone pirouetted out from the engine room, scuttling on the salon's grey-green carpet before stopping against Marcie's seated hip. — You solved it. You fucking solved it! Now remember I'm best at a two point eight on the f stop Maury's people prefer a shallow depth of field for their audition videos.

—Look Ima let that bland bitch comment slide only because I accused you of preemptive rape when you offered me your coat earlier but I don't see how sending an engine room selfie to Maury Povich or his predator or whoever the fuck is gonna get you-

—Oh ho! So now you're interested in my vision Marcie? Well my vision's your vision ya bland bitch said it yourself best way to get leverage against your risk is to cash out the collateral underlying that risk which got me thinking what better way to help shine a brighter light on David's future him than to leverage the publicity surrounding my own paterson patricide past because like remember that picture you took of the two of us the one that your sharkskin suited colleagues drowned out? Well maybe that was this like sign that Likecoin's

lights simply aren't bright enough yet to properly project a swashbuckling shadow and that maybe just maybe the recognition I've been refusing Maury's and Dash's calls on is what can get David to answer his because last I checked there's no brighter light than daytime tv now after you take the pic send it on over to Maury's predator Dash Balder he's in my contacts ok got all that?

11 | Marcie  
leverage risk  
advice (double  
down on your  
debenture)

— Sure dude but maybe wipe your face clean before we do anything. Here use these blue paper towels on the bench here.

— No don't you see Marcie?

— See what? A sweating bloody coked up fucking mess of a man who's kneeling against some dead battery? Wait...tapping the phone's still-locked screen to strafe a bright white light into the engine room below. — Dude are you crying?

— Oh ho! So you do see it!

— Damn it see what.

— That I'm about to wear it.

— Wear what.

— The three substances that make up the American Dream!...Byron's voice crescendoed like a monster truck emcee before thrusting a red straw into an unpinched nostril as its head bowed to powder piled on the battery then swept from negative to positive terminals. — Hoo-doggie! Hashtag blood sweat and tears! You know what it is!

With the quick twitch of a rejuvenated gunslinger, Byron flung a multimeter out from his coverall's back pocket; placing its red and black leads against the battery's two terminals, an eggshell-white preflash illuminated a wagged-tail smile whose raised cheeks' canted eyebrows funneled browbeaten sweat into glossed eye ducts brimming with dopaminergic reflex tears, these two conjoined fluids trickling down a swollen nosebridge to merge with thinned B positive blood beading off its right nostril and form a three-electrolyte stream falling off a snarled upper lip to splash upon the lead talon poised Michelangelically near the battery's negative terminal and conduct a bridge current just strong enough to keep Byron from letting go.

## byron &amp; the battery

Artist here. Let me first address you square in your rolling eyes and apologize for this chapter's existence. I fully recognize that in acknowledging your presence as a reader, I've taken a huge dump on your personal hopes and expectations that The Floating Studio would be a simple bildungsroman that told what it needed to tell without any rib-nudging metadialogue between author and reader. Like you, I am meta-over postmodernism's constant reminders that what you're reading is a constructed text in ways which have all the aesthetic appeal of a carbon monoxide detector testing itself.

So you might be wondering: if neither of us wants to be in this chapter, why does it even exist in the first place? The fact remains that as of this writing, memoirs receive a 250% greater monetary advance than fiction. And, to put it bluntly, my traumatic origin story was the sweetener The Floating Studio needed to obtain 920 status<sup>1</sup>. Even so, I tried to do us a solid by taking a hard line that my traumatic origin story would hold no plot-based weight whatsoever. There will be none of that embedded narrative bullshit here — no ma'am<sup>2</sup>, not me. So let my apology serve as an off-ramp of sorts before I begin handling my contractual obligations. Seriously: skip ahead to chapter 18.

<sup>1</sup> Dewey Decimal System's memoir classification.

<sup>2</sup> Women comprise approximately 70 percent of American readers.



Now at some level, you might sense a trap being laid, in that my offer to blow past this chapter without narratological repercussions actually *is* some kind of slick gatekeeping that meta-authors would totally deal in, which is to say that what follows *is* essential toward understanding *The Floating Studio's* deeper aims and earned truths. Look, I get it: you didn't get this far in life by taking an unreliable narrator's words at face value. And considering how I've berated David for bending his work to similar financial pressures<sup>3</sup> I'm bending to now, you might even think that I am a hypocrite. Which is flat fine by me, as I'd rather be called a hypocrite than a stooge: because insofar that memoirs are only as good as the trust between its reader and author, what I can't have you believe is that this right here is still David's voice and that he simply co-opted my origin story as a cheap cutout device to graft his own glitzy interpretations of trauma upon my very real and lived-through experiences<sup>4</sup>.

Which then begs the question: why the narrator switcheroo? This, like many decisions surrounding this chapter, came down to our publisher's steadfast belief that David's failings and firings did not meet a traumatic threshold able to sustain a profitable memoir. Though our publisher did not state this outright, their initial feedback on David's manuscript read like a coded plea for me to tell my story<sup>5</sup>. And so it was negotiated that in exchange for David's story to be told, I would grant our publisher the rights to the story they wanted all along<sup>6</sup>: *The Paterson Patricide*.

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<sup>3</sup> Cf haranguing David for wanting to be the rare writer who gets paid in "Flesh Wheelbarrow"; yawning after hearing him whine about his economic victimization in "Job is Job"; chiding him for wanting to sell his half of our cocaine egg gift in "Papa Grinnie's Toot Clear Float Recipe" etc.

<sup>4</sup> This happens more than probably you care to realize with regard to memoirs.

<sup>5</sup> That David's draft "lacked traumatic punch and apothecic epicosity", and that future drafts should "bring forth any clinically-recognized trauma (such as perhaps rape and/or child abuse) experienced by supporting characters as a way of contrasting David's ego-hallucinated socioeconomic traumas (seen here as chronic financial stress, social stigmata created by unemployment, etc.)."

<sup>6</sup> You often see this tactic in collegiate athletics, where coaches offer full rides to the spazzy nephews of a blue-chip recruit. While that's not entirely fair to David, it's important to keep in mind that despite fairly widespread cultural thirst for my story, I've never — not once — publicly discussed my father's abuse, his passing, my first work of art, and the state of New Jersey's attempts to connect those three events. I turned down Maury Povich for Christ sake.

That said, it was not my intent to sequester my traumatic origin story from the rest of the events chronicled in The Floating Studio. My original pitch was that we scatter sub-rosa breadcrumbs throughout our narrative in ways that surreptitiously ladder up to David's deep water apotheosis about creativity, trauma, and resiliency in The Floating Studio Part Two: The Rise of Cocoin. But, again, this creative choice fell at our publisher's feet: specifically their demand that in order to properly take David and I's swashbuckling stories to our millennial target market we needed to in no uncertain terms, "burn some creative calories on upping the postmodern quotient". Now to be clear, my frustration with our publisher's ask ran deeper than whatever personal animus I may have on the postmodern aesthetic. For one, it's a vague request; unlike other cultural discourses, postmodernism claims no specific technique or form, only an ironic chronological debt to modernism. Despite this ambiguity, I obviously wanted to help my friend publish his swashbuckling story. But before I could build out a scaffolding to prop up my metamemoir, I first needed to establish a foundational definition of postmodernism. This, I soon discovered, was as Sisyphean as establishing a consensus on the length of an afternoon. For her part, Joyce put me in touch with her needledick colleagues over in Seton Hall's liberal arts department, all forgettable except for the unanimity in which they fluttered a fresh fall off their corduroy coat, squat in their ergonomic kneeling chair and flap glib gums on Lyotard and Foucault, signifying nothing. A Johnny Utah's waitress whose ear I bent after one such feckless campus visit hit much closer to the mark, leaning an elbow poising a tray of long island ice teas on a mechanical bullpen's perimeter cushion to inform me between audible gum smacks and in the hushed tone of a former associate of Carmen Sandiego that postmodernism is defined by the tools the artist leaves in plain sight — tools like intertextuality and self-reflexive narration. After shooting my shot by downing all five of long island ice teas in an ungagged gulp, the last thing I remember was thrusting my index finger on the bullpen's cushion, slur that those kinds of navel-gazing titty-pinchers have been going on since Las Meninas, then scream "the artist is herself the vanishing point" as I felt myself being carried out by my flailing limbs.

Granted, we could've sidestepped this whole postmodern metamemoir demand by publishing *The Floating Studio* ourselves. To be clear, self-publishing is a serious choice with many unforeseen complications. I remember discussing the matter with David in hushed tones. Only when prompted did I provide my direct, but abridged personal view on the matter while in the same breath emphasizing my ultimate trust in his judgment. Because look: it's easy for the partner who plants the seed, not so much for the one bearing the thirty-chapter burden of carrying this swashbuckling story voyage to term. That stated, I will admit feeling relieved after David told me he'd rather vacate the whole goddamned manuscript altogether than let it enter the world with the feeble distribution and palsied marketing that typify self-published works, as if the totality of our lived experience was some limp accident of youth.

By now you've likely gathered that we ended up giving our big 4 publishing baby their bottle. Just as you can probably gather from my tedious unpacking of the aggrieved minutiae surrounding this chapter that I'm doing the bare minimum here the same way a Johnny Utah's waitress wears the minimum mandated amount of Gary Busey flair on her suspenders, or how in sophomore English class I would fill up my daily rough writing logs with random shit like "I like Ecto Coolers" just to satisfy the required word count. And while that is true, it's also true I'm flat fucking scared that in telling you my story, it'll change from being too good to be true into one too true to be good.

To the men who knew him, my father was a good man. In this way I believe he was like most men of his generation. Due to all the professional and extracurricular time he spent with these men<sup>7</sup>, bonding with my father was for the most part confined to Sundays<sup>8</sup>. I remember that my father's footwear would determine the trajectory of these Sundays; if I heard my bedroom ceiling groan from my father's black tasseled loafers clacking on our upstairs kitchen's floorboards, church was imminent, while the soft squeak of his socks scuttling on those same floorboards heralded a lackadaisical morning watching

<sup>7</sup> Usually posting up at JB's Liquor and Bar on MLK and Madison.

<sup>8</sup> And consistently enforced by my vagina mother's nagging.

political and football roundtables with my father.<sup>9</sup> On those Sundays our family our family did attend Mass, what I remember most — outside of the mindless rote chanting common to all organized religions<sup>10</sup> — was feeling my father's elbow jolt against my ribs as a means of redirecting my attention away from St. Eligius's stained glass stations of the cross projecting quilted midmorning light upon our fellow parishioners and back toward Monsignor Whack's homily making strained hermeneutical connections between that week's gospel reading and fundraising efforts for overdue narthex renovations<sup>11</sup> and/or sponsoring some bible-bludgeoning volentourism in foreign communities somehow more destitute than our own<sup>12</sup>. Another sharp memory was watching my father take off his Jack Fagman trousers after Mass in St. Eligius's gridlocked parking lot so he could preserve its pleats for the following Sunday. This very much displeased my vagina mother, who I remember browbeating my father for the entirety of our post-Mass drive up 46 to Applegate Farms for calling her pleat integrity into question in front of fellow parishioners. Her breathless haranguing would continue throughout our "sundae brunch", where my vagina mother would poll exiting diners and passing wait staff on the level of my father's gall in pairing the red Bermuda shorts he just changed into with black sheened hosiery still worn from Mass. I remember my father would wait until my vagina mother was in the throes of these distracted rants before hiking the hem of his bermuda shorts to his grundle and pull a pint of rumplemintz strapped to his inner thigh that he then slyly tipped into our shared boysenberry silo. Once I got older and developed the physiological resilience not to fall victim to a nappy poo after a spiked sundae brunch, I could spend Sunday afternoons working with my father in his garage. I remember racing to my bedroom after getting back from Applegate Farms so I could woozily slough off my clothes, then take several minutes wavering between carefully hanging my starched suit at locked angles or crumpling it in a ball and upset my suit's pleat integrity altogether as

<sup>9</sup> And, later in my adolescence, Glen.

<sup>10</sup> Not a knock mind you; I personally find the agnus dei soothing.

<sup>11</sup> Exodus 25:8 "Let them construct a sanctuary for Me, that I may dwell among them."

<sup>12</sup> Romans 10:15 "And how can they hear without someone preaching to them?"

a way of enabling my vagina mother's dependence on my depending on her. After making this choice one way or another, I would change into duck canvas coveralls I had self-sewn with repurposed burlap from my father's discarded tool bags and candlewax ganked from my bi-monthly duties as a weekday altar server. And as my father and I walked toward the garage together, I remember my vagina mother bleating "*now don't give him any ideas*" from out our kitchen nook's cantilevered window, and how my father and I both looked at each other, as if we each thought the comment was intended for ourselves.

At Joyce and Glen's engagement party, I remember the ticky-tack sound of my vagina mother's french-filed nails tapping Joyce's diamond ring; this was her way of punctuating her smarmy sanctimonious advice that marriage is about balancing a man's idea of himself with a woman's idea of family. While I'm still unsure what my vagina mother's idea of family actually is, it was clear my father's idea of himself resided in the Rebel Well, a single-family fracking system he conceived in the downtime during my infancy<sup>13</sup>. Some of my most vivid pre-adolescent memories were of watching my father's palsied attempts in making progress on his Rebel Well prototype<sup>14</sup>: I remember fidget-rocking my cozy coupe back and forth on our garage's green carpet as if revving up a hot wheel while my father slowly orbited his work bench clenching a beer satellite in each hand, almost as if he knew his work ethic lacked the motivational salience to pierce the stratosphere of his own fecklessness.

Due to geoeengineering headwinds we need not unpack here, my father's Rebel Well prototype lay dormant for most of my early adolescence. That was up until the state of New Jersey issued a statewide moratorium on all fracking operations – a ruling which in

<sup>13</sup> My father believed access to energy was an unalienable right. He'd often whine unprompted at parent-teacher conferences and end-of-season pizza parties about the eroding land use rights of property owners, many times pulling out a sketched electrotopographical rendering of Essex county on his mapkin as proof positive there's a stockpile of shale just waiting to be pulled out and profited from, and that if my guidance counselor/soccer coach refused this neat Rebel Well investment opportunity well hey that was no skin off his entrepreneurial dick, it just proved that they would forever be slaves to the government's grid.

<sup>14</sup> Which, to paint a crude picture, was little more than an erector set-sized oil derrick's traveling block bobbing at the rate of a drinking bird doll, its motion driven by an alternator belt patched to a Trump brand rotating tie rack.

effect triggered my father's energy bootlegging fantasies. I remember hearing the snap of calcified burlap unfurl off my father's Rebel Well prototype as I took in a mapkin titled Jim Chianti's Underground Shaleroad tacked to our garage's pegboard depicting several nearby townships at the scale and oversized iconography of a children's menu. And after I asked my father if he had considered the environmental impact of his inspired genius and that maybe just maybe the corrupt fused by all over fracking deposits exploited by a select few, I remember seeing my father's body convulse in a dismissive scoff, as if the environment were an inferior species, before parrying my question into some lame cajole about how much more tainted could the Passaic get if that MDMA dealer Rusty Irish is still floating around down there?

Despite this friction between me and my father, I did want to help him live out his energy bootlegging fantasy.<sup>15</sup> But I also wanted to avoid the pinched-nosebridge exasperation and personal putdowns that came after any suggestion that didn't align with wherever his thigh-strapped pint of rumpleminze was guiding him that day. And any inkling I had of improving his Rebel Well prototype at night without him knowing<sup>16</sup> was overridden by a stone-cold fear of upsetting the order of my father's garage. Like many fathers, my father made it matte-clear to neighbors, solicitors, and passing cyclists that the Chianti family garage was his and his alone. I remember my father would visibly bristle whenever my vagina mother would enter the garage, most times threatening that she had a good mind to reciprocate the disrespect my father had just paid to her space and begin leaving crusted cereal bowls on his work bench and cropdusting her farts with a folded-over Star-Ledger.<sup>17</sup> To which my father would ask my vagina mother in sarcastic crescendo would she puh puh puh please get back in the goddamned breakfast nook and quit the motherfuckin' puckerin'. And off they would go.

<sup>15</sup> What son wouldn't?

<sup>16</sup> A la Will Hunting connecting Professor Lambeau's hallway nodes as he mopped MIT's hallways at midnight, I initially believed I could electrically engineer all four phases of fracking shale gas reservoirs with my father was passed out in my bed.

<sup>17</sup> Clearly an idle threat — what mother can fart on command?

Like most of his deeply-held convictions, my father's belligerence surrounding both the physical and legal orderliness of his garage was all so much feckless caterwauling. Which is to say that for all his clenched-fist aggravation about keeping the garage organized, the space itself was both sparse and poorly utilized. A pithy case in point: I remember my father regularly squeezing my shoes about stacking back the garden hose holders my friends and I would use as seats whenever we'd play Crash Bandicoot, this despite our garden hose had been sitting calcified in its coil against the garage's brick exterior for the better part of a presidential administration.

More galling to me as a budding aesthete was the fact my father only hung two items in his garage: an easement grant proclaiming individual ownership of said garage<sup>18</sup>, and a motivational poster<sup>19</sup>. If you've ever worked in a cubicle, you've likely seen some version of this poster in your boss's office<sup>20</sup>. For most of my childhood, my only acknowledgement of this poster's existence was rolling my eyes at it whenever my friends brought it up while waiting out Crash Bandicoot's loading screen<sup>21</sup>. Even so, my vagina mother's lewd salt-and-pepper shaker collection registered far higher on my teenage mortification scale than some chintzy motivational poster. It was only later that I was able to view my father's motivational poster with a different perspective, which is to say that instead of rolling my eyes at it, events in my life had forced me to look at the poster squarely. Even now, having attested under oath to not having seen the poster in question since the night of my father's death, I can still remember its

<sup>18</sup> In exchange for his blessing in marrying his sister, my father compelled Glen to rezone our family's garage as an individual easement as some sort of reverse dowry. To which my grandfather, who unexpectedly bequeathed his home to my vagina mother after a grisly PATH accident involving a stuck pneumatic door and a protruding emergency access ladder and who the week prior to his death met my father during a time in my father's life when he had grown one sideburn in protest of affirmative action policies, likely had him turning in his urn.

<sup>19</sup> It was quite the shock visiting friends garages plastered with lewd license plates, taxidermied mammals, vixen imagery, and similar masculine gewgaws.

<sup>20</sup> And if you had a really shitty job, your boss's boss's office.

<sup>21</sup> I imagine this dismissive posture toward my father's motivational poster was roughly in line with any other child enduring the early 2000's plague of suburban home decor featuring insipid Escherian messaging ("e.g. love holds the heart, the heart holds the key the key opens the door:")

central image: a butterfly swimmer sheathed in the water he shaped; beneath it, the poster's core ideal — **SUCCESS** — set in Century Gothic along with its center-justified inspirational koan: *"Who you are, is what it takes"*. I recall this level of detail about the poster not because of its far-reaching legal implications after the whole messy dramatic event between me and my father, but rather it became a helpful centering image during difficult moments in our relationship, as I would often project that night's skin rhythms upon the swimmer's strokes slapping the water.

One aspect of the memoiring process I've come to respect is the sheer technical energy it takes to focalize the proper distance between a memoirist's lived experience and what the reader experiences in its rendering. It's a skill I imagine that's similar to optimizing a rollercoaster at a safe but sufficiently scary velocity, or a horror director shooting at one frame per second below a flash rate that triggers epileptics. Which is why, for both our sake, I think it's best that I gloss over any additional physical sensations surrounding my father's abuse<sup>22</sup>. What I will tell you is that, looking back, it was clear my father waited to abuse me. I believe it wasn't a coincidence that the first time I got dad-dicked was the same night I was able to bench press my own weight. What king wouldn't lash out after glimpsing the event horizon of their rule's end?

In my father's defense, I did have a stunted pubescence. This was a well-worn topic of conversation between my parents, with my father squarely placing blame on my "faggy interest in art", while my father's frustration with my body came to a head after my mother showed him the only picture of me in my freshmen year's yearbook<sup>23</sup>: a gym class candid of me bench pressing alongside 'U.S.S.' Millie Kent<sup>24</sup>,

<sup>22</sup> Again as a reminder: I am a naive, unpracticed traumemoirist. And so I fear if I were to loiter any further on the physiological sensations surrounding my abuse, I would subconsciously jazz up its severity and/or bricolage its details into some slick, easily digestible pellet of a revealed truth about trauma, resiliency, and creativity, which is exactly the kind of hinky dick-measuring I really honestly am doing my best here to avoid.

<sup>23</sup> Outside of the school-mandated individual headshot.

<sup>24</sup> Initially named for her forecastled nose and bulkheadesque forehead, then later after a homecoming preparty incident in which she mixed the insecurities brought on by her nickname, a bottle of Rumpleminze, and the burnout seniors on our JV lacrosse team, her capacity to house multiple semen.



our strength equally tested with a ten-pound plate on each side of our bars but with contrasting displays of said strength, with Millie hamming a cross-eyed, tongue-out pose as she steadied the bar flush with pubescing chesticles, a stark and in my father's eyes humiliating contrast to my bugged-eye and tongue-bit struggle with a tilted bar pressing against my adam's apple while I flailed both feet off the weight room's floor mats. I remember my father smacking its headline: **Girl Power!** with the back of his hand at the velocity of disgust before unilaterally declaring to my mother and I that I would be placed on a bodybuilding regimen. I remember my initial reaction to bodybuilding was that it seemed a far faggier pursuit than cultivating a skillset whose proficiency provided opportunities to charcoal sketch my trig teacher's tits. Yet I agreed to participate in what my father called body therapy sessions, as it allowed the two of us to spend quality time together, which as mentioned was a rarity outside of Sundays. The training itself was a fairly straightforward 5x5 hypertrophy program. But as any bodybuilder will tell you, the game's as much about what you consume as what you lift. To that end, my father placed me on an ABC diet<sup>25</sup> whose weekly dosages would be palsily scrawled on the back of a bar napkin tacked to the pegboard in our garage. You can probably gather the physiological benefits of a latently pubescing sixteen year-old consuming sixty milligrams of anavar daily, but as far as the two tablespoons of baking soda my father personally spoonfed me with each meal, his intent there was to delay the onset of lactic acid generated from that day's lift. The best way I can describe taking anabolic steroids is that they in effect tricked my Present Me into training at the rate and intensity I wanted my Future Me to train. Because over the course of six weeks, I had progressed from struggling to knock out ten reps on a bare forty-five pound bar to on the night I first got dad-dicked confidently placing forty-five and ten-pound plates on each side. I remember seeing my father's upside-down smile as he helped me lift the bar off the rack<sup>26</sup>, his glossed eyes

<sup>25</sup> Anabolic steroids, baking soda, and chicken breasts.

<sup>26</sup> I still flog my noggin about including my father into the intimate and liberating experience of hoisting something as heavy as one's self. Even today, I'm still kinda not sold that the alternate reality of not having a spotter altogether and maybe having the weight choke me out with the bar against my throat wouldn't have been a better path for me.

brimming with what I stupidly hoped was the sin of pride, but even then had a sneaking feeling it was one of the other ones. It was there, right at the exact moment I felt the full weight of the fallen bar upon my chest, I remember closing my eyes in a wince and feeling his nutsack plow my pre-furrowed forehead. Now while this was obviously bewildering, I remember in that moment convincing myself that what my father was doing was no different than, say, Earl Woods crinkling his car keys during his son's backswing, meaning I believed my father was teabagging me in order to impart some character-building lesson that while uncomfortable to endure in the present, ultimately laddered up to a resiliency I could use to my advantage later in life. I don't know whether it was the anavar or the adrenaline of the moment, but despite being blinded from my father sumo squatting his grundle on my face, I was able to lock out my rep. And after placing the bar back on the rack, I remember standing up to my father and offer a fist bump as in like you got me pops, now the image of you teabagging me is indelibly tied to my achieving this important physiological milestone. I remember feeling my father swat away my proffered fist so he could cradle my Adam's Apple real rough-like with his thumb, like a grocer evaluating green produce. Then I remember feeling my legs weaken as if flooded with lactic acid, this despite it being chest day. And after I felt my father squeeze my trap muscle like how I imagine proud fathers do, the last thing I remember feeling was my spine collapsing into mush right as he shifted his squeeze into a downward push.

Now the reason why I unpacked that whole yarn about my father's training regimen was that it was core to my initial defense strategy. In the immediate aftermath of my father's death, and in my defiant refusal to be viewed as a victim, I let Glen know in no uncertain terms that we weren't about to go to trial with your typical boy-with-the-battered-butt self-defense strategy, but rather we needed to portray my father as a negligent animal tamer who, after pumping his beast full of anavar and arm and hammer, failed to respect the instinct in the cage. And that if I were to become his client, he should get to burning some jurisprudential calories on establishing such a narrative. To his credit, Glen talked me out of that

pretrial strategy<sup>27</sup> by convincing me that our best path forward would be convincing the court of my juvenile standing. Which, as any seventeen-year-old will attest, swallowing the fact that you're still a child in the eyes of the law is tougher to swallow than most anything. Glen informed me that the adult-versus-juvenile decision hinges equally on the defendant's criminal record and the brutality of the crime. I remember the sobriety with which he admitted he was unsure whether the lack of the former could overcome the abundance of the latter. Adding to our uncertainty was the fact that, given the recency of my father's death and the publicized leak of his autopsy photos<sup>28</sup>, no Chiantis would agree to speak as character witnesses on my behalf. So Glen called in a chit in from Monsignor Whack, as he would be leading my father's funerary service at St. Eligius. Apparently Glen provided the parish some sort of legal absolution some years prior. I didn't ask questions.

While I was aware of Glen's talking point in advance,<sup>29</sup> it was only after hearing Monsignor Whack speak it into existence<sup>30</sup> that I felt its full weight. Because it was in the post-eulogy silence in which pastors like Whack sit down in their presider's throne and silently swish their egos under the guise of theological reflection that my manic laughter built to an uncomfortable decibel as I appreciated the line's apothecic irony; that is, instead of my father being the man that came in and I the man who came out, rather it was my father who was both men, as he had came both in the garage<sup>31</sup>

<sup>27</sup> As well as one where I pled guilty simply for the street cred, believing that residuals from my line of Free Chianti paraphernalia could finance my commissary needs.

<sup>28</sup> New York Post headline: Goo Goo Walls.

<sup>29</sup> I remember skipping school for a week in order to become a mall mole and A/B test our talking points by infiltrating focus groups set up outside Jimmy Jazz and Hot Topic at Pavonia Newport's shopping center, where I'd sidebar conversations to my trial, which during that time was top of mind to most New Jersey teenagers.

<sup>30</sup> "Fathering is not something perfect men do, but something which perfects the man. It will cost a man not only what he has, but who he is. And yet one day, having spent all his manhood, he will have shaped the man he sought. This is the glory of fatherhood. So as we contemplate the mystery of Jim Chianti's death, we take solace in the fact that God will always possess more mystery than the devil. And we are at peace knowing that as one man came into the garage that fateful night, so did one man come out."

<sup>31</sup> As in orgasm.

as well as out<sup>32</sup>. After leaving St. Eligius with what I now admit was a churlish thumb-on-nose nyah-nyah turkey waddle to the gaggle of local media that had assembled outside the narthex, Glen chauffeured me over to my father's wake. And as we pulled into a driveway deweeded from that same media gaggle's week-long loitering, I remember seeing torn ends of the yellow coroner's tape wound around our front yard's yucca tree flutter and feeling kinda like a returning soldier finding his family home had been foreclosed on. And while I'd rather not catalog what was said or thrown between me and my vagina mother that day, I can tell you that I vividly remember hearing our one-man in-out talking point sync between the Chiantis congregating at our kitchen nook and those broadcast on our living room television<sup>33</sup>. Then I remember feeling a sportcoated elbow's crook constrict against my forehead, immediately followed by a glass tumbler's bottom noogying my noggin with such celebratory intent that sloshed scotch spilled on my scalp as I heard Glen whisper "*told you they'd repeat that funeral line ad mausoleum*" behind my ear about as close as my dad used to.

Now whether Glen's talking point actually carried jurisprudential weight or I'm simply spoonfeeding you some apocryphal yarn as a belated way of thanking him is a choice you'll surely wrestle with in the weeks that follow my story. But after Judge Basu ruled I would be tried as a juvenile, the criminal trial itself was fairly pro forma. Evidently testimony can be massaged in just about any way a licensed electrician is coached to massage it. And as each day progressed without a chyronable quote or a memeable moment, I could feel the media gaggle getting restless, as their sales teams had priced a lurid trial into that month's ad buys. Once, while taking a piss during recess, I remember hearing "*we're talking Menendez brothers money*" growl from a speakerphone behind a stall. I bring all this up to make clear that when Glen recklessly ginned up a evidentiary sidebar right before resting our case, he did so unilaterally and without my consent.

<sup>32</sup> My father's detached eyeball shot out our garage's open ceiling duct with enough velocity that it landed in a patio playpen cattycorner to our property and mingle with young Harper's regular rotation of bouncy balls for more than a week before being discovered.

<sup>33</sup> Earlier that afternoon News12 interviewed my father's immediate family outside of St. Eligius for a soundbite montage which led that night's newscast.

Let me go back: during discovery, the Passaic County Assistant District Attorney Jennifer Urquhart submitted a crime scene photo depicting a spatter-free rectangle on our garage's wall, implying that a rectangular item had been lifted off the wall after it had been sprayed by my father's viscera, but before authorities had arrived. And so it was ruled that the government was well within their rights to discover the contents, location, and provenance of said rectangular item. Now not only did I know that the item was, but I also knew I had just used it as collateral for Glen's rendered legal services<sup>34</sup>. And because he shrewdly understood the poster's value hinged on public knowledge of its sordid provenance, Glen waited until just before closing arguments — right when the media gaggle would be at their most engorged — to announce that in his tireless search to satisfy prosecution's discovery, he had just now been made aware that not only the rectangular item in question was my father's motivational poster, but that it was currently up for sale on the dark web<sup>35</sup>. During the prosecution's subsequent motion for mistrial, Glen somehow argued successfully that because the motivational poster in question was being billed as a creative work of art and not some gruesome murder relic similar to Son of Sam's shell casings or Eric Garner's loosie, its sale as an art object was afforded legal protection against evidentiary seizure<sup>36</sup>. To which I remember thinking: yippee, we're in the clear. Unfortunately, said evidentiary protections are only afforded to criminal cases. And so, just as *State of New Jersey vs. Chianti* hinged on a criminal court's interpretation on whether or my dad died before my nuts descended, *Chianti vs. Chianti* hinged on a municipal court's interpretation on whether or not I was an artist before my father's soul ascended. And in a case that holds the rare

<sup>34</sup> At the time, I remember being touched by Glen agreeing to represent me in exchange for the poster; not so much due to his financial sacrifice, but rather that in defining his representation as a quid pro quo — and not pro bono — meant he valued my work as a fellow professional, and not with the patronizing sentimentality a father would place on, say, a braided pipe-cleaner keychain or punch-hole wallet.

<sup>35</sup> Even for Glen this was ballsy, as he had to have anticipated ADA Urquhart unleashing a semester's worth of Seton Hall's finest financial forensic interns to run down the transaction in question, but then again I remember Glen would regularly reassure me that I'd be surprised at the kind of protective subterfuge one can apply to an art sale, I really would.

<sup>36</sup> *Fairey v. Associated Press*, *Morris v. Thierry Guetta*, also *Supreme v. McSweeney*; though that case was still pending at the time of my trial.

distinction of being featured in law<sup>37</sup>, art<sup>38</sup>, and business<sup>39</sup> journals, here's what was in dispute: did my father's remains belong to him at the moment of his death? Was he his own Pollock? Or, like Van Eyck making tempera out of chicken bones and egg whites, did he merely save me a trip to the farmer's market? Glen's opening gambit was to project my father's social media feed in the months leading up to his death, sensing the jury would pick up that reposted Grover Norquist talking points and screenshot memes of Glenn Beck's chalkboard homilies were incompatible creative influences toward what was already being called art's metamuerte movement. Even so, I remember seeing Glen's eyebrows dislodge his toupee from scalp when opposing counsel introduced relevant case law, citing a child support case in Laredo, Texas that ruled against an illegal alien maid who, in an attempt to attain her American Dream, conceived an anchor baby after discovering an affluent hotel guest's unintentional death by erotic asphyxiation. Prosecution's contention here being that, much like Plaintiff Carradine, my father not only owned the creative materials used for the asset in dispute, he also owned the canvas itself, and his estate should be the sole entity to profit from its sale.

By the time we presented our case, Glen's egg was completely scrambled. I remember reading a witness list haphazardly stacked with expert testimony hail marys ranging from Schumpeterian economics<sup>40</sup>, chintzy metaphysics<sup>41</sup>, and aestheto-critical huckstery.<sup>42</sup>

<sup>37</sup> Remains To Be Seen: Creative Agency at the Time of Death

<sup>38</sup> The Vanishing Point: A Putrefying Palette in Paterson

<sup>39</sup> The aestheticized death: Exploring new profitability angles for end-of-life care.

<sup>40</sup> As the forefather of creative destruction theory, Schumpeter believed entrepreneurship depended on the old being blown up to make way for the new. Glen's argument being that this spirit of *Unternehmgeist* is also at work in the creative arts, or as he put it: "entrepreneurship for the soul".

<sup>41</sup> That the poster's creation was governed by a creation/destruction cycle weaving the very warp and woof of our cosmos. Glen even brought a small statue of Shiva to replace the bible for our expert's sworn testimony, which I remember leading to a lengthy sidebar in Judge Basu's quarters.

<sup>42</sup> A Seton Hall sociological professor<sup>(a)</sup> testified that my poster was a postmodern interpretation of grief painting traditions. Which hearing your first creative work being compared to Deming's *The Mourning Brave* got pretty cringey for yours truly as you'd imagine. This adjunct assclown's professional opinion being that I arranged my dad's spatter as a nuanced tribute to Deming's mottled red-black viscera and that the singe in the poster's upper left corner homaged TMB's daimonic stream of light as a commentary on the winnowing of noble savagery ideals in a postmodern world. But what really made my sockless

All seemed lost up until one afternoon recess, as Glen and I chased poodle legs atop his truck's center console I began bitching that the bureaucratic fuckery surrounding my trial followed the same inane civic logic as Vasari recounting the lunacy of a settled Roman law dictating whoever owned the frame owned the painting. At which point I remember watching Glen momentarily shellshock himself by his sudden solve, swiftly delete the rest of our baggie, then after rushing back into the courthouse to wheedle one last final last recess from Judge Basu, drive to the Hobby Lobby in Totowa to subpoena that day's shift manager<sup>43</sup> all so he could ask this poor girl that next morning why Hobby Lobby's headquarters, that neat special place that stored all their faux-shiplap and *Bless this Mess* kitchen tiling, why perchance was it in located in Oklahoma City instead of on Museum Row between the Met and Guggenheim?

Looking back, it was clear the sole puprose of Glen's performance was to draw out court proceedings until weekend recess, at which point we could regroup with an inbound eightball I had ordered from Silk Road earlier that week<sup>44</sup>. After playing a few rounds of don't fuck your brother<sup>45</sup> on Nine Inch Nails' *The Downward Spirals* cd case, I remember Glen gabbing about the Oj Simpson case during that time, then suddenly shaking his steering wheel with both hands as if cardiacally arrested by his own solve then shaking me by the shoulders to inform me that the only way the case was going to break our way was the same way any other high-profile case breaks for the defense: evidence of the prosecution's hypocrisy. That was about all the context I got on our three-hour drive down I-95<sup>46</sup> to Atlantic City; toes curl inside my tasseled loafers was when this corduroyed jamoke had the gall to hold up *Still Life with Skull, Leeks, and Pitcher* and make some limpdicted connection between Picasso's choice to place a skull besides humdrum everyday objects to my choice to layer my father's remains on an equally humdrum motivational poster.

a. whose eagerly volunteered testimony to me suggested Joyce had had an emotional affair with at a minimum.

<sup>43</sup> Hobby Lobby sold more of these posters than any other vendor for that fiscal year.

<sup>44</sup> Due must be given here to early drug networks – Incognito, Silk Road, Asap, Dream, Archetyp – upon whose rhizomatic network Cocoin's walled garden grew.

<sup>45</sup> After lining up a real straw-length, pinky-girth ripper, one person snorts all they can handle, forcing their counterpart to insufflate whatever's left over.

<sup>46</sup> Glen had been on the turnpike's lam for evaded toll fare.

where for the next sixty hours we canvassed all nine dry cleaners in its ten-mile radius while also taking recuperative bi-hourly bump breaks at a rotation of casinos where we'd pound hoagies, chase poodle legs arranged atop penny slot stools, and take in that sweet, sweet high-oxygen air casinos notoriously pump in. And after having driven back from Atlantic City before Monday's daybreak to arrive at the Passaic County courthouse in what felt like a kismetically cinematic nick of time, Glen called Assistant District Attorney Jennifer Urquhart to the stand so he could ask her one silly simple question: where was she on the night of April 14, 1989? And I vividly remember A.D.A. Urquhart stating that while she couldn't immediately recollect what she was doing on that specific time and date, she'll surely remember what she'll be doing on the times and dates of any future BAR renewal hearings for Counselor Grynzspan. At that point I remember Glen glancing at me with a percolating smirk suppressed by grit lips, wipe a runny nose with the saggy cuff of a suit that had gotten two sizes too big over the course of the trial, and submit two pieces of exculpatory evidence to the court — a ticket stub of Gallagher's 1989 spring residency at the Sands Casino and a copy of Ms. Urquhart's service receipt at Sea Breeze Dry Cleaning<sup>47</sup> before asking ADA Urquhart with arms wide open did she in fact pay to see the watermelon or the comedic artist who smashed it<sup>48</sup>?

<sup>47</sup> Glen would regularly tell me I'd be surprised how far back customer data goes at dry cleaners, I really would.

<sup>48</sup> Here setting the record straight on my courtroom portrait above the fold on the Newark Star Ledger's Local Ledger section: I did not bury my palmed face between my thighs so far down I remember my bangs touching sharkskin-suited balls in an "apotheotic release upon the conclusion of a protracted jurisprudential odyssey spanning two trials, three years and over half a million in taxpayer dollars"<sup>(a)</sup>; rather I was bracing myself in a cringe position anticipating Glen's own apotheotic release knowing full well his favorite courtroom scene in all cinema was of Jim Carrey's celebration after wheedling full custody for Jennifer Tilly's character on a similarly farfetched technicality in Liar, Liar. Meaning my only actual lived memory of this moment was blindly hearing Glen scream "How do you like them melons"<sup>(b)</sup>; with my head braced between my balls as if about to experience an airplane crash. It was only after seeing the courtroom sketch of our bailiff dispassionately rejecting the crumpled affidavit Glen skyhooked at the prosecution's wastebasket with one hand while flinging out his handcuffs from behind him with the other.<sup>(iii)</sup> that I grasped the full extent of Glen's contempt of the Passaic County's Municipal Court.

a. Sylvanshine, Gary: "Urquhart's court thwart" Newark Star Ledger July 11 2013

b. An homage to his other fanboner nerdy wet dream of a movie, Good Will Hunting.

c. Only later did I learn Glen cut both the bailiff and the courtroom sketch artist in advance as a way to split the proceeds which last I saw auctioned on firstdibs for the price of an engagement ring.



I feel like this is the right place to provide some color and context on the equally brief and intense cultural hoopla that surrounded my case, if only glancingly. Because our publisher's feedback on my initial draft was that my traumatic origin story was the perfect hand-in-glove, mise-en-scene metaphor for the millennial generation's existential socioeconomic struggles, their view being that the manner of my father's abuse and subsequent death were so chef's-kiss representatively perfect in that I not only blew up the man<sup>49</sup> who had been fucking me the ass, but then used my traumatizer's remains to create my creative career. I bristled at this suggestion for the simple reason that if it were so obvious to connect what I lived through to what my generation is living through, it suggests a far darker future for this country than any of my darkest moments.

Now perhaps on a subconscious level, rejecting any sort of dramatic framing of my personal life means I am still my father's son, as he would regularly seethe embarrassment at the prospect of any family member making a scene<sup>50</sup>. But the truth is that my father and I had no tipping-point showdown that primed our dramatic event. Traumatic memories tend to be too sharp to have narrative arcs. I recall my focus at that time wasn't on stopping my father's abuse from occurring, but rather knowledge of it spreading<sup>51</sup>. Because it was only after Chase Jimniss jostled the boys' bathroom stall<sup>52</sup> right as I was in the middle of replacing my manpon that I truly felt the full emotional brunt of my father's abuse. And as my clothed upper half scrambled to cover my exposed lower half, I remember watching Chase's face advance a stage of development, from piecing together why I needed a manpon in the first place to piecing together how to leverage this knowledge.

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<sup>49</sup> "The Man" as they see it.

<sup>50</sup> e.g. "Stop crying you're making a scene"; "Why are we making a scene and taking some picture when the gift shop right over there has postcards of the same goddamned canyon." So on and so forth.

<sup>51</sup> I believe I share this with other trauma survivors.

<sup>52</sup> No move more self-identifies a card-carrying douchebag than pulling stall doors in public bathrooms to see which one is unlocked instead of simply standing back and enduring the mild inconvenience of tilting one's torso and evaluating whether or not there's crumpled chinos in the space beneath below the stall's door. Later, as David and I drafted Cocoin's first legal codex, I was adamant that this type of social infraction be a hangable offense.

Meeting Chase's demand — a fifty dollar monthly retainer not to etch **BYRON BLOODY BUTT** on my locker — was impossible, as my parents did not believe in allowance or financial support of any kind<sup>53</sup>. At a certain point, the panic of my home self bleeding into my emotionally-gauzed social self compelled me to ask my vagina mother if she would commission me her portrait. This was a hail mary request, and one I had made only once before; I remember the blitheness with which my vagina mother had bit her honeycrisp apple before informing me with smacking dismissive lips that she wasn't worthy of whatever spurted from my charcoal pencil's tip. But for this request I anticipated her rebuttal, promising her that I'd never finish her portrait, as an unfinished work will always have the hope of perfection within it. But after she asked me how much all this would cost her with the hollow tone of a john to a whore, I remember feeling my vocal cords spazz on fifty's first fricative before seeing scoffed menthol exhaust signifying her refusal. Now to my vagina mother's credit, after refusing me, she did catch me when I crumpled in despair. And I as I watched my popping snot bubbles glisten the stretch-marked furrows on her cleavage, I very vividly remember feeling that my vagina mother could sense my rheumy whines and spastic heaves ran deeper than me hustling up funds for a new pastel set or the latest Crash Bandicoot. And that's when I spoke what happened below into existence, spoke it right through my mom's titty when I asked her if it was a sin to use sin to free yourself. But before my mother was able to answer me, I remember my father stumbling into my room with hand cupped on ear to ask what in the tarnation of fuck was I puckering my butt about, at which point my vagina mother brushed my father away by telling him I had simply blown a fuse.

*Retributive irony* is one of the search engine optimization terms our publisher purchased in advance of the *The Floating Studio's* nationwide release. Whether or not what follows redeems this investment is a choice you'll surely wrestle with in the weeks that follow this metamemoir. But having reflected on the totality of this dramatic event

<sup>53</sup> I remember regularly being teased for holding up my school cafeteria's vending machine line as I cradled the dollar earned from my charcoal chiaroscuro sketch of an upperclassmen couple sixty-nining in the drop-topped back seat of Principal Wageuspack's Miata with two hands as if it were a rare bird.

for the first time since my deposition, I really do believe I'm in the right focalized space to reflect on how an imperceptible ironic energy kismetically steered me in this one-pair-of-footsteps-on-the-beach way<sup>54</sup>. Even so, and with everything finally fully adjudicated and all limitations statuted, I do want to acknowledge my father's role in all this, as what follows was bricolaged as much from his own failures more than any ironic orchestration on my part.

"Blowing a fuse" was a catch-all phrase inside the Chianti household that we'd apply to all sorts of intrafamilial kerfuffles. A pithy but revealing example: I remember basing what kind of night my parents had by that morning's smell; stale air indicated an uneventful night, whereas anything appetizing wafting my way meant my vagina mother had been up all morning sublimating her beaten energy into her famous heart-shaped hash browns topped with boysenberry compote. I remember my vagina mother would place the plate of hash browns in front of me, then repeatedly flatten the pleats in her polka-dotted pinafore with the backs of shaking hands as she attempted to attribute last night's symphony of muffled pleas and thudding walls to the fuse my father had blown in frustration after unsuccessfully pitching his Underground Shaleroad concept to the barflied stools up and down Main Street. In my father's defense, he was facing some serious go-to-market headwinds regarding his Rebel Well prototype we need not discuss here. I remember the night Glen came over under the pretense of helping box up unsold cases of holy fracking water, but really to take both my father and I out for a sympathy drunk at Houlihan's. And after sucking down several rounds of mind erasers through a straw, Glen casually referenced he had recently been made party to several government-seized vessels in the process of being dry-docked in Edgewater, vessels whose hundred-amp lead-acid batteries inside could in some way be the electrovoltaic on-ramp my father's Underground Shaleroad needed. That next morning, I remember sipping Pedialyte with a crumpled bar straw pulled from one of my coveralls' pockets while reading a tacked Houlihan's napkin

<sup>54</sup> Roll your eyes sure, but the sheer fact remains I didn't simply resort to braining my dad brain dead with my mother's titanium driver but instead concocted a needlessly elaborate electrical circuit all so I could turn my father's flesh into a fuse.

outlining a major change to my body therapy regimen in which I would pivot from my current bulk of 60mg anavar supplemented by 5x5 pyramid sets to a cutting cycle of 40mg clenbuterol and 10x10 german volume training. It was only after I watched my father's dimmed truck lights sweep across Monte Marine's cast iron-slatted security fence that I understood the thinking behind my father unilaterally whittling me down to a waif over a six-week span: not only was I now slender enough to slide between cast-iron fence slats, but by implementing 10x10 supersets, I had retained enough strength through my cut to be able to hoist each ganked hundred-pound lead acid battery over the eight-foot fence and fall on my father and I's well-worn garage mattress.

My father's plan here was to freely distribute these dead batteries as "*grift gifts*" to his Underground Shaleroad subscribers, then up-sell/cross-sell a series of *MAAGA*<sup>55</sup> resurreccessories designed to recharge said dead battery. My father's thinking being that the grift gift's sunk cost — as in the literal inconvenience of removing an unasked-for hundred-pound lead acid battery off your front porch — would buy him enough time to create this line of resurreccessories. Like any other grift, my father's *MAAGA* scheme relied more on vilifying the problem than defining its solution. This meant sowing distrust of what my father regularly grouched as "*guvment-powered alternating current*". And so my father opened his *MAAGA* awareness campaign by resting a leg bent in halftime speech position against a puttering, open-hooded golf cart while cuntily whining to my easeled camera that back in his day America's greatness was powered by good old-fashioned direct current, but now that we got this Obama character monkeying around with all these marxian alternative energies, it's left to American-made business magnets like Mister Trump to keep the direct current dreams of the little guy alive. For both our sake I'll assume you don't have the time nor the inclination to unpack my father's logic in connecting Donald Trump to "*the little guy*"<sup>56</sup> much less the delusion that he would gave any electroengineering fucks about

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<sup>55</sup> Make America's Amperage Gridless Again. I know, I know; this was in early 2015, for whatever that's worth.

<sup>56</sup> All phallic innuendoes aside.

helping some Paterson wetback like my father or his merry band of **MAAGA** early adopters detach from the electrical grid. The relevant point in all this being that, in producing and editing these cockamamie product demos, I had now become my father's predator<sup>57</sup>.

Before shooting these demos, my father and I had a ritual in which I would pack chewing tobacco inside his rectum as a way of calming psychoperformative headwinds we need not unpack here. Now to be clear, my familiarity with chewing tobacco extended outside my father's butt-hole: during that year's varsity baseball tryouts, I pinched my fair share off Marcus and Michael Rivera, Paterson High's all-district mellizo middle infielders who I remember having neat matching dagger tattoos on the second base sides of their necks. Eventually I began to purchase my own tins; and after my vagina mother found one in my cup while doing my laundry, she carried out the scared-straight tactic of making me memorize each vile ingredient by stuffing a plug against my gums after each wrong answer. The upshot to all this being I was very much aware that lead was an active ingredient in snuff when one day, as I watched my father stoop to a squat in so he could bench test one of his dead lead batteries, I could see a plumber's crack plugged brown smack directly dab between the lead acid battery's two lead terminals; and I remember thinking that if I could find a way to somehow place a dastardly amount of lead into my father's snuff can, I just might be able to make my father's rectum into the retributively ironic fuse I desperately sought.

And so I began to slowly increase the lead tolerance in my father's anus. I remember skipping E block economics every Tuesday so I could fetch the freshest log at Power Gas over on Straight Avenue, often times arriving just as the Copenhagen delivery truck pulled out its parking lot. I would then race back to my room to shave ten percent more lead into the snuff tin zeroed out on my digital scale. Then after my father kismetically delayed his resurreccessory rollout due to a series of e-commerce headwinds we need not unpack here, I had the titration runway necessary to subtly ratchet up his dip enemas' lead dosages. When the time finally came to film his first resurreccessory demo,

<sup>57</sup> David told me puns aren't ironic, but our publisher kept it in for the metalinguistic wordplay.

I remember kneeling behind my father exposed bony buttocks and see his saggy ballsack aura in the halo light I personally rigged for the shoot. And after parting his cheeks with my left thumb and pinky in a shaka hang loose sign, I packed my pops's prostate with tobacco so leadened it felt heavy in my hand, then situating myself back behind our family's vhs camcorder duct-taped to my teak composition easel and recording over footage of my first communion and racking my focus to the familiar sight of my father zipping himself up with his back turned to me.

It's best we gloss over the gesticulations and catchphrases during my father's *Liquid Resurgence*<sup>58</sup> infomercial, as it would only caricature his legacy even further. Relevant to our story was the methods by which my father proved the battery had been resurrected. After questioning whether the camcorder lens in front of him actually believed that our demo battery was in fact dead and that there wasn't some hinky bait-and-switcheroo happening<sup>59</sup>, my father dramatically ripped my cherished New Jersey Devils satin heavyweight jacket off his chest by its snaps, clamped red and black gator clips first to the battery's positive and negative terminals then to his nipples, and filled all six of the battery filler ports with a gallon's worth of *Liquid Resurgence*, repeating "it doesn't even hurt" even as his distended areolas dripped blood on the battery. I then turned on a Paterson High-ganked overhead projector<sup>60</sup> as my father retracted a white vinyl screen displaying a magnified Underground Shaleroad mapkin which my father broke down the finer points of his *MAAGA* vision, thwacking various parts of the projector screen with my easel's teak dowel as if it were a lecture pointer for roughly half an hour – the time he suggested to his *MAAGA* customers to wait before their resurrected battery would fart out fresh amperage. I would then detach the blood-sheened gator clips from my

<sup>58</sup> Which was repurposed holy fracking water.

<sup>59</sup> Which it in fact was, as before the shoot I had painstakingly installed a voltage regulating diode into the jumper cables, then wired a wah pedal to the diode's on/off gate so I'd be able to toggle the Trojan's battery's outgoing amperage with my foot as I racked my father's nip clamping into focus from behind my teak easel, a detail which I bring up here not to further burnish my nigger-rigging bona fides but as another example of the type of straightforward, single-entendre patricidal opportunities I passed on.

<sup>60</sup> Also ganked.

father's nipples to two stripped wires splayed off his prized Trump brand Executive Tie Rack that I remembered still displayed the silk paisley Bill Blass ties last worn during his last full-time job as a residential phone technician. And as I heard the click of an activated circuit accompany the tie rack's whirring motor, I remember ruefully biting my top two knuckles while watching my father merely squirm in his squat before concluding the infomercial with less a call to action than a badgering, shouting over the activated Trump tie rack's whiny whirr to repeatedly ask the fourth wall if it still didn't believe him.

Faced with my first failure, I immediately began a post-mortem on what went wrong in my butt-snuff circuit, skipping school for a week so I could post up at my local library and figure out where my electroresistive headwinds were coming from. Eventually I learnt the culprits were the two plastic handles on my father's gator clips, which had been insulating him from the lead snuff's amplified amperage. Meaning I needed to somehow create a scenario in which my father touched the battery's lead terminal either with his bare hand or holding a metal implement. Here it bears repeating the State of New Jersey's Medicolegal board's fully adjudicated conclusion was that my father's death resulted from his reckless feckless entrepreneurial choices and not from any premeditated actions on my part, however incriminating and dramatic his goo may have been portrayed in the media. I state this because after some early *MAAGA* adopters began griping on our Facebook and ThinkedIn pages that their Liquid Blessings weren't resurrecting their dead batteries as advertised, my father made the unilateral and freely willed choice to sell tap and die sets as his next resurreccessory. Setting aside the blatant and borderline-patronizing double entendre, a tap and die set calmed my electroresistive headwinds in two ways. First was that, in boring a deeper connection into the battery's lead terminal<sup>61</sup>, a tap and die would be able to channel more amperage into my father; the second was that while the tap's reamer handle was made out of 316 grade stainless steel offered low electrical conductivity, if I could create a fugazi tap set out of smelted lead, that in conjunction with my father's leadened rectum might very well create the fatal anal amperage I sought. So when the time came to

<sup>61</sup> So his *MAAGA* rubes could install a girthier, higher-amperage battery post.

film our tap-and-die demo, I remember one hand twisting my fugazi lead tap into the stainless die behind my father's back as the other parted, then plugged his butt with leadened dip. And as I racked my focus to the image of my father again pulling up his coveralls with his back turned toward me, I noticed a pair of rubberized work gloves dangling from his back pocket<sup>62</sup> and snapping a dratting finger across my ribcage before filming my father's fully insulated hands place my fugazied lead reamer upon the battery's positive terminal, despondent that all my drudgerous hours spent ingotting molten carcinogenics resulted in my father briefly clawing his chest then pinching of the outside of both eye sockets, as if putting something mildly loosened back in place.

This rubber glove headwind really scrambled my egg, I tell you what. Because it wasn't like my father was demoing the same dead batteries he was foisted on his merry band of *MAAGA* rubes but rather a spanking-new Trojan Motive battery purchased at Jiffy Lube's quarterly Battery Blowout sale from the proceeds of a savings bond my late grandfather explicitly designated for my college tuition. So one night, after having successfully lured my father into passing out in my bed<sup>63</sup>, I slipped into the garage so I could load test the Trojan battery myself. After picking up the multimeter off my father's work bench and placing its metal talons to the 12V Trojan battery's two terminals, I remembered seeing **10.8V** blink on the multimeter's LED screen, then thumbing my forehead in disbelief, mildly shocking myself in the process as the tip of the multimeter's red talon I still held glanced against my sweaty scalp. Later that morning, I remember literally skipping past school so I could bone up on low voltage matter at Corey Fleming's public library. There I learnt that the fault in my retributively ironic circuit wasn't because the lead butt snuff or fugazi tap and die set wasn't conductive enough, but rather an external load was draining my father's Trojan battery into a non-lethal capacity, I remember nodding a frown in relief that I wasn't subconsciously

<sup>62</sup> As I reflect on this with the earned wisdom of a millennial life lived as capitalist prey for grifting civic predators, I think about how a grift's success hinges on reinvesting its initial profits into insulating yourself from the its wrought wrath.

<sup>63</sup> And not the garage mattress we'd usually share.



gaslighting myself by making up some electroimpotent headwind out of thin air<sup>64</sup>. And so after spending an additional skipped school week poring over exploded battery diagrams at Corey Fleming's<sup>65</sup> then biking back to my father's vacated garage<sup>66</sup> to bench test his haphazard charging circuit, and in the silence of deducing where the hidden draw draining the battery, I remember hearing a whirr come from the Trump tie rack we had been livestreaming as proof of his resurreccessory concepts and whose perpetual 10mA draw had over time hardened the battery's lead plates, dropping its voltage to non-lethal levels.

Before we go any further, and in an effort to provide the most context possible, let's take a collective beat to understand the difference between amperage and voltage. It's an important distinction. Many electrical engineering textbooks use water as an analogy, in that amperage represents the amount of electricity passing through a circuit and governed similar to a pipe's liquid width, whereas voltage is the rate at that which that electricity is discharged, which is similar to the water pressure within a pipe. A more meta-memoiry way to illustrate this amperage/voltage distinction is if I remembered when, in the cusp of adolescence, Joyce would take me to Liberty Science Center<sup>67</sup> and that I revelled in its oversized Van de Graff generator<sup>68</sup> wiggling fluorescent high-voltage squiggles within a glass structure shaped like a township's water tower. And that I remembered the generator's placard boasting it perpetually conducted 500,000 volts of electricity, and yet I enjoyed a hair-raising yet harmless experience due to the fact that it could only deliver a nanoamp's worth of current into my body. Remixing metaphors a bit as I loop back to the water analogy: if one compares a high-volt low-amp Van de Graff generator experience akin to prancing around a sprinkler-capped fire hydrant in the street, a low voltage current conducted at a high amperage would be similar to a commercial pressure washer ripping through several dermal layers using only a water bottle's worth of water.

<sup>64</sup> I believe this is common to many trauma survivors.

<sup>65</sup> Nigel Calder. *Boatowner's Mechanical and Electric Manual* ISBN: 9780071790338.

<sup>66</sup> My father spent his day drinking.

<sup>67</sup> I remember weirdly feeling my pituitary gland crown whenever I was around Joyce.

<sup>68</sup> I was also partial to their dredging scooper, but felt weird queuing with toddlers.

As a novice traumemoirist, I struggle with how much I should attribute my father's death to me asserting myself in the cosmos and how much I should simply acknowledge with shrugged shoulders that the whole dramatic event was fatefully sewn without my input or influence. I state this because, after spending another hookie week poring over exploded battery diagrams at my local library, I returned to my A Block physics class right as we were being assigned our senior class project: constructing a functioning battery from a household item. This pivot from sabotaging my father's Trojan Motive battery to building my own meant my choice of household item for this project would be critical, as it not only needed to deliver a killshot amount of amperage into my father, but also possess a level of personal significance<sup>69</sup>. My first thought was to construct a battery out of lemons, as they were my father's gag of choice in the early months of his abuse<sup>70</sup>, but I didn't have a lot of confidence my father would register this reference in any meaningful way during what would likely be hectic final moments together. I also considered layering alternating zinc and copper pennies in a voltaic pile, but I sensed that having a bunch of pennies laying around might arouse his suspicion<sup>71</sup>. And so again, my egg was scrambled until one morning, while fidget-twirling a can of *Surge!*<sup>72</sup> on our family's kitchen table, a sip's worth ejaculated

<sup>69</sup> Since irony's recognition depends more on its recipient than its sender.

<sup>70</sup> Back when I made noise; I remember he'd bring back several soggy, sucked-on wedges back from the bar faintly tasting like Wild Turkey.

<sup>71</sup> I received a greater understanding of fuses after my father caught me scrounging our sofa for spare change to pay Chase Jimness's manpon ransom. I remember my father grabbing my wrist with one hand so that his other could pry open its fist and thumb through my unclenched change; finding two specific pennies – one minted on each our birth years – my father scattered the rest of my cobbled change across his garage's grey-green carpet with a dismissive swipe at my hand, then walked me by my throat out to the garage where he plopped my 1990 zinc millennial penny into a fusebox connecting his Trojan battery to his Trump brand executive tie rack, then picked up the tie rack's splayed red and black wires so he could whip his own nipples while keeping his sloppy overbearing gaze at me. Then after replacing the 1990 zinc millennial penny with his 1957-minted baby boomer copper-based penny, my father yanked down my pants, spread my cheeks, and whip my fuzz-pubed perineal area with those same – but now activated – wires. If I had to guess the intent of his hillbilly operant conditioning, it would be that his generation was flat made from stronger stuff, in that the copper-based 1967 penny more conductive and resistant to corrosion whereas the zinc-based 1990 penny is overly reactive. Again, just speculation.

<sup>72</sup> I remember can twirling becoming my dissociative tic of choice whenever caught in the crossfire of growls and epithets my parents hurled at each other.

out its mouth hole to land upon the webbed skin between my thumb and index finger; that last part of our reptile selves. And as I felt the high-electrolyte sting that gave **Surge!** soda its iconic, gum-numbing tang, I remember remembering a similar sensation from the leaked battery acid dripping off the ganked 8Ds that my father and I pushed over Monte Marine's slatted security fence.

One way my father embodied the tired cultural trope of the cringily unoriginal father was that he regularly took comedic inspiration from popular advertising campaigns. A pithy example: the earliest video footage of me isn't crawling or cooing, but rather we three Chiantis cosplaying as Budweiser frogs at a Halloween block party, complete with my father's slurred commentary on the proprietary training methods able to compel an eight-month old to bark "er" at his index finger's pointed command. So when Coca-Cola began rebroadcasting 90's-era **Surge!** commercials to hype the soda's limited re-release in select tri-state markets, my father and I immediately began canvassing convenience stores across Union, Passaic, and Sussex counties for the better part of a weekend, eventually hoarding enough cases that I remember my father had to pull over on Route 22's shoulder so I could ratchet-strap the case load to his truckbed. These **Surge!** commercials formulaically opened on a group of college-aged men<sup>73</sup> chasing a tumbling **Surge!**<sup>74</sup> at the intensity of greyhounds hunting a mechanical rabbit; where after nose-manualling down a cobblestreet-lined hill or centripetally rolling down some cragged mountain inside a monster truck tire, whichever man reached the **Surge!** first would crack the can open before triumphantly raising it above a face tilting above the horizon; then after cutting to an interstitial product shot<sup>75</sup>, the spot closed with another buddy yoinking the **Surge!** right at its quenching apex, who after slugging the whole soda down, would punctuate his conquest by yell-belching *Feed the Rush!*<sup>76</sup> six inches from the yoinkee's face as this half-ribbing, half-domineering ride that really is the conversational glue holding together the social bonds between males of that or any age.

<sup>73</sup> Mostly caucasian, sprinkled with token racial inclusion proportional to obesity risk factors.

<sup>74</sup> Despite having passed multiple corner bodegas fully stocked with the soda they chased.

<sup>75</sup> A closeup of neon green fizzing above the pint glass's horizon.

<sup>76</sup> The campaign's tagline.

To be clear, yoinking refreshments was nothing new for my father. I remember whenever he managed to attend my U-9 indoor soccer games, he would regularly freshen his flask with my halftime Ecto Cooler but only after I penetrated its finicky foil hymen with its bendy straw. Eventually the cumulative weight of my vagina mother's chastising began to take hold so that outside of the occasional block party or parent-teacher conference, my father's yoinking outbursts had laid dormant for the better part of my adolescence. That was up until the reaired **Surge!** commercials; which, similar to New Jersey's fracking ban years earlier, triggered my father into yoinking relapse. During this time I remember our family dinners having this kabuki theater feel in which my vagina mother would first proffer a **Surge!** to both me and my father; then after I would reply yeah ok sure but before my father could begin his initial trolled refusal<sup>77</sup>, my vagina mother strongly suggested that my father take her up on her offer because she's flat fucking done taking two trips to the pantry for one shitty joke. At which point my father would reassure the both of us he got all the yoinking out of his system during last night's dinner; that he's seen the light in being manipulated by some lame-o corporate ad gag; and that besides, how could he even be thirsty if he just got back from the bar? My father would then lay in wait until mine and my mothers' hands were both on the **Surge!** — so as to triangulate the yoinkage — before prying the can from our combined grip; at which point he'd stand up from the kitchen table with a triumphant noble posture uncommon to him, delete the entire can in a continuous gulp, all punctuated by belching "*Feed The Rush*" in my face at a velocity that always managed to flutter my bangs. And if I revealed my frustration or sense of victimization about the yoink in any way, my father would have enough left in his tank to punctuate his taunt and expel the Chianti family motto: "*Life Isn't Fair*".

I've unpacked these yoinking anecdotes not to caricature my father's legacy even further, but to illustrate the degree to which **Surge!** soda was top of my father's mind during this time. And now that I had landed on a retributively ironic solution for my battery project, the next step was to fabricate the anodic and cathodic cells

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<sup>77</sup> critical to any yoink.

to be submerged into each individual soda. While I possessed all the low-nobility zinc I needed<sup>78</sup> to construct the cathodes, my egg was a bit scrambled about how to source a highly anodic metal like magnesium – at least without sifting through a shitload of seawater<sup>79</sup>. Which meant I had no other choice than to bring Glen into the fold; who in exchange for a chit to be named later, gifted my father magnesium-coated dragon's breath bullets for his birthday and which I ganked later that night after my father passed out in my bed<sup>80</sup>.

As important as denying my father a single-entendre death was that I craft its means while in his presence. During one of our last Sunday afternoons together, I remember taking a break from sawzalling the tops of **Surge!** cans to watch my father pace our garage's grey-green carpet in four-step laps, teeth clamped against his beer's raised circular rim like a vise grip's locked jaw so freed hands could sketch circuit schematics instrumenting a line of rectifiers that were about to go to market as **MAAGAs** latest resurreccessory. These rectifiers represented a significant pivot in my father's **MAAGA** vision; that is, while my father pitched his previous resurreccessories as being able to charge the dead battery internally<sup>81</sup>, my father was selling these rectifiers so his **MAAGA** customer base could convert 120-volt alternating current coming in from the public grid into 12-volt direct current necessary to charge their dead lead acid battery. It wasn't lost on me that my father had resorted to leeching off the "guvment-powered" energy he despised; hypocrisy is the last refuge of the damned. But because of this public-grid pivot, my father was now facing some severe instrumentational headwinds in finding a use case that wouldn't trigger the cognitive dissonance of a **MAAGA** customer base we had just riled to a socioelectric lather from the anti-alternating current awareness campaign we filmed at Trump Bedminster<sup>82</sup>.

<sup>78</sup> Leftover from my failed butt-snuff and tap-and-die schemes.

<sup>79</sup> A liter of sea water contains about a gram of magnesium chloride, which could then be separated either through laminar coflows or solar evaporation — neat facts sure but I neither had the time nor inclination to act on.

<sup>80</sup> He couldn't legally give the ammunition to me due to my being a juvenile.

<sup>81</sup> Either through the tap and die set or holy fracking water.

<sup>82</sup> In that even the roundest rube in the **MAAGA**-verse would notice the usage increase on next month's power bill and make the connection that using electricity from the grid to charge a battery designed to free them from said grid wasn't the big-brained play they thought it was.

Put another way, my father's *MAAGA* grift now depended on his ability to persuade his griftees to begin grifting off the grid themselves. I remember watching a strip of smelted magnesium jostle off the tweezer I held poised over a open-topped can of *Surge!* as I felt my father squeeze my trap muscle from behind. As you recall, grabbing this particular muscle was the way in which my father would enlist my help for a variety of tasks. Here he needed me to haul his Trojan battery outside the garage so he could bench test a rumpleminzed-inspired rectifier use case he had thought up earlier that morning. I remember my heel tripping on my father's garden hose coiled brittle and hidden by overgrown crabgrass as I drug the Trojan battery out the garage and down our dandelioned driveway by its rope handles; where after wiggling it near our home's utility meter as directed, my father unfurled two 0-gauge, pornstar-girthed jumper cables which he positioned between meter and his Trojan Motive battery. My father then connected the jumper cables from battery to meter, first clamping one red gator clip to the meter's top right lug<sup>83</sup>, then the other to the Trojan battery's positive terminal; then after attaching one of the black gator clips to the Trojan battery's negative terminal, I remember watching my father shake both gloved hands in an anxious shiver, pick up the black jumper cable's unclamped clip and palsily hover its jagged teeth near the meter's grounding lug as if defanging a venomous snake and whose glancing touch I remember seeing sparks shoot off at all four junctures of my father's nigger-rigged<sup>84</sup> circuit before feeling its ambient current shimmer within my bone marrow. While my father and I waited for his Trojan battery to charge, I remember feeling my thigh vibrate from Glen texting me with all-caps urgency about how I needed to procure a koozie from the garage stat so I could insulate the pair of plier handles sticking out my father's coveralled back pocket before they would be used to pry the gator clips off the meter's lugs<sup>85</sup>. Glen's meddling here was clutch

<sup>83</sup> My father wired his rectifier to the jumper cable via a haphazard application of electrical tape and wire nuts.

<sup>84</sup> His words.

<sup>85</sup> Glen surveilled all this from halfway up a utility pole he rappelled using a cummerbund rented from the big and tall section at the Men's Warehouse off 17 in Paramus, which he then had the gall to try to return spackled with wood splinters and tar.

for two reasons. First is it cemented my father's trust in me, in that even if we didn't see dick-to-mouth on a range of issues, my koozie save demonstrated I would never ever put him in some risky retributive position where a stray spark could turn him into goo. But just as important, if my father had been electrocuted to death that day, even though the end result would have been the same, none of this — the retributive irony, the trial, me and you here right now — would exist.

Even though my father somehow stumblebummed into successfully nigger-rigging his ganked electric meter to rectifier circuit, he shrewdly understood that his merry band of **MAAGA** rubes had neither the gumption to physically drag their dead battery out to their home's electric meters, much less the focus to rig a high-amperage circuit<sup>86</sup> themselves. Which meant my father was forced to burn even more electrocircuitous calories figuring out how to funnel meter-ganked electricity into his **MAAGA** rubes's homes without triggering a house call from whatever Joe Jerkoff was manning their local PSE&G substation. And as my father and I attempted to knock our creative cobwebs out by playing a game of don't fuck your brother with a pint of rumpleminze, I remember my vagina mother storm into the garage waving a white trifolded electric bill over her head as if it were the incandescent bulb of Mowbray's electrical muse; because her pitched bitching about the garage's lights being on at all kilowatt hours<sup>87</sup> that was the kismet nag my father needed to square his electrocircuitous circle by instrumenting motion sensing lights into his nigger-rigged battery charging circuit<sup>88</sup>.

By and large, motion sensor lights are installed for their ability to illuminate: say, a driveway flood lamp above a restored classic car, or a sconced porch light deterring loitering raccoons from food deliveries. My father's vision was the opposite of their intended use

<sup>86</sup> Tampering with the meter makes it impossible to control the voltage you're tapping into, and few homeowners have equipment — much less wherewithal — to perform this kind of "hot" work.

<sup>87</sup> Not about the two of us futzing with the meter (or each other) as initially thought.

<sup>88</sup> In which electricity would flow through the jumper cables, into the home's interior where my father's rectifier would step down the voltage from 120V to 12V before entering into motion sensing lights which when deactivated would trickle the charge into the dead battery's positive terminals.

in that he sought to adapt the sensor's shutoff mechanism as a logic gate which could sluice meter-ganked electricity into the Trojan battery with a subtle enough voltage drop that it wouldn't disturb the thumb squarely lodged up whatever Jimmy Jabroni manning our local PSE&G substation. To be clear here, we're talking fractional salami slices of sluiced amperage here<sup>89</sup>, but when aggregated and compounded over time, adds up to a significant amount of energy. As you might imagine, these motion sensing lights made what was already an uncomfortable home life even more uncomfortable. I remember weekly movie nights<sup>90</sup> – our family's closest approximation of a bonding activity – becoming unbearable, as any lumbar adjustment or lunge toward the popcorn bowl would trigger our living room's track lighting and illuminate my father's nosebridge pinched in exasperation that my selfish fidgeting had stopped our livestream<sup>91</sup> of a whirring Trump brand rotating tie rack acting as proof of our rectifier concept's go-to-market motion. A more relevant inconvenience surrounding these motion sensor lights was the way in which they interfered with the stilled hours metallurgy demands; I remember bobbing my head like a drinking bird doll so that my bedroom lights would continue illuminating the post-midnight drudgery of poisoning a blue butane flame over a vise grip gripping a dragon's breath bullet<sup>92</sup>.

Despite our family's sporadic Mass attendance as mentioned, I'm grateful that my father was afforded the chance to embrace his spirituality in his final weeks. And with all cases adjudicated and limitations statuted, I'm now able to freely share my role in his defining moment of conversion. I remember slapping, then squeezing my father's trap muscle with one hand while the other held a stapled stack of printed screenshots from this neat new business intelligence dashboard<sup>93</sup> I had taken the initiative to first download then bike over to our local library to print out some interesting revenue projections.

<sup>89</sup> A concept admittedly similar to the plots of Office Space or Superman 3.

<sup>90</sup> MacGruber, Saving Silverman, Horrible Bosses 1 + 2.

<sup>91</sup> Recorded with a night vision camera purchased with the rest of my grandfather's savings bond.

<sup>92</sup> Another reluctant shoutout to Glen for sourcing a drinking bird doll that kept steady motion.

<sup>93</sup> Obviously fugazied.



After first pointing to the dashboard's beta artificial intelligence plugin defining<sup>94</sup> our target **MAAGA** customer's purchasing mindset as "*socioeconomically enslaved to America's culted, capitalist Christ*" and punctuating that point by smacking the dashboard's projected revenues if we were to pivot our marketing toward evangelical Christians with the back of my hand — it was then I remember watching my father's eyes gloss with greed just like Masaccio's tax collector shaking down St. Peter with his back turned to Jesus.

That Father's Day, during our family's last supper together, I gave my father the first of his two gifts: a magnesium cross I had spent most of June's nighttime hours painstakingly smelting from dragon's breath bullets. And as I watched my father open the engagement ring box ganked from my vagina mother's vanity earlier that morning, boy howdy did it feel neat to see his smile brim to the heights of the night I first benched my weight. I still remember playfully smacking the top of my father's shoulder so that he sit still while I clasped the cross's chain on over his topmost vertebrae, as he had already revved himself into a manic tizzy calculating the potential profit boost now that he had this gaudy evangelical in. I also remember my father's penultimate command was that I begin burning some serious cinematographical calories on how to rig our halo light to optimize the glimmer of his neat new cross dangling in his upper left ventricle<sup>95</sup>.

The final gift I gave my father was a feigned helplessness surrounding my school battery project. I remember reminding myself to tinge my ask with the same hesitant tone and halting breath as when I used to ask my father if what he was doing was wrong just before he did it; where after prefacing that surely he had better Father's Day plans than helping his faggy meager artist son nigger-rig up some silly soda battery, I remember whine-whimpering with bat eyes that he was the only man in my life who could help me make my deadline. I remember watching my father's proud smile shift into

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<sup>94</sup> After having fugazily fed my dashboard my father's social media posts of bigotry aligned perfectly with (prosperity gospel individual over community, selective morality on sexuality or family while neglecting others, such as poverty, systemic injustice, or care for the environment.

<sup>95</sup> Pacemakers are placed on the non-dominant side. My father was right handed, hence the upper left ventricle.

a patronizing smirk before he led me into the garage by my slapped trap muscle. And after enduring some last final sweaty moments with my father while watching a jostling motivational poster on all fours, I put my duck canvas coveralls back on one shrugged shoulder at a time the same way he did before revealing by school project, earnestly unfurling burlap off twelve open-topped twelve-packs of **Surge!** like a complete dweeb so that three cans' worth spilled on our garage's grey-green carpet. I remember watching my father pinch his nosebridge between rolling eyes taking in 141 open-topped cans of **Surge!**, each with a smelted zinc and magnesium strip bobbing in soda the green of cartoon nuclear waste and all rhizomatically connected to their adjacent cola cells through overlapping daisychains of red and black gator clips dipping into each can like licorice straws before mansplaining to me that given my **Surge!** Soda battery's limpdicted amperage, choosing 12 AWG wires to daisychain each cell was complete overkill. But in my father's defense it probably was, given I only needed to generate less than a tenth of an amp to keep him from letting go.

Due to post-Columbine safety policies banning explosive materials on school grounds, my battery project wouldn't be graded by Mr. Meyers inside Paterson High's ramshackle science lab. Students were instead instructed to film our batteries supplying a draw to any twelve-volt DC appliance we had laying about. This meant, I told my father, we could fugazily wire my **Surge!** battery into his grid-ganking motion-sensing battery charging circuit so that its situated it near his whirring Trump brand rotating tie rack as proof of concept while making sure the Trojan 8D battery<sup>96</sup> that actually powered the tie rack would be outside the shot<sup>97</sup>. And before my father could fully weigh out all the piezoelectric angles in wiring some feckless faggy low-voltage soda battery to a high-capacity 8D Trojan battery<sup>98</sup>, I reminded him how we could use his latest rectifier ressurecessory as circuit protection – rectifiers whose internal fuses we had yes replaced with pennies as part of several penny-pinching measure to maximize our MAAGA margins<sup>99</sup> and that just as a reminder to remember that the

<sup>96</sup> A.k.a the actual source of the tie rack's load.

<sup>97</sup> Which I readily admit was a huge kismatic boon to my case.

<sup>98</sup> The larger capacity battery will always try to force current into the weaker soda cells.

<sup>99</sup> And suggested by my AI dashboard.

pennies we put in weren't highly conductive copper pennies minted during my father's era but a bunch of weak millennial-minted zinc pennies meaning even if a short did occur, the weak millennial-minted zinc penny would absorb the stray current – not either of us – and certainly not at a voltage that could threaten our internal goo. And that besides, I had already advance-ganked an extra pair of jumper cables from Mr. Meyers' trunk for precisely this purpose.<sup>100</sup>

Even today, I remember this string of moments with such distant but concrete detail<sup>101</sup> that recalling it feels more like rewatching a movie than reliving a memory, which I'm told isn't unusual for people who witness traumatic event up close. I remember my father squirting dielectric<sup>102</sup> grease onto the jagged fangs of all four fugazi gator clips before attaching them just as he did during our ganked meter bench test; first clamping one end of the red jumper cable to the Trojan battery's positive terminal, then the other to my **Surge!** battery's red downstream wire; and after clamping one of the black jumper cable's gator clips to my soda battery's black wire, I remember watching my father, gloveless in paternal underestimation and with the rote familiarity of a roadside mechanic, clamp the other gator clip to the Trojan battery's negative terminal and jolt straight upright from a hunched kneel posture just like how when during eucharistic prayer, my vagina mother would elbow my father's ribs whenever he'd snooze-drool on the pew he hung over while hungover.

Now I know what you're thinking. You're thinking I expect you to believe that some faggy meager millennial artist chopped a fully-grown homeowning baby boomer down simply by nigger-rigging a bunch of three-quarter volt sodas. Well: by daisychaining both the individual sodas within each twelve-pack as well as the larger twelve-pack cells

<sup>100</sup> Painstakingly fugazied by hot-dipping gator clips into liquified titanium smelted off a big bertha driver ganked from my vagina mother, then later dipping the titanium gator clips into melted typewriter ribbon, then finished in red and black vats of melted Maker's Mark wax heavily adulterated with magnesium dragon's breath shavings to make the wax conductive.

<sup>101</sup> Memories become more plastic each time they're remembered. Only with traumatic memories is this not the case.

<sup>102</sup> Also fugazied with magnesium and copper shavings to cancel out the dielectric grease's nonconductive properties – here is closer to an entendre or pun than prima facie irony so partial credit?

themselves in series<sup>103</sup>, I was able to stack 141 three-quarter volt salami slices into an 108 volt pile – enough force to push a 20 milliamp current through the fugazi red lead gator clip my father held and patriculate up his left hand, arm, and shoulder before release electrons into the low-nobility magnesium chain and cross dangling against his wifebeater’s parabolaed hem, a hem sweat-dampened from fucking me one last final last time, each electrolyte-glistened chest hair lowering his internal resistance like a drawbridge to let my circuit breach my father’s moat of torso flesh and scuzz his high-nobility titanium pacemaker before flowing out his leadened puckered butt and seek ground by shooting down his right leg’s bent knee squished against carpet intentionally accidentally soddened with high-electrolyte **Surge!** soda<sup>104</sup>. And as I watched my father’s jaw bulge bulbous above neck webs straining as if there was something inside him desperately trying to get out, I knew I had successfully arrested my father’s heart. But I also knew I still needed to bring it to justice, as this initial **Surge!** circuit was the patricidal equivalent of pitching yeast. This is why I implemented my father’s grid-ganking motion-sensing circuit into the fold, not as some aestheticocritical mic-drop as in America look upon ye feckless hypocritical baby boomer grifts and despair, but because it was the only way to deliver on the Chekhov’s-gun promise I made with myself that I would fire an retributively ironic surge<sup>105</sup> into my father and blow his soul’s fuse. Because if I could still my body in harmony with my shocked father’s and turn off the garage’s motion sensor 120 volts of meter-ganked current could sluice through the Trojan battery – and, by proxy, my father – in its attempt to equalize the **Surge!** battery.

<sup>103</sup> i.e. positive to positive negative to negative

<sup>104</sup> Magnesium is very reactive, while lead is an electron acceptor.

<sup>105</sup> Here complying with our publisher’s request that I unpack my ironic thinking. So my intention with the **Surge!** battery was to take ironic retribution on irony itself – to ironize irony if you will – in a way which could perhaps subvert an audience’s expectations of irony due to the fact that **Surge!** soda battery did not deliver the fatal surge of current, an involuted irony to be sure and one which if one squints you can see that building a whole meta-memoir ambiguity about whether anything sincere I am intentionally blurring the line between sincerity and mockery any effort here sincere here creates even more doubt – doubt which some in the publishing world would interpret as meta-ironic<sup>a</sup> – especially if the speaker has previously mocked the very idea of irony. Even so, I readily admit my rhetorical plane was not operating at that aestheticocritical altitude while in these moments.

a. Although I am a bit less open minded.

Let me go back. Most electric shocks, such as a wet hand hurriedly plugging in a hair dryer or a bored Paterson adolescent taking sparking selfies of themselves whipping chain wallets against wall sockets, has a jarring yet fleeting effect. This is because an alternating current actually crosses zero volts at over 120 times per second<sup>106</sup>, giving the shockee ample micro-opportunities to pull away from the shorted circuit. The same cannot be said for a shorted direct current circuit, particularly if a load<sup>107</sup> is drawn from the circuit after the short. Even so, there still existed paths for my shorted **Surge!** circuit to pass through my father and take to ground – either through his right hand holding a black rubberized gator clip<sup>108</sup> clamped to the trojan battery's negative terminal or from the rectifier's weak millennial zinc penny fuse failing and breaking the shorted circuit altogether. But if I could shunt my short in advance by say, replacing the zinc millennial penny in the fusebox with a metal of higher nobility; say, a baby boomer copper penny minted the same year as my father, I could bridge the short and divert that all grid-ganked high-voltage current back into my father.

And yet, despite audio confirmation that I had successfully funneled grid-ganked energy into my father — with senses amplified by the garage's demotioned darkness, I remember feeling a breeze generated from the overrevved Trump tie rack accompany the sound of 141 **Surge!**sodas simmering from ohmic heat — I still felt iffy that I had done enough to actually have fully deaded my dad. So I began to swivel my torso to search for a tool I could use to shovel additional voltage into my father; a movement which reactivated the garage's light to illuminate my father's glossed eyes bulging from a slacked face as if he had just seen the face of God superimpose itself on his faggy meager artist son of his. The garage lights turning on also meant that my shorted circuit was now turned off; I remember watching my father's feeble, palsied attempts at taking advantage of his temporary stay of electrocution, eventually prying his burnt pushed hand off my fugazi lead gator clip that I remember looking like a slice of griddled rye being pulled off a patty melt. And as I watched my father's goood

<sup>106</sup> Talking conventional 60 Hz AC systems here.

<sup>107</sup> Like, say, a rotating tie rack.

<sup>108</sup> That I forgot to fugazi.

digits extend toward me seeking assistance, I remember immediately looking down at our garage's carpet, as passively averting my father's gaze was my go-to move whenever my father would ask something from me I didn't want to give. And staring at that grody garage carpet the grey-green of old money, I'll admit feeling flat fucking triggered thinking about all the dry winter nights spent on chafed elbows and knees where right before the dad dicking began my father would rev his black sheened hosiery still worn from Mass earlier that morning on said carpet before poisoning his penis close enough to my anus to static-shock it. It was this triggered memory that triggered my index finger to shoot skyward; where, as if shellshocked by my own solve, I held my eureka pose long enough to trigger the motion sensing lights off and shock my father again to keep him at bay. After that it was as simple as flicking off my redwing boots, paw the garage's carpet for a dry swatch, rev merino work-socked feet back and forth just as I did with my cozy coupe as a toddler, and stab a proud, static-shocked, voltage-piled, pudder-daring hand at my father.

I can feel your eyes rolling again. Which is flat fine by me, because the one takeaway I'm taking from this postmodern metamemoir of ours is that rolling eyes might be the only way to view an unfair postmodern late capitalist world. Because we've come too far here not to dialogue like dutch uncles about how millennials have gotten an unfair shake: how twenty percent of our collective net worths were flat yonked from us with the carefree ease of a halftime Ecto Cooler; how we've been forced recognition while being starved of compensation, then gaslit into believing that we're the ones setting the socioeconomic menu in this country; worst yet is how we now can't shake this passive compliance where we use social media the defining technology of our generation to post either doomcore whining or flexcore flaunting navel-gazing or hopecore caged-bird thank yous to the corporations laying us off all of which keeps we merry millennials cheerleading each other on the sidelines while these oligarcho-capitalist boomer fucks are out there dad-dicking us playing to win<sup>109</sup>. But, as my father reminded me with

<sup>109</sup> Which was the whole thrust behind Cocoin – I mean did anyone expect an entire generation to be subjected to this kind socioeconomic dad-dicking through their prime earning years without at least a little retributive uprising? Hey please huh?

with burped **Surge!** breath, his closest approximation to paternal wisdom, that's life. Now maybe this is some weak millennial bullshit, but I wish my father's generation showed mine how to make the world a little more fair instead of showing us how to grift off its unfairness.

Let me tell you what felt fair. It felt fair to watch my father coat my fugazi titanium gator clips with the same dielectric grease I used to lube my manpons. It felt fair for my feet to paw dry carpet like a bull's hooves torquing arena clay right before being released from his darkened pen. It felt fair to extend a fugazi<sup>110</sup> helping hand's index finger within Sistine proximity of my father's limp, lifeless hand extended in front of me so I could could ejaculate 30,000 volts into my father then feel my shorted circuit whipcrack back into my bone marrow at the depth and intensity of a rebooted computer. And it felt fair – if not just – that our stilled bodies turnt the lights out one last final last time; where, with senses amplified by the garage's darkness, I heard a feeble, ironic “surge” wheeze out my father like a toy being deflated before being stored away for a good long while, the hollow thudded crunch of a man taking himself down a notch with legs twitching themselves fractured<sup>111</sup>, all punctuated with a wet thwack against my canvas.

<sup>110</sup> Here using the term by its original Vietnam-era acronym “fucked up, got ambushed, zipped in a body bag” 66% literally as a body bag to store father's remains was impractical as previously mentioned.

<sup>111</sup> In a phenomenon similar to how rivers run backwards after burning, the polarities of my father's Trojan battery had been reversed due to their interior lead plates calcifying from the Trump rotating tie rack's perpetual low-amp draw. Meaning, I was informed later by Glen's electrician's corroborating testimony, what my father and I thought was the Trojan battery's negative terminal during the night in question was actually positive — and vice versa. This meant the series connection I had intended between my **Surge!**soda battery and the Trojan battery — as in the red gator clip connecting my **Surge!**battery's red 12AWG wire to the Trojan battery's positive terminal — was in fact a red-black parallel connection that kismetically boosted my circuit's amperage in this random chance way as in like battery bank error in my favor, collect two hundred more milliamps.

A much more significant consequence of this polarity reversal was the fact that the Trojan battery's cells had become brittle in a way which made them unable to accept the charge incoming from my father's ganked energy circuit. Unbeknownst to either myself or my father, the byproduct of voltage entering a battery with nowhere to go and nothing to catalyze with being that these cells began releasing highly-combustible hydrogen gas to balloon the battery in this unstable cartoonish way, eventually leaking into the garage's airspace through the battery's water vents and subsequently ignited by my handshake shock to make the whole dramatic event far gooier and ghashtlier than intended.